

Phil 216 Ideas of the 20th Century Part 2

1. Dust and Dreams

- 1.1 Well, welcome back, everyone. Today, I want to talk about Dust and Dreams. This was Horace's idea of what we human beings really are like—dust, dust, and ashes. Well, dust and dreams. Or in the original Latin, it actually says dust and shadow. But that's the idea. There is something more to us. We're going to look at three thinkers today who reflect on what more there is, and ways in which people have forgotten that, and it's a very dangerous thing to forget that. If we just focus on the dust part without the dreams, we can get ourselves into big trouble. And that's happened during the 20th century.
- 1.2 So, we're going to look at three thinkers. The first one is Miguel de Unamuno y Jugo, so ordinarily referred to simply as Unamuno. I'm going to talk in particular about one book of his called "The Tragic Sense of Life." It came out in 1912, so shortly before the First World War, but it's talking about an intellectual tendency that he sees going on in society around him that he thinks is very dangerous.
- 1.3 Let me start with one of his most famous speeches. Donald Trump famously was shot in Butler, Pennsylvania, in July of 2024, and he went back to the same spot three months later and began to give the talk that he had been giving there in Butler, and he began by saying, "As I was saying." As soon as he did that, I heard that and immediately exclaimed, "Unamuno!" I talked to a friend of mine who had been a Spanish major in college, and that was her reaction, too, because the reference here was to Unamuno.
- 1.4 He was professor of classics and Greek, as well as a rector, something like our Provost, at the University of Salamanca in Spain, for 24 years. Then, for six years, he was suspended due to political incorrectness, basically. But eventually, in 1930, he was reinstated. And so, for six more years, he taught at the university. He got back after six years of being suspended for political reasons, and he began his first lecture by saying, "Decíamos ayer," "as we were saying yesterday," actually. In doing that, he wasn't even original. He was echoing a friar who had been suspended during the Spanish Inquisition and who is commemorated there at the University of Salamanca.
- 1.5 And so, there's this tradition of people feeling like "I've been pushed out, or I've been endangered in some way," but then managing to come back. Unamuno was someone who not only wrote philosophical works, but wrote on culture very broadly. He was a figure who commanded a huge amount of attention in the Spanish-speaking world and is, I think, far too little known in the English-speaking world, but nevertheless exerted a huge influence over a variety of areas of culture.
- 1.6 And so, one of the themes I'm going to focus on is his conception of humanity. He's against systems and especially against reductive systems. They're going to say, "A human being is just this or just that." He's going to say, "No, we're not just anything. We're all

those things and more, besides." Then he talks about the significance of reason as opposed to feeling, as well as circumstances. He's thinking that most of the Western tradition has treated reason as fundamental to who we are. He says it's one of the things we are, but actually, feeling, emotion, is even more fundamental in human beings.

1.7 Both of them are shaped deeply by our own circumstances. We are always philosophizing or thinking or feeling from here, from a specific place in time. If you leave that out and just think about humanity in the abstract, you're missing something hugely important. We aren't abstract beings. We are real concrete beings who exist at a certain place in a certain time in a certain social context, and all of that is vital to who we are. Then he draws some ethical and political implications from all that.

1.8 He begins the book by citing Terence. He says, "I'm a man; no other man do I deem a stranger." A line from Terence, the Roman poet, who says that, "I'm a human being; I consider nothing human alien to me." Or at least that's what one of his characters says in one of the plays. And so he says, "There is a problem. Intellectuals tend to think about humanity, but in this abstract way." He says, "My subject isn't going to be mankind in that abstract sense. I'm going to be writing about 'the man of flesh and bone, the man who is born, suffers, and dies—above all, who dies; the man who eats and drinks and plays and sleeps and thinks and wills; the man who is seen and heard; the brother, the real brother.'"

1.9 Now, notice there, "the man who thinks," that's part of it. But that's only a small part of life. I mean, I'm a professional philosopher. My life is spent—my livelihood comes from thinking. And yet, am I thinking all the time? Well, no. Often, I'm just eating or drinking or playing Pokémon or doing whatever it is that I do. And so that is, even for me, only a part of my life. So he says, "I want to focus on people as they really are, not these abstractions."

1.10 And so, start with the question of what it is to be a human being. What's essential to humanity? What is it really to be human? He says, "Look at what various people say about that, and you can get disturbed because they have this very narrow and reductive conception of what human beings are." He says, "There's another thing that people investigate, which is called man, and he's the subject of not a few lucubrations, more or less scientific. He's the legendary featherless biped." This was Plato's definition. What is it to be a man? It's to be a featherless biped. Well, it's said that someone refuted Plato by throwing over the walls of the academy a plucked chicken. OK, featherless biped, but hardly a human being.

1.11 Another possibility is, well, the "zoon politikon," the political animal of Aristotle. So we could be understood as political beings who exist in communities, and yes, that is an element of what we are. The "social contractor" of Rousseau, so we can look at this from the point of view of sociology and say, "All right, we interact in a society, and we interact with other people in that society and enter into contracts with them and form governments and so on."

1.12 Or the "homo economicus" of the Manchester School. In other words, economic man. We could be understood as rational economic agents, maybe rational utility maximizers, or what have you. The "homo sapiens" of Linnaeus, so we'd be understood as a biological kind of creature, an animal of a particular kind, a particular species. Or if you like, he says,

just "the vertical mammal." But however you think about humanity, all of these are picking out one thing that we are.

- 1.13** So, I've talked a bit in the past about the contrast between the scientific image and the manifest image. This two-level conception of the world, according to which there is a surface level revealed to us in experience, and that consists of the objects we ordinarily encounter— people, tables, chairs, cats, stones, etc. Then there is, underlying that, a hidden level, a scientific level. It's what happens at the scientific level that ends up shaping and determining what we perceive at the manifest level.
- 1.14** Now, some versions of this are really fairly uncontroversial. Chemistry studies the substances and their interaction by talking about their atomic compositions and their molecular compositions and so on. That's all fine. That doesn't lead us to any disturbing conclusions about humanity in itself. But when we start reducing humanity to just a biological category—so what is it to be human? It's to be homo sapiens, and it's just maybe to have this kind of DNA or what have you.
- 1.15** Or if you think of us just in terms of politics, we are simply this kind of political creature, or as social contractors, or as something else understood from a sociological perspective. Or if you try to reduce humanity to just some economic thing, like being a rational utility maximizer or some other kind of economic agent, however you conceive of that. Or if you think of us, as Marx does, as a representative of a class, or for that matter, a representative of a race or an ethnic group. Or like Freud, you start thinking of us as simply driven by subconscious drives, and so you think of us as simply having the lives we lead at the manifest level because of certain subconscious hidden forces.
- 1.16** Well, all of those are saying that humanity can be understood in terms of this one dimension, so it reduces us to an economic thing or a biological thing or a chemical thing or whatever it happens to be. Unamuno is saying, "Look, all of those are wrong-headed. We aren't just one dimension. Yeah, we are biological beings, but we're not just biological beings. We are beings that exist in a society. We aren't completely understandable just in sociological terms. And the same thing is true with our political character or our economic character."
- 1.17** So he's saying in the end, sure, lots of things are relevant to understanding what it is to be human. Biology is relevant. A theory of rational choice is relevant. Economics is relevant. Sociology is relevant. Political science is relevant. A theory of the emotions and, in general, human psychology is relevant. All of that matters. But you can't understand us in terms of one dimension alone. We aren't just any one of those; we're all of those things. And he says, moreover, we're one other thing, too, at least. That is to say, you have to take into account our concrete circumstances.
- 1.18** Now, what does he mean by that? I am shaped by the particular circumstances I'm born into and then that I face throughout my life. I am constantly responding to the world around me. And if you don't think about the nature of that world around me, you can't understand me. A lot of what I, in particular, face, has to do with where I was born, when I was born, what the life is like that I lead. If I were a 17th-century goatherd, presumably my life would be really different. I would be really different. I would understand the world really differently and understand myself really differently.

- 1.19** He says, "All of this matters partly because we are, in addition to being rational beings, we are emotional beings, and our circumstances and our emotions are tied up closely together. I feel the way I do about the world and about choices I make, because I face a certain set of circumstances and become a certain kind of person in response to those circumstances." So he said, "Here's what's wrong with all of those reductive accounts." What they study is "a man neither of here nor there, neither of this age nor of another, who has neither sex nor country, who is, in brief, merely an idea. That is to say, a no-man."
- 1.20** And we shouldn't be doing that. We shouldn't be looking at man in the abstract. Here is why we really can't leave out the concrete circumstances. He says, "Philosophy answers to our need of forming a complete and unitary conception of the world and of life, and as a result of this conception, a feeling which gives birth to an inward attitude and even to an outward action." In other words, the philosopher, going all the way back to Socrates, let's say, saying, "You want to know how to live? Let's begin by thinking about life. Let's think about what it is to be a human being, what it is to live a human life."
- 1.21** The idea here is, if we think about this in the right kind of way, then we're going to feel the right way about it, and we're going to be able to lead the right kind of life. Now, that idea isn't just restricted to Western philosophy, even. In Confucius, there is this idea that it is knowledge in the end that really makes a difference. It shapes the way we think about the world. Those virtues of thinking lead to virtues of feeling. I'm going to feel the right way about things if I think about them the right way. If I feel the right way about them, then what results is virtues of action. I'm going to do the right thing in response to them. So, it's thinking, then feeling, and then action. The same pattern exists there in Confucius as in Socrates. You can find that sort of idea all over the world.
- 1.22** But Unamuno says, "All right, that's the ideal, that somehow philosophy shapes how we think about things. That shapes how we feel. That shapes what we do." But he said, "I don't think that's the way it works. I don't think that's what human beings are like." He says, "The fact is, this feeling, instead of being a consequence of this conception"—in other words, of the thinking—"is the cause of it. Our philosophy, our mode of understanding or not understanding the world, and understanding life, springs from our feeling toward life itself."
- 1.23** So he says, "This idea that we think, then we feel, then we act, I think it's wrong. We start feeling. Actually, the feeling itself is partly shaped by our circumstances. So the world and the feelings are kind of interacting together. It's not like one comes before the other. And then thinking follows that. So, actually, I am interacting with the world and responding to it in a certain way, and I'm thinking about it a certain way, as a result of feeling about it a certain way."
- 1.24** Look at all these accounts of what it is to be human and what's really essential to us. Aristotle said, "We are rational animals, and what is really distinctive about us, our function is rational activity." Acting according to rational plans puts the thinking and the acting there. But notice, feeling is gone. Descartes says, "What can I be sure of? That I think and that I am." OK, so what's really essential to me? Thinking. Immanuel Kant says, "Yes. How can I define myself? I am a thing that thinks." All of those put rationality first.
- 1.25** But Unamuno says, "Why? Man is said to be a reasoning animal. I don't know why he hasn't been defined as an affective or feeling animal. Perhaps that which differentiates him

from other animals is feeling rather than reason. More often, I've seen a cat reason than laugh or weep." And I have seen cats reason. I've had a lot of cats in my lifetime, and sometimes they are very clever. In fact, they routinely outsmart me.

1.26 I had a cat that didn't want to be outside, but nevertheless would race out the door any chance she got. As soon as she raced out the front door, she would race up a tree and then go up on the roof of the house. The only way for me to get her in was to open up the window in the second story—she would be outside that window—and then open up a can of food and lure her in. She gets hungry, race out that door, climb the tree, get on the roof, and she knows I'm going to have to feed her in order to bring her back in. She could have just gone into the kitchen and meowed, but that was her way of doing this. I didn't know how to stop it. So, yeah, that cat was reasoning, and reasoning really very cleverly.

1.27 Anyway, I sympathize with this thought here. What's really distinctive about us is not the "I think," but the "I feel." He says, "Now look, if that's right, then when we think about thinking, and when we think about philosophy, or in general, shaping a theory about the world, we need to think about the feeling that underlies it and the approach to life that underlies it." So in philosophy, he says, "What most should concern us is the man, the person." When we do that, we actually get to some disturbing consequences.

1.28 Historian Paul Johnson, for example, a number of years ago, wrote a book called "Intellectuals." It was just a short biography of a variety of different significant intellectual figures, people like Jean-Jacques Rousseau or Karl Marx, Ernest Hemingway, Bertolt Brecht, Bertrand Russell, Jean-Paul Sartre, and so on. He said, "Look at the life these people led. You have to think about their thinking in connection with the life that they actually led." What he found is that every single one of them led a pretty awful life from a moral point of view, often a really unhappy life as well. But even if it wasn't terribly unhappy in their terms, it was terribly unhappy for all the people around them whom they treated terribly.

1.29 Johnson is in part saying, "What do we do with these people who were looked up to as great intellectuals, and yet led monstrous lives?" It is a disturbing thought. Now, a lot of philosophers would say, "Look, what matters is the rationality part." So if they didn't live up to their own theories and their real lives, well, whatever. However, I think the thought in Unamuno is, we should take that very seriously, because that philosophy is arising from somebody who led that kind of life. If that's what results from seeing the world this way, we should have second thoughts about their philosophical views, too.

1.30 So, Unamuno continues—Hegel said, "Everything that's real is rational, and the rational is real." But he says, "I'm not convinced by Hegel. I think the really real is irrational. In fact, reason builds on irrationalities." Now, what does he mean? He's willing to go so far as, "Hey, life is contradiction. We live only in and by contradictions." Now, at first glance, that's shocking. He's saying reality is contradictory and so on? Well, he could be saying that. But I think what he really says is, "Thinking results from feeling, not the other way around. And feelings can contradict each other. Facts don't contradict each other, but feelings do."

1.31 So, think about Catullus' famous poem, for example, *Odi et Amo*, I hate and I love. And then he goes on to say, well, actually, I can quote the whole poem because it's very short, it's a two-liner. He simply says, "I hate, and I love. Why, you may ask? I don't know, but I feel it, and I am in torment." That's the whole poem. But that's something we can

sympathize with. There are times when we have these psychological conflicts, and we find ourselves torn. We both love someone and hate them for various reasons, or we find ourselves liking something and yet disliking something about it.

1.32 Feelings can contradict each other, and we can feel both at the same time. If that's right, and feeling is more fundamental than reason, then we end up saying life is a matter of resolving these contradictions and finding our way through these conflicts, finding some balancing, finding some compromises sometimes, or sometimes just having to choose. But in any case, it's not to be thought of in terms of this fact and that fact, which, of course, have to be consistent. It's not even a matter of, I'm reaching this conclusion or forming this belief. It's rather, I've got these contradictory feelings, and I'm trying to resolve them in a certain way.

1.33 So he says, "The values I'm talking about are values of the heart." Reasons don't really do much good. In other words, let's say you have had a disastrously bad love affair. You're in love with this person, but you know they're bad for you. There are things they do, they treat you badly and so on. Then a friend is, let's say, giving you reasons why you should leave, why you should get out of this. But the problem is, reasons don't matter at that point. In the end, it's really the feelings that are driving the decision; the reasons are following after that.

1.34 So he says, "Yeah, against the values of the heart, reasons have no avail." They don't really do anything. Why? "Reasons are only reasons. They aren't even truths." And so in the end, our decisions are made on the basis, mostly, of feeling. Now, some decisions may be purely rational. I don't have strong feelings about certain things. Which mutual fund should I invest in? I don't really have strong feelings about this sort of thing, and so on. But other things, yes, we're driven mostly by feeling.

1.35 So he says, "Here is the key problem of philosophy. It's how to bring thought and emotion together. It's about reason and trying to develop a view of the world and of life that actually makes sense of the feelings we have." We have certain necessities of the heart, values of the heart, but reason matters, too. And so we've got to reconcile intellectual necessities and the necessities of the heart. We have to combine what emotion drives us to and what reason drives us to.

1.36 And that's a hard thing, because there is often a contradiction between the way we think about things and the way we feel about things. It may be possible to derive a certain kind of intellectual conclusion, and yet look at life and say, "That doesn't make sense to me. That's not the way I feel." And so he says, "That's where things really break to pieces." Yes, you can construct a consistent intellectual framework, but all too often, you're leaving out a huge amount, like the biologist who says we're purely biological beings, or the economist who says we're purely economic beings. Well, that's part of what we are. It is not all of what we are. There's a huge amount left out, and in particular, the feeling part, the attitude about life part, is completely left out. And so somehow we have to try to bring all of these together.

1.37 What does this mean for how we live? Unamuno himself was a political centrist, and really, in ethical terms, not a particularly innovative person, but I don't mean that as a criticism. He was a person who just thought human beings mattered. Life had dignity, and we deserve to be treated with respect and valued as having dignity.

- 1.38** That got him into big trouble in Spain. He was pro-democracy, anti-extremism, but in a time leading up to the Spanish Civil War, that was a dangerous place to be. He started out being anti-communist when he saw the communists taking over the republican movement. But then, as the fascists took over the Falangist movement, the more traditionalist side, he ended up feeling, "Wait, this started out being tradition versus reform, and now it's communism versus fascism." He said, "I don't like either one. I don't want to be a communist, and I don't want to be a fascist." He says, "One day I'll rise up and throw myself into the fight for liberty, by myself. I'm neither fascist nor Bolshevik. I'm alone!"
- 1.39** Franco placed him under house arrest. He was murdered, and probably by a fascist militant, though it's unclear. Both sides blame the other for murdering Unamuno. In any case, the center turned out to be a lonely place to be. As Yeats said, "The center does not hold," in situations like this. But what was his ethical view? Well, I've already mentioned, it was basically that of Immanuel Kant. It was fairly simple. "Man is an end, not a means. All civilization addresses itself to man, to each man, to each I," not to man in the abstract, but to individual people in their circumstances.
- 1.40** And so, his ethical theory rests on Kant's categorical imperative. Treat humanity always as an end in itself, never as a means only. And specifically, treat each individual person as an end in himself. Each of us has dignity as a human being, and that's not something that should be denied. Notice how easy it is, if I have one of those reductive views, to ignore this, to say, "Well, you're just an animal," if I look at it from a biological point of view, or "you're just an exemplification of this social group or this social force or this political group or this political force or this economic perspective or whatever."
- 1.41** I'm reducing you to something that then can be used as a means. After all, if I'm just an economic agent, we use economic agents as means all the time. People employ me. I'm a consumer. They sell to me and so on. That's not a problem. It's very easy, if I have this narrow and reductive view of humanity, to start treating people as means to my own ends, rather than as ends in themselves. He says, "Political leaders, in particular, often do this." They adopt one of these reductive perspectives, and then they have a vision of humanity based on that, and a vision of utopia based on that, and they start sacrificing individual people to achieve that end.
- 1.42** So he says, "As far as I'm concerned, I will never willingly yield myself or entrust my confidence to any popular leader who isn't penetrated with the feeling that he who orders a people orders men, men of flesh and bone, men who are born, suffer, and although they do not wish to die, die; men who are ends in themselves, not merely means; men who must be themselves and not others; men, in fine, who seek that which we call happiness."
- 1.43** So we can't be reduced to one dimension. We're all of those dimensions at once, and that has to be respected. Each person has to be treated with respect. He says, in particular, it's inhuman to sacrifice one whole generation of people for, well, some distant goal, some goal that may or may not be achieved. That generation deserves respect, and the people in it deserve respect. They cannot be discarded simply because they are obstacles to achieving a certain kind of goal.
- 1.44** I mentioned earlier Paul Johnson's book, "Intellectuals." There's been a follow-up to that. Neven Sesardic wrote a book called "When Reason Goes On Holiday," talking about more recent philosophers and their lives and their political perspectives, and ended up telling a

depressing story about how figures as great as Albert Einstein or Kurt Gödel, Ludwig Wittgenstein, Hilary Putnam, all ended up being fans of totalitarian movements in the 20th century.

- 1.45** It turns out, for example, that Wittgenstein and Gödel were great admirers of Stalin, that Imre Lakatos, actually behind the Iron Curtain, turned in certain colleagues of his for anti-Soviet thought, that Hilary Putnam was a Maoist and so on and so forth. They were all enamored of various totalitarian movements. And why? Well, they led lives of a certain kind that were actually, in this case, mostly not highly immoral lives, but more just really peculiar lives, but they were fans of totalitarians.
- 1.46** Unamuno would say, "Yeah, that's what I'm saying." You have a certain way of thinking about humanity, and really, that stems from a way of feeling about humanity, a way of feeling that is going to allow you to sacrifice individual people to some distant vision. It's a fundamental mistake, a moral mistake, a political mistake, and a tragic human mistake.
- 1.47** I want to move on to a second figure who wrote during the 1920s and, I think, developed some of these ideas in a slightly different way, but nevertheless, a way that's going to help us understand the rise of totalitarian movements during, especially, the '20s and '30s. That person is Julien Benda. He ended up writing a book called "The Treason of the Clerics," often translated as "The Treason of the Intellectuals," in 1927. He denounced intellectuals in general as a group that were treasonous and destructive to society.
- 1.48** Now, a little strange of me, as a professional philosopher, to be praising this book, but he thought of himself as observing what was happening. The cynicism that we saw rising before World War I, but then even much more intensely after World War I, was something that led a whole group of people, who were the people who were the dedicated thinkers of the society, to start reconceiving their role, and reconceiving it in a way that he said is becoming really dangerous.
- 1.49** This group is setting itself up in opposition to those who are in charge of society, and that might not really matter, except that these are the people in the universities or in the media, in film, and all sorts of other departments of society, that are shaping ideas and educating the leaders to come. He says that's why this is very dangerous. If they were just off in their ivory towers thinking weird thoughts, no one would really care. But the fact is, they're teaching the young who are going to end up leading this society.
- 1.50** They are putting out the newspapers and the magazines and the films and the other things that are actually penetrating ordinary people's ideas, and in particular, leaders' ideas. He said that this group is going to create a group of leaders who no longer identify with their own society or its interests. In fact, they're going to be hostile to them. Because this group of intellectuals is hostile to their own societies, they're going to produce leaders who are hostile to their own societies, and that's a very bad place to be.
- 1.51** So, here, he says, is the traditional view. Societies have, throughout history, allowed a certain group to be set aside and spend most of their time thinking, rather than engaging in farming or manufacturing or something else. From one point of view, that's an amazing luxury. After all, why do this? These people aren't seeming to produce much of anything, so why have this class of artists and musicians and writers and so on?
- 1.52** Here was the idea: you've got, let's say, the mass of people and then the leaders, the ruling class, let's call them. But the thought was, the intellectuals are supported, more than

tolerated, but actually paid to do this kind of thing, because they were able to step outside the ordinary bounds of society and think about things like "what is good, what is true, what is beautiful?" Because they were able to dedicate their lives to these transcendental ideals, they could produce great art, for example, or great music, great literature, great philosophy. They could do things that would help to shape society in the future.

1.53 Just as you might say, "I shouldn't consume everything I earn; I should set aside some for the future; I want to invest," this was society's way of investing. We're going to invest in the future by having people whose job it is to come up with new ideas and ways of improving human life. And so, they were willing to do this and have a bunch of people who were saying, "This is what's really good. This is what beauty is. Here's a work that is really beautiful," and so on, because the thought was, this is an investment in the future.

1.54 Now, often humanity didn't live up to the ideals that they had and this group articulated; said, "Look, humanity did evil for 2,000 years, but it honored good." That contradiction was an honor to the human species. Yes, from one point of view, it was hypocrisy. But he says, that's how civilization arose, through hypocrisy. Yeah, we were down here living in the trenches. We were fighting the fights. We were having tough times most of the time and making all sorts of moral compromises. But we honored good.

1.55 We had this group of people we set aside to say, "Your job is to think hard about how we ought to be doing this and how we can do it better." That was, you might say, the homage that we were paying to virtue. We may or may not have lived that way, but at least we said, "That's our goal, that's our ideal, that's what we hope the future is like." It was hypocritical, maybe, but nevertheless, it was something that allowed civilization to arise.

1.56 Now, Benda said that's the way it had been, but it's started to change. Why? Well, first of all, it was an intellectual thing. People began to denounce hypocrisy and not just think it was, in general, not a good thing, but that it was the central sin. Nietzsche, for example, said, "Authenticity is the only thing I really value." I want you to be sincere. I want you to be authentic. And in a sense, to say, "I'm living like this, but I honor that good. I go to church on Sunday, and I pray, even though Saturday night, I engage in every form of debauchery, and Monday through Friday, I'm out to get everyone I can."

1.57 Well, yeah, but at least you're praying on Sunday. At least there's something good there. You may be a hypocrite, but nevertheless, you're honoring good. You're building civilization. There is something important and right about that. And if you abandon that, you say, "No, live authentically," well, here's one way to do it. Live throughout the week as I preach on Sunday morning, and as I pledge to do on Sunday morning, or I can start preaching the way I live Monday through Saturday. And that's what intellectuals began to do.

1.58 So, Benda says, "Intellectuals have given up that search for these transcendental truths, for the good, the true, and the beautiful." Instead, they followed Nietzsche. You're to become the person you are. Well, the person most of us are does not produce civilization. It produces the kind of thing that we were trying to get away from and improve our lives from. One cynical version of this actually came earlier in Marx. "The ruling ideas of an age," Marx had written, "are the ideas of its ruling class."

1.59 And so, in the end, he says, "Look, yeah, intellectuals said they were following the good, the true, and the beautiful, but actually, they were just mirroring the ideas of the ruling

class." So they weren't leading us to something better. They weren't really investing in the future. They were basically consuming and entering into the ruling class through this way of interacting with them, leaving out the masses.

1.60 Well, the thought was, the Marxist self-conception was, "But we, guys like Marx and Engels, are able to identify with the masses, and so we're going to actually be hostile to the ruling class instead." Traditionally, these intellectuals have claimed to be doing this higher thing. They haven't been. They've just been the voice of the ruling class, but we're going to be a different kind of voice; we'll be the voice of the masses.

1.61 Now, what did that mean? Benda said, "For the first time, the class generating ideas and training leaders to come sees itself primarily and permanently in opposition to the ruling class." So now the job of the intellectual isn't to search for the good, the true, and the beautiful; it is to engage in revolutionary activity and revolutionary thinking.

1.62 He says, "That's different." It's one thing to have a few people over there, plotting revolution. Not maybe a good thing, but nevertheless, it's a thing. However, when they train the people who are going to be your leaders in the next generation, that's a very dangerous thing. So he says, "Our age is the age of the intellectual organization of political hatreds." Why? Because the core thought now is not the search for these transcendental ideals, these things like the good, the true, and the beautiful. Now, it's really a matter of hating that group, hating this group.

1.63 And so Benda predicted, "We're heading for the greatest and most perfect war ever seen in the world." Keep in mind, he is writing after the First World War, the war that people said at the time is the war to end all wars. He's saying, "That didn't end all wars. Actually, I see trends that are going to lead to a much greater war." He was entirely right about that.

1.64 To see how this worked out in practice—after all, here's just some French intellectual thinking about this—but look at the Bloomsbury group in England, which was highly influential during the teens and '20s and '30s. That group was thoroughly pacifist. Most belonged to the National Council Against Conscription, opposed to the draft, opposed to any British war effort. They opposed World War I, in fact. They opposed British imperialism, and they argued for moral equivalence, or even the moral superiority, of Britain's opponents.

1.65 So they were people who consistently sided, for example, with Stalin against Britain, or with Hitler against Britain, and so on. One of the most popular of them, novelist E. M. Forster, wrote, "I hate the idea of causes, and if I had to choose between betraying my country and betraying my friend, I should hope that I'd have the guts to betray my country." And he was someone teaching the young people, leading, a group of leaders, who, in many cases, did indeed betray their country and ended up spying for Stalin.

1.66 Well, that brings me to the third figure I wanted to talk about today, José Ortega y Gasset. Ortega has a number of different ideas. He wrote widely about philosophy, as well as literature and culture more broadly. I'll talk today mostly about two of his books, "The Modern Theme," where he outlines a kind of perspectivism and then "Revolt of the Masses." Let me begin by telling you a little bit about who he was. He was born in Madrid and spent most of his life there, educated there for the most part, and then became a professor of metaphysics at the University of Madrid.

- 1.67** He, again, is someone highly respected and well known in the Spanish-speaking world, much less so in the English-speaking world. But he did write a wide variety of books, some on philosophy, some on politics, some on literature. His "Meditations on Quixote," for example, is a very well-known book. He wrote, "What Is Philosophy?" It's really "The Revolt of the Masses" that maybe most directly leads us into the rise of totalitarianism that he began to see around him by that point and predicted would be much more intense in the future.
- 1.68** But let's start with "The Modern Theme," written in 1930. He talks there about perspectivism. It's a relative of relativism, but it's not the same thing. He wants to stress that it is not the same thing. Perspectivism is the view that truth is relative to a perspective or a standpoint, a point of view about the world. He says, "Absolute truth is not impossible. It's not incoherent." He says, "I'm not a relativist. I'm not like Nietzsche, at least at one stage of his thought, who said, 'There's no such thing as an absolute truth or an eternal fact.' No, no, no. It's not an incoherent idea."
- 1.69** He says, "But you have to understand, you can never be positioned in a way that you see it completely." That absolute truth makes sense, but as the limit or the sum of these individual perspectives. So, think of a line in mathematics, let's say, that asymptotically approaches another line but never actually intersects it. It gets closer and closer, but they never intersect. He says, "That's what it's like." Absolute truth is like that thing, and we can, by considering more and more perspectives, approach it. But it's something like the limit. If we had infinitely much time and infinitely much experience, maybe we could reach it.
- 1.70** But the fact is, within a human life span or even all of our human life spans put together, we can never get there. But that's what it would be. It would be that limit or the sum of individual perspectives. It is not itself a perspective. Only God or some kind of enlightened being could somehow see things from all points of view at once. We're limited, but we can approach that truth. We can consider more and more perspectives.
- 1.71** Think about an object. You can't see everything about it from one point of view, just looking at it from one angle, but you can move around it. You can look at it from different points of view and understand it better. And yet, in doing that, there is no time where you say, "Ah, I see it all right now." No, you never see it all, but you can see more and more of it, and understand it better and better. So that's his idea.
- 1.72** A good example of perspectivism is the traditional story of the blind men and the elephant. Each one is approaching the elephant, trying to understand what this strange animal is like. One grabs hold of the tail and says, "It's like a rope." One grabs hold of one of the legs and says, "It's like a tree." One touches the side and says, "No, it's like a wall," and so on. They're all right, but in a sense, they're all wrong. It's correct from that perspective. Yeah, the side of the elephant feels like a wall. This leg of the elephant feels like a tree trunk, and the tail feels like a rope. But none of them give you an entire picture of what the elephant is like. And yet, even the blind person moving around the elephant and touching the various parts of it would form a better and better understanding of what the elephant is really like.
- 1.73** Like Unamuno, Ortega stresses the importance of circumstances. He says, "Who am I?" Well, I can think about that from all sorts of points of view. As Unamuno stressed, no one

is going to get everything right. Each one is giving us a perspective. So yes, there is a standpoint from which we are biological entities, another standpoint from which we are sociological entities or political entities, and so on. Rational beings, yes, emotive beings, yes, all of those things, but also circumstance. So here he's really following Unamuno.

1.74 But he stresses something else. He says, "But also, part of the circumstances is not looking at how things are now, but looking at how I got here, and how we got here." In other words, the historical perspective is vital. I cannot understand humanity, myself or anyone else. I can't understand the world around me without understanding how it came about, how we got here, without seeing it historically.

1.75 And so he says, "This is what I call vital reason." Vital reason, because it has to do with life, and life cannot be understood without understanding the dynamics of it, the way that it developed, the way we got here. So he says, "That is something that I have to think about with respect to my own life, as well as everything around me."

1.76 Now, here he outlined something in part that he's influenced by Heidegger and Husserl and others in the phenomenological camp. But he articulates it, I think, very beautifully and much more clearly than they ever do. He says, "Our existence is at every instant primarily the consciousness of what is possible to us." In other words, in thinking about my life, I don't just think about what has happened to me or what I am now. He says, "Too often, philosophers just say, 'What are you now?' Well, that's really a very limited perspective. Thinking about how I got here is vital. I've got to understand that."

1.77 But he says, also, "How do I think about my own life?" It's not really in terms of how I got here; it's what I'm going to do in the future. I'm looking at the range of possibilities open to me, and I'm thinking about how to decide what the rest of my life should be like. So he says, "To say that we live is the same as saying we find ourselves in this atmosphere of definite possibilities," what Heidegger called our horizon. This range of possibilities, that's crucial to our understanding of who we are. It's not just what I've been and what I am at this moment; it's what I could be, all of those things.

1.78 He says, "That's what I'm calling my circumstances." It's not just where I've been and where I am; it's where I could go. That is absolutely vital. If you want to think of this as the world, think of the world as the sum total of our vital possibilities. Not just what's happening right now and the way the world is right now, not even its past and how we got here, but think of how things could be, that modal aspect, what's possible for us. That's vital to understanding the world. That's a crucial part of the world.

1.79 He says, "Well, then, to feel your own existence and have a sense of living a human life is to constantly confront that liberty, but also the bounds around that liberty." I think, "Here's what I'm doing and acting. I am looking at that range of possibilities in front of me, and I'm making choices among them." When I make a choice, I'm narrowing that field. You might say, life consists of having a very broad field of possibilities that gradually gets narrowed through our own choices until, at the moment of our death, those choices collapse, and there's no more future.

1.80 And by the way, that's a rather depressing view of human life. But nevertheless, that's vital. We think about ourselves in terms of what we're capable of doing, what we're going to do in the future. And we decide, in other words, what we're going to be. So we have, from one point of view, this huge freedom. My life is a matter of choosing from this huge

range of possibilities. But he says, it is, from another point of view, bounded. After all, not all the things that could be, even for any human being, are available to me. The older we get, the fewer and fewer of those we are.

1.81 I mean, maybe at one point I could have decided to become a professional baseball player, but I'm not going to work now. I'm way too old for that. There are other kinds of lives I could have led, but too late to make those choices. And so he says, "My freedom is bounded partly by the decisions I've made in the past, but partly by other kinds of things, partly by just what I can do and what I can't do, my own abilities, but partly because, well, I live in certain circumstances."

1.82 I could not decide I want to be a 17th-century goatherd. I couldn't decide I want to be a Roman consul. I couldn't decide that I would really love to be the person who discovered the theory of relativity. Sorry, too late. I can't do any of those things. I can't decide to be a Starship captain. Well, maybe. I live in Austin. If I hung out with Elon Musk enough, maybe I could become a Starship captain. But anyway, yeah, these things are not really available to me.

1.83 So, our lives are dramas, in which we confront the bounds of these choices, partly internally imposed by our own capacities, partly by what's available to us in the world, in our own time and place and so on. And I make choices from among that wide, but nevertheless restricted set of choices. That's what life is. Now, when I'm doing that, I'm not only choosing to limit my perspective in a certain way and actualize certain potentials, I am also adopting a certain perspective. I am seeing things from a certain point of view, and I'm adopting a certain point of view in making that choice.

1.84 So he says, "Look, I am not a relativist. I'm not saying, 'Oh, truth is just truth for you or truth for us, or something like that.'" He's saying, "No, there is such a thing as absolute truth, but my perspective on it is always a partial truth." I'm always giving you a glimpse, and it's very rare that there's just nothing true in how I see things. Maybe it's a complete illusion and so on. But ordinarily, I'm seeing something that's partly right but incomplete.

1.85 So he says, "I am not talking about this view," the cynical who just says, "Well, in the end, if we disagree, there's nothing; maybe that's true for you and false for me," and certain things are like that. I say I like mushrooms, my wife doesn't. There's no arguing about this. There's no reaching agreement and so on. It's just you like them, I don't. That's it. Sometimes, maybe there are disagreements that are like that.

1.86 But the relativist says everything's like that. It's just a matter of taste. He's saying, "No, it's not." For example, we can disagree—a real disagreement that my wife and I had. We visited an apartment building years and years ago. I said it was brown brick. She said, "No, it was yellow brick." We argued about it all the way through lunch, so much so that we drove back by to see: "What was it?" Why was I saying it was brown, and she was saying it was yellow? It turned out, as we walked up there, there were two big columns, brick, and the one on the right—that was the side I was looking at—was brown, the one on the left was yellow. It was both brown and yellow. It's still there, by the way; you can find it on Google Maps. Yes, that's the way it looks, even today.

1.87 Then we were like, "Oh, now I see it from your point of view." Sometimes you can do that. If one blind man says, "It's like a rope," and the other says, "No, it's like a wall," well, get over here and feel this. You can see it from the other person's point of view. None of these

views are arbitrary. None are merely a mental construction. They aren't matters of taste. They're really the way it looks from that point of view. And so, he says, "Yeah, sometimes you look at a house, and it looks one way from one side, another way from another side, but it's the same house," in this case, the Stuart Gilbert house in Philadelphia.

1.88 Yeah, you'd like to see the house. Well, you can walk around it and so on. You could even take a helicopter and fly over it if you want. You can see it from different points of view. You're going to learn more and more about the house if you do this. You can tour it and go inside and see it from the inside. But there's no one place you can stand and see it from all possible points of view at once. So, that tells us the absolute truth is not a perspective, at least not a humanly occupiable perspective. God can occupy it, let's say, but nobody else can.

1.89 And so we inevitably see the world from human perspectives. We cannot see it from the perspective of eternity. We can't see it from God's point of view. But still, we can get better and better and approach the truth more. Why or how? Well, why? Because it is available to us from different partial perspectives, and they can lead us to approach the truth. Also, we can see things from other points of view. OK, again, the landscape—we can move around the house and see it from different points of view. The same thing is true of an ordinary object. We can look at it from different points of view. The same thing is true of other people. We can see them in different kinds of settings, in different kinds of contexts. We can learn more and more about that person.

1.90 How can I find out about the world? Well, I can travel, for example, and see it from different points of view, or I could read literature. I can study history. I can do all sorts of things to try to understand how people in different times, in different places, or even right now, but seeing things from a different point of view can actually have a partial truth.

1.91 To some extent, he, like Unamuno, is standing in the center of things, saying, "Look, you're all kind of right and all kind of wrong." Try to see things from other points of view. Read history, read literature, and talk to other people. Travel, try to understand how different cultures, how different people see things. You're going to sometimes say, "I think that's fundamentally wrong." That's a really narrow, mistaken point of view, primarily. Still, there is likely to be an element of truth somewhere in it.

1.92 He says, "You're going to get better and better and closer and closer to the absolute truth, the more of these perspectives you consider, and the more you entertain." So you will never be in the position of seeing things from God's point of view. That little dot, incidentally, you're seeing there is Earth from the perspective of the rings of Saturn. That's impressive. You can't really see it from that point of view, except through photographs like that. But you can see life and the world from as many different perspectives as possible.

1.93 It's true even of self-understanding. You can see more and more about yourself by seeing what you do and how you think and feel about things in different kinds of circumstances throughout your life. So, as you do that, you get closer to the absolute truth. You can never fully attain it, but you can get closer. You can do a better job.

1.94 However, there are things that endanger that. In "The Revolt of the Masses," a few years later, he begins to be a bit less optimistic because, in "The Modern Theme," his view is, "Look, the relativists have gone way too far." They've suggested in the end, there's no way to sort out any of these disagreements rationally. It's just true for you or true for me.

And so, in the end, if we're going to settle anything, we have to fight. He's saying, with his perspectivism, that's not true. We can understand each other. We can understand other perspectives. We can get a better view of the world and a richer view of the world.

1.95 But by the time he writes "The Revolt of the Masses"—and keep in mind, in those intervening years, those were the years that Spain was leading into civil war and things were becoming very dangerous—he was saying, "I think people aren't doing that." And there's a tendency away from the absolute truth, actually. People aren't willing to see things from other points of view. He sees danger all around him. Here's the reason. He says, "Mass communication has changed things fundamentally. It's made people less willing and less likely to see things from different perspectives and to, in that way, get closer and closer to the truth."

1.96 Now, here's what happens. Mass media are producing a certain kind of person. He refers to this as "the mass man" at some points, or as "Mr. Satisfied." But it's not really meant to be gender-specific. The idea is, this person is just satisfied with their life. I mean, they're at ease from a material point of view. They have what they need, and they don't have to think very hard about things. They don't have to work all that hard to survive. And so, they just absorb the ideas of the people around them. They just absorb the narrative of the mass media, whatever it is.

1.97 And this produces in a society a kind of conformity. Everybody just goes along. "Hey, did you read in the newspaper that blah, blah, blah?" Everybody hears it. Everybody just parrots back the line. And it threatens individuality. It threatens dissent. It threatens excellence, he thinks, and it threatens the search for truth. Why bother to listen to other people and get different perspectives? You're told what's true. Just pay attention. And so, this person doesn't really care to give reasons. They don't even care so much about being right. They're simply resolved to impose their opinions on others. Hey, this is what everybody's saying. They just go with the common wisdom. They just go with the narrative and repeat it.

1.98 And so, he starts by saying, from one point of view, this looks like the triumph of populism. "There's one fact that's of utmost importance in European life now. That's the accession of the masses to complete social power." But it turns out, well, it's not much power, in a sense, because the masses are just absorbing the idea from mass communication. And so, yes, the masses have great power, but on the other hand, they're just being led around by this story.

1.99 So he says, from one point of view, "We're witnessing the triumphs of hyperdemocracy, the masses acting directly outside the law." And that is one thing he sees as a serious symptom that something has gone wrong. It's one thing for people to have a certain set of ideas, and for them to have a large agreement in society, and to seek reform through the law. But, he says, I see people increasingly acting outside the law, willing to engage in violence against the people on the other side, willing to kick people like Unamuno out of their positions, and eventually to assassinate them. He says that's a very dangerous place to be, because all of a sudden, people are saying, "I don't have to wait. I don't have to convince other people. I don't have to try to see it from your point of view and talk this through and persuade you. Instead, I just steamroll over you. I just find direct ways of trying to get what I want."

- 1.100** Now, he says that changes things fundamentally. The old democracy, you might say the republic, was one where there was, yes, the voice of the people having an important role, but also there was a generous dose of liberalism, by which he means classical liberalism. In other words, a respect for freedom, a respect for liberty, and an enthusiasm for the rule of law. That constrains individual actions. It makes us be disciplined, saying, "Well, I want this. I think people are crazy not to see it my way, but I'd better try to persuade them. I've got to try to work within the law to actually bring this about."
- 1.101** In that way, minorities, not only just ethnic or racial minorities, but people who are in the minority on a position, who see the majority against them, well, they can still live and act in some way. They're protected by the rule of law. And so, there are human rights respected, human liberties respected. Democracy and law work together. He says, "Now, I see all that being threatened. People are too impatient. They don't want to see things from other points of view. They think they already know what's right." And so he says, "There's something very dangerous about this. The mass feels its own omnipotence, but also its attitudes are ephemeral." In other words, there's the passion of the moment.
- 1.102** You can see this today in social media. In fact, I think if Ortega had seen social media, he might be even more appalled than he was in the 1930s because, all of a sudden, this is the thing. Everybody's concerned about this. Everybody has, in their little Facebook tag, some symbol to indicate, "I'm with the prevailing sentiment of the moment." But then a month later, it's something new and so on. He said people just start going along. They're just drifting along. Somebody says, "Hey, pay attention to this." They're like, "Oh, yeah, that's the thing." And so, they are led by emotion, but on the other hand, that's not a good thing. They're not constrained by the rule of law or by a need for persuading other people.
- 1.103** He says, "The same thing has been happening in education as has been happening in mass media." So it used to be that people were educated in the classics of the past. They knew history and they knew great literature, and they could see things from different points of view. They could say, "Well, here's how Virgil or Homer would have thought about this. Here is how other people would have thought about this. Dante would think this," and blah, blah, blah. Now, people don't do that. They're given tools for manipulating this society from a technical point of view and for getting a job, but they aren't really taught the fundamental ideas of civilization.
- 1.104** Now, notice, he's already saying this almost 100 years ago. When contemporary people say this, I think, "Yeah, people have been shouting this for a century, and it hasn't really done a lot of good." But he was one of the first to notice, "Wait a minute, education is changing. We've stopped teaching these classics, and we're starting to just teach people to get a job."
- 1.105** That's a dangerous thing. It's not that it's bad to get a job. It's just that these people are now placed in a civilization they don't understand. They don't get the fundamental ideas, and they can't see things from different points of view. They're stuck in their own point of view, and they can't say, "Well, yeah, in ancient Greece, they had this idea that blah, blah, blah, and then the Romans came along." No, they just see things from a contemporary point of view, given their place and time.
- 1.106** And so, they're faced with a complex society that actually they only know how to maneuver in, but they don't understand what built it. He said lots of things could be blamed

for this, not just education or mass communications, but material ease. People don't have to confront the hard realities of life very often in a modern society. They live longer, they have greater freedom. There aren't really social barriers of the kind that used to exist. So they have a much greater realm of possibilities. And from one point of view, given this sort of perspective on life, that should be a great thing, right? Look how open my future is.

1.107 But he says, what really gives life meaning is having a purpose. And if it becomes too wide open, you lose that sense of purpose. How do you possibly choose? And so he says, "All of this is placing in danger the principles to which our entire civilization owes its existence." In 30 years, we're going to revert back to barbarism. It actually only took about, well, less than 10. But nevertheless, he's seeing we're in danger, because people no longer understand their own civilization. They can't see things from different points of view.

1.108 He says, "You would think maybe we can appeal to the best and brightest, get us away from the rule of the masses." But he says that's actually worse. They're the ones who most absorb the narrative. They're the ones who pay attention to what the media are saying. They know what the mass media narrative is better than anyone. And so, they are maybe the least to be trusted with a real firm grasp on reality.

1.109 Moreover, all of these people, the masses, and this group who consider themselves the best and the brightest, have even more radical desires than in the past, but also a deep ingratitude. They don't understand what got them there. And so, he says, they haven't developed the virtues that reality used to force us to develop. The result is that this whole magnificent edifice could disappear very, very quickly. People are basically spoiled.

1.110 They start thinking that all of the things that are there, that promote their own well-being, are just natural rights that come from heaven, rather than things that people have fought for and earned over the centuries. They don't understand those battles. They don't understand the very foundations of the things they rely on and that make their lives good. And so he said, "In the disturbances caused by a scarcity of food, the mob goes in search of bread; the means it employs is generally to wreck the bakeries." Why? Because they don't understand that's where the bread comes from.

1.111 They destroy the very ideas, the very institutions, that give rise to everything good about their lives. So, as a result, they become barbarians, barbarians in the sense that they give up values. They become cynics or relativists or skeptics or nihilists. He says, "If you're unwilling to submit to any norm, you have, willingly or unwillingly, submitted to the norm of denying all morality." That's not just amoral, it is immoral. And so he looks around and says, "Everybody's living as if none of the rules apply to them." That makes their lives empty, and they feel that spiritual emptiness, but also it makes them more and more willing to engage in terrible kinds of acts. And so, increasingly, they are willing to impose very harsh measures on others. That absence of standards or of norms, that's what barbarism is.

1.112 Here's the story I've tried to tell you today. Unamuno says, "I see a group of people who have this reductive, narrow understanding of what it is to be human and, in consequence, are willing to treat human beings merely as means to their own ends."

1.113 Benda says, "I see an entire group of people who are doing that, and doing it with the goal of destroying this society around them." Then the idea is, oh, magically somehow, it will be

replaced by something better, but they're willing to actually engage in this and train the leaders to come to hate their own societies and to try to revolutionize them.

1.114 Then Ortega says, "Moreover, that group claims to be speaking for the masses, but actually, they aren't." They're feeding, through art, through movies, through literature, through mass media, the masses telling them what to think, and the masses have been educated to go along. So, actually, we're in a really bad place, where people no longer understand their civilization, no longer trust its values or its rules, no longer obey the bounds, and are willing to do whatever this group tells them to do. Next time, then, the rise of totalitarians. Thank you.

1.115 I guess with Unamuno, Benda, and Ortega, my question is, these gentlemen seem to have a very different philosophical view in terms of not just being reductionists, not just being more, or not really rational-based, looking more at the full view. I find it interesting that two of them are Spaniards, one of them is a Frenchman. Geographically, it's very different than what you see a lot of the other philosophers saying. I'm wondering if you can comment on that, especially how that reflects in what's going on in the world at this point, because if you look at Russia right now, it's falling apart at this point. They're almost predicting what's going to happen on it. It's probably not a very good-worded question, but geographically, why the difference?

1.116 Yeah, that's an intriguing question. As I see it, they're all trying to hold the center together and feeling as if their societies are being torn apart. It's fairly easy to understand why somebody in Spain would feel that way. Spain had a long tradition, an intellectual tradition, an artistic and literary tradition, that was, in a sense, really being changed dramatically by extreme forces. And so, here are people who are grabbing onto the middle, saying, "Look, I'm trying to hold things together," and yet feeling that the falcon is getting further and further away and they can't call it back. In the end, Unamuno gave his life as a result of all that.

1.117 So, they're in positions where they see the danger. But unlike people in Russia or in Germany, it hadn't yet, or for that matter in Italy, it hadn't yet gone over to the extremists. That center, by the time they're seeing this, there wasn't much of a voice coming from the center in the countries that were a bit further ahead in the drift toward totalitarianism.

1.118 In places like England, you see the groups that are exemplifying what they're saying, but seemingly, without much self-consciousness. They have a moral view of things, they're not complete cynics, but for example, the Bloomsbury group, they say, well, the highest goods of human life are simply aesthetic appreciation and social interaction. So friendship and the appreciation of art and beauty—that's what really matters in human life. Well, they do matter in human life, but that leaves out a huge amount. So I see, basically, the intellectuals in England whistling past the graveyard, saying, "Everything's fine."

1.119 In fact, here would a traffic way of putting it. Intellectuals in Italy and Germany are seeing the yellow light flashing, and they're hitting the gas pedal. They want to go on through. Here in France and Spain, the people seeing the light flashing are trying to hit the brake, saying, "Look, stop this. Stop this race to extremism." In England, they don't even see the yellow light. They're just like, "Hey." Why that intellectual—I think it was partly that Germany and Italy were already too—there wasn't much of a center left, and the few who were there decided, "It's time to leave, because we lost."

- 1.120** That battle was still taking place, and it still seemed possible to hold it together in France and Spain. In England, the danger really wasn't seen yet. Here, I've got to say, I think there's a part of your question that I don't understand at all. It's not that I don't understand the question; I don't understand the answer, because Churchill is the lone voice in England throughout that entire period who is seeing this kind of danger and trying to warn everybody about it.
- 1.121** But the leaders on both sides, on both of the dominant parties, are just saying, "We should disarm. And yeah, we were unfair to Hitler before, at the Treaty of Versailles, so sure, let him build up his army. Oh, he's taken that region back over and he's sent troops into the Rhineland. Well, we messed up with that treaty, so whatever." And they really don't see the danger. They are convinced it's fine. Yeah, he has some grievances, but we're taking care of it, and it'll be all good. It was very naive. But how they could be that naive, in retrospect, seemed shocking.
- 1.122** But I think, even when you try to think yourself back into that time, things were happening all around them. I mean, look what was happening in Russia, look what happened in Italy, and look what was well on its way to happening in Germany. They continued to fiddle while half of Europe was burning. I don't understand it.

2. Disintegrating This World

- 2.1** Now I want to talk about Disintegrating This World, or maybe more prosaically, the rise of totalitarianism. We're going to look at the rise of these movements in Italy and maybe not the origin, but nevertheless, the perfection or the extreme version that arose in Russia, and then what happened in Germany. So, I want to think about not just the intellectual conditions that led to the rise of totalitarianism— that was our focus last time—but instead, think about the ideology of those who were the totalitarians themselves.
- 2.2** Let's start in Italy and think about the rise of Mussolini. Who was Mussolini? He started out as a socialist journalist. He was the editor of the Future of the Worker, and he became the leader of the Italian Socialist Party. He took over the government of Italy in 1922 after the March on Rome. Italy was badly weakened by World War I. It was an ally of France and Britain and the United States.
- 2.3** We don't really think a whole lot about that front in the war, but there were battles, very bloody, very costly battles throughout the war between Italy and the Austro-Hungarian Empire. They took huge numbers of lives on both sides, badly weakened both the Empire, which fell, and also the Italian government. In a sense, people were very dissatisfied, and Mussolini simply took power by force, not even so much force of arms, but just a popular movement that descended on Rome and shut down the city and demanded different leadership.
- 2.4** He ran for re-election in 1924, and when he was re-elected, he then discouraged dissent through violence and intimidation. So throughout, he seized power outside the general legal means of doing that. He did actually submit to elections then, but as soon as he was re-elected, he forgot about the rule of law and engaged in violence against opponents,

intimidated them. In a sense, that's what the March on Rome had been about from the very beginning. He then declared himself il duce, "the leader," the person who was in charge of everything in the government. Then he adopted fascism as his reigning ideology. It was there all along, but really, at this point, it was articulated most clearly.

2.5 Now, what is fascism? We hear that word all the time, used as a political insult. In fact, just today, I read an article on the evolution of the meaning of the word and how we've gotten here, basically from a certain form of social and political organization, to then anyone who tries to control somebody else's life, to anyone who imposes restrictions on anyone else, to now anybody who disagrees with anyone else, and so on. That thing isn't a new phenomenon. It is something that has been going on almost since the origins of the term.

2.6 This is George Orwell writing about the use of the word fascism decades ago, in fact, in the 1940s, and already by then, he was saying, "The word 'Fascism' is almost entirely meaningless. In conversation, it's used even more wildly than in print. I've heard it applied to farmers, shopkeepers, Social Credit, corporal punishment, fox-hunting, bull-fighting, the 1922 Committee, the 1941 Committee, Kipling, Gandhi, Chiang Kai-shek, homosexuality, Priestley's broadcasts, Youth Hostels, astrology, women, dogs, and I don't know what else. Except for the relatively small number of fascist sympathizers, almost any English person would accept 'bully' as a synonym for 'fascist.'" That's about as near to a definition as this much-abused word has come. So the abuse isn't new. It's been going on for at least 80 years.

2.7 Why? Well, what is fascism? If you look at historians, they give you long lists of characteristics of various fascist movements. Many of them have to do with particular movements in particular countries and don't really generalize. In fact, much of what historians say about this doesn't even apply to Mussolini's Italy, which is where the term originated. That seems to me bad. Here, I've tried to isolate some of the ones that I think do apply pretty generally to fascist movements.

2.8 What are some common elements? One is the idea of a vanguard party. Power is to be concentrated in the hands of the party, and it's a party that is supposed to lead and not only lead the country, but also be the ones who are the revolutionary leaders. They are the vanguard in the sense that they're out ahead of everybody else.

2.9 It is an authoritarian movement. It believes in violence and militarism. It is a movement that stresses an ultra-nationalism, a veneration of the state, not just a patriotism and respect for and admiration for the state, but really a veneration of it, the state as expressing the true essence of humanity. Then, it favors a corporatist or mixed economy, some elements of free enterprise, but large elements of state control.

2.10 What is its enemy? It opposes democracy, certainly. That conflicts with this idea that a vanguard party is supposed to have all political control. It opposes individual rights and liberties—that violates the authoritarian nature of it. It opposes the free market and capitalism, but it also opposes communism. It wants a mix of these things, in fact, heavy government control, but also some degree of free enterprise. In fact, often fascists consider themselves the third way because they are a mixture of communist and socialist and free market elements. And it opposes conservatism. It wants a radical reformulation and reevaluation of things, so it considers itself a radical extremist movement.

- 2.11** If you think about what it opposes then, you can actually think about the American Bill of Rights and see how every single one, for example, of the first 10 amendments, are things that fascists would reject. Freedom of speech, for example, freedom of religion? No, no, no. Freedom of assembly? Certainly not. Right to keep and bear arms? Definitely not. What about the right to have due process apply to you if you're accused of wrongdoing? No. No cruel and unusual punishment? Certainly not. And so on. Every single one of those would be rejected by the fascist.
- 2.12** How did Mussolini get there? His parents were socialists and anarchists. He was deeply influenced by Marx, but also by Nietzsche. So, one way of looking at Mussolini is that he's a combination of a variety of different influences. One of them is Marx, who heavily influenced him. One of them is Nietzsche. Then one is someone I'll get to in a moment, George Sorel, who preached a doctrine of revolutionary syndicalism. But Marx, he considered the most important. He said, "Marx is the father and teacher, the magnificent philosopher of working class violence." So, he considers himself, at least in his younger days, a Marxist.
- 2.13** So, the first thing to notice about fascism in its roots here is that it is a form of socialism. Now, it's a particular form, but it is a form of socialism. What is socialism? Here is a definition that I've adopted from Hayek, a definite opponent of socialism, but nevertheless, somebody who had a very broad view of the movement in different aspects. He defines socialism as "a system of social and economic organization that places key institutions under centralized conscious direction toward consciously chosen ends." So that idea of central decision making, of consciously figuring out what to do as a society, and then selecting the ends we adopt, the means to be sought, and so on, and doing that in a conscious, intentional, and centralized way, that's really what he takes as fundamental to socialism.
- 2.14** If you think about why you would think about things that way, think about an individual decision making, especially with respect to a complex problem. You think: what am I trying to accomplish? What situation am I facing? How do I go about doing it? What's my goal? How do I get there? That rational process that we engage in as individuals, that's something that the socialist says the society should do as something like an individual. So think of the society as one individual, one organism, let's say. It should behave rationally. It should choose its ends. It should choose the means to the ends and pursue that in a rational and centralized, directed way.
- 2.15** What is communism then? It does all of that. It is such a system of social and economic organization. It places key institutions under centralized, conscious direction toward consciously chosen ends. But now it has a particular means that it recommends through centralized state ownership and control. Socialism itself could accept many different mechanisms of social decision making and social direction. However, the idea that the state should own the means of production, there should be no private property in that sense, no private ownership of means of production, and then that direct control, that's what communism is. It is a form of socialism that is, as it were, a highly direct form of socialism.
- 2.16** Then what is fascism? It's a more indirect form. It wants a combination of things. It says we could do it through direct state ownership and control or various forms of indirect

direction through indirect direction—it sounds like an oxymoron. But anyway, the idea was we could regulate. We could have the government select the directors of companies. We could have government-management labor boards. We could have people involved in government who were simply closely connected to leaders of industry and cooperate with them mutually to achieve these common ends.

- 2.17** In short, what happened in Mussolini's Italy is that about 75% of Italian industry was nationalized. It was, as it were, 75% communism, 25% free enterprise. But it was a mixture of these things. People were allowed to keep their private companies but had to work very closely with the government on these joint government, private enterprise boards.
- 2.18** One thing is then it is a form of socialism, but a less extreme form than communism. The communists certainly considered the fascists right wing simply because there was some element of free enterprise, some respect for liberties in the mix. It was not totally direct control. Then, it was nationalist, so communism is typically internationalist in focus. On the other hand, the fascist is nationalist.
- 2.19** Mussolini made a change in his earlier Marxism when he saw Lenin's policies in Russia after the 1917 Revolution and said that the result of that is a disaster. He's virtually destroyed agriculture and industry in Russia. He said there's something fundamentally wrong. This isn't just a failure of individual policies. There's an intellectual failure behind it. It's a failure ideas. He said this whole idea of class struggle in Marx—Marx says that's what the whole history of the world is about. But what if he's wrong about that? What if that's only one of the things it's about? It's also about lots of other things.
- 2.20** In particular, what if he's wrong about the materialism? Maybe it's not all a matter of people's material circumstances. Maybe it's not all economic motivations. In fact, he says, there are different classes, and it is true that there's much struggle going on between the bourgeoisie and the proletariat, the industrialists and the workers. But what if we get them to work together? What if, instead of saying the solution to that is to abolish the bourgeoisie by abolishing private property, instead we say, "Guys, let's have a goal we can both work toward. Can't we all get along?"
- 2.21** He said, "But what could such a goal be?" I mean, profits, that's going to appeal only to the industrialists, not to the workers. But hey, some dignity of work, that's going to appeal to the workers, but not to the industrialist. However, they're both within the country. So we can unify them, get them beyond these divisions, beyond class conflict by unifying them. The most natural thing to unify them, to serve as a common goal is the state itself.
- 2.22** The communists could say it is the humanity that's at stake. Marx talks about moving beyond civil society to socialize humanity in the "Theses on Feuerbach." But Mussolini would say, "I don't see how that's going to work. Come on, we're both human beings. That's not going to be enough to bring labor and management together. But to say, 'you're both Italian,' or 'you're both German,' or 'you're both this or that,' that can unify people." The nation, patriotism, that can unify in a way that simply, "Hey, we're all human," can't.
- 2.23** And so, he says that Marx is making a fundamental mistake by thinking the solution to that conflict between the bourgeoisie and the proletariat is to just eliminate the bourgeoisie. Instead, give them something that encompasses both, that is larger, but still something with which people can identify, namely the state. So it is nationalist.

- 2.24** It also encourages violence. Violence is a fundamental part of this because the idea, as we'll see, is that the state has to have all power in principle, and so it cannot respect the rule of law. Mussolini advocates vanguard minorities: a small, trained, dedicated elite, much like Lenin's elite, to raise the consciousness of the proletariat, but then eventually to direct people toward that larger goal. He says that violence is going to be necessary. Prepare the proletariat for the greatest bloodbath of all. Actually, in Italy, it turned out it didn't take as much violence as Mussolini predicted partly because the country was so badly weakened after the First World War. The government had lost so much respect from so many people. It was not hard to actually take it over with a minimum of violence.
- 2.25** But now, something that is, I think, a fundamental factor in fascism: there is an underlying philosophical idealism. What I mean by that is a belief that reality really comes down to perception. That is to say that everything depends on the mind and that what we think of as objective reality is entirely shaped by our own perceptions of it. There's an emphasis on narratives, on symbols, on propaganda. This is a deviation from Marx, too. Marx said it all comes down to material circumstances. Mussolini is saying, no, if anything, it all comes down to ideas. It all comes down to the story that people accept and that controls their behavior. What we have to do is shape the narrative, shape the story, give people symbols to look up to, and have a propaganda network to make sure everybody's together with the program. Everybody absorbs the ideas.
- 2.26** Here is where he's following Sorel, this French Marxist philosopher who was the revolutionary syndicalist, he wrote a book in 1908 called "Reflections on Violence," where he not only advocates violence as a political tool of liberation, but stresses the power of social myths, of narratives, of telling the right story. He says, here's what people do. They, in part, respond to pressure. They respond to violence, especially. You want to be effective in using pressure to control people and to push them to your side? The best way to do it, really, is to force them using violence.
- 2.27** But he said that you may not have to resort to that because actually you can do a huge amount through persuasion. But I don't mean reason. Reason doesn't persuade people. In fact, what persuades them is absorbing a narrative, seeing themselves as part of a certain story. That's not a matter of persuasion. It's just a matter of getting them to see the world and see themselves as characters in this story. You have to give them a role. You have to tell the story in the right way so that they see themselves as part of the story. That's how you influence people.
- 2.28** It's a way that involves not—I mean, there is an element of rational persuasion there, but there's also a very large element of just the use of symbols, the use of myths, of telling a certain story. So, it is an idealist version, you might say, of a nationalist socialism, and then it is utterly totalitarian. All of this goes to the extreme. Not ownership—it's not direct ownership where it would become a form of communism, but it is totalitarian.
- 2.29** In fact, Mussolini's slogan is, "Everything within the state, nothing outside the state, nothing against the state." If the state is what unifies all of the social classes, then it has to be really the only thing that can command people's allegiance. That means everything outside the state has to be destroyed. In particular, there should be no individuals or groups. That means no political parties, no cultural associations, no economic unions, no social classes, no religious organizations or anything like that outside the state. There is

the government, there is the individual, that is it. Even the individual shouldn't be recognized as an individual, but simply as a member of the state.

2.30 The philosophy is something he elaborated with the help of someone known as the philosopher of fascism, Giovanni Gentile. He wrote and was a hidden co-author of the doctrine of fascism. Gentile described his own view as actual idealism. He thought, yes, everything depends on minds, on perceptions. But he said, there are no individual minds. That's a weird combination of things. Everything depends on the mind and there is no mind. You find that combination of views in certain forms of Buddhism. But he means something really different. In Buddhism, it's a way of saying everything is really mental, but there's no such thing as a mind. There are only individual thoughts, feelings, and perceptions. Then somehow, some of them get bundled into what we call a mind, but it's an atomistic view.

2.31 Gentile is the opposite of that. He says right, everything depends on the mind, but there are no minds. Why? Because each thing we call a mind is part of a larger network. Really, there is just that network. There is everyone as part of this society, as part of this state. The minds are really just nodes in the mental unit, a mental fabric that is the state. So liberty is found only in the state, and the state is the only authority. Fundamental to fascism is the character, is the totalitarian character of its doctrine.

2.32 Mussolini echoes that thought: "The Fascist conception of the State is all embracing; outside of it, no human or spiritual values can exist." So it is something that is utterly totalitarian in the sense that it commands the allegiance of everyone in every aspect in that society. What does it reject? Yes, not only free enterprise, it rejects the internationalism, for example, of communist movements or other globalist-type movements. It rejects the rule of law, rejects materialism, and so traditional Marxism, but also rejects realism, and so rejects anything that has a role for tradition or the constraints of the real world. It rejects individualism, any conception of liberty, individual rights or individual freedoms.

2.33 He says, "Outside history, man is a nonentity. Fascism is opposed to all individualistic abstractions." That means he's criticizing here John Locke, David Hume, Adam Smith, the American founders. He's saying, down with all of that. All of those oppose fascism. Fascism says: don't tell me about the pursuit of happiness, don't tell me about natural rights and liberties. All that is nonsense. They're abstractions. No, fascism opposes all of that stuff. It reasserts the rights of the state as expressing the real essence of the individual. That is key, where we've got people like Unamuno and Ortega saying that the individual person has dignity in their own concrete circumstances and reality. The fascist is saying no, the individual is just a node in a fabric. They have no individual value at all. Their value is purely as part of the fabric.

2.34 So what is liberty? He says, it's really just the liberty of the state. Your freedom is just to be identified with the liberty of the state. So it opposes the doctrines of classical liberalism. By what he means the tradition from the 18th and 19th centuries of Locke, for example, or Adam Smith or John Stuart Mill that talks about individual human rights and liberties. No, all of that is to be rejected. "If liberalism spells individualism, fascism spells government." All of this is in the government.

- 2.35** Gentile says there are really two concepts of liberty. There is this concept you get from Thomas Hobbes, Locke, Jefferson, Madison, Adam Smith: liberty is rooted in the individual. That opposes the individual to the state. In fact, the problem then becomes: how do we protect the individual from potential tyranny on the part of the state? But Gentile says, "That's not my conception of liberty. The state is your very essence. So the maximum of liberty for you coincides with the maximum force of the state." The freer the state is to pursue its goals, then the freer you are as a member of the state, even if pursuing those goals means imprisoning you or killing you; that is when you're freest.
- 2.36** So the entrance to that concentration camp, labor liberates, work makes you free, Gentile would say, "Yeah, that's what it is. That is the state exercising maximum power over you, and that is your true freedom." Why? Because that's your true essence. Your essence is to be a member of that state and to do what that state commands.
- 2.37** Now, is this a right-wing movement or a left-wing movement? Most people think of fascism as a right-wing movement, and the Bolsheviks certainly considered them right-wingers. They were plainly to the right of people like Lenin and Stalin. But it's still really similar to Marxism in a lot of ways. So, how do we describe it? I think it's a weird question to try to answer, partly because right and left tend to vary so much. I mean, I found in talking to European friends that they tend to use the terms quite differently from most Americans.
- 2.38** There is a problem that over history, different issues have become salient, and so people think of the left and right as defined by certain different issues. But I think right now in the United States, it would be pretty fair to say, here are some of the key things. On the left, people are concerned with the redistribution of wealth. On the right, there's more an emphasis on free enterprise. The left is mostly secularist. The right tends to talk about the importance of religion. The left focuses on equity and group identity or equality of outcomes. Whereas on the right, people talk about individual merit and equal treatment under law.
- 2.39** The left talks about a mistrust of private associations, of private companies for example, whereas the right tends to talk about the significance of that, about the importance of social capital, networks of cooperation, what Burke calls little platoons, these clubs and associations and so on. The left tends to champion a larger government, the right a smaller government. The left wants fewer limitations on government power. The right wants extensive limits on government power.
- 2.40** In all those respects, fascism agrees with the left in contemporary America. So, it's odd to think about it as a right-wing movement in our contemporary scene. Now, sometimes people will say, but maybe instead of thinking of a political spectrum, it's a horseshoe where the ends meet. But that doesn't really make a lot of sense. That already suggests it has to be understood in at least two dimensions, so what are the dimensions, and how does this happen? So, I think it's a weird thing to think about this in those terms, especially when it seems like: where is it like the right? Well, maybe in stressing nationalism, maybe in accepting that military force is important and so on, but there aren't many places.
- 2.41** Now, a more illuminating way maybe to see this is in terms of a bottom-up or a top-down approach to political authority in general. The bottom-up theorist, like John Locke, for example, says that government gets its rights, its freedoms, its powers, its privileges from the people. We have natural rights to life, liberty, and property, for example, and then the

government gets some of those through our voluntary consent. A top-down view says, no, people have no natural rights or liberties. Instead, people get rights or freedoms or powers or privileges from the government. Rights start with the government, and then all rights are really civil rights granted by and subject to the authority of the government. The bottom-up view says, no, people have this inherently as human beings, and then they voluntarily give over certain powers to the government.

2.42 Well, there it's very clear exactly what fascism is. It's plainly a top-down theory. It's communitarian. It says the state is the essence of the individual. It talks about the rights and liberties of government, not the rights and liberties of the individual. It's authoritarian. It doesn't have any use for democracy or the rule of law, and it wants no limits on government power. It doesn't have any conception of limits or checks or balances or rights that are to be protected from government interference. Nothing like that.

2.43 In any case, what did Mussolini want to do in practice? What did he do? He wanted rule by an elite, and so he appointed a National Council of Experts who were to control industry. He established an eight-hour workday. He established a minimum wage. He empowered unions. He put workers' representatives on corporate boards and on government agencies. He established a retirement age of 55—I'm a little late for that. He established a national militia, nationalized any military industries, and by the end, 75% of Italian business. He had a strong progressive tax on capital, seized church property, and in that way, really exerted very extensive power, culturally and economically. He asked for people to donate their jewelry to the state through a Gold for the Fatherland movement, and he established wage and price controls.

2.44 All of that, it was said in the West, made the trains run on time. I'm not sure Italian trains have ever run on time. In any case, a lot of people say yeah, a lot of that really didn't work, but some people think it did. In any event, the effects of this were mixed. Let's just safely say that.

2.45 He did establish a very strong system of propaganda. He took seriously that idea that controlling the narrative is vital. So, he promoted fascism as a wave of the future. All teachers had to swear a loyalty oath to Mussolini. All editors were appointed by Mussolini.

2.46 He created this cult of personality around himself. You often see him up on balconies or on rooftops. He was a relatively small man. He had a huge office, an incredibly huge office, in which he had one small desk at the end. He sat there petting his orange cat, but someone had to walk into this huge space to get to finally talk to Mussolini. You see him often giving speeches with this pose, the chin jutted out and the arm raised like this. He created this cult around himself as the great leader, the one who had to be looked up to who is idolized as the hero of Italy. He would see himself—he would have himself pictured on horseback in military uniforms. Again, with this thing as if he's leading an army. In fact, in the photograph, if you back it up a bit, you see there's somebody there holding the reins of the horse. He couldn't really ride, but it was all done for the sake of propaganda.

2.47 Let's move from Italy to a different form of totalitarianism in Stalin's Russia. It began, of course, with the Russian Revolution in 1917 when Lenin seized power through force. But on the other hand, you might say Lenin wasn't in control for very long. He was for a short time, nationalizing industry, nationalizing agriculture. The result of that, partly as a result of the war and the revolution, but partly through his actions, was a disaster. Iron production,

for example, fell 98% in Russia from the beginning of the war. Agriculture was devastated down to about 13% of what it had been. People were starving. There was widespread starvation. Millions died.

2.48 Shortly after that, he proposed the New Economic Program, allowing people to actually control some of what they were producing, to give them an incentive to actually produce something on their farms, for example. But it never really got implemented. He had a stroke, and by 1924, he was dead.

2.49 It was Joseph Stalin who was his successor, and Stalin's reign far outstripped Lenin's in its brutality. Historian Paul Johnson has said that this was moral relativism in monstrous incarnation. Trotsky had already identified revolutionary morality with revolutionary strategy and tactics. In other words, what's moral is simply what works, what works to promote the revolution. And so if it's a good strategy for the revolution, if it's a good tactic, then it's morally good. There are, in other words, no moral constraints on what the revolutionaries may do. Stalin took that idea very seriously. By 1924, when Lenin died, he had already taken power.

2.50 How did he do it? He posed as a moderate. He also put out a lot of fake photographs of himself, for example, sitting beside Lenin as if they were best buddies. Many of these photographs were doctored. In fact, a few if you look carefully at them, you can realize they're not really sitting on the same bench at all. They are fused together through photographic trickery. But nevertheless, what he did is convince people he was the true heir of Lenin. He was Lenin's best buddy.

2.51 Moreover, he got all the others to suspect them, each other. What he would do is really a tactic that I describe in terms of the movie, "Mean Girls." You say, "Trotsky, did you hear what Bukharin said about you? And Rykov, did you hear what Trotsky and Bukharin are talking about and how you're going to be out of power and probably killed?" He did this and convinced them all that everybody else was conspiring against them and that Stalin was their only friend. So he very cleverly maneuvered people against each other, spread division in this way, and emerged as the obvious successor: the one who was the closest to Lenin, the one who was everybody's buddy.

2.52 Now, in fact, he wasn't at all their buddy. His competitors, chiefly were Trotsky, Zinoviev, Kamenev, and Bukharin. He managed to get all of them out of power within a couple of years, most of them exiled and shortly thereafter, murdered. It was not good to be a friend of Stalin and Lenin in those days. You were about to end up in a very bad place.

2.53 If you look in general at what happened to the members of the Central Committee of the Communist Party in 1917, at the time of the Revolution, it is a pretty shocking set of outcomes. Some people died of natural causes or in war, but a huge number were either imprisoned where they died or were murdered. Go through the list and it's: shot, shot, typhoid fever, shot, civil war, assassinated, shot, et cetera, et cetera. This is true for the entire Central Committee. Almost everyone other than Stalin in the leadership, got killed.

2.54 Stalin, meanwhile, builds up this cult of personality around himself. In fact, it makes Mussolini's look like minor league. He was the Man of Steel, the Granite Bolshevik, the Universal Genius. Statues of Stalin were put up all over the Soviet Union, much larger than life. He asserted his authority over almost every sphere in the Soviet Union, not only every sphere of life, but every sphere of intellectual inquiry.

- 2.55** For example, he said, "I know what the true facts of economics are. I know what the truths of this field are or that field are," and he got rid of anyone who challenged any of that. Here is a Soviet economist, for example, saying, "Our task isn't to study economics, but to change it." Here he's reflecting the last thesis on Feuerbach, where Marx had written, "The philosophers have only interpreted the world. The point is to change it." He said, "Yeah, we're going to do that to economics. We are bound by no laws." Well, sorry, supply and demand really are laws. If you try not to be bound by them, bad things happen.
- 2.56** Really, Soviet science suffered in biology, in meteorology, in all sorts of spheres. About the only ones that were safe were mathematics and physics because Stalin had no views about mathematics and physics. Soviet math, Soviet physics was first-rate all throughout the Soviet Union's history, but every other field was pretty badly corrupted through Stalin's influence.
- 2.57** Now, in the late 1920s, really without any deliberation or even direction from Marx's writings, he decided to collectivize Soviet agriculture. This required taking a large amount from the countryside because he wanted to industrialize the country. So, we need to move many people into the cities and have them engaged in these industrial activities: building factories, building power plants and so on. They're going to need food, so we've got to get more food produced by fewer people out in the countryside. How can we do it?
- 2.58** Well, he decided to collectivize. Part of what drove that was this general emphasis on industrialization. But part of it was Marx saying in the "Communist Manifesto," we'll have to have industrial armies as well as agricultural armies. And part of it was just a poor harvest in 1927, so poor that the peasants wouldn't take paper money for their crops. The government, since it recognized no economic laws, was driving the currency to be virtually worthless. The peasants said, "We're not going to accept those rubles in exchange for our grain. The grain is valuable; rubles aren't."
- 2.59** So people started hoarding food, which led to increased shortages. There was no food in the towns. People were starving. Stalin's response was not the New Economic Program. That was Lenin's response in 1921. Instead, he sent 30,000 armed party workers into the fields to steal the peasants' food. If you're a peasant, what are you going to do if you produce this harvest and then they come and just take it all away from you? You're going to be pretty angry, and you decide, "Next year, what am I going to do? I'm not going to work hard and plant more. I'm going to plant less." So, the harvest in 1928 was even worse.
- 2.60** The Russian government was desperate for cash. People in the towns were desperate for food. The Russians ended up selling off art treasures. In fact, much of what is in our National Gallery in Washington, DC, came from Russia at this time, and Andrew Mellon privately went over and bought up a lot of this art and brought it back to the United States. He set up the National Gallery to show that private philanthropy can outperform government. Sadly, he called it the National Gallery, and so now most people think it's a government institution. But actually, it was Mellon privately who took advantage of this crisis in the Soviet Union.
- 2.61** But now, in 1929, in response to all this going on, this is when Stalin said, the solution, apparently, is to collectivize agriculture. Stop relying on individual peasants. Instead, just have these huge collective farms. The peasants will simply work on the farms. With no

debate at all, he forced 105 million peasants into these collectives. That was three-fourths of the Russian population. Any private farmer, he referred to as a kulak.

2.62 The image he tried to promote is that these kulaks were rich oppressors. But in fact, it was really anybody who owned their own plot of land. You could be a small farmer, barely producing more than you needed for your family, but if you owned a horse, you were a kulak. You owned the land, you were a kulak. So, he declared an all-out offensive against the kulak: "we must smash the kulaks, eliminate them as a class. Liquidate the kulaks as a class!"

2.63 The result of that was a disaster. Leszek Kolakowski, in "Main Currents of Marxism," writes about this and says, "It was probably the most massive warlike operation ever conducted by a state against its own citizens." Absolutely shocking. The results were: more than 10 million people were slaughtered. They simply refused to leave their farms, or they were designated as kulaks and were executed. More than 10 million were transported to Siberia and told they had to farm. Ten million were put in concentration camps because they refused to go.

2.64 Those who actually went along with this program and weren't sent into situations that were certain death, lost all their properties, were in effect enslaved in these grain factories, these collective farms. The result of that was a man-made famine. More than half of all farm animals were slaughtered, and many more died in conditions where you simply could not farm or raise any animals.

2.65 Here's an eyewitness account to illustrate the level of—I don't know what to call it—brutality, idiocy involved in this program. "Barefoot and poorly clad peasants were jammed into railroad cars and transported to regions of Murmansk and the like"—very top of Siberia in the Soviet Union. "Peasants were unloaded into snow about two meters deep. The frost stood at 75 degrees below zero. Without even an ax or a saw, we began building huts from tree branches. In two weeks, all the children sick, and elderly had frozen to death." Imagine trying to farm in those conditions. It was impossible.

2.66 It didn't work. Stalin needed someone to blame. So he began a series of show trials. He accused some mining engineers of sabotage. And this began a general process. Why isn't it working? Because some people are working against it: the wreckers, the hoarders, the saboteurs. And so there were trials of people who were accused of one of these crimes. A 12-year-old son actually testified and demanded the execution of his own father. It was all carefully scripted, carefully orchestrated. The claim or the insistence here was: "Arrest! Try! Shoot!" All of these people ended up being convicted and executed.

2.67 Now, the action shifted to Ukraine. The Ukraine, after all, is the greatest grain-producing region in Europe. It was really what was keeping Russia afloat, to the extent that it was afloat at all during this collectivization. So, since collectivization was not working and it didn't help grain harvest to just accuse mining engineers of sabotage, he demanded more and more grain from Ukrainian farmers. They, in return, refused to release the grain stores. It was a replay of 1929 or even 1927, where they said, "We're not going to accept these worthless rubles for grain that is more and more valuable because we have great shortages. He insisted upon it and sent troops there to seize it.

2.68 The result of that was a massive famine. It's known as the Holodomor. It is not clear how many people died as a result of the Holodomor. Estimates range from 5 to 40 million

people. But it was, in any case, a gigantic disaster, and it was clearly caused. This was not a natural disaster. There was no huge flood or drought or hurricane or something terrible that afflicted the Ukraine. This was entirely human-induced through the direct orders of Stalin.

2.69 Now, we have not talked yet about the rise of Hitler, but in 1934, Hitler realized certain allies of his were becoming too powerful. In what was known as the Night of the Long Knives, he had 5,000 of them murdered in one night. That inspired Stalin. Until then, Stalin had been playing these "Mean Girls" type games to get people out of power and imprisoned. He had been conducting these show trials. He suddenly realized, "Wait, I can just have people shot? Why am I doing all of this? I don't need to do that. I can just order people to be shot."

2.70 So, he had more than 5,000 opponents murdered, partly inspired by Hitler, including including some of the top leaders from the Revolution: Kirov, Zinoviev, Kamenev. And he began secret negotiations with Hitler. He said, "Here is a totalitarian of my own heart."

2.71 Then, another series of show trials for those who were really the top people and the most visible, where he thought, "Maybe I need an excuse to have them shot." He started with Zinoviev, Kamenev, and some others in 1936, but then moved on to Radek and a number of others. In 1938, more of them, the Trial of the Twenty-One. In all of these cases, people confess to the most absurd crimes. Under torture, Krestinsky recanted on the first day of the trial, said, "Actually, I plead not guilty." Then, he came back in the second day and pleaded guilty with a dislocated shoulder, having been severely beaten in his cell overnight. Almost all of them were executed. A few were sent to prison where they soon died.

2.72 What on earth was going on here in what became known as the Great Purge? This is Kolakowski writing about this: think about Lenin's idea that we start with society, having power distributed around it. We eliminate all the power that is outside the party, then concentrate all the power in the party with the revolutionary vanguard, and then push it down to the totalitarian leader himself.

2.73 That's part of what Stalin was doing, actually turning all of this not to forces outside or hostile to the party, but to the party itself. That's what was happening. This was the destruction of the party because anybody in the party could become a rival force to Stalin. So, he wanted all power during that time concentrated in himself. Every potential rival was killed. That was the destruction of the party. That's what the Great Purge really was about.

2.74 Were any of these show trials legitimate? No. There was a Commission of Inquiry set up, headed by philosopher John Dewey from the United States, to ascertain the truth. It concluded in a book called "Not Guilty" that there was no attempt made to ascertain the truth on any of these charges against anyone. The confessions contradicted available facts. They were obviously not true. Trotsky, for example, never plotted anything that he was accused of, neither did the others. All of this was a smokes screen for getting rid of rivals and destroying the party.

2.75 But it wasn't just of those top leaders. It extended far beyond that: 1,500 writers and artists were killed, 27 astronomers. Stalin said there's some contradiction between Marx's theory and sunspots. So any astronomer who had ever written about sunspots was executed. A meteorologist? A dangerous profession to be in. How often have you seen an incorrect

weather forecast? Under Stalin [gestures as if someone is being executed]. "Incorrect forecast?. You said it would be okay for the picnic and it's raining. Pow."

2.76 In general, anybody who was considered an ex-kulak, an anti-Soviet element of any kind, was executed. Four hundred thousand were executed on those grounds alone, plus more than 100,000 Poles in the areas that were controlled by the Soviet Union. That's just the tip of the iceberg. When you look at the Soviet archives that were finally released after the fall of the Soviet Union, it turns out that according to the official numbers, more than a million and a half people during this era were imprisoned. About 700,000 were shot. That's an average of a thousand a day.

2.77 A lot of historians think this is an understatement, that the numbers could be anywhere from just under a million to over two million. We've discovered, subsequently, huge killing fields in the Ukraine that contain 200,000 corpses. The level of murder here is astounding. It went far beyond those people who were the top people in 1917. It is sometimes known as the Great Terror. André Gide wrote, "In 1936,"—mind you, before the worst of the Great Purge. Already by then, he said, "No country today, not even in Hitler's Germany, is the spirit more suppressed, more timid, more servile than in the Soviet Union."

2.78 This extended, by the way, to police, to the administration of justice, to the military. So senior police officers, 90% of prosecutors were murdered, and vast numbers, I mean, tens of thousands of army officers were killed. In the end, maybe as much as 10% of the population was murdered in the Great Purge—anyone who knew anything about the history of the Revolution.

2.79 By the way, you might wonder when Hitler invaded the Soviet Union, why the Soviet Union was in so much trouble and had to retreat, and Hitler came very close to taking Moscow. The answer is: almost all the top leadership had been murdered just a couple of years before. In fact, in the Red Army, 1937, three out of five field marshals, 13 out of 15 commanders, eight out of nine admirals, and so on and so on were killed. So the results of that were disastrous.

2.80 In addition to all those murdered, this is when Stalin created the vast camp now known as the Gulag Archipelago—hundreds of prison camps all throughout the Soviet Union, many of them in Siberia. At certain times, as many as six and a half million people were held in these prisons. There might have even been more than 10 million at certain times, and more than a million and a half people died in them. One brigade commander said during this period, "I'm afraid to open my mouth. Whatever you say, if it's the wrong thing, you're the enemy of the people. Cowardice has become the norm." Nobody dared to speak out.

2.81 In face of these numbers, it can become overwhelming. So, I want to put a human face on this. This is one of the people who was sent to a prison camp, in fact, the worst prison camp by reputation in the system, Kolyma, and died there. He was a Ukrainian poet, professor of English, actually, and literature at a university in the Ukraine. He was seized in the middle of the night, taken away from his family, and sent to Kolyma, where he died not that long afterwards. What was his crime? Partly it was writing poetry in general, in a classical style, not the socialist, realist style that Stalin wanted. But there was one poem in particular, "White Swans," which he wrote in Ukrainian. Now, part of the danger here was writing in Ukrainian rather than Russian. That was a problem. But in addition, the content of the poem.

- 2.82** Here is the poem. This is my translation, so apologies, but nevertheless, I think it gives you something of the feel of the thing that could get you killed. "On the quiet lake where willows faint, the swans splash and paddle, floating in silence. Crossing the waters in summer and autumn, their necks bend like lush vines. When the frost come, resounding like plate glass, the river glazes over. Diving into crystal dreams, the swimmers shatter sheets of ice. Suddenly, fearlessly, the threat of winter. Aquatic quintet, invincible choir. Through snow and thunder, you chant your victory that breaks the ice of despair and unbelief. Be bold, swans. From bondage, from obscurity, a sparkling constellation leads you to a world where foams a whirling ocean of life."
- 2.83** What is that poem about? In the face of it, it's about swans. Swans who are there in an icy river in winter, but managed to break through the ice and have this hope of spring, spring that will further break the ice. "Hey, be bold. Break through. There's a whirling ocean of life out there." But from a commissar's point of view, it's written in Ukrainian. It is not written in appropriate socialist style. The swans are white, the color of the anti-revolutionary during the Russian Revolution. It's implying that we're in the midst of winter. I mean, the things are bad right now, but there's a hope of smashing through this. Oh, dear, this is a call for counterrevolution against the government.
- 2.84** So, as a result of that—and by the way, he was a party member. Draï-Khamara was hardly a revolutionary or a counterrevolutionary. He had no political designs at all. But nevertheless, he writes a poem. And if you're familiar with Greek or Roman pastoral poetry, this is something you could find in that literature. It's following the lead and the patterns of poets like Tibullus, for example, who write this poem. So it's really doing things in that classical style. I don't think he intended to symbolize anything with white swans hoping for spring. But nevertheless, that got him sent out to Kolyma, where he was forced to mine gold without shoes in sub-zero temperatures.
- 2.85** He did write letters back to his family, collected in that book. And the very last letter that he wrote ends this way. It was at this point sent to his daughter. "Write me about your mother. For a long time, I've had no news from her. She's probably very lonely on those Bashkir Steppes. Tell me all about the family in Kiev because I miss them. Be well. I wish everything good for you. Study; be severe with yourself because you're an orphan; your fate is in your own hands." That was the last his daughter ever heard from him.
- 2.86** Why were people like this killed? There was no credible threat. That man and millions like him were no threat to the state. That's one question. Another question is: why did nobody resist this? Why did people go along and agree to be sent to prison camps and so on? Why go after these millions of underlings? Maybe a few people at the top could have been potential rivals to Stalin, but most of those people were no threat of whatever. Why do it? And why then, finally, did Western intellectuals defend all of this? And they did.
- 2.87** Kolakowski writes about the first of those questions: what on Earth was going on here? There was no threat. Why? He said, the whole object of a totalitarian system is to destroy all forms of communal life not imposed by the state. "Nothing outside the state, everything within the state." The point here is you have to isolate individuals. You don't want groups of individuals who trust each other. You want everybody to feel isolated, alone, and vulnerable. The citizen belongs to the state and must have no other allegiances, even family, or even ideology, even the official state ideology.

- 2.88** It might seem paradoxical, but actually, if you know this system, you recognize it. All forms of revolt against this party, all factions, all fights have to do with the ideology of the state. "Hey, this isn't true Marxism. That is true Marxism," etc. You have to establish yourself as the sole custodian of the ideology. Consequently, you got to revise that ideology so nobody quite knows what it is. The thing you say today might get you in big trouble tomorrow. Today, that's the politically correct thing to say. Tomorrow, no, sorry, you are canceled. You are sent to the Gulag for that. You are perhaps even shot for that.
- 2.89** The idea is that faith has to be changeable enough, vague enough, indefinite enough that anybody could be accused of anything at any time for any reason. And so that anything you do, you can say, "But that is true Marxism." There's no real change of doctrine because it was always rather vague, and you're the sole authority for what it really is. Stalin had said in his short course on Marxism—which, by the way, has relatively little to do with Marx's actual writings or theory—but everything depends on the conditions, on the time and the place. Meaning, "Yeah, that might have been the right thing then. In 1917, it's not the right thing now. Hey, that's true Marxism. Change with the times."
- 2.90** Why did nobody resist? Partly because there was nothing they could appeal to. They had gone along with the fake trials, the show trials, the executions, and so forth. By the time we get to them, "But wait, why me? If only Stalin knew what people said." Stalin did know, and he intended this. But to what could you appeal? You had already participated in all this. You had already given the party all authority to make these judgments, and now they're making it about you. You have no ground to stand on. You've got no moral principle to appeal to.
- 2.91** As one person said, "We were all of us up to our elbows in blood. There was nowhere we could stand and say, 'But that's wrong because of this.' We had gone along with it. In fact, we had gone along not only with all that revisionism, with revising the facts, revising the history."
- 2.92** Kamenev and Trotsky were in the original picture right beside Lenin. Then it's republished under Stalin. They're gone. They're just steps now. There's nobody there. Or here, actually in the original, there's Stalin and four other people. Then it's three other people. Then there were two. Then there was one. Then there's just Stalin as those various people got sent off to the Gulag or were convicted in a show trial and executed. Or here this poor fellow right there besides Stalin. Oops, I guess he went overboard. So the history was constantly being revised. The ideology was constantly being revised.
- 2.93** Meanwhile, why did people in the West defend this? Here's Walter Duranty writing in The New York Times. Reports of corpses, of all these executions and so on, he says, "All bunk. Conditions are bad. There's no famine." There's no Great Purge going on. He says, "But—to put it brutally—you can't make an omelet without breaking eggs." So even if there is some, it's worth it in the end. The future lies in Moscow. Well, at this point, we have 100 million broken eggs and no omelet. You might think that's a pretty bad sign. But the whole idea that people can be used to make this eventual utopian omelet is the very thing that Unamuno and Ortega were protesting against.
- 2.94** Now, look at this response of Bertolt Brecht. When his own sister was accused of these crimes, but she pled that she was innocent. They asked Brecht his opinion. He said, "The

more innocent they are, the more they deserve to die." The party is the only authority. He wouldn't defend even his own sister.

2.95 In general, Lionel Trilling wrote about the response of Western intellectuals to all of this. He said, "In any view of the American cultural situation, the importance of the radical movement of the Thirties can't be overestimated. It may be said to have created the American intellectual class as we now know it in its great size and influence. It fixed the character of the class as being through all mutations of opinion, predominantly at the left."

2.96 Why? Because either you had to take a stand against Stalin and point out with honesty what was going on, or you had to go along with it. And once you've gone along with that, where do you draw a line? It is like that, "up to your elbows in blood" thing. Even if you were simply far away, thousands of miles away, writing about it, you would have gone along with that. What are you going to not go along with? So there were what people considered heroic lies.

2.97 Some who wrote about it were clearly fooled by Stalin's Potemkin villages. They were shown things. George Bernard Shaw, for example, was led around, and he saw these model factories and model villages that were created just for Western observers. So Shaw may well have been simply fooled. But many others knew what was going on, and they simply lied. It was simply an untruth. They just thought, "For the sake of the revolution, we must put this out, even though we know it's not true."

2.98 Malcolm Muggeridge wrote a book after visiting Stalin's Russia called "Winter in Moscow." He was one of the only ones who told the truth. He said later, "This will be one of the great puzzles of posterity, looking back on this age, to understand why the liberal mind, the Manchester Guardian mind, the New Republic mind, should feel such enormous sympathy with this authoritarian regime." An interviewer said, "You're implying the liberal intelligence didn't simply overlook the regime's brutality, but actually admired and liked it?" He says, "Yes, I'm saying that. They wouldn't have admitted it, maybe not even to themselves. I remember Beatrice Webb, who was a very cultivated, upper-middle class, liberal-minded person, an early member of the Fabian Society, saying, 'It's true, people disappear in Russia.' She said it was such great satisfaction, I couldn't help thinking there were a lot of people in England whose disappearance she would have liked to organize."

2.99 That is just one example. In the end, Kolakowski, writing about all of this, is amazed as well and says, "Hypocrisy and self-delusion just became the permanent climate of the intellectual left." Why? Because to be a good Leftist, you had to defend Stalin. That meant you had to defend widespread murder or cover it up or do something that would at least justify the lie to cover it up. All of that put you in a highly, morally, compromised position.

2.100 So far, I've only been talking about Italy and Russia. I haven't even gotten to Germany, where fascism made its most horrifying appearance. It's astounding how that managed to happen. I have very little time left to talk about it. But this course is about the ideas of the 20th century. In a certain sense, there weren't many ideas. It's not as if Hitler, despite the massive tome he produced in prison, "Mein Kampf," really had an ideology.

2.101 The one thing he added to Mussolini's ideology was really just a very strong racial element. Marx had said, "The whole history of the world is a history of class struggle." Hitler added racial struggle. It's really one race against another race. Moreover, he said, "I've got this Darwinian conception of how all this goes. It is indeed a struggle, and the

struggle is like a Darwinian fight for survival." And so these races compete with each other. They fight to survive, and your job is to stand up for your race and help it fight for survival. So take what Mussolini had said—the authoritarianism, the totalitarian nature of the doctrine, the emphasis on propaganda—and then put this strong racial element in it, together with this idea of nature as red in tooth and claw, and what you get is Hitler's Germany.

2.102 Did this have strong appeal in Germany? He tried to rely on resentment over the Treaty of Versailles, which did treat Germany very badly. But actually, it was a small movement, primarily a student-university type movement that was fringe, never got more than 2% or 3% of the vote, until the Great Depression. Unemployment in Germany went to 25% and then to 45%. At that point—the Nazi Party actually, by the way, was considered the most moderate of the four extreme left-wing parties. But nevertheless, it managed to get a plurality, and the communists aligned with the fascists in order to get a majority and put Hitler in a position of power.

2.103 The idea was, "This guy's some chump. He's a former army corporal. He's nothing. We'll get him in power, and then we'll push him aside and take over." That was why the communists cooperated with him. Well, it backfired on them. Hitler took power, and then within a month, had the Reichstag burned down and convinced people that it was the communists who were behind that. He banned the Communist Party. In fact, banned all opposition parties. Once he had done that, ended up creating a system of concentration camps and sending his political opponents there by the thousands. This all took place within two months of his taking power. So it was very, very rapid.

2.104 Then he reconvened the Reichstag that passed what is called the Enabling Act. It put all legislative power in Hitler and his cabinet. At that point, he said to the Socialists and the Communists, the other groups who had cooperated to get him into power, "I have no further need of you," and he took complete power over the whole country. That's when he created the Brownshirts, the Blackshirts, the Gestapo, these elite groups to force people into accepting the Nazi ideology. And thereafter, he had complete control in Germany.

2.105 So there weren't really many new ideas, at least new ideas that led to his rise. It was to some extent a historical accident that the Weimar Republic that started in hyperinflation and resentment over war, but then became very successful, was vulnerable to the Great Depression and conditions became so bad, people were willing to vote even for Hitler. They had no idea, for the most part, what they were getting themselves into.

2.106 Next time, we're going to turn away from totalitarian movements and start reflecting on the nature of human existence. We're going to jump from the collective back to the individual and think about what it is to lead a good human life.

3. Constantly Risking Absurdity

3.1 Constantly Risking Absurdity—that's my theme in this talk, discussing various movements that broadly go under the name of existentialism and are talking about the significance of absurdity in human life. We're going to then look at a couple of reactions to this movement

and to other intellectual trends that I think are part of what led this movement, to try to understand more deeply what it is to think about human life from an individual point of view.

3.2 To some extent, you could be thinking that the existentialists, even though some of the themes were articulated before the Second World War, really have their heyday during and then after the Second World War. Some people, like Camille Paglia, are quite dismissive, saying, "Yeah, this is what happens when your country falls to the Germans within six weeks. You become depressed about life. You start thinking nothing means anything. Everything's absurd," and so on. And so, she thinks this whole movement is just silliness, born of defeat.

3.3 But I think there are some deeper themes here. Some of the themes we've already seen, actually, in figures like Ortega y Gasset. I think here they get developed in a certain kind of way, but a way that leads to some conclusions that others have responded to, by saying, "Well, wait, that shows this can't be right. If that starting point leads you to these conclusions about how to live, maybe there's something wrong with your starting point."

3.4 So let's take a look at this movement that goes under the banner "existentialism." It is a broad movement, including philosophical writers, literary figures, artists, and all sorts of people who all cluster around certain themes, but I'm not sure they really have doctrines that they exactly share. There is, however, one thing that Jean-Paul Sartre, the founder of the movement, thinks defines this, which is that existence precedes essence. We'll talk about what that means. A key concept also is the absurd, and so we'll talk about absurdity, what they mean by this, and how they see it as central to understanding the meaning of human life.

3.5 Let's start with Jean-Paul Sartre. He argues that the central problem of human life is just existence. What does it mean? What's the meaning of life? If you ask most contemporary philosophers, "What's the meaning of life?", they really don't know what to say. They'll say things like, "Well, words have meaning. I don't know if lives have meaning," and so on and so forth. In short, they approach it in the most boring possible way.

3.6 But I think intuitively, we have some sense of what it means to ask about the meaning of life. What's the point of it all? What does it mean? Why am I here? That idea, that we're just given the brute fact that we exist, and we think, "What am I supposed to do with this existence? What does it mean that I exist? How do I live a life like this?", those are the themes that we have to confront as human beings. To say, "Is there a meaning to this? Is there something that needs to guide me throughout all this?", that seems like a fundamental problem of human existence.

3.7 So I don't think it's a silly misunderstanding or something to ask about the meaning of life. I think it's a deep question. Sartre says it's the central question. He thinks that, as we try to answer it, we're going to confront the absurd. And confronting it, we're going to find ourselves alienated, alienated not just from the world around us, but from our own lives, from other people as well as ourselves.

3.8 Albert Camus, another writer in this movement, puts it much more graphically. Here, I've got to say, Sartre is somebody who writes large philosophical tomes that are very dense, difficult to make your way through, as well as some literary works. Camus writes beautifully, though. And so, he becomes the public face of this movement, partly because

he is such a great writer. And he puts it dramatically. He says, here's a way of framing the central philosophical problem. It's suicide.

3.9 That's an incredibly negative way to put it, but he's in effect saying: what's the point of it all? That's the question: Does life have a meaning? Does it have a point? Is there really any reason to live? And if not, then he's not saying, so commit suicide already, but he is saying, if not, that tells us something important. Why not commit suicide? What is wrong with that exactly? It's not so much a moral question; it's a question about the point of human existence: does it have a meaning?

3.10 Here's a traditional approach, an approach that goes at least all the way back to Aristotle. What's the point of human existence? Well, you're asking, "What do I want out of things?" I want to be happy. I seek happiness. My excellence consists in fulfilling my function well. What's my function? Rational activity, Aristotle says. I am to act according to rational plans, and success in life is acting according to rational plans well. Getting the rationality part really well, so that's intellectual virtue. Getting the action part well, so that's moral virtue. And so, really, focus on acting according to rational plans. Seek happiness.

3.11 Sartre thinks there's something fundamentally wrong about this. Not that people don't want to be happy. Of course, we'd like to be happy. But instead, he's saying that it rests on this idea that we have a function. Can I answer the question: What are human beings for? That's a very strange question. If I ask you, "What is a pencil for?", you have no problem answering. "Oh, writing." "What's a screwdriver for?" "Fastening or unfastening screws." "What's a hammer for?" "Driving nails." "What am I for?" That's a really odd question.

3.12 Aristotle says, "Oh, you're a rational agent, so you're supposed to act according to rational plans." Sartre says, "No, wait, I think it's a deep and important question. It doesn't have an obvious answer." What am I for? What is my human life for? Sartre says, "I don't think that comes with a built-in answer." I don't think I come with a function. I'm not a screwdriver. I'm not a hammer. What that means is that my life is something that has no real intrinsic meaning. It isn't given a meaning. It's not automatic. I have to figure it out. I have to give it meaning in the end.

3.13 That's what he means by his phrase: "Existence precedes essence." The fact that I exist is the first thing. Then I say, "What am I for? What's this life for? What's the point of it? What's the meaning of it?" I have to figure that out. It's not that I have an essence given to me already. It is that I exist. That's the given. And now I've got to construct an essence for myself. I've got to decide what my essence is, what this life is for. And so he says, from one point of view, that makes me radically free. I am free to define myself as I choose. I get to decide what my own essence is. I get to decide what my own meaning is, and therefore, what the point of my life is. I get to select a lot of things. That selection is bounded, as we've seen. It's not something that is absolutely infinite. But on the other hand, I am free to choose within very broad bounds what the meaning of life is, what the point of it is, how I'm going to live it.

3.14 Now, he says, in this respect, we are really different from other things. We can take a third-person view and look at facts about various things. When we do that, that's fine. We can describe things objectively. Those things are what they are in themselves, and they can't really do anything about it. If I say, I'm going to consider this screwdriver a musical

instrument, that's not going to work very well. It's a tool for a certain purpose. It's built in that way. It has its function.

- 3.15** But now, our own past is like that, too. It's already given to us. We can't change it. However, I'm not like that. He says, "Look at life from a first-person point of view." Then it's not something whose meaning or point is already given, whose function is already given; it is something that I get to define.
- 3.16** As Charles Taylor puts it, we are self-interpreting animals. We get to decide our own meanings. A rock cannot decide what it's for, or what its own meaning is. A screwdriver can't decide; it's already given to it and fixed by the people who make the screwdriver what it is. But we're not like that. We, actually—the existentialist says—have this first-person view where we get to define the meanings of our own lives.
- 3.17** How do I do that? Here, I think Sartre is taking ideas from Heidegger. In fact, some people think his book, "Being and Nothingness," is really not a whole lot more philosophically than a rip-off of Heidegger's "Being and Time." I have some sympathy with that view. But anyway, here's how Heidegger understands it. I give my life meaning through the projects I select. That choice is mine. The range of choices is typically not mine. That's something which Heidegger calls my horizon. That's something that isn't up to me, at least largely isn't up to me. Some of it is. I'd pursue a higher degree, for example, and that opens up certain possibilities for me, and I've chosen to open up those possibilities. So some of it is up to me, but a lot of it isn't.
- 3.18** Heidegger says, basically, I am thrown into the world. I'm just tossed here. I didn't choose to be born in this place or at this time. I didn't choose to be born at all. I'm just tossed into this world. This is what inspires, I think, the thought in Sartre, that existence precedes essence. I'm here, I find myself here, and I think, "What's this all about?" Inevitably, I'm going to feel a bit alienated from that. It's not obvious. So, I'm tossed into this world, and I have to figure it out for myself. It doesn't come with an instruction manual. It doesn't come with built-in natures of me that already predetermine what I'm going to do.
- 3.19** As a result of that, I am looking for meaning, but I have trouble finding it. That means I sometimes confront the absurd. I am looking for things to have meaning, and some things do have meaning. Pencils have a function. I get that. Screwdrivers have a function. Got that. Words have meanings. Excellent. But now I look at things that really matter in human life. I look at my own life, for example, or the lives of other people, and I think, I'm looking for meaning, and I can't find it. I don't know where to even look for it.
- 3.20** Now, Sartre, at this point, uses one of his paradoxical phrasings, the kind of thing that drives an analytic philosopher crazy. "We are not what we are," he says, "but we are what we are not." That sounds like a logical contradiction, but here is, I think, what he means. In a way, it is the same point that Ortega was making by saying, "Really, my world is defined by my future possibilities. Really, in thinking about myself, I am thinking of myself in terms of not so much what I am now and what I've been in the past, but what I could be in the future." And so, this is Sartre's way of putting the same point.
- 3.21** It's memorable. It's, however, not ideally intelligible, as he states it. But here's how I interpret it, at least. I am not to be identified merely with what I am right now. I am not even to be identified with what I am now and what I have been in the past. I am partly defined

by what I am not yet. So we are not what we are right now and have been. We are what we are not yet, but could be. That, I think, is what this really means.

3.22 Part of what defines me is not just what I am right now or what I've been in the past, but what I could be in the future. I am a being that is oriented toward the future, and that future is open to a large extent to me, and so I've got a lot of choices to make. I can assign that future a variety of different meanings. Maybe not every meaning— I cannot jump back in time and fulfill some sort of function that no longer exists at my time. But nevertheless, I can choose from a large number of things. I am defined in part by that range of choices that I have. And so, I am in part, at least, what I am not yet, but could be.

3.23 If that's true, Sartre says—and here is something where he goes beyond Heidegger, and in a way that is somewhat controversial. He says, if I am that radically free and defined in terms of my own choices about what to become in the future, then I carry the weight of the whole world on my shoulders. Everything becomes responsible. The responsibility gets assigned to me. OK, I'm responsible for everything. I become responsible for the world. I become responsible for the way I am and my whole life, really, because it results from choices I make.

3.24 Admittedly, as Heidegger says, I'm tossed into the world. I didn't choose to be born then or there. However, after that, I make lots of choices. Those choices help to define the range of possibilities I face in the future. My choices among those define this path and so on. I have an absolute choice of self. That means I can't blame anybody else. And to the extent that I try to blame anybody else, that's bad faith. To be authentic, he says, is to accept my responsibility for making those choices and recognize that they are mine.

3.25 So if something goes badly in my life, I don't say, "Well, I couldn't have done anything about it. It just happened. I had nothing to do with it. It wasn't my fault." Sartre says that's nonsense. It is your responsibility. You chose it. What happens to me happens through me, through my choices, in other words. I can't affect myself with it or revolt against it or resign myself to it. Moreover, "Everything which happens to me is mine." So he means this in a very strong sense.

3.26 Now, some of it, I think, we sympathize with. We're tempted to say that, yeah, it is true that a lot of the trouble people get into was a result of their own choices. And a lot of the good things that people experience was the result of their own good choices. So, yes, you are responsible for much that happens to you in your life. On the other hand, we think, wait a minute, but aren't there things that I don't have any control over?

3.27 For example, a few years ago, I was in a car accident. I didn't choose that. Some other person went through that light and smashed into me. Or actually, I smashed into him, but I didn't have a choice. Suddenly, there was a car in front of me. I was just going through a green light. And so, I didn't choose that. It's not like I thought, "What will I do today after lunch? Oh, I think I'll be in a car accident." It wasn't like that at all.

3.28 Similarly, Sartre is living, at the time he's writing, through the Second World War. Well, it's not as if you thought, "You know, what kind of life do I want to lead? I think I'd like to live in the middle of a world war, have my country quickly conquered by the Nazis and have to live under occupation." No. So, he ends up saying, if I'm caught up in a war, it's my war. I chose it. I could always get out of it. I could always flee the country. I could always commit suicide. And so if I'm here, it's my choice.

- 3.29** Well, that's a very strong way of putting it. But in the end, he says that means I have to accept responsibility for anything, everything. I can't say it just happened to me. It wasn't my fault. Yeah, it kind of was your fault. Not in the sense that you chose that specific thing, of course not. But in the sense that you ended up in that position and didn't somehow get out of it. There are always extreme measures you could take to get out of it.
- 3.30** Simone de Beauvoir is another existentialist thinker who wrote a book called "The Ethics of Ambiguity." It's a very rich book, but also a very ambiguous book that is somewhat hard to understand. But nevertheless, she says certain things, I think, really well, and maybe more clearly than Sartre does. Because at one point, she says, "One can't start by saying that our earthly destiny has or has not importance, for it depends on us to give it importance. It's up to man to make it important to be a man."
- 3.31** Here she's addressing that question: What's the point of my life? And does my life have any point at all? Is there a meaning to my life? She says not to start by saying, "Does it have a point or doesn't it have a point?" That's not where to start. It depends on you to give it a point, to give it importance, to give it meaning. So what do you want your life to be about? You get to choose that. That's something that is, in the end, simply up to you.
- 3.32** You have freedom over the point of your own life, and that is a really radical freedom. Maybe we don't want to go as far as saying that you're responsible for being in this war. You're responsible for being the victim of that car accident or the victim of that crime or something. Nevertheless, we can say, still, you're responsible for the choices you've made in your life. You are giving things value. You are giving things significance and assigning meanings. Take responsibility for that. That is your choice.
- 3.33** So, she says, "To will yourself moral and to will yourself free, that's the same decision." Because to accept responsibility—that this is my choice—is to place yourself under the demands of morality. You're recognizing, this isn't just something happening to me. I am choosing this, and so it is my moral decision. And I—yes, Sartre stresses the moral responsibility side—she stresses the moral freedom side. She says that you are free to do that or escape it. You are moreover free to assign it a certain meaning. And so, even if you didn't have a choice about the accident, you have a choice about the meaning to assign that in your life.
- 3.34** Let me move to Camus, who I think puts all these things a bit more clearly and more dramatically, certainly, being a much better writer. He was born in Algeria and won the Nobel Prize for literature in 1957, the second youngest person ever to win that prize; the youngest was Kipling. He was also the first African-born writer to win it. He cultivated this image of himself as the paradigm French intellectual and paradigm existentialist. He's often photographed in these dramatic poses with shadows. He just is everybody's impression of a French intellectual. It looks like he stepped out of a film noir movie from the 1940s or 1950s. That public image certainly didn't hurt his literary reputation, but it was in many ways justified. I mean, he was a fantastically good writer.
- 3.35** His history is remarkable and rather changeable. He joined the Communist Party as a youth of 22, but he was thrown out two years later. He was a highly independent thinker, and Marxists don't tend to appreciate that. He became an anarchist and decided, yeah, what's the point of government at all? So swinging from the "no private property" to the "let's have no government" side.

- 3.36** And he became a pacifist, until the Germans invaded France. And then he thought, "Well, this is terrible. I don't want Nazis coming in here and killing Frenchmen." So he decided to join the French Resistance. Now, in this respect, by the way, Camus could be mocked as somebody who was quite flighty. But I think, on the other hand, there's something really admirable underlying this. He responds to conditions. He has these ideas, and then he sees what's going on in the Soviet Union with the purges, and he says, "Wait, I don't go along with that. I disagree."
- 3.37** Unlike so many Western intellectuals that said, "We've got to go along with whatever Stalin's doing," he said, "No, I'm not going to go along with it." Kicked out of the party. Then he becomes a pacifist until the Germans invade France, and he realizes that pacifism is great as long as nobody's acting on aggression toward anybody else. But the moment they are, you've got to fight back. Then it's not just a conviction that pacifism doesn't work. He actually joins the French Resistance.
- 3.38** In that respect, Sartre actually worked with people in the Vichy government. He didn't do anything to really resist the Nazis; even though later he writes about it as if he was part of the French Resistance; he was not. But Camus really was. He had the courage of his convictions and said, "Well, if I'm going to oppose the Nazi regime, I'm going to do it." And he actually takes part in the resistance.
- 3.39** He does point out, "It's easy to be logical. It's almost impossible to be logical to the bitter end." And I think one of the things he tries to do in his work is be logical to the bitter end. Take some premises and show you where they lead and go all the way to those conclusions. He sees a lot of intellectuals as going part of the way and then chickening out, either not going and accepting those conclusions, or going up to that and then lying, frankly, about what the conclusions are. He says, "I'm not going to do that. I'm going to try to tell the truth and be logical to the bitter end," but it's difficult.
- 3.40** Let's start with the problem. We seem to have this problem of existence. What's the point of it all? We don't find a meaning. But yes, we assign our lives meaning. We go to work, for example, or we study. We do various things that define our lives. We take part in our family. And in short, we fill our lives with things that we think are giving our lives meaning and that do give them meaning. But at certain points, he says, that starts to break down. "At any street corner, the feeling of absurdity can strike any man in the face."
- 3.41** How does this happen? And why does that happen? "It's elusive," he says, and often it's just this momentary feeling. And yet, somehow you feel like, "I'm just going through the motions here. What's the point of what I'm doing? Why am I doing this?" At some point, yes, you choose these things. They were your choice. You're leading this kind of life and you're in these routines. And then something happens, and you think, "How did I get here?"
- 3.42** There's that song, in fact. "How did I get here with this beautiful house and beautiful wife," and so on. My favorite version of that is a meme that has a car that somehow went off the road and goes through the wall of a house. But in any case, you suddenly think, "How did I get here? What am I doing with my life?" You realize, "I don't have an automatic answer."
- 3.43** There is a variety of things that can lead to this. Sometimes I'm just weary with the routine. I wake up and realize it's Monday morning, got to go to work. I'm thinking, "Why am I doing this?" That is, in part, the feeling of absurdity, this confrontation with the absurd, where

sometimes you just see something out of context. You think, "What? What is that?" That too is a feeling of absurdity. Sometimes it's just recognizing the density of the world, our own inability to understand what's going on or do anything about it. It feels as if something's there, and it's bizarre. I don't get it. I don't understand. I can't do anything about it. That, too, is the absurd.

- 3.44** So he says, here is what generates that problem. We define ourselves by make-believe, as well as sincere impulses. So it is true, I sometimes make choices. Sincerely, I do that. I decide to go to graduate school, let's say, or I decide to get married. I decide to do certain things, and I'm well aware of what I'm doing. I'm doing it consciously. But other times, I'm defined by make-believe. And here, I think he's pointing out the danger of deception, with that idea that I'm defined by the range of choices I have in the future.
- 3.45** There's a saying that academics judge each other by what they have done, but judge themselves by what they could do or might do in the future. There is a little bit of that. Like, "I haven't written anything that good, but I've got this idea. I could write something really good." There is self-deception that arises from that. Be careful about defining yourself too much in terms of that horizon, that range of possibilities for the future, because you can start thinking, "It could be that. It could be that," and taking credit for it. There's a little bit of make-believe that enters in here. Self-deception is a real problem.
- 3.46** But he says, there's another factor of this. Partly because of this, we can easily find ourselves doing things that really don't make a lot of sense. Any elementary school teacher knows the experience of having a child misbehave, and you say, "Why did you do that?" The little kid says, "I don't know." Often, they're deceiving you, but they might be, like, "Yeah, I don't know why I did it." "Why did you punch Johnny?" "I don't know. He was just there, and he looked punchable."
- 3.47** I mean, sometimes we do that. Even as adults, we act that way. "Why did I do that?" I don't know. Or, "Why didn't I do that? Somebody told me on the bus in 2010, 'Buy Bitcoin. I thought, 'This guy's weird. Now I'd be a billionaire if I had done it.'" There are times when it's like, "Why didn't I do that?" But anyway, that idea, that sometimes we do things without really thinking about it, without knowing why, can also lead us to the absurd. He says, "All great deeds and all great thoughts often have a ridiculous beginning. Great works are born on a street corner or in a restaurant's revolving door. So it is with absurdity."
- 3.48** I once asked my dissertation director, Wilfrid Sellars, where he got a certain idea, and he said, "Well, I was on an airplane to Minneapolis, and it was a long flight, and we were delayed, and I was tired, and I just started scribbling, and I got this idea." It was a ridiculous beginning. It was not a question of, "I was really working my way through Bertrand Russell and blah, blah, blah." No, it was like, "I was bored with looking out the window, and doodling, and suddenly this occurred to me."
- 3.49** So a lot of things turn out to be like that. Newton with the apple, let's say, or the dream that made Singer invent the sewing machine. It's something absurd, something seemingly ridiculous. And so he says, sometimes you ask somebody what they're thinking about or why they did something. They say, "Nothing," or "I don't know." It could be pretense, it could be deception, but it could indicate, "This odd state of soul in which the void becomes eloquent, in which the chain of daily gestures is broken, in which the heart vainly seeks the link that will connect it again. That's the first sign of absurdity."

- 3.50** Sometimes, "the stage sets collapse." You get up, go to work, four hours in the office or factory, eat some lunch, then four more hours of work. Then you go home. Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday. Do all of this according to the same rhythm. "Then one day, the 'why' arises, and it begins in a weariness tinged with amazement." Like, what? Why? How did I get here? Why am I doing this? He said "begins." This is important. It's not just that that's it, and then it passes, and you're okay. Sometimes that's the case. But he says, no, this feeling begins. Everything begins then.
- 3.51** Or it might begin when you hit a certain birthday. You notice, say, you're 30. Well, in part, you're reasserting your youth. Partly, you're realizing, "I'm located at a certain point in time, and this is kind of a milestone." You recognize you're on a certain curve that ends at a certain place, and you belong to time. And a horror seizes you. You recognize time as your worst enemy. Earlier, you were longing for tomorrow. "Oh, to be older." Every little kid wants to be older. And then at a certain point, for me it was around age 25, you start wanting to be younger. That revolt of the flesh against what he later calls "the cruel mathematics of our condition," that's also the absurd.
- 3.52** As one teacher of mine put it, time is the monkey on our backs. It is constantly haunting us, constantly weighing us down, and leading us to a place we do not want to go. That sense of mortality, that is something that is also the absurd. It seems to undercut a lot of possible answers, not only to how we should live, but also to what the point of it all is. If the end is always death, then is there any such thing as achieving anything or winning at life? I mean, how do you win a game where, at the end, you're wiped out? It seems as if we're playing a game we all lose at, and that makes it especially hard to understand what the point could be.
- 3.53** There are other things that could prompt this: the strangeness of the world. You see somebody talking behind a glass partition. You can't hear him, but you see the person moving around. He says that you wonder why he's alive. Now, I'm not sure I'd react by thinking, "I wonder why that guy's alive." But still, there's something bizarre about it.
- 3.54** Watch the television without the sound on, and it all looks rather bizarre. I once watched all of Saturday Night Fever without sound. It actually was a much better movie without the sound, in my opinion. But anyway, it somehow removes things from the context that gives them meaning, and it all looks kind of absurd. I thought it was a really interesting absurdist drama about class conflict. Then I heard the music. I was like, "Oh, this isn't at all what I thought it was." But in any case, that's something that you realize. Wait, there's something that seems very strange about this when you look at things out of context.
- 3.55** In fact, the same thing happens to us. Sometimes, when we look at the mirror or when you see yourself in a photograph, that distance, it's like, "Here I am out of context. That's what I look like?" It confronts you with this sense of absurdity. The result of that is, he says, an inevitable distance I feel between my life and whatever the point of it might be, even if it's my choice. I'm very aware of that choice, not here as a wonderful exercise of freedom, but as something that's really, in principle, rather scary. I know that I exist. I know that my heart exists. I know the world exists. But he says, "That's all I know." What the meaning of anything is, what the point of all is, all that's construction.
- 3.56** He says it's even worse than that, because the Oracle at Delphi said, "Know thyself." That's the first principle, the first rule. But he says: Can I actually know myself? Actually, I

find myself really elusive. "If I try to seize this sense of self, if I try to define it, I try to summarize it, it's like water slipping through my fingers." I can't do it. Instead, I can't add up the various things. Sure, I have this thought, that feeling, that perception, that history, and so on, but that's me.

3.57 I think we get a sense of that absurdity if somebody says, "Can you send me a resume?" Or in academia, it's called a curriculum vitae, a CV. But either way, it's like, "Wait, that's my life. That's me." In fact, the academic word for it is even worse: this is the course of my life. It's like, really? That's it? I can summarize it in that many pages? It feels like there's more to my life than that. I look at things like that, and I find my own self is elusive. Do I really understand myself?

3.58 He says, "I think it's impossible. I shall be a stranger to myself forever. In psychology, as in logic, there are truths, but no truth." I exist. I try to understand it, but I admit there's a lot, even about myself, that is opaque to me, that I do not understand. So I'm a stranger to myself. I'm a stranger to the world. You're saying to me, Heidegger or Sartre, "Hey, but it's up to you. You get to define it." It's, yes, it's your responsibility, but it's also your freedom. It's great. He says it's great. I can will the meaning I want, but "to will is to stir up paradoxes." You're asking me to assign meaning to something that doesn't have any intrinsic meaning.

3.59 Maybe you've heard that this year, the word of the year was declared to be "six, seven." And what they said about it is that the point of this word is that it has no meaning. Well, I don't know if that's a word. It sounds to me like two words put together in a nonsense way. But in any case, whatever you think about that, it's, in effect, assigning it a kind of meaning when it doesn't have a meaning, and that does feel absurd.

3.60 So, Camus is saying, "You're telling me I'm free to assign any meaning I like to something that has no meaning." So I say, "What's the point?" You're telling me it has no point; that's okay, make up one and be happy. And he says, "Well, I don't feel entirely comfortable with that." Now, at the end of the book, he compares himself to Sisyphus, pushing the rock up the hill for eternity. And he says, "But I can imagine Sisyphus happy. I can imagine Sisyphus saying, 'OK, there's no real point, but I can choose to give it a point, so I'll do that. I'll pretend there's a point, and I'll make myself happy. Maybe I can push it up there and then see if I can beat my record and do it more quickly next time.'" Whatever it is that assigns it a meaning for Sisyphus, he can do that.

3.61 In the final analysis, he's going to say, "Maybe I can be happy doing this." But throughout the book, he doesn't sound very happy about it at all. In fact, he says it's a certain paradox. I've got to assign meaning to something that doesn't have a meaning. It's not just that the world is absurd; it's my expectations of the world. I want it to have a point. I want it to have a meaning. I want it to be rational. And the fact is, it's not. So the absurd depends as much on me and my expectations as on the world.

3.62 Does it have a meaning? He says, "I don't know. But I know it's impossible for me to know it." Maybe I can make one up. I don't know. Maybe it has one that's hidden from me. But in any event, I cannot know it. So he says, "I can't reconcile my longing for the absolute, and then the impossibility of reducing this world to a rational principle. I want the world to be intelligible, and it's not." And so, my mind demands intelligibility. It demands a reasonable principle. The world doesn't give me one. I find that a tension I can't resolve.

- 3.63** What then do I do? Sartre, remember, said, "Be authentic. Take responsibility for your life. Don't go into bad faith and blame something or someone else." Camus says something different. He says, "My goal is to live without appeal." What he means is that any meaning I assign to my life is my meaning that I'm assigning. There's no outside authority or standard, and so live that way. Don't appeal to things outside me as justifying my life. I justify it myself.
- 3.64** So he says, "I draw three consequences, my revolt, my freedom, and my passion." My revolt, because I revolt against the meaninglessness of this world. I interpret my own assignment of meaning not as bad faith, not as some kind of absurdity, but instead my revolt against the meaninglessness of existence, my freedom to assign it the meaning I choose, and then my passion. After all, that meaning is my meaning, and now it's one I should live with passion.
- 3.65** He did that. He married two women to give you some indication of what life this leads to. Okay, that's not so unusual. But here, from 1959, December 29th, he writes to his mistress, announcing he'd shortly be returning to Paris. He had spent the summer away with his wife and children. He said, "This frightful separation will at least have made us feel more than ever the constant need we have for each other." The next day, he wrote, "Just to let you know, I'm arriving on Tuesday by car. I'm so happy at the idea of seeing you again, I'm laughing as I write." The next day, "See you Tuesday, my dear. I'm kissing you already and bless you from the bottom of my heart." There was yet another letter setting up a date in New York. They were all to different women.
- 3.66** So, why is Sisyphus smiling as he pushes the rock up the hill? His revolt, his freedom, and his passion—he is revolting against this task the gods have given him, and he is recognizing his own freedom to assign that a meaning, part of which is the revolt against the meaninglessness of the task. Why is he smiling? Because he can do that with passion. We already knew why Camus was smiling.
- 3.67** The point of that was not just to amuse you, but also to make the point that actually committing to a long-term project like a marriage is something that seems to go against this idea that I am free to choose whatever. After all, I enter into contracts, including marriage contracts. I make promises to people, and that does limit my own freedom. In fact, it seems to me important to guard my freedom, to limit my own freedom, as long as I do it voluntarily. So, you might think the view of life that comes out of existentialism in general is a rather distorted view of life.
- 3.68** Now, I want to turn to two people who are going to reject this, but for different reasons. One of them is Saul Bellow. Bellow was a Trotskyite initially, rather like Camus, but ended up changing his mind and becoming more conservative as he got older. He taught at a variety of universities, ending up mostly at Chicago's Committee on Social Thought. He won the Nobel Prize for literature in 1976.
- 3.69** He describes things in a way that should remind you of Unamuno. He said, "I read Marx and Bertrand Russell and Morris Cohen. I read the logical positivists. I read Freud and Adler and the Gestalt psychologists and the rest. I know how a modern man is supposed to think." In other words, he's saying, "I looked at all these people who have very reductive sorts of understandings, narrow understandings, of what it is to be a human being." He

says, "I think there are deeper motives in a human being. We are not captured by any of those accounts of what a human being is."

3.70 So, he writes a number of novels illustrating people with different attitudes about this, and one of them is "Seize the Day." Now, what is "Seize the Day" about? On the surface, it's a depressing story about a middle-aged guy who has constant conflicts with his father, who is divorced and has a child. The child and the ex-wife don't like him very much. He's running out of money, and he tries a stupid scheme to get rich and blows it completely. It's about that. It's about city dwellers who are trying to get what they need from strangers and the human alienation that involves.

3.71 In the end, Bellow says, "I can sympathize with Wilhelm,"—the main character here,—"but I can't respect him." What's the title about? "Carpe diem" is the Latin phrase from Horace, "seize the day." And that's the poem it comes from. It really means, "While we talk, envious time will have fled. Seize the day. Trust as little as possible in the future."

3.72 In the book, there is this weird character, Dr. Tamkin, who befriends Wilhelm and tries to teach him how to live, essentially. He doesn't know what he's doing. He badly misleads him. He's the one who leads him to lose a lot of money. But anyway, Bellow says, these people think they know the score. They're going to teach you. They're lunatics. They go around, "a bunch of fragile mirrors with hammers," and end up easily destroying people's lives. So they're con men. On the other hand, they're somewhere near the truth because they are near enough to the truth to convince people that they're right and to go along with them.

3.73 And so he convinces Wilhelm that the solution to his problem is to make money. Here is one of his speeches in the book that, I think, is revealing. He says, "In here, the human bosom—mine, yours, everybody's—there isn't just one soul, there's a lot of souls. But there are two main ones, the real soul and a pretender soul. Now, everybody realizes he has to love something or somebody. He has to go outward. 'If thou canst not love, what art thou?' Are you with me?"

3.74 He quotes this as if it's a famous quotation. It's close to one. Sir Thomas Browne had written, "If you can't love God, then may you look on the grace of God and take comfort that God loves you." Well, "if you can't love God," but that's not what Tamkin says. Just, if you can't love, what are you? That omission is important and one of the themes of the book: leave God out of the picture, and then you're stuck in this position where life has no point.

3.75 But on the other hand, Browne is affirming, "Wait, we're noble animals. We're splendid even in ashes, pompous in the grave. We live by an invisible sun within us. Life is a pure flame. We are more than our present selves," and not just in that we're going to exist in the future and can make choices. We have a spiritual self, and that's what's missing from Tamkin's formula. If you can't love, what are you? But wait, something is missing there. A man is only as good as what he loves.

3.76 So, here is how Dr. Tamkin fills it in. What are you? Nothing. That's the answer. And notice that's the existentialist answer. What are you really? What's your essence? The answer is: I don't have an essence. I'd make one up for myself, but there's no intrinsic point. There's no intrinsic meaning. There is no essence. So Tamkin says the same thing. "What are you? Nothing. Nothing. In the heart of hearts, nothing." So, of course, you can't

stand that. You want to be something, and you try, just what the existentialist is doing, saying, "Hey, freely choose the meaning of your life."

3.77 Bellow thinks part of that is this orientation toward the present, because after all, yes, I'm making choices about myself in the future. But on the other hand, there's no meaning that constrains any of that. And so I'm free to just seize the day and focus on the present. Don't worry so much about the future. I'll get to choose whatever I want then.

3.78 So Tamkin says, "Nature knows only one thing, and that's the present. Present, present, eternal present, like a big, huge, giant wave. OK, go along with that, the here-and-now, here-and-now, here-and-now. Be in the present. Grasp the hour, the moment, the instant." That's the way to live. Live with your freedom and your passion. Grab the moment.

3.79 That does confront Wilhelm, our main character, hearing this advice, with the absurd. He's thrown into this world. He keeps thinking, "How did I get here? What did I do wrong to deserve this?" He feels this sense of alienation from everyone, from his father, from his family. He thinks of life as this burden. It was like "an accretion, a load, a hump that he had to carry." He started thinking, "Oh, this mysterious weight, it must be what the business of life is. It's to carry this about. That must be what a man is for."

3.80 And so, he really ends up being the person who feels as if his own existence is a burden and has no meaning. There is no point. He can't really find that he can give it one. He feels like, "I'm a bearer of a load, but not just the load of my alimony payments, or this or that or the other thing—the load of my own self." Who am I? I'd like to know why I exist, even though I've never seriously tried to find out why. He starts thinking, that's the burden of life, to carry—or that's the business of life, to carry this burden. Maybe that's the point of it all.

3.81 But now, he also realizes that he's weak of will, that he's constantly giving in to temptation. He does these things that he knows he shouldn't do. Why does he do it? He doesn't know. Now here, I think, there's a resurgence that is manifested in a variety of ways that we're going to look at over the course and is manifested here in existentialism. It is this revival of feeling over reason, this emphasis on imagination. It's something that Bellow is suspicious of. He says, "I think that people in Western countries live Romanticism all the time." And notice, he's writing this several decades ago, but he's already noticing that we're all starting to become Romantics.

3.82 And he doesn't mean—well, in some sense, he means, yeah, people who put emotion or feeling first, the kind of thing that Unamuno was championing and that Bellow is doubting. He's saying, "People don't know it, but they do this. They think of the proper mode of life as highly stimulated, ecstatic, a life of infinite possibilities, thinking about that horizon, that future of things you could be, the individual utterly free, your responsibility just to fulfill yourself. Realize your own desires as you can."

3.83 In other words, that's exactly the existentialist picture. It is also a picture, by the way, that has certain elements going all the way back to the 19th century, where, "to burn with a hard, gemlike flame," as Walter Pater put it, is the vision of life, that intensity. But here, driven by my revolt, my freedom, my passion, my utter liberation to define life however I want. And he says there's something fundamentally wrong with that picture. Here's how it emerges in the book.

- 3.84** Near the end, Wilhelm is walking along, realizing he's lost a huge amount, and he sees on the walls words in chalk: "Sin no more," and "Do not eat the pig." In the dark tunnel, he starts feeling all these people around him, sensing them and feeling this sense of love for him. They were imperfect, they were lurid-looking even, but a love burst forth in his breast. "One and all, he passionately loved them. They were his brothers and sisters. He was imperfect and disfigured himself. What difference did that make if he was united with them by this blaze of love? And as he walked, he began to say, 'Oh, my brothers, my brothers and my sisters,' blessing them all as well as himself."
- 3.85** What's going on here? When I was studying this novel in English class as a high school student, my teacher kept saying that he recognizes the brotherhood of man, as if that's the answer to everything. I don't think it's the answer to everything, but it is a key to an answer. Because what Bellow is saying when he talks about this is, here's what's happening. He recognizes that his life has a much larger meaning, that he's been ignoring this transcendent meaning, that his life is, at root, some kind of serious religious enterprise.
- 3.86** That's what occurs to him. That's the significance of the "sin no more" and "do not eat the pig." Those are religious commands. It's not just, do the right thing or something like that. This is not a secular ethic thing. This is a religious thing. And he senses that. He realizes there is something spiritual, and that's what unites him. Not just that you're a fellow human being, but that you're a soul. You are something more. As Browne was saying, "You are more than your present self," and it's a spiritual more. It's more than just the hurly-burly of existence.
- 3.87** And so, as in the novel, Wilhelm starts recognizing that there is a kind of essence here. "I labor, I spend, I strive, I design, I love, I cling, I uphold, I give way, I envy, I long, I scorn, I die, I hide, I want." All of those are elements of the human spirit. All of those are elements of human life. They all matter, and they're things that are there in every human being. It's a common stamp. "We have this idea," Bellow writes later, "of being self-created individuals of genius, as if we don't derive from anything. It's a very false idea. It's an immoderate idea." I think I get to create my life ex nihilo. He says that's absurd.
- 3.88** "All through ancient times and clear through the Renaissance into modern times, people had the idea that if they wanted something, they couldn't do better than study the great models and imitate them." You learn greatness from others, and then you add a quality of your own. But that's just an increment to the rest. Newton said, "I stand on the shoulders of giants." But we, Bellow says, "in the tradition of the 19th century, we think we're our own authors." Pirandello had said, "We are the authors of ourselves. I am the puppet of myself," and so on. We act as if we're this way from the ground up, and we just get to recreate ourselves from nothing.
- 3.89** "That belongs to the Romantic tradition, as if every individual had to reinvent himself and everything surrounding him in an original way, as if to live were an act of genius, as though we had no resemblance whatever to people who preceded us. All this sort of stuff is obviously wrong." Here is his analysis of what goes wrong in existentialism. It's partly that I imagine that here I am as this isolated individual, bracketed, as Husserl said, away from everything else. I just view myself in isolation, my life in isolation. What's the point of this? Why am I here?

3.90 And yeah, in isolation, that makes sense. But that's not the way it is. We're born into not only a family and a genetic group that has a history, we're born into humanity which has a history. We are born into a civilization. We come equipped and already shaped by so many things and are going to be shaped by so many things. We aren't building ourselves from the ground up. We already come with a huge amount. And among the things we come equipped with is a knowledge of good and evil, a recognition, an intuition, of what's right and what's wrong.

3.91 So people know that already, Bellow says. "That's what faith means. It doesn't even require discussion. It means there's an implicit knowledge—very ancient, if not eternal—in which human beings share a knowledge of what's right and what's wrong, just and unjust. They based their relationships on that knowledge. If people understood that, their existence could be transformed." Here is how "Mr. Sammler's Planet," a different novel, ends. "The terms which, in his inmost heart, each man knows. As I know mine. As all know. For that's the truth of it—that we all know God, that we know, that we know, we know, we know."

3.92 In other words, stop pretending you don't know what human life is about. Stop pretending you don't know what the function or purpose of a human being is. There is one, and you know it. In your heart of hearts, you know it. You might not admit it to yourself, but we all know it. It is built into us. It is intuitive, and we all know, we know, we know. And that recognition, I think, is what produces the last bit of the novel in "Seize the Day."

3.93 Wilhelm goes in, and he's swept along by the crowd. He's very upset by having lost a lot of money, realizing, "I don't know how I'm going to make the rent payment, let alone pay my wife alimony," and so on. He's swept up in this crowd, and he's pushed into this place, and he realizes, "Wait, this is a funeral. All these people are coming into this church for a funeral." He finds himself in this line going up to the casket. And so he goes up there and gets up to the casket and looks at someone he does not know. He has no idea who any of these people are, but he's looking at the casket, and that commonality of what is human, what is intrinsically human, comes through to him very strongly. And so, he starts crying with all his heart.

3.94 In one way, it's a very sad scene, in one way, a very funny scene, because the people at the funeral are saying, "Who is he? Is he that cousin from Cleveland?" And so on. Nobody knows who he is, but they say, "Well, they must have been very close." In fact, he has no idea who this fellow is. But it's just that common human character and that spirituality that overwhelms him. And so, "He hears all of this and sinks deeper than sorrow, through torn sobs and cries toward the consummation of his heart's ultimate need." What is that need? It is that need to understand that there really is a true spiritual self, that we are more than our present burdens, our present troubles, our present selves.

3.95 Well, that is one reaction to existentialism, saying it is artificially cutting us off from things we really all know, and all understand, that has to do with something very fundamental in us, something spiritual in us, that it simply denies and ignores. I want to look at a different approach, interestingly now, from someone who is known best, really, for his religious writings. But on the other hand, in the thing that we're going to look at, is separating his argument from things that are explicitly religious or explicitly Christian. I'm talking about C. S. Lewis.

- 3.96** He was born in Belfast and got quite a birthday present for his 19th birthday. He arrived at the Battle of the Somme, not the way I would like to spend my birthday. In any case, he spent most of his life at Oxford and Cambridge. He was a fellow and tutor, first at Magdalen College, Oxford, and then at Magdalen College, Cambridge. He begins this book, "The Abolition of Man," and he sees that as what's happening in existentialism and a variety of other intellectual movements in the 20th century, including totalitarianism.
- 3.97** He says people are trying to abolish humanity, trying to abolish what it is really to be human. But he says there are two facts we have to start from. "First of all, human beings all over the Earth have this curious idea they ought to behave in a certain way, and they can't really get rid of it. Secondly, that they don't, in fact, behave in that way. They know the law of nature and they break it. These two facts are the foundation of all clear thinking about ourselves and the universe we live in."
- 3.98** So he, too, is saying, in effect, we know, we know, we know there are things we ought to do. We know we often don't do them. We know there are things we shouldn't do. We know we often do them. That's where we start. So here is what he is arguing for—and much of this book is spent arguing against other things, so it's important to point out where it's all going. He's arguing for a version of natural law theory. He is saying that morality is objective. There really are things we're supposed to do and other things we're supposed not to do. Those norms are rooted in nature, both the world around us and in ourselves as human nature.
- 3.99** Morality is something that simply follows from the nature of human beings and the nature of the world. It is not some foreign thing that somehow can't be found there among the facts. Wittgenstein says the world is the facts and then goes looking around, says, "I don't see any moral facts, so I guess you can't even articulate morality." Lewis says that that can't be right. Morality is objective. It is determined by the world.
- 3.100** Now, philosophers draw many distinctions here between cognitivist approaches. That is to say, they think that moral claims can be true or false. If I say murder is wrong or generosity is good, those things are true. If somebody says, no, murder is fine, and generosity is just a sop to weakness—as maybe a Nietzschean would say. I could say, no, that's wrong. Those things are false.
- 3.101** The noncognitivist says that's not the right way to think about this at all. Moral claims are not capable of being true or false. They're not declarative sentences, despite their surface grammatical form. They're really something like interjections or commands or something else. They're of a different grammatical mood and category. They couldn't be true or false.
- 3.102** Now, the cognitivist, the person who says, no, they can be true or false, tends to have two possible approaches to this. The moral realist says that there are mind-independent moral facts. In other words, these are facts about the world I'm talking about. It is true to say murder is wrong, and that's a fact about the world, that murder is wrong. The subjectivist says there is a fact here, but it's a mind-dependent fact. In other words, it's really a fact about my attitudes or about our society and its prohibitions or something like that. It's something that has to do with something mental; it is not about the world out there.
- 3.103** For example, for the moral realist, a moral assertion says something of the world. "Murder is wrong" says this action has a certain property of being morally wrong. Or this other

action, a virtuous, or rather a generous action, has the property of being virtuous. All of that comes from the nature of human beings and the nature of the world.

3.104 But there is a subjectivist approach. David Hume is a good example. He says, "Actually, we look like we're saying something about the world, but we're saying something about our own feelings." So if I say murder is wrong, I'm just saying I, or maybe we, our society or something, disapproves of murder. Generosity is a virtue, which just means I approve of generosity, or maybe our society approves of generosity. So I'm making a claim, and it could be true or false about the world, but it's just a claim about attitudes, about approvals and disapprovals.

3.105 So it forces us to ask questions like: How do we get from is to ought? That's Hume's question. He says, "Why is cruelty wrong? Why is generosity good?" There's no fact of the matter in them. It's not out there in the world. It's just a matter of my having a feeling of praise or blame. It's just a matter of my approving or disapproving.

3.106 The noncognitivist says, no, it's not like that. Either I'm expressing attitudes, or I am giving commands. In neither case can those be true or false. If I say, "Good! Yay!", that's not true or false. I'm just cheering. My football team scores a touchdown, I say, "Yay." It would make no sense for you to say that's false. Even if you're cheering for the other team, it's not the kind of thing that could be true or false. Or the same thing with a command. If I say, "Open the window," that's not the kind of thing that could be true or false. And so, this sort of person claims that's what morality is like.

3.107 So what is, for example, emotivism? What do I mean when I say murder is wrong? I'm saying murder—boo. Generosity is a virtue. Generosity—yeah! That's all the content really is. It couldn't be true or false. Or I could be a prescriptivist saying, no, it's more like a command. Murder is wrong, that's just me saying, "Don't commit murder." Generosity is a virtue. I'm just saying, "Be generous." Again, it can't be true or false. Well, that is a complicated map of that for my graduate students.

3.108 But now, emotion is important. He says it motivates us to act. Now he says, look, too many people are on this noncognitive side, saying it's more like saying, "murder, boo"—or don't commit murder—or on the subjective side of saying, it just means I disapprove of this.

3.109 He says that's not what's going on. "The task of the modern educator is not to cut down jungles, but irrigate deserts." He says, until recent times, people had this idea that certain emotional reactions on our part could be congruous or incongruous, could be appropriate or inappropriate, that things could merit our approval or disapproval. If I say murder is wrong, I'm not saying I disapprove of it. I'm saying we should disapprove of it. It merits disapproval. If I say generosity is a virtue, I'm saying we should approve of generosity. Generosity merits approval. And that's a stronger claim.

3.110 Augustine defines virtue as "ordo amoris," that is to say, the order of loves, the order of affections. And he's saying, basically, get your priorities straight. Give things the amount of love and affection or approval that is appropriate to them, and the same with this approval. Similarly, Aristotle says, here's the point: get people to like and dislike what they should like and dislike. He thinks our tendency to get away from that is removing something important. He says, "The head rules the belly through the chest." In other words, the mind rules our appetites, our desires, through emotion. Insofar as we reject that, we're doing something that is really misleading.

- 3.111** He says, in fact, these other attitudes, the attitudes that don't take it as an objective truth about the world, end up undercutting the very virtues that we want. So in the end, it is self-defeating. Now, why? Well, he famously says, "All the time, we continue to clamor for things we are making impossible. In a sort of ghastly simplicity, we remove the organ and demand the function. We make men without chests and expect of them virtue and enterprise. We laugh at honor and are shocked to find traitors in our midst. We castrate and bid the geldings be fruitful."
- 3.112** It gives us no reason to do the right thing or to seek virtue. If I approve or I say boo or yay, it gives you no reason to do anything. So I like mushrooms. Do you now have a reason to eat mushrooms? Not really. Similarly, I approve of the Pittsburgh Steelers. I cheer for the Steelers. I was born in Pittsburgh. I grew up there. Does that give you a reason to cheer for the Steelers? No. Why should you care what I approve or disapprove of? Even if Texas scores a touchdown in a football game, I cheer or I shout, "Texas, fight." Gives you no reason, whatever, to cheer for the Longhorns.
- 3.113** So as a result of that, he says, look, this gives no reasons, and that's the whole point of morality, but it's worse than that, because it implies that virtue and vice are matters of taste, like cheering for this or that football team. But he says, wait a minute, developing virtue requires a lot of hard work, a lot of delayed gratification, a lot of resisting temptation. Why would I do all that if it's just a matter of taste? He says that's the reason why people who have this other sort of attitude about morality tend to become immoral themselves. Because if it's a matter of taste, why bother to develop virtues, those virtues that hard work is required to become a good person?
- 3.114** And he says here's what they're ignoring. There is a set of objective, universally held moral values. He calls it the Dao. And in the end, we can figure it out by looking at various world religions or various philosophies. They don't agree entirely, but they largely overlap: don't harm other people. Don't steal. Don't fornicate. Don't lie. Don't covet. Don't kill. Don't be unchaste. Do eliminate selfish desire. Do not covet. All of those are things that are pretty universal. We find them in Daoism, in Confucianism, in Christianity. We find them in Judaism. We find them all over the world, in secular as well as religious accounts of ethics.
- 3.115** And so he says, all of these things are basic to us. Indeed, to echo Bellow, we know, we know, it isn't a mystery. Yes, life has a point. Yes, there is an answer to whether these things are good and those things are wrong, and it is already given to us by our own nature and the world. It is something we already know, and people all over the world somehow seem to know it. It takes a special kind of theorist to pretend not to. The end.
- 3.116** Looking at all of this, it seems that whether we call it God, whether we call it the soul, whether we call it intuition, it seems that a lot of maybe the response to existentialism is more about just saying—and it even goes almost to the hemisphere idea of the brain. Let's not look so left hemisphere. Let's look a little more right hemisphere. Let's look a little more global. Is that fair to say? Can you maybe elaborate on that?
- 3.117** All right, that's a really interesting observation. I think different authors would have different reactions to that. For example, in Unamuno or in Lewis, I think they would like that idea very much, saying, yeah, the existentialist is looking at life, saying, "I'm looking for a reason that I exist." I can give a causal explanation maybe, once I take eighth-grade biology or something, but I can't really understand why I specifically exist. It looks like a

puzzle to me. Lewis, and I think Unamuno, and a variety of others would say that you feel it deep down.

3.118 We could interpret, actually, the intuitive understanding that Bellow is talking about that way, too. But the reason I'm less willing to say that Bellow would like your point is simply that he worries that the Romantic puts too much emphasis on feeling and too little on reason. So he says, yeah, part of it is that I'm supposed to already feel the answers to these questions. I should feel that spiritual self.

3.119 And what happens to Wilhelm at the end of the book there, in recognizing, it's not just his common humanity, but the fact that they're all more than their present selves. It doesn't matter that they are basically ugly-looking people. It doesn't matter that their lives are a mess. It doesn't even matter that this fellow is dead. Somehow, there is something beyond that, something deeper. It's that deeper understanding that is the heart's ultimate need, not just to recognize I'm a human being, and you are, too.

3.120 That's why, in high school, I thought, "What's going on with this book? Why does recognizing the brotherhood of man answer anything?" Who am I? What's my life for? Lots of other people are in the same position. That's no answer. But it's that, I think, really, I think the key to the novel is that, if thou canst not love, what art thou? Recognizing that's leaving a really important word out. Bellow is a religious Jew, and he's thinking, "Yeah, you leave God out," and then it looks like there's no answer, and the answer is nothing. You're nothing.

3.121 But in that respect, it is partly Wilhelm coming to that feeling. He's not reasoning himself into this at the end. But on the other hand, Bellow says, it is possible to go too far in the direction. You need those hemispheres working together, because leave reason out, and then you're tempted to think, "Oh, so I can just do whatever I want," as if I am creating the world ex nihilo. Indeed, from his point of view, the existentialist is trying—and they're aware of this. In fact, sometimes they celebrate it.

3.122 We're putting ourselves in the position of God. It's not that God exists and has given our lives a purpose. There's no God, and I get to give myself a purpose. Bellow's saying that's not the way it is. And it's not just that that's not the way I feel; it's that that's not the way to think about things. Here's how you become good at something. You study the great people of the past, and you put your own twist on it. You don't say, "Let me start from zero and see what I could be." You start somewhere. You're given a heritage. He's worried about people who want to go so far in the emotional direction that they forget about all of that.

4. The Prospects of Freedom

4.1 I'm going to be talking about the Prospects of Freedom, in particular, a certain view of economics, of politics, of society that I think promotes freedom, and then George Orwell's worries about threats to freedom. Let me begin with the positive side and the thought of Friedrich Hayek.

- 4.2** I want to start by mentioning that although I've largely bypassed World War II, we talked a little bit about the rise of totalitarianism and the possible setup. We've also mentioned briefly the utter incapacity of people in Allied countries to recognize the growing threat. In fact, their bizarre response, really in weakening their own countries in response to a growing Germany. But for now, I want to bypass that and think about the postwar era.
- 4.3** After the war, Europe and most of the countries of the world bounced back very, very rapidly. You would have thought, given the destruction of the war—I mean, tens of millions of people killed, huge amounts of property damage—that there would be devastation that would last for decades. But that didn't really happen. The economies rebounded very quickly. That was true not only in the Allied countries but even in the defeated countries, partly due to the Marshall Plan, but partly due to the politics and the economic program of the person I'm about to talk about: Friedrich Hayek.
- 4.4** Who was he? He was born in Vienna, a second cousin of Ludwig Wittgenstein, the famous philosopher, it turns out. He fought for Austria-Hungary on the Italian front in World War I. He ended up going to the University of Vienna and earning two doctorates in law and political science. Then he taught at a variety of universities for quite a long time at the University of Chicago, helping to make it a leader in the field of economics. He won the Nobel Prize in 1974.
- 4.5** Now, it's his definition of socialism that I've been talking about throughout this course as the centralized conscious direction of social forces to consciously determined and chosen ends. Underlying that, he says, is a vision of the collective good and an attempt to be rational in pursuit of it. The appeal of this is a society based on reason, on ethics, on, you might say, rationally choosing a goal for society and then rationally pursuing means to it. But he says, that's the idea, that's the motivation.
- 4.6** However, the reality is that socialism means slavery. And so he argues against it very powerfully, even though he says, "I understand the motive. The motive is an orderly world. The motive is something that can be designed by people. And in our individual lives, if we do certain things, let's say something even simple, you want to build a dog house, good to have a design. It's not great to just start hammering things at random, the way my father-in-law used to do. It's good to have a plan. It's good to actually decide what it's going to look like and figure out the best means of getting there. And so, fantastic. That's the idea. But in reality, he says it's very, very different.
- 4.7** Why does it end up that way? He gives us a number of arguments, and the first one is an argument from respect. He thinks that socialism inevitably, even though it often claims to start with a respect for the individual, leads to a rejection of that and disrespect for the individual. He says that here's the problem: if collectively we get together and decide on ends in a centralized way, some of us are going to support that end, but some of us are not. He says that only those who work for the approved ends are really going to be regarded as full members of the community.
- 4.8** The others are going to be obstacles. It might be that they actively oppose this, but it might just be that they have separate ends. They are interested in pursuing other things. In any case, whether they are actively opposing the pursuit of this end or whether they're simply doing things that are irrelevant to it, they're not going to really have a full status. He says, the problem then is that people have dignity and are treated with respect only as members

working for the common goal. If you opt out of the group, then you aren't really a member of the community in a full sense.

4.9 Imagine a club that decides to do something, and you don't want to participate. They say, "Hey, we're going to clean up this park," and you say, "I'm out. I'm not interested in doing that." Well, then you're not really a full member of the club, and you're likely to be treated as somebody who's only a sort of member. You aren't really participating in the "let's clean up the parks" club. So it's like that. And he says that in that way, socialism ends up undercutting human respect and human dignity. The focus on the common good erases limits of power over individuals.

4.10 So he says, here's the problem at root: Western civilization, from the very beginning, not only in the Judeo-Christian tradition, but also in Greek philosophy, for example, in Roman philosophy, it's built on respect for the individual person. As a person, not as somebody who is working for the common good, not as somebody who's doing this or that thing, but instead, simply as a human being, you are thought to have inherent dignity. In the religious tradition, you are a child of God made in the image of God, and that's the ground of your dignity. But even apart from that, there is an idea that human beings are special. We are unique in some way, and that gives us a special moral status that other animals and other things do not have.

4.11 Now, that entails a respect for choices that you make within your own sphere, whatever that is. Your dignity gives you a certain amount of liberty, and you are allowed to develop what Hayek calls your individual gifts and talents. You get to choose how you're going to live your life, at least within certain limits. So there is something important about that. Now, we can argue that in one sense, it's good for society to have people doing that, developing their individuality, making choices spontaneously. John Stuart Mill gives a variety of arguments like that saying that this makes for a better society overall.

4.12 Hayek agrees with all that, but he says there's something even deeper. It's not just that it's socially good if people are allowed to do these things and pursue their own good in their own way. It's also the case that that's part of what it is to be human. I can't choose to do anything I want. After all, other people also deserve respect and have rights. Nevertheless, within a large sphere, I can. My dignity, in part, consists in my ability to shape my life within those boundaries.

4.13 But socialism, by saying, "We're going to decide together what we are going to do," is, in a sense, the enemy of individuality, the enemy of spontaneity and the enemy of liberty. I'm supposed to be intentionally pursuing this or that other thing, and that puts me within certain bounds. He says that in the end, this leads to a neo-feudalism. Hence, he says that socialism means slavery, or in the title of the book, "this is a 'Road to Serfdom.'"

4.14 Now, I think there's something interesting here in Marx that you might remember, where he says that capitalism has torn apart all of the traditional idyllic relations. He talks about patriarchal relations. He talks about feudal relations. That's one place where you get this glimmer that Marx, while he's looking toward the future and predicting a utopian future, in fact, is looking at the past, saying, "I liked it better when we were in the Middle Ages, and people knew their place, and there was a hierarchy," and so on. He praises that as if, "I miss that." There's a nostalgia for that.

- 4.15** I think Hayek notices that and says that's actually a very deep thing. Socialism is really a form of feudalism. They're going to be people who, like the nobility, are going to make decisions and be in charge of carrying out these centralized conscious directions. They're going to be making the directions and supervising it all, and the rest of us become their serfs. We no longer have any individual role. We are just to serve the social good. He says, what about those people who take on that role of the nobility in feudalism? Well, they're going to start substituting their own preferences for the preferences of the people they're leading.
- 4.16** Again, John Stuart Mill points out some problems with that. Those people are going to really not care as much and not know as much about us as we know about ourselves. That's one problem. But also, those people are going to start taking on a different set of values. Think here about Ortega talking about the revolt of the masses, where we've got this group of people who suddenly start thinking of themselves in different terms and thinking about their goals as expressing the goals of the society, when it may or may not have anything to do with the goals that people otherwise have. And so that attempt to substitute things, he thinks, is part of what's going to be going on.
- 4.17** In that respect, socialism is actually built on a disrespect for the individual. He says, "Although the professed aim of planning would be that man should cease to be a mere means, in fact, since it would be impossible to take account in the plan of individual likes and dislikes, the individual would more than ever become a mere means to be used by the authority in the service of such abstractions as social welfare or the good of the community." So he worries that centralizing decision-making is not only going to wipe out individual preferences, but it's also going to make the whole thing more vulnerable, not less vulnerable to manipulation. It makes it very dangerous.
- 4.18** Think about a monopoly. We don't tend to think it's a bad thing, except in certain natural monopolies like the water company or something, for a monopoly to develop in a certain industry, because then there's no competition. People can raise prices. There's little you can do if you want that product. But think about the government now. "Government is the most powerful monopolist conceivable," Hayek says. Because you can't easily opt out. It's not like you can say that now it's all one company that is controlling, let's say, sales of this thing. "Maybe I just won't buy that thing." You can do that in a private enterprise. But in the government's case, I can't just say, "I'm not on board with this. IRS drop dead. I'm not going to do this anymore." You have to leave. You have to leave the country. That's a much more radical thing. It's much harder to avoid the power of government than it is to avoid the power of a private monopoly.
- 4.19** Now, in that way, the agents, the people who are carrying out this conscious direction, are actually largely insulated from accountability. Why? Because they're part of a monopoly. There's very little people can do except flee the country. So, it's going to be hard to motivate them, to actually care about the welfare of the people they're leading. After all, those people really can't do anything to hold them accountable.
- 4.20** There's another problem: planning or this centralized direction, Hayek says, "Is going to make it more difficult for the individual." Actually, if you want an illustration of this, think about the history of the Great Depression. Why did it last so long? Well, it was partly because there were individual policy failures on the part of Hoover and of FDR. But part of

it was simply that policies kept changing. People did not know what the rules would be, what the tax rates would be, and so on, a year hence or two years hence. Things were constantly changing.

- 4.21** Indeed, I've read accounts of how this looked from the point of view of the Roosevelt administration and the people in it, and they were, to some extent, panicking and thinking, Well, maybe this will work, maybe that will work. But when you do that thing, you make it very difficult for anyone else to predict what conditions are going to be like. Who knows what the government will decide to do next year? So, when the state starts substituting its judgment for individual private judgments, what happens to the rest of us is that we have to think: what is the government about to do? That makes it really hard for us to decide what to do. Indeed, I think a lot of the reason people did not invest or did not hire during the 1930s was simply they didn't know what the rules were going to be in the very near future.
- 4.22** There's another problem, which is that insofar as this centralized authority is making decisions, it's going to tend to make them on the basis not of the actual rules, but instead it becomes a matter of who you know rather than what you know. Because it's going to be really important to actually be able to get people who are in charge to listen to you and to care about you. It's going to matter a lot whether you happen to have an in, whether you happen to know someone who's in charge of that, or at least know someone who knows someone, as opposed to simply being someone who is just out there and unknown.
- 4.23** In a different society, you might be able to have a government of laws, not of men. But he thinks that eventually erodes under socialism. It becomes less and less a matter of the rules because there's more and more unaccountable discretion at the very top of the system. So he says, in the end, you can treat people equally, applying the same rule to everyone, or you can seek some outcome, for example, let's say, equal results for various groups or equal outcomes for individuals. You can't do both.
- 4.24** It becomes obvious the moment you try to teach anyone anything. Some people pick it up very quickly. Some people get it much more slowly. Some people are never going to get it. The difficulty then with wanting equal outcomes is you've got to treat those people very, very differently. Some students, you hardly have to tell them anything. They just get it right away. Others, you need to help a bit. Others need a lot of help. In that case, you've got to treat people differently in order to get something like the same outcome.
- 4.25** Hayek's most famous argument, however, is his argument concerning distributed information. It's really this, I think, that won him the Nobel Prize more than any other single thing. Let me back up and start with a general idea. Hayek is a pluralist. He says that there are many values, many different kinds of values, many things we care about in society. We care about liberty. We want to make choices ourselves. We care about social order. We want happiness. We want prosperity. We want to be healthy. We'd like to have pleasures. We seek honor. We care about morality and religion and strength and civility and peace and dignity and virtue and many other things. There are countless things we would want a society to exhibit or our own individual lives to exhibit.
- 4.26** He says that there's an infinite number of these good things, but here's the problem: any one of them can be achieved only at the sacrifice of others. And so life consists of trade-offs, of compromises, of balancing. Now, I think a lot of people have made this point all the

way from Edmund Burke to Isaiah Berlin and Iris Murdoch. The good is important, but there are many different kinds of goods. It's not one thing; it's many different things. So, we're faced with these choices of making trade-offs, seeking balances.

4.27 Thomas Sowell has said, "There are no solutions in life; there are only trade-offs." I think that's the key idea here. We have to decide: how hard am I going to work to be prosperous, and what do I have to give up in order to do that? All of our lives are spent thinking about those conflicts. We can't have it all. We've got to decide, "I really want this, so I'm going to be willing to compromise on this in order to get it."

4.28 What does that mean? He says it has a really important implication right away. When we talk about the common good or the general welfare, he says that doesn't have any definite meaning. All of those things are good. And so the common good, the social welfare, the general welfare, etc, it's some combination of all of that. But what combination? What trade-offs should we make? What compromises should we make? How do we properly balance them?

4.29 It turns out there are lots of possible balances, lots of compromises. And he says it means there is no particular content to those phrases. We might talk about what's promoting the common good and have very different ideas of what that common good would look like because we're seeking different kinds of balances. It's not that you think that's good and I think that's bad. Let's say I want something where there is order, where I can feel safe on the streets. It's not as if I say, "Oh, I don't care about that. I want crime and violence in the streets. I want to feel unsafe." Nobody really thinks that. But they're going to compromise in various respects, thinking, "I'm willing to sacrifice this degree of this to get this degree of that." People are going to do those balancing in different ways.

4.30 Now, he says that if we had a complete scale of values so we knew exactly how much this was worth and how much that was worth, then we could actually compute: what's the proper balance? But he says there is no such scale. There is no scale that tells you how much liberty, for example, you should sacrifice for the sake of order. They are just competing things to some extent. You cannot really say, "Oh, this is exactly the right trade-off to make among them." He says that even if there were such a scale, it would be so complex that no human being could understand.

4.31 If there is such a thing, we don't have access to it. Maybe God is up there thinking, "Guys, this would be utopia. This is the right balance." But we don't know what that is. We have no way of finding out what that is. At best, we have a bunch of different possible solutions, each of which has some appeal, none of which is the solution that has to be sought. There are just trade-offs. So he says that values can be compared only in people's free choices among them.

4.32 Here he's thinking like an economist: suppose I applied this argument to fruits. Somebody has a fruit stand and you say, wow, there are all sorts of different fruits here. There are apples and oranges and lemons and limes. How do you possibly compare them? How many apples are worth how many oranges, and how many limes and so on? An insoluble problem. Well, if you think of it as a philosopher, it might look like an insoluble problem. "Yeah, there are many different trade-offs. I don't know."

4.33 But in economics, what do we do to actually figure this out? We allow the price system to work. We think, well, how much supply is there of each of these things? How much

demand is there? And we eventually, through a complicated process, reach some equilibrium. So you go to the fruit stand and here's the price of apples, here's the price of oranges, and of lemons and limes, and so on. It's people's free choices about supply as well as about demand for these things that ends up telling us roughly what the comparisons are.

4.34 He says that's the right model to have as well for these social goods. How much liberty should we have? How much social order? How much should we care about strength? How much should we care about peace? He says there's no one way of doing this in the abstract. We just have to see what choices people make.

4.35 At some point, somebody is going to propose, "Hey, listen, I think we need to spend more on the military." Other people are going to say, "No, I'd rather spend that on other things." We argue about it. We determine something, and there's something like a political mechanism analogous to the economic mechanism for determining how much we're going to do, what balance we're going to seek. But, he says, you've got to do that by having people talk about, fight about all of these individual things and make choices among them. There's no way to decide in the abstract what the right solution is.

4.36 Go back to my idea of building the dog house. You need to decide what to do, and then how to go about doing it. But if somebody says, "Wait, you don't understand. Lumber is really expensive right now. Maybe you should wait a while and see if the price drops," and so forth. You meet these various constraints, and maybe you think, "Oh, man, I was going to make it out of oak, but you know what? I'll settle for pine because oak's really expensive right now," and so on. You're making these compromises as you go, and you're doing that in a rational way.

4.37 But now in society as a whole, to some extent, we do that, but by having lots of people contribute their ideas and actually debate these things, discuss these things, and make individual choices about them in their own lives. The result of that is that a limited government allows people to seek and put value on different goods. It tries to accumulate those, partly economically and partly politically. And in that way, it reflects the opinions of the people.

4.38 However, if you've got a centralized group making decisions about this, it's very different. It's as if somebody says, "Yeah, I don't really care how easy it is to get oranges and apples and lemons and limes. I'm just going to put these prices on them and see what happens. If I run out of limes, oh, well. If I have way too many apples, oh, well. I'm not really going to worry about demand and so on. People will take whatever I have." Unless you've got a captive population, for example, in an airport or a movie theater or something, that's not going to work out very well. Even then, people are going to decide, in a lot of cases, "I'm not going to pay \$12 for this bag of popcorn."

4.39 In any case, he says the real question is this: who's going to decide what these balances are? Who's going to decide? Really, in the end, it comes down to a simple division: is it going to be the people together making individual choices, or is it going to be the planner? So either you have this top-down direction, somebody or some group of people up here choose and then impose that on the rest of us, or it is our individual choices that shape, in something analogous to this price mechanism and the economy as a whole, how we actually achieve some social balance.

- 4.40** So he thinks it's partly, as John Stuart Mill says, that the people at the top aren't going to quite know enough, and they're going to interfere wrongly and in the wrong place. They're not going to care enough to get things right. But he says it's actually more. It's more serious than Mill thought because, actually, the government can't possibly know enough to value these goods appropriately. It can't care enough either. But for the moment, the distributed knowledge argument is that it cannot possibly know enough. There is a massive economic calculation problem.
- 4.41** Market forces incorporate vast amounts of information about, for example, the supply of oranges and the weather in Florida and in California and all of this stuff that goes into eventually determining a price. There's a huge amount of information about supply, about conditions and possible future supplies, about people's preferences, and so on. No individual person can match that. No agency can match that. He says the sheer complexity of this problem requires decentralization.
- 4.42** That seems obvious in economics. Economies where people decide that this is going to be the supply of toilet paper or of oranges or whatever, don't tend to work very well. It leads to massive shortages and empty store shelves. The same thing happens when people establish wage and price controls. All of a sudden, there are shortages of all sorts of other things. It's not exactly that the planner is doing this on purpose or something; it's rather that the problem is so complex, no human being, no group of human beings could figure it out.
- 4.43** Some people have said that AI is going to solve this problem because AI can incorporate vast amounts of information. Yes, it can, but the difficulty is, first of all, insofar as it would work, it would just be duplicating what would happen anyway. Why have an AI system that's going to give you the prices that are already in the store automatically through a natural mechanism? But the other problem is simply: can it really look toward the future and anticipate the future in the way that people can? People, after all, have ideas for improving things, and they say, "Hey, if we were to do this, then maybe we could blah, blah, blah." The AI system is going to be based on the past. It's not going to be able to make the same decision.
- 4.44** So, I think even an idealized AI system is not really going to duplicate what people are able to do just through making their own individual choices. The problem is too complex, and it's too oriented toward the future. It's not just a matter of the past. But even if it could, it would really just be redundant. It would give us the same solution we would have had anyway. So what's the point?
- 4.45** Hayek is honest about all this. He says that makes it sound as if the price mechanism works great and everything works out well. But there are market failures. There are circumstances where we get too much of something or too little of something. We have excess. For example, go into any bookstore—and for an author, this is very sad—but you'll see these piles of books that are unsold and remaindered, and you can get them for 99 cents and so on. It means they anticipated much more demand than was really there. In other cases, it's very hard to get something you need because there's a shortage. They didn't anticipate so much demand. A lot of video games, when they first come out, are like this. So, sometimes markets fail. People don't always get it right, even in their own individual calculations.

- 4.46** There are also situations like tragedies of the commons, where we each do things that are rational for us individually, but the result of that is that collectively we run into trouble. Environmental pollution is a good example. It might be that each of us is doing something that harms the environment, but so trivially that it doesn't seem to make any difference. I mean, a simple example is people walking on the grass instead of on the sidewalk. You might think, "My walking across the grass doesn't make any big difference." But if all of us do it, it turns out we wear a path into the grass, and it's a mess, and we cause a problem. Sometimes what makes sense for each doesn't make sense for all. Those things happen, and Hayek is honest about that. Yeah, markets are not perfect.
- 4.47** On the other hand, he says, why think a government is going to do better? After all, it's not just a matter of, "Oh, this has a problem, so let's not do it." It's rather, "Suppose we do the other thing. What problems does it encounter?" He says that the government can be expected to fail at least as often. I call this the tragedy of the Congress. But in any case, it might be that what makes sense for each decision maker doesn't make sense for all the decision makers.
- 4.48** So the same tragedy of the commons can occur at the level of collective decision-making. In fact, I think it often does. Without government involvement, we often get too little investment in public goods. On the other hand, governmental mechanisms often give us an overinvestment in public goods. Why? Because you gain points by having that bridge built in your district or by having that new park created. People are impressed by that, they forget about how much it costs.
- 4.49** In fact, here's the root of the problem: the thing itself might produce some real benefits for a small subset of people, but the costs are distributed over a very large number. Are you going to go to the state capital or the national capital and protest a bill that is going to, in the end, cost you about five cents? Well, no. And yet it might be that there are a lot of those five-cent-type projects for each of us that add up to a huge amount of money.
- 4.50** In each case, you say, "It's not costing me much." It's just like walking on the grass. Yeah, that project doesn't cost you in particular very much. Neither does that one. But what about these multiplied by hundreds of thousands? All of a sudden, you realize, "Wait a minute, my taxes just went up by \$15,000, and it's on all this stuff that benefits only a few people." It's easy for this thing to happen at the governmental level. In fact, he says it's much more likely to happen there, partly because of mechanisms like that, but partly because of the knowledge problem.
- 4.51** The market as a whole does take into account a huge amount of information, and the government is not going to be able to do that nearly as well. It's going to be acting on the basis of much more limited information. So he wants to stress that the fact that a better solution exists doesn't mean that anybody knows how to find it or is likely to find it. In fact, he thinks the government is less likely to find it than private individuals. So are there problems with the market? Yes. But there are at least as many problems with the government.
- 4.52** In the end, Hayek says this, "The curious task of economics is to demonstrate to men how little they really know about what they imagine they can design." In this respect, he thinks, yes, economics is the dismal science in part because you have this idea, "Hey, if we only did this, we could actually make society rational, and we could do a much better job of

decision making." Well, probably not. You don't know enough. You aren't going to be able to solve these immensely complex problems. You're going to end up in a worse place, not a better place. Sometimes, that's not universally true. Sometimes, you can make an improvement. But he says that the odds are against you. There is very little you can actually do to make the world a better place.

4.53 The last argument he gives—and here I'm framing it in Leninist terms: "Who, whom?"—who gets to do what to whom. Because after all, socialism is a matter of centralization. That's the key idea. But when we centralize, we are empowering certain people to make decisions for the group. So some are going to be making decisions; some are going to be subject to those decisions. It transfers power from the individual to the state to this collective group that is going to direct things. Either choice and risk rests with the individual or with someone else.

4.54 One of the great dangers here is that if you invest in something and it goes bad, you lose money, you are the one who pays the price. On the other hand, if the government invest money in something and it loses, do the government officials pay a price? No, you do again. They get off scot free. It turns out that government officials can make bad decision after bad decision, even corrupt decisions, and still get reelected and still maintain power.

4.55 There was a congressman from Pennsylvania when I was young, who got reelected while he was in prison, serving a jail term for corruption. It didn't matter to his people; he brought jobs back home. Well, okay. But the result is he made certain decisions and really—other than serving a jail term—didn't really pay a price in electoral terms.

4.56 The difficulty here is really much more general than just government. It's an instance of the principal-agent problem. The agent's job, whether it's an agent, let's say a real estate agent or a lawyer or something, they're representing the interests of the principal, the person who hires them, and the agent's interest can diverge from the principal's interest.

4.57 For example, I hire a lawyer. I want this to be done in the least expensive, quickest way possible. But the attorney doesn't necessarily value that. They want to be able to charge me as much as they can. I wanted an attorney, for example, a few years ago, to make a small change in my will. He came back and presented me with a bill for a lot of money and said, "By the way, that was a really sophisticated, wonderful will you had. I learned a lot in spending time studying this." It's like, "Wait, I just paid to educate you about a state law? What's happening here?" I was a little upset. His interest clearly diverged from mine. I wanted it done quickly. "Just change these few names." He took the opportunity to spend hours studying the details of, "Oh, this is an interesting feature of all this." Anyway, it's not as if my life is that complicated, but apparently, I once hired a really great attorney to write that will.

4.58 In any event, what keeps the agent focused on the principal's interest? In the case of politics, we elect people, let's say, to represent our interests, but what keeps them focused on our interests instead of their own interests? Ordinarily, you might say, the more the system is bottom-up, it's us who have the job of keeping them accountable. If they stop representing our interests, we should vote them out of office. When we have a lot of people in an administrative bureaucracy, we can't really vote them out of office. That becomes an increasing problem.

- 4.59** But in addition to those factors, how well does it function that we actually can shape their decision-making and hold them accountable? The worry is that it's not very easy, even in an idealized democratic system. I mean, if it's not a democracy, then really good luck. It's very difficult to hold anyone accountable. But even in a democracy, it's quite difficult. Something like 98% of incumbents are reelected, and that should shock us. That's a Stalin's Russia number that comes up. It's not that we're not free to vote for other people. It's that we don't tend to.
- 4.60** So, the whole idea of public choice theory is that government officials actually have incentives to look out for their own interests, including their own electoral interests, and not really for your interests. It's very difficult, given that, to actually keep them focused on people's interests and to hold them accountable. The result of all that, Hayek says in a marvelous chapter entitled "Why the Worst Rise to the Top"—at first, I thought, "Wow, that's so cynical." Then I've spent decades in universities looking at administrations, and I thought, "I now get it."
- 4.61** Who becomes an administrator? The people who aren't very good professors. Who becomes a consultant in a certain field? The person who wasn't really making it in their own business, and so on and so forth. You start realizing, wait a minute, the people who are up there are often the people who were failing down here, and that's the alternative.
- 4.62** In a socialist system, he says it's worse than at a private business or even a university—I say even a university because there aren't many mechanisms for holding people accountable in universities. In fact, the way it seems to get a higher administrative job is to come up with some grand thing that transforms blah, blah, blah, imposes a lot of work on other people, and then, before it becomes an obvious failure and people get rid of it, you take the next job. It's a ladder, and as soon as that person leaves, people say, "Why do I have to write these 100-page reports all the time?", and they get rid of it all, but it got the person the next job.
- 4.63** In any event, that happens in a lot of institutions. But he says that in a government, it's worse, and in a socialist government, it's much worse. Because here's what happens: the people up here are substituting their own preferences for the preferences of people. The more aggressively they do that, the more they tend to rise. And so he says, "Socialism can be put into practice only by methods that most socialists would disapprove." It starts with this idea of being rational and respecting individuals. But it turns out that it's aggressively disrespecting individuals that makes you rise to the top.
- 4.64** A lot of times, people will say, "I know the record of socialism isn't very good, but it's because the right people weren't in charge." He says here's the difficulty: the right people are never going to be in charge. They get stepped on by others who are climbing over them. The most aggressive people get to the top. In lots of contexts, the Peter principle applies: employees rise to their level of incompetence. But that's a problem in a lot of organizations. In socialism, it's even worse because it's the most aggressive that rise to the top, the most dangerous that rise to the top.
- 4.65** It's partly that power corrupts, and absolute power corrupts absolutely. But also, that system attracts people who are attracted to power. There's a corruption of morality, partly because this is a system that rewards aggressive power-seeking. "I like power. I'm going to go into that system." So, it attracts the people who are the most vulnerable to this. As a

result, he says, in the end, the practice of socialism becomes totalitarian if it lasts long enough.

4.66 Now, sometimes countries elect socialists and then kick them out of office because there's still enough accountability left in the system. But he says that if they stay in power for long, it eventually becomes totalitarian. Why? Because you have to go along with this collective pursuit of that good we've decided on. If you don't, you're an obstacle. We have to get rid of you. We either have to control you or we have to push you aside and get rid of you.

4.67 He says the ethics that results is really different from the ethics that motivates the system altogether. You've got to pursue the accepted ends of the group, and the person who rises is the one who is willing to use maximum power to do it. The result of that is everybody has to be brought into line. Everybody has to think the same way and act the same way and pursue the same good, pursue that common set of values. It requires the general acceptance of a common worldview.

4.68 Hence, you get things like cancel culture and political correctness and all sorts of control of thought and speech, propaganda. You get censorship because everybody has to be brought into line with all of this. He says the moral results tend to be really bad. The whole system is based on an ethic of "the end justifies the means." That leads to disrespecting individual people. So, it is not a shock that in the end, the worst features follow with necessity. Everybody's got to serve this one goal.

4.69 The things about socialist systems that horrify us, when we look, for example, at Lenin's Russia, or Stalin's Russia, or Hitler's Germany, those things are really just part of the system. They aren't individual quirks of individual leaders. In the end, it's only the leaders who profit; everybody else ends up suffering. Notice that the leaders of these countries often end up billionaires and living like royalty.

4.70 Here is Richard Fernandez: "The thing about communism, at least to the uninitiated, is it appears to be identical in all respects to a hereditary aristocracy. If you didn't know better, it would seem the more communist a country, the more it resembles a monarchy." In other words, yes, a road to serfdom, a feudal system where it's as if we have a monarch at the top who becomes fabulously rich while the people are serfs, are really poor.

4.71 Another point Fernandez makes is that socialism tends to run into trouble. Here, he's going beyond Hayek, but I think it's a very interesting extension of Hayek. He says that it's just that the worst rise to the top because they're the most aggressive and the most willing to discard people as ends in pursuit of these ends that they are pursuing. It's also that they corrupt their own database. In other words, everybody has to be brought into line. At first, people are willing to tell the heroic lie, but they are succeeded by people who no longer understand that it's a lie, and they become less and less capable of actually distinguishing truth from lies.

4.72 He says the result is that increasingly the database gets corrupted. We say, "Here are the facts. Boy, the economy is actually doing very poorly, but we don't want people to know that. That challenges our power. So we'll put out false statistics." That happens in socialist countries all the time. It certainly happened in Russia. It happens in China. The result of that is, at first, you're lying to the world. You've got to keep two sets of books: "here are the real numbers; here are the numbers that we've made public."

- 4.73** But that's hard to maintain, and what happens is they start mixing together, and even the leaders don't know what the truth is. It's not as if Mao, during the Great Leap Forward, knew that these things were causing a disaster. People fed false numbers all the way up from the bottom because they'd get into big trouble if they didn't. You told the truth, you might be killed, so lie. In the end, the leadership not only is dealing with a problem far too complex to be solved, it's that they've got bad data, and the system is designed to produce increasingly bad data.
- 4.74** Now, I want to move on to a different critique of socialism. It's the one we find in George Orwell's "1984," where it corrupts integrity. Orwell himself was born Eric Arthur Blair. George Orwell was a pen name. He was born in India but educated in Britain. He worked as a police officer in Burma as a high school teacher, a bookstore clerk, a propagandist, a literary editor, a war correspondent, a dishwasher in Paris, a hop picker. He had all sorts of careers and all sorts of jobs on his way.
- 4.75** He went to Spain during the Spanish Civil War, fought on the Republican side. He was wounded, shot in the neck, in fact. But he ended up deciding that war was a mistake. In fact, he saw what we've described of the communists taking over the Republican side and the fascists eventually taking over the other side. He got disgusted with both sides. In 1944, his house was hit with a bomb. Luckily, he wasn't home. However, the manuscript for "Animal Farm" was sitting there in the house that was bombed. Luckily, it survived. He coined the term the Cold War.
- 4.76** He's an interesting case because he's a democratic socialist, so he doesn't really go along with Hayek's critique of socialism, but he's strongly anticommunist, and he's pointing out a different problem that can arise in a society that initially starts pursuing good ideals. This book has been described as a good-bad book because it's really not great as a novel. Nevertheless, it's great for its insights into social and political systems and into human psychology in a way. It was originally entitled "The Last Man in Europe," and it was published just before his death.
- 4.77** Here is Isaac Deutscher on the book: "1984 is a document of dark disillusionment, not only with Stalinism, but with every form and shade of socialism. It's a cry from the abyss of despair." On the other hand, Richard Rees says, "Obviously, it was just because he believed the issues were still undecided that he thought it was worthwhile to write these terrible warnings." So, from one point of view, this really is a critique of socialism. From the other point of view, no, he's still something of a socialist. It's just that he sees there's a way in which this can all go terribly wrong and has gone terribly wrong, and so he wants to warn you against going down that dark path.
- 4.78** It's hard to say exactly what was in Orwell's mind. He couldn't be interviewed after publication. He died. But he is, in a way, producing a book that induces despair in the reader and suggests despair on the part of the author, not only because he was dying, but because I think he saw that these, what he thought of as very good ideas, had a tendency to go terribly, terribly wrong.
- 4.79** Philip Rieff describes it this way: "Orwell's problem is how to live honestly in a world that's no longer liberal,"—classically liberal, that is, in the sense of respecting human rights and freedoms. His unique perspective on the politics and poverty of the world was gained from being very honestly involved in both." And he was very honestly involved. He was not

some ivory tower thinker. He went out there. He actually fought on various sides. He was involved in the world's affairs very closely.

4.80 He's trying to warn us of the intellectual implications of totalitarianism. And he says, "I think totalitarian ideas have taken root in the minds of intellectuals everywhere. I've tried to draw these ideas out to their logical consequences." Part of it is, all of this, he thinks, leads to a deadly emptiness at the heart of things, a meaninglessness of existence, hence the rise of existentialism and other things in this postwar period. He says, "The real problem of our time is to restore the sense of absolute right and wrong when the belief that it used to rest on—the belief in personal immortality—has been destroyed."

4.81 In other words, when you believe that if you step out of line, God will punish you, then there's a strong motivation not to step out of line. But if you've given up that belief, either because you gave up belief in God or because you think of God as either indifferent to humanity or one that's so forgiving that anything will be forgiven, then you've lost that sense that I better be good. How do you keep people actually distinguishing right from wrong and pursuing the right and trying to avoid the wrong once that's gone? The worry is that it's very hard to be a decent person and be fully alive.

4.82 Now, if we start thinking about what happens in the novel, we've got this leadership group called INGSOC, which is short for English Socialism. It's pretty clear what his target is. Amazingly, a lot of students now do not understand that. They don't realize that after the Second World War, even as Hayek's ideas were applied in Germany and Italy and the United States and Japan and a variety of places, hence the rapid rebound, actually, the opposite choice was made in Britain. They immediately, as soon as the war was won, kicked Churchill out of office and replaced him with the Labor Party that then proceeded to nationalize industries and turn England, to a large extent, into a socialist country. That remained that way until Thatcher, at least. Lately, it's been flirting with going back to it.

4.83 But in any event, he says, "The only secure basis for oligarchy is collectivism. Wealth and privilege are most easily defended when they're possessed jointly. The so-called abolition of private property, which took place in the middle years of the century, meant in effect the concentration of property in far fewer hands than before." This is something like the point that it turned out that, "Let's get rid of private property, let's have this all serve the people," ended up serving just a very few. It's as if he's saying exactly what Fernandez was saying. It turns out this starts resembling a traditional monarchy.

4.84 The problem, again, is that it centers on power. "Power is collective. The individual only has power insofar as he ceases to be an individual, but instead just pursues the goal of the group." What is power?—This is the part now that is distinctive about and horrible about "1984"—He says, "Power is an inflicting pain and humiliation." He wants to bring up the negative side of power. It's not the side of power, "I get to choose. I get to have my favorite balancing of all these various goods." It's rather, "I get to show you I'm your superior. You are down there," and inflict humiliation and pain on you. So, power, he says, tends to become not a means, but it becomes the end.

4.85 Here is another way of thinking about why the worst might rise to the top. He said, "The party seeks power for its own sake." Not for the sake of the party. He means for the sake of power. "We're not interested in the good of others; we're interested solely in power," pure power. It's not a means. It is the end.

- 4.86** I've sometimes wondered that. Certain people seek office, and they'll give you a campaign speech, and they'll say, "Here's what I'm trying to do. Here's why I want to be your president or your representative or your senator." They'll give you reasons. But others simply want that. If you say, "Why are you seeking this office?" They actually don't know what to say because they just want the power. It's not because they want this goal, and they want the power to be able to bring it about. They just want the power. Those people are dangerous.
- 4.87** I was talking to someone yesterday, in this case, about university administration. He said, "Yeah, the only people I want to be in charge are the people who don't really want to be in charge." As Plato said in *The Republic*, their motivation is, "If it's not me, it's going to be someone worse. I'm going to have to work under them." That's a good motivation. But if the motivation is, "I want to be in charge. I like being in charge of things," that's a very bad and dangerous motivation. He says that's what actually happens in a socialist system. The power is supposed to be used for the collective good. In fact, partly because that doesn't have a very definite meaning, power becomes an end in itself.
- 4.88** So he says, really—and here he's giving you the fictional history in the book—he says, "But in each variant of Socialism that appeared from about 1900 onwards, the aim of establishing liberty and equality was more and more openly abandoned. The new movements which appeared in the middle years of the century, things like Ingsoc or Neo-Bolshevism or Death-Worship, had the conscious aim of perpetuating unfreedom and inequality." That's what happened in practice.
- 4.89** So he says, "Ingsoc, which grew out of the earlier Socialist movement, and inherited its phraseology, carried out the main item in the Socialist programme, with the result, foreseen and intended beforehand. That economic inequality has been made permanent." So the sales pitch is equality; the reality is inequality. Anything, even taking a walk by yourself, was thought to be slightly dangerous. "Hey, you're supposed to be on the team. Why are you off doing that?" Everybody, in effect, is supposed to be a team player all the time. There is no I in team.
- 4.90** Well, that's inspiring if you're trying to get a baseball team motivated, maybe. But the understanding is, yeah, on the field, you're a member of the team. But you mean basically, in a social system, you're always on the field. There is no time when "I put in my eight hours, now I can go home and do my thing." No, you can't. There was a word for it in the book: own life. You're not allowed to have your own life. You've got to be on the team. You're a team player all the time. No individualism, no eccentricities. You've got to be working for the team all the time.
- 4.91** The result of all that is "a world of fear and treachery and torment,"—Orwell says—"a world of trampling and being trampled upon." It becomes more and more just vicious toward individuals, less and less merciful toward anyone. "Progress becomes progress toward more pain." And so everything ends up in the end being destroyed. "If you want a picture of the future,"—he says—"imagine a boot stamping on a human face forever." It doesn't get much bleaker than that, except when you read the book or watch the movie, which is even bleaker than the book, you realize maybe it can, because not only is this a world of trampling and being trampled upon, it is an ugly world. The ugliness comes through very strongly in the book and in the film.

- 4.92** Philip Rieff says, "Orwell describes the winter of Western civilization. Both worlds are 'desolate,' 'dank,' 'windless,' 'bleak,' 'colourless,' 'grey.' The slummy wilderness of capitalist civilization is succeeded by the slummier wilderness of totalitarian." And so it is depressing from beginning to end.
- 4.93** The thought was that socialism is going to enlarge the sphere of liberty. It's going to work for human rights. But actually, that's not how it works. It moves us in the direction of totalitarian dictatorship, where freedom of thought is the first deadly sin. Eventually, it becomes a meaningless abstraction because it becomes impossible. How does it become impossible? Well, to rule in this way, he says, you have to dislocate the sense of reality. You have to make people not able to distinguish truth from lies.
- 4.94** There has to be a constant campaign of disinformation. There's a Ministry of Truth saying things like, "war is peace," "freedom is slavery," "ignorance is strength," all of these things that are obviously false, but nevertheless have to be drummed into people's heads. The belief has to be that Big Brother is omnipotent, the party is infallible. Of course, they aren't, and that's why this falsification has to occur. If I am up there saying, "I'm a leader, but I'm a human being. I'm imperfect. I'll do the best I can, and if I make a mistake, I'll just admit my mistake." Okay, that would be honest, and I can stay honest if I have that attitude.
- 4.95** But now, how often have you ever seen a politician say, "Yeah, that policy was a mistake. I supported that policy. I now regret it. I think we should now repeal that bill," or something. It almost never happens. People keep doubling down. Well, if they are in positions of real power, greater power, and they don't even have to face an electorate, it becomes worse and worse. And so there's increasing flexibility on facts. There can even be all these contradictions: "Yesterday, I said this; today, I say that." Both times, completely sincere. You say, "You changed your mind." "No, I didn't." There are all these contradictions.
- 4.96** Basically, the party starts opposing everything that socialism once stood for, and it claims all this is true in the name of socialism. Think about Stalin saying that it all depends on time, circumstance, place. In other words, "The fact that I said that yesterday means nothing today. Today, socialism is something else." And it becomes a strength of the system that it has that flexibility. It talks about having all of these things done in the name of the working class. But in fact, there is contempt for the working class among the leadership.
- 4.97** In the end, he says, there's a Ministry of Peace, but in fact it promotes war. There's a Ministry of Truth, but it tells the lies. There's a Ministry of Love that tortures people, and a Ministry of Plenty that actually produces starvation. It's exactly the opposite of the truth.
- 4.98** Here, in a way, he says, is the root of the problem: "You believe that reality is something objective, external, existing in its own right. You also believe the nature of reality is self-evident. When you dilute yourself into thinking you see something, you assume that everyone else sees the same thing as you." But the socialist denies that. I think here, it's partly that socialism produces a situation where you have to deny it, but it's partly that it arises out of that idealist temptation.
- 4.99** Jorge Luis Borjas tells a story of a planet that is thoroughly idealist. There are no nouns, in fact. There are no objects. There are just ideas and combinations of ideas. Everything in the end is mental. So there are no facts. There are just perceptions. And in that world, he says, it starts as a fiction, but it increasingly takes over the real world. Why? Because it

has an order to it. And he says that people forget that it's an order of chessmasters, not an order of angels. In other words, yes, it's something that we can decipher, that we built, and that we think we therefore can understand.

4.100 There's an appeal to that. But reality starts yielding to it. In fact, he says that it longed to yield because we want rational order. We want to think it's all intelligible. There's something appealing about the thought, "Yeah, it's just perception. There are no hard facts we really have to confront." But if you have that attitude, not only you're going to be tempted to say, "So I can tell you whatever story I want."

4.101 By the way, I've interacted in my time with many people in the world of advertising, and they tend to be idealists in this way. They'll say, "The product doesn't matter. It's all a matter of perception." I tend to say, "That's not right." You may convince me this is great, for example, and delicious, but if I taste it and hate it, the classic thing is that the dogs don't like the dog food. That's a problem. Eventually, people are going to realize that. It doesn't matter how many commercials you run and how much you shape the perception. Well, it matters initially. They'll say, "Oh, I want to try that," but the dog doesn't like the dog food, or you don't like this new product or something, it falls apart.

4.102 That's what happens in socialism. When you have it starting to fall apart in that way, you have to deny the reality, and it helps if you say, "No, the world is just how you perceive it." That's how I tell you. He says, at one point, the person who is trying to get Winston, the hero of the novel, to change his mind to become a good socialist, "I tell you, Winston, that reality is not external. Reality exists in the human mind and nowhere else. Not in the individual mind, which can make mistakes, of course, and in any case, soon perishes; only in the mind of the Party, which is collective and immortal. Whatever the Party holds to be the truth is truth. It's impossible to see reality except by looking through the eyes of the Party. We control matter because we control the mind. Reality is inside the skull. Get rid of these nineteenth-century ideas about the laws of Nature. We make the laws of Nature."

4.103 Kind of like under Stalin, the economist saying that we're bound by no laws; we get to decide on the laws of economics. "Nothing exists except through human consciousness," says this leader. "Outside man there is nothing." So you imagine, you think eventually, you'll defeat this system. "There's something called human nature that will be outraged by this and turn against us. But we create human nature. Men are infinitely malleable." People are plastic. We can mold them into whatever we want.

4.104 Here is the response of Winston at that point, before he is actually finally converted. "I know that you'll fail. There's something in the universe—I don't know, some spirit, some principle—that you'll never overcome." But the difficulty is, even Winston, in the end, gives up and actually loves Big Brother. So it is a depressing story.

4.105 Orwell says, "In our society, those who have the best knowledge of what's happening are also those who are furthest from seeing the world as it is. In general, the greater the understanding, the greater the delusion, the more intelligent, the less sane." He says that there are some things that are so crazy that only an intellectual could believe them because you have to tell yourself such a story to talk yourself into that. "One has to belong to the intelligence here to believe things like that. No ordinary man could be such a fool."

4.106 Indeed, it all comes down to things like this, very simple truths like $2 + 2 = 4$; if that's granted, all else follows. But he says the problem is sometimes it's hard to articulate and

defend, and actually not get persecuted for saying such obvious things. He says, "We've sunk to a depth at which the restatement of the obvious is the first duty of intelligent men."

4.107 In the most famous scene in the novel, this leader is holding up fingers and says, "How many fingers am I holding up, Winston?" "Four." "And if the party says it's not four but five, then how many?" "Four." "Sometimes, Winston. Sometimes they're five. Sometimes they're three. Sometimes they're all of them at once. You must try harder. It's not easy to become sane." So in the end, they force Winston to deny certain obvious truths.

4.108 The language has changed to make that easier. Newspeak actually tries to get rid of language that could possibly express a dissident thought. All other modes of thought become impossible. The whole aim is to narrow the range of thought. You can't call things what they really are. You have to describe them in terms that don't fit. In that way, even the simplest use of language involves a lie. There's a sense of delusion that goes with it.

4.109 The last point he makes about this change of thought is doublethink. It's hard to understand, but the idea is that you hold two contradictory beliefs in one's mind. Simultaneously, you accept both of them, and yet you're aware they contradict each other. It's not because you believe that in some sense, reality is contradictory. You say this, and at the time you're saying it, you know it's not true, and yet you say it with complete sincerity, not just in the sense of being a good liar, but you actually believe it as you say.

4.110 I would not have thought this was possible. I read this book in high school. I thought nobody could be like that. Then I started watching the news and realized, yes, they can. It really makes you think, "I'm not lying. I totally believe this as I say it," even though in some sense you know this is a false narrative. It is a necessary deception, and yet when you say it, you completely believe it. Once you get into that, it becomes very hard. Big Brother is watching you all the time. Any thought crime, any slip of the tongue, can get you into big trouble.

4.111 So you, in the end, start denying your own memories. You start denying the obvious truths in front of you. In the end, why? Because really, you start believing this claim that there is no objectivity, there is no external existence, there is no fact to which you have to actually be held responsible.

4.112 What's the point of all this? Hannah Arendt said that it's not really about making people believe the lies, but making sure nobody believes anything anymore. No one can distinguish truth from falsehood or right from wrong. In other cases, as Theodore Dalrymple has said, really the goal is just to humiliate you. They don't expect you to believe it. In fact, the less it corresponds to reality, the better. The point of getting you to deny $2 + 2 = 4$ is not to change your minds about math. It is instead to make you humiliated and make you realize that they can make you say and do anything, to utterly lose this sense of dignity, self-respect, or even sanity.

4.113 How do you stay sane? How do you stay a normal person? How do you remain ethical in such a system? Today, people sometimes read "1984" and are astounded that already then, he foresaw so many things that would later happen in the world. Boy, did he call it or what? The end.

4.114 Number one, thank you for your definitions in one of the past lectures on fascism, socialism, and communism. I've never heard it explained better.

4.115 Oh, thank you.

- 4.116** In light of that, globally, so many different countries, especially in Europe, but even here in the United States, you see a lot of parties that say democratic socialism, just as I think Orwell was a democratic socialist. It seems an oxymoron, democratic socialism. Could you comment on what democratic socialism, I guess, how would that even work?
- 4.117** I think democratic socialism is possible, but it's also delicate. Let me explain. Socialism is the centralized conscious direction of social forces to consciously chosen ends. But how are they consciously chosen in both cases? There is this conscious choice of leaders at the center who are going to then be in charge of pursuing these consciously chosen ends. But somebody has to be consciously choosing the ends. Somebody has to be consciously choosing the means and consciously choosing the leaders. So the question is: how does all that happen?
- 4.118** The democratic socialist says, "I want those processes to be democratic." That is to say, people will vote on the proper ends. People will vote for at least the leaders who will choose the means. Normally, they don't have the people choosing the means directly. There'd be no need for the centralized leadership then. So the people can have two things, two roles: one is helping to choose those ends, and one is choosing the leaders to choose the means. That can happen. There are countries where democratic socialists have been democratically elected and then also can be democratically thrown out of office. I don't want to say that always we end up with a totalitarian society as a result of all of this. There are counterexamples to that.
- 4.119** On the other hand, once somebody is in office, it can be really tempting to say, "But wait, if you vote me out of office, you chose that goal, and I'm the guy who's pursuing that goal. These guys don't want to pursue that goal. You want me to leave the office?" So they find ways of clinging to power. And so, actually getting rid of a socialist government is often not so easy. There's a saying that you can vote your way in, but you have to shoot your way out. Again, I don't think that's always true, but it turns out often to be true. Why? Partly because now this centralized group has a great amount of power. You've given them that power, and they can use it for their own ends. You can get rid of them in theory, but it's pretty hard, and they have a temptation then to use their power to stay in power.
- 4.120** Consequently, I think in theory, you could say that, sure, the people will vote on the ends, and then they'll vote on the leaders who will pursue those ends. Great. Those leaders will be accountable, and if they don't achieve those ends, the people can vote them out. It could happen, but it's a danger because you're in effect giving a large amount of power to a relatively small group. Will they actually leave office? Will they actually give up that power voluntarily? Maybe. There are cases where they have. But Orwell, as well as Hayek, are worried that all too often that doesn't happen. It becomes hard to get rid of them.
- 4.121** In fact, think about the history of socialism in Italy or in Germany: Mussolini did face an election in 1924. Hitler was democratically elected in 1932, and yet once they were in power, elections were canceled, opposition parties were ruled out, and so on. There have been cases in Italy or the Labour Party in England where socialist programs are enacted, but eventually people are voted out of office, and they get overturned. So, it can happen, but it requires a very strong system of respecting the people's voices and not allowing that

group to claim permanent power. The UK and Italy have had that, but Russia and Germany and Italy at an earlier stage did not have it.

4.122 I think a lot depends on the democratic conditions or traditions of a country and how strong that basis is for maintaining that form of government. It's hard to do. I don't know what the statistics are, but I don't like the odds. They were seeing case after case after case where it had turned totalitarian. They hadn't yet seen the cases postwar, where there was a flirtation with socialism, but then countries backed away.

4.123 This rhymes with the idea of Newspeak in "1984." We talk about propaganda. We talk about terms like gaslighting. Particularly in the 20th century and even now, can you comment on how the morphing of language is really affecting the situation we're in? I mean, for example, fascism doesn't mean what it's always being used as. We're seeing—you alluded a couple of times to classical liberalism versus what we take liberal to mean right now. The language is really morphing. I'd really be interested in your thoughts on how that language adjustment is playing into the devolution of what we're seeing right now.

4.124 Language does change, and terms start being used sometimes just through a subconscious shift in language. There are all sorts of changes that occur, some of which we're going to be talking about soon. But I think in a lot of cases, there's also this attempt to take a label that starts having a certain significance and either appropriating it if it's a good significance or rejecting it if it's a bad one and applying it to your opponent.

4.125 For example, the tendency in the United States of people to call somebody else their political opponent a fascist is not a new thing. Actually, FDR was doing it in 1940 in that election campaign, and it's frequently been done. In fact, I'm trying to think of Republican candidates who were not called fascists when they were running for President. About the only one I can really think of as a clear case is Dwight Eisenhower, simply because he had just been the Supreme Commander of the Allied Forces, defeating the fascists. So, it was pretty hard to call him a fascist. But everybody—it just becomes this label.

4.126 And already in politics and the English language, in 1944, Orwell was complaining that people were applying it to dogs and so on. And I think it's something like this: fascism starts out being a particular thing started by Mussolini in Italy. It has those features of being a nationalist form of socialism that has a strong idealistic foundation, believes that narratives and stories and perceptions are really fundamental and that you should govern primarily through that, but also through a willingness to use violence, forgetting about the rule of law.

4.127 Pretty quickly, people start thinking, "Okay, so fascism is about control." They think, "All of that comes to really controlling my life." At first, it's total control of your life. But then, it's like, "You're trying to control me in this sphere." Then it's like, "You're trying to tell me I can't do this. Then you're telling me I shouldn't do that." And what started out being, "Hey, I want complete control of everybody's lives," becomes "You told me no, and I don't like that." So, you imagine the two-year-old calling mommy a fascist for saying, "Don't do that. You can't have a cookie." You can see how that progression has happened.

4.128 In politics, I think it's been the same way. Partly, it's total control to partial control, to saying no and then just disagreeing with me. All of a sudden, I'm calling fascists anybody who disagrees with me, which is, I think, a pretty crazy thing. Now, I have some time—I confess, I once called a dean a fascist, simply because he wanted to ban all fraternities

and sororities on campus. I thought that was an inappropriate form of control of students' lives. But on the other hand, now I feel guilty about having done this. I myself at that point contributed to the devolution of this term. He did want to control the social lives of students, but that's very different from the control that Mussolini and Hitler and other fascists have pursued. I myself have been guilty of this in the past when sufficiently angry at someone. And by the way, I did say, "By the way, I apologize, nothing personal. I think all administrators are fascists," something that probably a lot of faculty members feel, but nevertheless, a bad use of this term.

4.129 So, I think sometimes it is natural enough, and it gets watered down. But here's the problem with it: the highly pejorative sense doesn't really go away. It would not be so bad if it starts out being a terrible thing after World War II to call a person a fascist. In fact, the famous Supreme Court case, *Chaplinsky v. New Hampshire*, is where the fighting words doctrine comes from in free speech jurisprudence. The fighting words were somebody calling someone else a goddamn fascist. That was justified—that justified a punch in the nose, according to the Supreme Court at that time. That pejorative sense of "this is a profound insult" remains even once it means "you disagree with me" or you just said no to someone. I think that's part of why this becomes both a potent weapon, but also a problem in society.

4.130 The same thing can happen with things that are good. For example, classical liberalism had a very strongly positive connotation. But then when progressivism got a very bad name at the end of World War I, the Democratic Party decided, "We're going to call ourselves liberal." That seemed like a very good thing. People supported liberalism, and they added this other dimension of liberality: not only freedom and human rights, but also generosity. It's like, "Yeah, we're all for that."

4.131 But over time, that started getting a pejorative reputation. At some point, probably after the Dukakis campaign, the Democrats decided that liberal had become poisoned, so "we're going to call ourselves something else." People had forgotten that progressivism was bad. It had this really negative connotation by 1920. So, they said, "Let's call ourselves progressives." I think actually there was a philosophical change there. That wasn't just a labeling issue.

4.132 However, the problem is then these emotional contents sometimes linger for a very long time, but sometimes they go away. That lets us use language in ways that become pretty misleading. Maybe now what I'm saying is, "You disagree with me. I think you're wrong," but instead I call you this bad name. Or maybe I adopt a label that actually, if people remembered the past, they would say, "Wait, that got us into a lot of trouble, didn't it?" But people have forgotten about that connotation of the term, so they think, "Yeah, that's okay. I haven't heard that one in a while."

4.133 That thing, I think, happens with socialism as well because it develops a negative reputation, let's say. In 1989, with the fall of the Berlin Wall, unimaginable that people would then, a few decades later, be embracing socialism. And yet that pejorative sense goes away. And even though the concept doesn't really change, the emotional content changes. So I think the problem, in a sense, is the real content of the term and this emotional connotation don't always go together, and one can be used to mislead you about the other.

5. A Renaissance of Wonder

- 5.1 A Renaissance of Wonder—that's what I'm going to be talking about now. This is a wild tie that I'm wearing, and I'm going to be talking about some wild ideas. But there is a sense in which, after the Second World War, people were very concerned with questions of what I've been calling normativity, the oughts, questions of just and unjust, right and wrong, good and bad.
- 5.2 It was easy to be cynical about those things before the Second World War, very hard to be cynical about them afterwards, because after all, there were examples of real evil, and there were real moral dilemmas that even the leaders of the good countries, from our point of view, had to face. To what extent do you respond to, let's say, bombing of civilian areas in your country by bombing civilian areas in other countries and so on? So there were hard moral choices and examples of real evil.
- 5.3 So it became difficult to be cynical about morality, cynical about right and wrong, and say, "Oh, it's just a matter of murder, boo, genocide, boo," and so on. That led to the reconsiderations that we've been contemplating, but there are additional questions that began to arise. I want to talk about a number of people's ideas that began to think hard about this underlying moral question and underlying philosophical question, really metaphysical question, about the extent to which we can actually get through our own perceptions, through our own language and thought, to the reality itself.
- 5.4 Is our contact with reality direct? Or is it the case that reality is nothing but the perceptions, the idea that, in a sense, seems to motivate some of the direction toward totalitarianism or socialism or other kinds of movements? But also, is it possible that even if there is an external reality, our perception of it so extensively filters our access to it that we are always operating at one remove? We have no direct contact with it at all. And so, we're going to begin thinking about a number of movements and thinkers that start questioning that contact between us and reality.
- 5.5 From one point of view, raising, I think, the deepest philosophical question of all, which is really, what is the connection between mind and world? What does thought have to do with reality? What does language have to do with reality? How do we actually function in a world that we may or may not have any very direct contact with? So that broad question of the link between mind and world, if any, is really the thing that's going to be underlying what I say now and then in our next lecture as well.
- 5.6 Let me begin with the thought of Iris Murdoch. Iris Murdoch was a British philosopher and novelist. She was born in Dublin and worked for many years with the United Nations, was a philosophy fellow at St. Anne's College in Oxford, and published 25 books, many of them novels, and many of them highly accessible, really wonderful novels. One of her themes is that we live in a fantasy world, a world of illusion. The great task in life is to find reality.
- 5.7 And so the metaphysical question of our ability to find reality and get out of the realm of our own perception, the trap of our own minds, she says, is not only a deep metaphysical question, it is a deep moral question. She's a fan of Plato partly because he sees the metaphysical and the moral as intimately connected together. Indeed, her last book is

called "Metaphysics as a Guide to Morals," which is really all about that connection between questions of mind and world, metaphysical questions, and moral questions about the nature of leading a good life.

5.8 So I want to talk in particular today, mostly about a book called "Under the Net." It is a very funny book, at least I think it's funny. I just assigned it to my students. Most of them did not get the jokes, which I find sad. But on the other hand, it requires a level of sophistication to understand her humor. There's a lot of humor, but it's subtle. It's British humor.

5.9 In any case, it's all about a certain character, Jake, who in many ways lives as an existentialist, lives by moment to moment, sleeping in other people's places, living on people's couches. He doesn't really have much of a plan for his life. He translates some things from the French in order to make a living. The books aren't very good, but he thinks, "Well, it makes me some money, and they sell pretty well," and so on. Now, he encounters this fellow Hugo, who turns out to be very wealthy.

5.10 There is this long dialogue in the book between the two of them about that metaphysical question: What is the connection between mind and world? If you think this doesn't sound like a very funny way of organizing a novel, trust me, it is. It works. But nevertheless, there's a huge amount of discussion about the nature of language and the nature of thought. And so, at times, the idea of truth in the novel is treated in an ordinary way, as if it's not a problem to think about what's true and what's false. Look, a thought or a thing I say, an utterance, is true if it matches the reality. That's traditionally the correspondence theory of truth. It corresponds to reality. It pictures it in some way. It represents it in some fashion.

5.11 "If I spoke now, there was always the danger of my telling the truth. When caught unawares, I usually tell the truth, and what's duller than that?" says Jake. And so, at this point, truth is something he doesn't think much about. It's like, yeah, it's just the obvious thing. If I say that the floors are white, if they're white, then it's true. No problem.

5.12 But then he meets Hugo. Hugo, he says, is a really interesting person because, in one sense, he has a theory of everything, no matter what the topic. His business is fireworks, but he talks about almost anything. He knows something about a huge number of things, and he always has a view about it. He always has a theory. On the other hand, there's no master theory. There's no grand narrative. There's no one story it all fits into. It's like, this topic comes up, "Oh, let me tell you all about that. Here's my ideas about that." He has ideas about everything, but no grand idea.

5.13 And indeed, Jake says, "I've never met a man more destitute than Hugo of anything that could be called a metaphysics or a general Weltanschauung," a general worldview. He seemed to be purely objective. It was just, I look at this and take it on its own terms, look at that and take it on its own terms. He was a detached person, as "detached as anyone I've ever met—only in him, detachment showed less like a virtue and more like a sheer gift of nature, a thing of which he was quite unaware." Surprisingly unemotional. Knew everything about everything, it seemed, and yet had no grand theory and also didn't seem emotionally involved in much of any of it. "He noticed details. He never really classified. Each thing was its own thing, and he had his own separate view of it." But now they start talking about the nature of language and the nature of thought.

- 5.14** Then Hugo begins to make Jake doubt all of this. Hugo says, "I try to describe things, but things are falsified from the start. As soon as I start to describe, I'm done for. The language just won't let you present it as it really was." They've been sitting around—
- 5.15** By the way, the setup here is that Jake has no money, and so he decides to enter into this experiment, medical experiment, where they purposely give people colds and then try out various cold medicines. You're just confined there for a couple of weeks as you have this cold. Hugo, it turns out, is his roommate in this thing, also being a subject of these medical experiments. They start talking, and they find they have so much in common and talk about all these issues, that they keep getting reinfected until finally they kick them out, thinking, "This is a danger to your health. Why don't you leave?"
- 5.16** But in any case, they're talking about things like this. Hugo begins to say that maybe all thought, all language, falsifies things. At this rate, almost everything one says turns out to be a sort of lie. Jake is summarizing the discussion, and "Hugo pondered this. 'I think it's so,' he said with seriousness. 'In that case, one oughtn't to talk,' I said. 'I think perhaps one oughtn't to,' said Hugo, and he was deadly serious. Then I caught his eye, and we both laughed enormously, thinking how we'd been doing nothing else for days on end."
- 5.17** So maybe you shouldn't talk at all if language falsifies things. Now, why would you think "language is a machine for making falsehoods" and that "we never really communicate"? Hugo says, "I suppose actions don't lie." But here's the idea. When we use language, we do classify, we think of things in certain terms. And the worry here—and by the way, this is a worry that goes back at least to Nietzsche, but in some ways, I think, all the way back to Plato's dialogue, the Gorgias.
- 5.18** Because what's happening is that we are saying that is that. "That is a cat," let's say, or "this is a glass of water." We're classifying things. We may be right about that in the tradition. It's like, yeah, that is a cat. It's true. If that's a cat, what's the problem? Similarly, yes, is that a glass of water? Well, is it a glass? Yes. Is there water in it? Does it correspond with what's actually in the glass? Yes. So it's true. What's the problem?
- 5.19** Indeed, when you think of it from that point of view, this whole discussion seems bizarre. But the thought is, I'm classifying it, and I'm now saying something about it, saying it's like these things, not like those things. I'm imposing a scheme on this, saying, "Here is my grid in thought or in language. I'm imposing this grid on reality and saying, 'Here's how it lines up.'" But what if it doesn't line up perfectly? There are two worries I can have.
- 5.20** First of all, I'm leaving a lot out. I'm saying, "That's a cat," but that's a very incomplete description of what's in front of me. I might worry that it's not so much I'm falsifying, I'm just saying something so incomplete. And insofar as it's that, then we are communicating. It's just that our communication is fragmentary. I'm describing one fact of infinitely many that I could say about that creature in front of me or the glass of water. Yes, it has many, many features, and I'm just singling out one or two.
- 5.21** And so in that respect, you might say I'm falsifying by oversimplifying reality. So that would be one interpretation—falsifying just by making it way too simple. There's, in fact, infinite complexity here, and I'm singling out a few features. Still, that doesn't seem enough to make it false. That just makes it fragmentary.
- 5.22** I think something deeper is underlying this worry that Hugo has and that Murdoch has in the book, which is, what if, in the beginning, the things don't line up? The way

philosophers sometimes think of this is, what if language, what if thought, does not carve reality at its joints? That's a way of thinking about it that might be better expressed this way. What if I, in language or in thought, have a bunch of square pegs and I'm trying to fit them into round holes? That is to say, reality is entirely round. But I've got, in thought, these square pegs, and I'm trying to stick them in there and say, "This is the cat one." Well, it sort of fits that one, but not really. There are always things that it is getting wrong. It's the wrong conceptual framework.

- 5.23** Imagine someone trying to understand what's happening, let's say, at very high temperatures in plasma physics or at high velocities, when you're thinking about the theory of relativity, but without the relevant concepts. In a way, you don't have to go that far back. Think about, let's say, chemistry before people understood oxidation, and they talked about phlogiston, or think about Newtonian physics for that matter, and then try to apply it to plasma-type situations, or try to apply it to velocities very close to the speed of light, and problems emerge.
- 5.24** And so, you take Newtonian physics, let's say, and you're describing the reality. Really, this is high school physics. This is what we teach people in high school. But we're giving them a bunch of pegs and asking them to fit them into a reality where they don't exactly fit. It's roughly right, but the edges aren't right. It's not really quite fitting in correctly. What if all language is like that? What if all language, all thought, is basically us trying to apply Newtonian physics or phlogiston chemistry in a situation where that's not really what's going on? I think that's the underlying worry.
- 5.25** After all, we have evolved to be a certain kind of creature, and this is a worry that Alvin Plantinga has brought up, I think, and other people in other contexts, like Sharon Street, have thought about in morality. What if it turns out that evolution is responsible for a set of concepts that are good for survival, but not very good for describing reality?
- 5.26** Now, from one point of view, you might say, "But wait, wait, wait. They've got to be good for describing reality, because we're surviving. Or at least most of the time we're surviving, so we must be getting things right." I mean, I back out of the street because I see the bus is heading toward me. I survive. The bus goes by, and I think, yes, I perceived that correctly. But not all things are like buses, first of all, and that obvious. But secondly, when you start thinking about the nature of reality itself, you might realize, "Hold on a second. Actually, the way I ordinarily perceive the world isn't that close to the way the world is."
- 5.27** Let me go back to that idea that I've been talking about periodically: the contrast between the manifest and the scientific images. Suppose I think, here's the nature of reality. It's described in the scientific image. That's what the right physics, anyway, the right chemistry, the right biology would be talking about. Maybe we're close to that in certain areas, maybe we're not. It might be that people of the future will look back and think of us as something like phlogiston chemists. But nevertheless, whatever is going on there, it's described in a sophisticated scientific theory.
- 5.28** Now, you and I are up here talking about cats and dogs and tables and chairs and people. What if, from the point of view of that physics, the actual underlying reality, cats and dogs and people and chairs, I mean, that's not what the world really consists of. It consists of these microparticles or these fields or whatever it is that that ultimate scientific theory says.

- 5.29** If that's right, then in a certain sense, we are going around all the time with these square pegs. The reality is a bunch of tiny round holes, and we're with these big, blunt square pegs, trying to talk about things. Well, there's something we're communicating maybe by doing that, but we're doing a lousy job of actually discussing reality. I think that is part of what underlies Murdoch's worry and Hugo's worry in the book. What if we never really communicate and never really get things right, simply because the language—we're dealing with concepts that aren't even at the right level of fine-grainedness to describe reality. So, in part, we're doing it very roughly and approximately, but partly we're just using a set of concepts that in the end we would just discard as not really relevant to the underlying reality.
- 5.30** Anyway, that's the worry. And so, Hugo, and actually at this point, Jake, he feels terribly guilty about it, but he writes a book that is about these conversations. He stylizes it, fills in details later, fills in arguments later and so on, but he's describing all this. In his summary, the characters that represent himself and Hugo, one of them says, "The movement away from theory and generality is the movement toward truth. All theorizing is flight. We must be ruled by the situation itself, and this is unutterably particular."
- 5.31** There is a philosophical view that emerges from this, which is known as particularism. The idea is, whenever we generalize, we're falsifying. If I say murder is wrong, there's a kind of falsification in that, for example, because I can talk about particular events or occurrences, and I can maybe, maybe get those right. But as soon as I generalize, now I'm at the level of kinds of things as opposed to particular things. I'm at the level of "all other things being equal," or as Aristotle puts it, "roughly and in outline," because it's never the case that, well, let's say all murder is always wrong. Maybe there could be justifiable murders.
- 5.32** Or maybe I look at other kinds of generalizations we make. I say, "Birds fly," and you say, "Not poor Tweety there, Tweety's sick." Or, "Hey, I've got a penguin here. It's not flying," and so on. What if all generality involves a kind of falsification? It's true only roughly in an outline, to use Aristotle's phrase. Then the only real truths are just particular truths. Some people have taken this thought very, very seriously.
- 5.33** Jonathan Dancy, my recently retired colleague, is a particularist in ethics, the world's leading particularist, really, who has revived that view and applied it to ethics and says, in fact, in his book, "Ethics Without Principles," that people think of ethics as acting in a principled way, but forget about that. All principles move us away from the truth. In effect, he thinks this is exactly right. Moving away from theory and generality moves you toward truth. In the end, the ethical truths are all particular truths. That that was wrong or that this is right. They are not generalizable. We're always, in effect, flying from reality by generalizing it all.
- 5.34** In this book, the worry here is this. "Indeed, it's something to which we can never get close enough." In other words, the reality, the fact, we can never get close enough, "however hard we may try, as it were, to crawl under the net." That's the passage that gives the novel its title. The idea is, the net is thought, the net is language, the net is our conceptual framework that seems to be the terms that we use for describing the underlying reality. But we can't get there. It looks as if we can never get close to the reality itself; we're always caught inside this net.

- 5.35** We're seeing things filtered through the net. We're seeing things with this as our framework for understanding them, when the reality looks very, very different. And so, that's the worry, that we're trapped in our own thoughts. We're trapped in our own language, trapped in our own conceptual scheme. We can't get at the language, which may have a radically different form. And so, the conclusion in the book: "Truth can be attained, if at all, only in silence." You can just appreciate the particular. But the moment you say anything, the moment you frame a thought about it, you're already falsifying.
- 5.36** Here, I think, she is echoing Wittgenstein's sentence at the very end of the *Tractatus*. "What cannot be said must be passed over in silence." There are certain things and certain truths, maybe all truths of the world, can't really be said. So what Wittgenstein thought was true about ethics and certain other things, the meaning of life, for example, he said that it's not that it's a meaningless question, really. It's not that it's an insignificant question. It's just that it can't really be articulated. It can't be expressed, and no answer to it could be expressed. And so, it must be passed over in silence. What if everything's like that? What if everything, really, in the end, if you don't want to falsify it in any way, has to be passed over in silence?
- 5.37** Eventually, Jake shows Hugo this book, confessing that he wrote some of this down. Hugo reads it and says, "I know you think this reflects our conversations," but he said, "I don't recognize the reflections. I don't get it. I don't remember it that way at all." In the end, he says, "I don't really think any of that's true. I mean, truth lies in blundering on." Jake responds, saying, "Oh, to hell with truth. Actions don't lie. Words always do." Here, he's just echoing what Hugo had said to him in these conversations. "But now I see that this was all a hallucination."
- 5.38** This is the place where Jake has this sudden revelation because he was sucked into this. At first, he's naive, just truth is matching the reality, whatever. And then he gets sucked into this way of thinking, which is, wait, what if truth is false? What if truth is on a table? What if language and thought falsify by their very natures? Then, when he realizes, "Wait, Hugo doesn't remember any of it this way," he starts saying, "Wait, what if all of this is a hallucination? What if, in other words, I was right in my naive approach in the beginning? What if all this is nonsense?"
- 5.39** He's reflecting then about things, and thinking about that theme of the relation between mind and world. And he says, as he's walking around London and being silent and just contemplating, he says, "There's something compelling about the sound of a fountain in a deserted place. It murmurs about what things do when no one watches them. It's the hearing of an unheard sound, a gentle refutation of Berkeley."
- 5.40** Berkeley was the person who said, "To be is to be perceived." There are no objects in the world. There are just thoughts, feelings, perceptions, ideas, that somehow get bundled together and we call them objects, but there are no material objects. Or if there were, we'd have no way of knowing about it. Instead, all we have are these thoughts, these ideas.
- 5.41** That leads to the traditional sloppy philosophical question—if a tree fell in the forest and nobody was around to hear it, would it make a sound? Well, does a fountain make a sound if there's nobody around it? As he passes by, he's thinking, "Yeah, that's a gentle refutation of Berkeley." In other words, yeah, it's there, and it's doing what it does, whether there's anybody here or not. The fountain is real. It's not just a question of perceptions.

- 5.42** At that point, Jake starts thinking about the nature of reflections, Hugo saying to him, "I don't recognize the reflections." But also, reflection is something that is a theme of the novel. I think here, too, is an underlying idea that Murdoch is gradually commenting on. What is the relation between mind and world?
- 5.43** Here's a traditional way of thinking about it. The mind is a mirror of nature. It is a mirror of the world. That's a thought that goes far back in Western philosophy, but it's also there in Chinese philosophy throughout its entire history. The thought is a mind. The mind is a kind of mirror of the world, and it's important to keep it clean because it's easily clouded by desire or other things.
- 5.44** So, from one point of view, you could say the whole question of this book is: Is the mind a mirror of reality? If it is, can you clear it? Or is it inevitably cloudy, inevitably giving you a funhouse distorted picture of the underlying reality?
- 5.45** I don't know if you've ever been into one of these funhouses. You will stand in front of this mirror. You look very fat. Stand in front of this one, and you look very thin. I actually have one in my house. It's not intentional. It's just not a very good mirror, and it always makes me look thin. I love that mirror. It's like, that's the way I really want to look. But in any case, is the mirror reflecting the actual reality, or is it distorting it in some way? And so, that thought about reflection, and the mind as reflecting reality, that's something that is constantly mentioned. Reflections is a big deal in the book.
- 5.46** At one point, Jake says, "At a certain point, perhaps one ought to simply stop reflecting." It's rather like that idea of maybe you should just stop speaking. But later, once he gets disillusioned with Hugo and with Hugo's failure to remember any of this, he says, "Hugo was a man without claims and without reflections. Why had I pursued him? He had nothing to tell me." So maybe some reflections are distortions.
- 5.47** Now, one of the things that, from a philosopher's point of view, is funny, but I think actually has a real significance in the book. Dave, this friend of Jake's, who is a philosophy professor, and by the way, reflects a real person, David Pears, but anyway, "he was writing an article for Mind on the incongruity of counterparts. He'd been working on this for a long time in front of a mirror, staring at his reflection, examining his two hands. He had several times tried to explain to me a solution, but I hadn't yet got as far as grasping the problem."
- 5.48** David Pears was a real person, and he really did write such an article. There it is, "The Incongruity of Counterparts," in the early '50s, in Mind. He says, "If I look in a mirror, the left side of my face will appear as the right side of my face." That's partly why we're so shocked when we see photographs of ourselves. It's like, flipped around. That's not how we see ourselves. But the same problem arises with hands. I think about the right hand and the left hand, and from one point of view, they match, but from another point of view, they don't. The thumbs are on opposite sides, as you find out when you try to put on the wrong glove, and you realize, "Oh, they're similar and yet they're somehow different." That's what this whole thing is.
- 5.49** But here's the point: in a way, the mirror reflection or the two hands, they're in effect reflections of each other. One is like the other. My image in the mirror is like me, but not exactly. It's flipped around somehow. And so, what if the mind, as a mirror of nature, is doing that reality? It's not that it's so cloudy you can barely see through it and so on; it's

not that there's a net over it or something. But what if it's just flipping things around? After all, mirrors do that.

5.50 And so what if our minds are like that? What if they are flipping reality around in some way? Are we actually seeing the reality, or are we seeing this mirror-type of image, as if reality is the right hand and we're thinking of things in terms of the left hand? We're getting it kind of right and kind of wrong. At one point, indeed, Jake says, "The eyes are a mirror of the soul." So that idea of mirrors, of reflections, goes all the way through the book, something that is in part telling you what's there and, in part, flipping it around, distorting it in some way.

5.51 There's another theme, too. "I seem to be throwing away the substance for the shadow," as Jake puts it at one point. "What I was preferring was an emptiness of which I could give no intelligible account whatever." That idea of the substance versus the shadow is also there. You see the shadow of something, and it shows you something about the reality, but not the full reality, and it's often distorted. Your shadow might appear very much shorter than you or very much longer than you at different times of day and so on. It's similar and yet different.

5.52 That idea of shadows runs throughout the book, and I think is, for Murdoch, really important. He starts realizing, yes, I've been seizing the shadow instead of the reality. In other words, he sees himself as a writer. He wants to write these books, but instead, he spends his time translating rather bad books from French.

5.53 Near the end, the person he's been translating actually writes a brilliant book. Jake is terribly upset by that, partly because that guy is supposed to be a hack writer. What do you mean, he wrote a really good book? But he also realizes that if that guy can do this, I can do this. And he realizes, yeah, I've been just doing cheap stuff. I've been writing this junk. I have been translating bad books. First of all, I should translate his really good book. But secondly, I should write my really good book. And so he realizes, yeah, I've been chasing after these shadows, not the thing that really matters to me. There's this path ahead of me, and if I don't take it, it's going to lay untrodden forever. What am I doing? I'm chasing these shadows instead. I'm doing all this mediocre stuff. But he said, "I see now the possibility of doing better. I smiled with a smile that penetrated my whole being like the sun."

5.54 That idea is deep in Plato and Murdoch, as a Platonist in the end, the thought of Plato's cave. We, Plato says, are like prisoners being held in this cave. We're seeing shadows cast on a wall, and we think the actual objects are just those shadows. We think of them as the realities. But in a sense, our minds are reflecting something, but what if it's just reflecting the shadows? The reality is something else. It's casting those shadows.

5.55 But on the other hand, we're prisoners who are captured in this realm where we are seeing nothing but the shadows. "The truth would be literally nothing but the shadows of the images," says Plato, or Socrates as he's describing this scene. He says philosophy is about this. It's turning people away from the shadows toward the realities, turning you toward the actual objects that are illumined finally by the sun, by the forms in Plato, these abstract things that are the true realities.

5.56 Now, I think Murdoch takes all of that very, very seriously. When Socrates is describing it, he says, "The prison-house is the world of sight. The light of the fire is the sun. You won't

misapprehend me if you interpret the journey upwards out of the cave to be the ascent of the soul into the intellectual world." At the end, what we see when we do that is the Form of The Good. The idea of The Good appears last of all. It's seen only with an effort.

5.57 So in Plato, we've got the visible world around us, but it's really just a world of shadows, of reflections. In the end, we're pushed beyond that to the realities by thinking hard, by an intellectual process of inquiry, and eventually, we can attain The Good. Well, that question of the good is really what interests Murdoch throughout all of this. It isn't just the question of reality, mind, and world. It is also the question of how to live. So "ought" brings you back to "is" in the end, yes, but what sort of "is"? In the end, we want to know, what are the true realities and what we should do, what we should follow?

5.58 Here is how Murdoch links the moral question to that metaphysical question. She says we spend most of our lives in a kind of inner dialogue with ourselves. It matters hugely what kind of dialogue it is. The nature of that inner dialogue determines at least as much as anything external that happens to us, what kind of life we lead. We are constantly thinking. We're constantly in this dialogue with ourselves. What is it like? What are we talking about? What are we telling ourselves? That matters.

5.59 She says every moment has a moral tag, a moral flavor, given by our inner dialogue, what we're telling ourselves at that moment. It's not as if in silence, we're actually not applying concepts to the world. We're actually using language internally all the time. We're thinking all the time. We're talking to ourselves. And that talking to yourself, not out loud, but silently inside your own head, that's what much of our lives consists in. It matters what our dialogue is. She said it might be filled with egoistic fantasies. It might be filled with selfish habits. It might be serious thinking that's honest in trying to get at the reality. And she says, "What I'm giving you is a kind of moral picture of the mind." It's in constant engagement with an independent reality.

5.60 Her point is that the mind isn't just this passive mirror. It isn't just a reflection, whether it's cloudy or clear, whether it's flipping things around or not. It is an active thing. We apply our minds to things. We engage in thinking. It's not just a passive mirror. As soon as we think of it that way, we realize this metaphysical question of the connection between mind and world is in part a moral question. Am I trying to get the world right? Or am I happy with a cloudy mirror? Am I happy with a flipped-around reflection? Do I worry about the reality, or am I just chasing the shadows?

5.61 In the end, she says, "Truth is not just a collection of facts. Truthfulness, the search for truth, for a closer connection between thought and reality, demands and effects an exercise of virtues and a purification of desires. Thought, goodness, and reality are connected." That, I think, is really the deeper theme of her work. To think about things and to try to get them right, that is a moral command. And so the truth has a moral claim on us, not just an epistemic claim.

5.62 Part of that is involved in figuring out what you ought to do. "Every man must have a trade," Hugo says near the end of the book. "Yours is writing, mine will be making and mending watches." He decides to give up the firework business. "'What about the truth?' I said wildly. 'What about the search for God?' 'What more do you want?' said Hugo. 'God is a task. God is a detail. It lies close to your hand.'"

- 5.63** In other words, the source of value here is in that connection to what you do. Are you pursuing the truth? Are you pursuing the reality, instead of the shadow? Are you happy with the shadows? Are you just willing to live in, or even deciding you want to live in this world of illusion, this world of shadows? To say, "I'm going to live in that world of shadows, I'm going to engage in double-think and act as if the world is the way I would like it to be," that is really a moral failing, not just a failing in the quest for knowledge.
- 5.64** So, in the end, there is a reality out there. The cat that hangs out in Mrs. Tinckham's shop finally gets pregnant and is about to have kittens, and some of the kittens then turn out to be one way, some the other. Jake says to her, "'Well, that's the way it always is. It's simple.' So Mrs. Tinck says, 'Well, why?' He says, 'Well, it's just a matter of—' I stopped. I had no idea what it was a matter of. I laughed, and Mrs. Tinckham laughed. 'I don't know why it is,' I said. 'It's just one of the wonders of the world.'"
- 5.65** In other words, there are things about the world that go beyond the reality as we understand it, and we can recognize them. We can say, yeah, that's one of the wonders of the world. That's the way it is, and way it is independently of our thinking about it or our concepts or our understanding of it. And so, the world does have this independent existence, and thought is supposed to reflect it, but that "supposed to" is a moral command.
- 5.66** Now, I want to move on to a very different way of thinking about the connection between thought and language, a way that is broadly known as postmodernism. It says, wait a minute, wait a minute. The problem is real, but her solution is too simple. So, let's start thinking of it this way.
- 5.67** Structuralism is the belief that phenomena are not intelligible except through their interrelations. This is very different from a traditional philosophical way of thinking about things, where you think about what a thing is in terms of the properties it has, its essence, what's necessary for being it, what makes it what it is. We ask, what makes this water? The answer is something internal to it: H₂O.
- 5.68** But the structuralist says, "That's not the right way to think about it." To understand something is to see how it relates to other things. The truth is revealed in the relations, not inside the thing itself. The relations constitute a structure, and there are constant laws of structure, but that's really what we're understanding. That's really what's going on in thought and language. We're creating a structure. We're creating a model of reality, if you will, and we're applying that model to the reality. And so, the elements aren't really the key thing. The key thing is the structure.
- 5.69** Well, how do we understand exactly what post-structuralism or postmodernism are? There are different ways of thinking about it. Moe Szyslak on The Simpsons says, "Weird for the sake of weird." That's one way of thinking about it. Here's Gary Aylesworth's definition. He is a postmodernist. He says it's "a set of critical, strategic, and rhetorical practices employing concepts such as difference, repetition, the trace, the simulacrum, and hyperreality to destabilize other concepts such as presence, identity, historical progress, epistemic certainty, and the univocity of meaning." Well, that should clarify everything.
- 5.70** Really, he's just saying we're replacing this set of concepts—like things, and things being identical to other things, and what a thing is, and things progressing through time, and

being sure of things, and things meaning one thing—we're getting rid of all that, and we're replacing it with a bunch of other concepts.

- 5.71** Now, what are these concepts? I think there is a kind of cynicism in the background, that what matters is the story, the narrative, the myth. Partly, it's Borges' idea that I mentioned, that reality longs to yield to a structure that we can understand. We'd like for it to be a labyrinth that we design so we understand the solution, not a labyrinth that the angels or God designed so that we may never be able to figure it out. And so, it's easy for fiction or narratives or stories to start taking over reality in the way we think about things, at the very least.
- 5.72** What does he mean by a simulacrum, for example? The idea is that it's "an image without resemblance." In other words, it's my image of this thing, and yet it isn't very much like any underlying reality at all. The worry here is that our thought is just filled with these simulacra, these things that are part of my model but don't have anything to do with reality.
- 5.73** When you think in terms of the manifest and scientific images, you start realizing that maybe that's not as crazy as it sounds at first. Often, people like this are talking about cultural artifacts or movies or other things. But really, if you start thinking, "But wait, my everyday experience, what does that have to do with the world as a physicist describes it?" And I might think, "Oh, what if I'm always in this realm of simulacra, that are my images that I use to navigate the world, but the fact is, it doesn't have any resemblance with the actual structure of the world?"
- 5.74** What is hyperreality? Models of something that's real, but without an origin, without a reality. In other words, substituting signs of the real for the real. So what if I'm always dealing in thought or in language with these models of reality, but the models don't match up with the reality very well at all? I've got this structure and it lets me survive, but is it the actual structure of the world? Well, what if it's not?
- 5.75** I managed to survive, and in fact, then evolution produces these models, and I actually thrive, and they develop further and further. But what if my doing that is not getting closer and closer to the underlying reality? What if, I mean, what if there is no underlying reality, but even for getting that thought, what if I can't have access to it? What if I'm always at this level of these simulacra, these elements of a model that don't really match up to anything?
- 5.76** And so, there is in postmodernist art this concern with the relation between the reflection and the reality, that mind and world question. What if my mind is filled with these models that have very little to do with reality? At first glance, you might think that's a wild thought, but when you think about some of the scientific theories of the past, you can end up thinking, "What if—maybe it's not so crazy."
- 5.77** I mean, think about medicine a few hundred years ago, where everything that's going on in the body is determined by the humors. Now we look at that, and we think, "What a crazy model to try to use. That's hopeless." But on the other hand, it was something that people used for centuries and thought that's the underlying reality. What if a future group is going to look back on us and say, "Look at what they were using. What a ridiculous model to have of reality." But then they will, in turn, what if it's all just ridiculous models of reality, one after the other? And what if we aren't really getting better and better? What if we have no idea?

- 5.78** Hegel attacks this idea of immediacy, that I can immediately or directly contact reality. What if I'm always looking through a foggy mirror or a net, or have constantly got those square pegs I'm trying to fit into round holes? Or if I think of it in structuralist terms, what if there's a structure here, and I've got this other structure and I'm trying to match it, but they just don't match up at all? This is one kind of structure, let's say a chain, and I've got this net, and I'm trying to use the net to capture the image of the chain. It's not going to work. The structures are just fundamentally different.
- 5.79** So, we can talk about things and refer to them, but when we do that, we are always using concepts. We're always trapped in language. We're categorizing things. In fact, even purely apart from physics, at the level of sensation, what you're experiencing now is an immensely complex thing. You're seeing all sorts of things. There's a huge amount of information being put onto the retina. Only a small amount of that is being transferred to your brain. Your brain is processing it and using all sorts of concepts and nodes that are already there to organize it into objects.
- 5.80** Then you have something that you call a visual sensation, but it's also linked to auditory sensations. You're hearing things, you're feeling things, you're seeing things, all at the same time. And somehow your mind puts all of that together and calls that an experience, but it's a highly complex mix. And what Kant called "the synthesis of the manifold" of experience is going on all the time. You're taking this huge mass of information and constructing a model in your mind.
- 5.81** It's not as if then you're seeing the reality directly. It's not a very direct process at all. Even if you assume there's a reality out there, you think about the actual physical process, and you realize there is processing going on all the time. There's something that's happening just with the cones and the reaction to the eye. Certain things are perceivable, certain things aren't. Then the brain is receiving only a subset. Then it's processing this two-dimensional thing and producing a three-dimensional image. It's also getting signals from the ears and other things, and building that into the image as well. A huge amount of processing is happening.
- 5.82** Then we say, "Oh, that's a cat," or "that's a screen," or whatever it is. Well, that's the outcome of a very complicated process. Is that actually corresponding to anything that was an input to that process? It is taking this swirling mass and somehow organizing it into something that you call the perception of a thing. So, all of that seems to involve structures in the brain that are partly a matter of our sensory apparatus, partly a matter of our concepts. It is a hugely complex thing.
- 5.83** And so, we have this myth that the thing is just given to us. It's right there. But the fact is, it's not like that. We could start thinking that about all sorts of language. I can say "the cat," but Russell would say that that already is categorizing it, for one thing, cat as a cat. But for another thing, I act as if I'm referring directly to an object in the world, but it's not quite like that.
- 5.84** He says, what if the thing doesn't exist? For example, the present king of France. There is no present king of France, so there's no thing I'm referring to, but I still managed to say something meaningful if I talk about the present king of France. It sounds ridiculous to say one of the great works of 20th-century philosophy was a paper on the present king of

France, and whether the present king of France is bald, that's the problem that he starts with, the puzzle. But it turns out to be a serious puzzle.

5.85 He ends up saying, "Well, the present king of France is bald." It can't be just referring to the present king of France and describing him, because there is none. So it's saying something general. It's saying there is a present king of France, and there's exactly one, in fact, and that person is bald. And since there is no present king of France, it's false. But nevertheless, that's what it means. It's a general description of the world.

5.86 So in effect, he says, you might think you're saying something particular. You're not. You're always at the level of generalization. So if you think you can solve the problem by just using particular things, sorry, you can't do it. You're always trapped in a screen, something behind this realm of concepts, this whole sensory apparatus as well. But you're really seeing reality very indirectly and describing it very indirectly.

5.87 Let me move on then to one of the major figures of postmodernism: Jean-François Lyotard. Lyotard says modernism is the view that there is some meta-discourse, some grand narrative. Maybe it is the dialectics of spirit, as in Hegel. Maybe it's hermeneutics, the science of meaning, as in Schleiermacher. Maybe it is something having to do with the class struggle or the emancipation of the working subject, like Marx. Maybe it's creating wealth, like Adam Smith, rationally maximizing utility.

5.88 Maybe it is a matter of, as Unamuno was saying, maybe it's a biological thing. Maybe it is some other kind of thing—a subconscious desires account, as in Freud, or whatever it is. It doesn't matter. There's some grand narrative that says, "Here's what it is to be human. Here's what's going on in the world. It's all a matter of class struggle, or it's all a matter of the underlying biochemistry, or it's all a matter of this, or that or that other thing."

5.89 Where Unamuno said, "No, no, no, look, it's all of those things together, and more besides," Lyotard says, "What I want to do is reject this whole idea. I want to say the whole thought of having some grand narrative, some account of that underlying scientific image,"—he says—"that's wrong-headed. There is no one account of that grand story at the bottom." So he says, "I define postmodern as incredulity toward meta-narratives." In other words, get rid of that kind of picture. That's what he means by a meta-narrative.

5.90 It says that there's this manifest way of looking at the world, but then there's what's really going on in the world. This is what has causal power and determines what's happening up here. He says, "Reject that whole idea," partly because there is no unification at that bottom level. In a certain sense, it is like Unamuno, but he also is suspicious of anything that tries to tell one grand story, whether it has that character or not.

5.91 Part of the reason is that there are multiple communities and multiple systems of meaning. He says there are many different language games, an idea he's taking over from Wittgenstein, "a heterogeneity of elements. They only give rise to institutions in patches." There's a local determinism, but there's not a global determinism.

5.92 So you want to ask the physicist, "Why did that thing explode?" The physicist will say, "Here's my explanation," blah, blah, blah, blah. "This produces a certain amount of energy," and so on. Now you say to the physicist, "So why are the Eagles having trouble winning football games this season?" And the physicist says, "I can't tell you that." That doesn't help.

- 5.93** But then you go up to the football player, and you say, "Wow, you managed to catch that ball even though you were leaping high in the air. How did you manage to hang on?" And he says, "I just saw where the ball was, and I jumped there, and I grabbed on." And you say, "No, I want to understand the physics. How did you manage to do it? I mean, it seemed me that the velocity in the ball was great enough that you would not have been able to exert enough force." And the football player is going to say, "Dude, that's why they pay me the money."
- 5.94** So, there are these explanations, but they're local explanations. If you're on the football field, saying, "Why did the quarterback call that play? It seemed like a dumb call," let me tell you about the underlying biochemistry. Here were the neural—no, you don't go to the neuroscientist. That is basically his account. They're just these different areas. They explain different things. There is no grand narrative. There's no one story. Physics isn't going to help you all that much if you're thinking about football strategy. The football player isn't going to be able to help you with the underlying physics. It is just a bunch of things going on.
- 5.95** Somebody says, "Listen, I've been following. I know a lot about physics, and I've been following American football, so now I want to understand ballet. But surely I can use these principles." Well, no, no, that's a different thing again. They're just a bunch of different things to figure out.
- 5.96** It's rather like Hugo, in a way, in the book, saying that you could have a theory of ballet. You can have a theory of football. You could have a theory of physical relationships and physical events. But if you want one grand story that explains the whole world of our experience, forget it. That's not how it works. Anyway, that's part of it.
- 5.97** But really, Lyotard says, there's something else going on, too. There are different kinds of knowledge, and this acts as if everything in the end is a matter of scientific knowledge, having a causal account that explains things. But he says that's not right. "Knowledge can't be reduced to science or even to learning." All of these, he's using different French terms for. "Learning is the set of statements which, to the exclusion of other statements, denote or describe objects, and may be declared true or false." But a lot of that involves things at the manifest image. It's not at the scientific level at all. It's not science.
- 5.98** If I know that Charlemagne was crowned Holy Roman Emperor on Christmas Day in 800, that's not a scientific claim. It has nothing to do with the underlying physical structure of the world. It's something that is made at a different level. It's factual. That sentence is true, but on the other hand, it's not part of science as such. And similarly, if I say that I'm wearing a multi-colored tie, that's true, but it's not something you expect to get out of your scientific theory.
- 5.99** And so, he says, now that's part of it, but there's something else. He says knowledge is broader than either of those things. It's not just scientific knowledge and also learning of various other kinds of things. It also includes know-how, knowing how to live, knowing how to listen, knowing how to fix a broken toilet, knowing how to do this and that other thing. And that is not a matter of scientific theory, nor is it a matter of reading a book. Maybe it's a matter of watching a YouTube video; that's been super helpful on the toilet thing. But in any event, it's a matter of knowing how to do certain things, and not only a matter of knowing how.

- 5.100** I think he doesn't go further, but you could say, knowing to do certain things, knowing not to do other things. That's very helpful in this part of knowledge. That is a question of competence, he says. It goes beyond knowing whether something is true or false. It's a question of, can you do it? Are you competent? Are you good at it? That's a matter of knowledge, but knowledge of a different kind.
- 5.101** It's not scientific knowledge. It's not even book-learning and that kind of thing. It is just knowing how to act, knowing what to do, knowing how to solve this problem. That is a matter of knowledge for real, but not something you're going to get out of that narrative where you've got this scientific image, and it explains everything at the manifest image. It's not going to explain that.
- 5.102** He constructs this picture where, yes, there is science, and really, if you think of that as what's going to describe things at that base level, he says, already you've got a problem, because science includes a lot of different stuff. The biologist is studying things and giving explanations that the physicists can't give, and vice versa. That's already complex and a multitude of things. But then you go to learning. That also is a multitude, and it doesn't reduce to science. Then you've got knowledge much more broadly, and none of that reduces to science or even to learning.
- 5.103** And so, you have to replace this picture of base level and manifest level with something much more sophisticated, much more varied, and with all these multiplicities at every one of those levels. Roughly speaking, science, that's what would correspond to the scientific image. But again, it's a bunch of stuff, not just one thing. Learning, that's something that would include the level of the manifest image, but again, it's many, many different things.
- 5.104** Then the norms, the narratives, the language games—that's all at this broader level of knowledge. Knowing to do this and not to do that, knowing how to do this, knowing how to avoid that. Those are questions that are knowledge that have really no direct relation to those other things. Some direct sub-relations for sure, but on the other hand, are at a different level and not at all reducible to the others.
- 5.105** So he says that there isn't just one narrative. There are many narratives at different levels for different purposes. "They allow the society to define its criteria of competence and to evaluate, according to some criteria, what's performed or can be performed." I can evaluate the student as good or bad at philosophy. Someone can say, "Are you good or bad at fixing toilets?" That's the kind of thing that we can actually do in society. We do it all the time. It's super, super important. And yet, it's not something that we can study, or a physics textbook to help us with. So in the end, he says, "That's part of the problem."
- 5.106** Now, another part brings out a different element of postmodernism because it is, at some level, a skeptical view of the world. He says, "What I say is true because I prove it is—or I justify it, I say—but what proof is there that my proof is true?" He's giving you here a very traditional, skeptical regress. Some beliefs we count as knowledge. Here we're at the level of science or of learning. After all, they aren't exactly beliefs at the level of knowing to do something or knowing how to do something. Knowing how to ride a bicycle isn't just having a bunch of beliefs. If it were, you could learn how to do it by reading a book. It's not like that.
- 5.107** A belief counts as knowledge within that restricted sphere—only if some criterion, he calls them "rules of adequation," justifies it. But this can't go on forever. If I say, "Here's my rule

of adequation, here's my criterion," and you say, "Why is that the right criterion?" If I say, "It says it is," that's not very satisfying. It's circular. If I say, "Oh, I have this other criterion," now I'm off on an infinite regress, but I can't have these infinite chains of justification.

5.108 So, can I ever actually have any knowledge? Or at some point, do I just give up? I have things that I call basic, but they aren't really beliefs. They aren't knowledge at all. The puzzle here goes all the way back to Plato's Theaetetus. He says, here's what in the end we do. We just have certain things that aren't susceptible to proof, and we can use them as evidence. He says, traditionally, people would have said that these things are just self-evident. They're basic. They're foundational. That's a classic way of looking at it.

5.109 But he says, "I look at it a different way. It's not that I can prove something because reality is the way I say it is. It's, as long as I can produce proof, it's permissible to think reality is the way it is." In other words, I'm not saying this is true because it matches the reality; I'm saying it's true because I can justify it and root it in this evidence. As long as that holds up, I get to say reality's like that. It's not that I have access to the reality first, and then I see if I'm matching it. I can't step out of my own net and do that. Instead, I say, "Is the net holding?" If the net holds, I call it true.

5.110 I also assume that God isn't deceptive, that the reality underlying this is consistent. In other words, that in constructing my net, as long as it holds up, number one, it's good. And secondly, it's got to be consistent. I can't have contradictions in my net. If I've got contradictions, then I think that something's wrong with the net.

5.111 You might think, even if you think there is this net between my mind and my world, what about knowing my own mind? Descartes thought that knowing the external world, that's a hard one. But I can know my own mind. Could I be wrong that I think? Even if I doubt that, doubting is thinking. Couldn't be wrong about that. If I think that I am, I've got to be right. Every time I think or utter "I am," it's true. What would it mean to say, "I'm thinking that I am, but I'm not"? Who's thinking then? So he says, "I am a thing that thinks." In fact, I'm essentially a thing that thinks. I know myself more directly and more clearly than I know anything else. I'm given to myself. I am right here. I'm not caught between me and something else, as if there's this screen between us or this net or this web or something. I know myself directly. I'm on this side of the mind-world split, so I don't have to worry about anything that intervenes in between.

5.112 Now, let me go back to this idea of reflection. How do I know how I look? I see my reflection. But that's not something—I mean, that seems indirect. It doesn't seem direct. And so, Lyotard says that even with the self, I don't get a get-out-of-epistemic-jail-free card. It's not like I have direct access there. He says, "A self doesn't amount to much, but no self is an island. Each exists in a fabric of relations that's now more complex and mobile than ever before. Young or old, man or woman, rich or poor, a person is located at nodal points of specific circuits."

5.113 So in effect, he's saying, "I am not given this direct access to myself. I don't know my own mind better than I know anything else." In fact, I think he thinks, "I probably know myself less well than I know anything else." Because actually, I'm not at the center of my own world or my knowledge of it. My own mind is not given to me directly. I'm thinking about it in terms of relations, in terms of concepts that I've been given from other things. And so it's

not as if I'm looking at myself directly. There is always some screen, something separating me from myself, even.

5.114 Wittgenstein said, "The limits of my language are the limits of my world." Maybe, but from a postmodern point of view, I'm not at the center of that world. In fact, really, in the end, all knowledge, even knowledge of myself, is mediated by concepts, by language, and so on. Language is just a system of differences; it's describing a structure. That's all it can do. I can't really use it, or thought itself, to get at the nature of the individual thing. I can talk about the structure and the relations. I can't talk about the things that are the nodes in the structure. I can, but only by relating them to other things. I can't talk about their very essence as they are themselves.

5.115 The same is true, even when I apply this to myself. I can describe the structure, but not what it's the structure of. So at best, I can describe this form, but that's it. People like Derrida say that means there's no difference between fiction and non-fiction, because I'm always just pointing out this structure, which may or may not hold up eventually and have anything to do with anything else.

5.116 So I want to point out, at this stage, how different this is in the end from the Enlightenment theses we started talking about at the very beginning of the course. Remember, Enlightenment thinkers assumed there were mind-independent truths. They were absolute; they were universal, that it was possible to know, at least some of them. The postmodernist says, "That's not true. No truths are absolute. They're always relative to something, relative to the framework we're using and the things that determine that framework."

5.117 The classic picture is that we can have objective knowledge of some of these truths. But the postmodernist says "No, that's not right. Objective knowledge is impossible. We're caught in that skeptical regress." The Enlightenment theorist says, "Reason is the best way to do it." But from a postmodern point of view, that's often not true. It depends. Maybe sometimes reason is the best way at the level of science; it's not always the best way at certain other levels. If it's a question of learning how to listen, maybe reason isn't the best tool for that. In particular, reason can too often become a tool where some groups oppress other groups.

5.118 Then, finally, the Enlightenment thinker says acting rationally is the best way to achieve progress. But all too often, the postmodernist says, "Our job is to fight oppression and get out of these things that are traps." Eco, for example, says, "The sense that the past is restricting, smothering, blackmailing us," that's really what postmodernism is—an attempt to try to get out of the trap of language, but never really succeeding. And so, often postmodernists conclude everything is really a social or a linguistic or a conceptual construction.

5.119 That seems really strange. Our concept of a tornado is something like a conceptual construction, but tornadoes aren't social constructs. Our concept of a neutron may be a social construct, but neutrons aren't social constructs. The concept was defined in 1933, but there were neutrons before 1933. You might think, at some point, we actually do confront reality. As Murdoch says, sometimes the cat actually gives birth to these kittens, and we can't understand why. It's just one of the wonders of the world.

- 5.120** And so, you might think the postmodernist is always thinking, "I'm always so far removed from reality that what I'm thinking and what I'm saying doesn't have much to do with it at all." But that can't, in the end, be the full story. The end.
- 5.121** In talking about how thought and language and the net of the meaning, what I wonder about is the progression through history of written language versus spoken word versus action combined with spoken, and now the change back to a lot more written and even symbolic, like the emojis as the modern-day hieroglyphics. How does this now affect the expression of thought, and what's filtered? Because now an emoji can stand for something, no matter what language you speak. So somebody in a completely different country can understand language, but then are they? How is that affecting all this?
- 5.122** OK, very good. Yes. Often these discussions assume that, just as my earlier scientific image, manifest image thing, assumed a kind of unity at both levels that isn't really there, at least according to the postmodernists, but I think they're right about that. There isn't really a unity. Maybe eventually we'll have a theory of everything, but there's no real reason to expect that we have to end up in that position. But they tend to assume, well, thought and language can be talked about in this unified way, too. But really, as Lyotard stresses, that's not right either. There are a bunch of different language games.
- 5.123** What you're pointing out is, it's not just, oh, there's this way we have of talking about football, way we have of talking about physics, etc. It's also that we have written language, we have spoken language, we have emojis, we have gestures. I mean, I'm constantly doing this. People have actually done studies recently on that use of gesturing and the intelligibility of things from the audience's point of view. They found out that, actually, you're getting a huge amount of information from gestures. It's part of the reason I hate to have to stand behind a lectern and stay in one place.
- 5.124** When I filmed a course many years ago, they made me stay on this mark. I did terribly, because here's what happens. I get nervous and I should be moving around and I should be gesturing, but I can't. I start speaking faster and faster and faster and faster. Now I listen to that and I think, "You have to put it at half speed to understand what I'm saying. This is crazy." But it makes the point that there are several levels. There's the spoken level, there's the written level, there is this level of gestures, and also inflection.
- 5.125** I mean, a huge amount is going on in spoken language that's not there on the page. Emphasis and things like that. Falling and rising inflection. None of that is really there. This is one version; the spoken version is another. And yet I find that if I'm watching a video, for example, I understand things better than if I'm just listening. Why? Partly because I'm getting a lot of information visually. And then you bring up emojis and things like that. That's a different sort of language. I say something, and then I put a smiley face at the end.
- 5.126** Sometimes now I've realized, that smiley face is hugely important. Because I say something, and am I serious or is this a joke? Sometimes I realize, if I don't put that there—and here I feel guilty because I think this is a decadence of modern life in general—but on the other hand, I think, if I don't put that there, the person is going to take me seriously. At one point, that actually happened. Somebody called me up on the phone and said, "Look, are you serious? Please don't do that." It was a joke. It's OK. I realized, yeah, the

emoji needed to be there because, in speech, you would get that it's a joke. But in writing, you don't get that.

5.127 So, I think you're right, that at the level of speech or language, or really just say language, there's already this multiplicity that have complex relations to each other. Now, add to that what's going on in thought, and you get further complications. What is the relationship between thought and language in any of those forms? There are people who think that, basically, language is trying to represent what's going on in thought. There are people who think, no, thought really has a linguistic structure. They talk about a language of thought, or my own dissertation director talked about thought as sort of practice speech, and there's some point to that.

5.128 Yet others have said, wait, a lot of thinking is not really linguistic. It's not symbolic at all. There are different kinds of processing in the brain. If you think about the emotions we feel, you start thinking, well, that's part of thinking. Feeling is part of thinking. And yet I can't, I don't have—I mean, I can talk about it in language and so on, but what's happening in the brain isn't linguistic. Anyway, there's that level of complication, too. You've got this multiplicity at the level of language. Then, undoubtedly, this multiplicity at the level of thought, the relations between them are unclear, so it's a huge mess.

5.129 I don't know if that helps. Really, I'm just saying your question is really a bunch of deep questions that largely get ignored in this way of thinking about things. But on the other end, I'm not sure they undermine it. Maybe they make us think, "Oh, Lyotard and these other postmodernists are seeing something, but they're only seeing a part of it. It's much worse." I'm not sure how to think about that all myself.

5.130 I'm hoping that the neuroscientists and the cognitive scientists help us with this and help us understand the structure of thought and its relation to language. I do think that's partly happening. But I also think the relationship between thought and language, the relationship between thought in the world, the relationship between language in the world, maybe those are really three different problems, and their relations to each other aren't yet, at least, very clear at all.

6. Something to Say about Reality

6.1 I want to return to this question of the relationship between mind and world, and closely related to that is the question of the relationship between language and world. Does language, does thought, really have something to say about reality? My way of phrasing it there comes from a poem by Lawrence Ferlinghetti, who talks about a democratic dog who has something to say about ontology, something to say about reality. I'm not that big a fan of Ferlinghetti's, but on the other hand, he does use really clever philosophical phrases, and he's raising a deep issue here.

6.2 Let me start with the condition of confusion that I think arose at a certain cultural moment and helped people to think about these questions of the relationship between the mind and reality. Because throughout the 1950s, that we've been talking about, there is this worry that language and that thought trap us, and we can never get at the actual reality.

- 6.3** I think corresponding to that was a kind of moral confusion. You might have thought— and initially, I think it was true that after the Second World War, there was a feeling of moral clarity. Not only can we not be cynical anymore about right and wrong, we've seen examples of real wrongness, and that does seem, whatever else we say about it, not just an emotional reaction, not just an urging, but instead something that is a reality that has to be faced.
- 6.4** On the other hand, throughout the 1950s, people began to find various things that clouded that—partly the Cold War, McCarthyism, partly more general worries about the nature of thought and the nature of language. The more we found out, as it were, about the brain, the more it seemed like this is a complicated story and not a simple thing of just a mirror of reality. Let's talk for a moment about the confusion before we get to attempts to clarify.
- 6.5** I'm thinking of the confusion here as partly arising at least in the United States, but I think more broadly throughout the Western world as a result of the Vietnam War. It arose in 1964 when North Vietnam, allegedly anyway, attacked American destroyers in the Gulf of Tonkin, and then Congress authorized the use of force. Johnson was reelected in a landslide. This was already after the assassination of President Kennedy. That itself created a feeling of not so much moral confusion as just general confusion and concern about the direction of the country.
- 6.6** Then we saw the beginning of extensive bombing campaigns, and then a military strategy that added to the confusion. The Joint Chiefs of Staff said it would take almost a million men and seven years to actually achieve victory. Johnson's strategy was to say, "Well, I don't want to commit to that. Let's see if we can do something smaller. Let's see if we can do something shorter." It was incremental. Let's only do things if we have to. The result was a strategy about warfare that's totally different from traditional strategies of war.
- 6.7** Von Clausewitz, for example, said that here's what you do in the case that war becomes inevitable. First of all, avoid it if you can. But secondly, if war happens, war is terrible. That's the first and most basic truth about it. So you want to get it over with as quickly as possible. That means the most moral thing to do is to fight to win and fight to end the war as quickly as possible. He thinks that means fight with full force, no holds barred. But the whole point is, that sounds cruel. He says it's not. The whole point is to get it over with fast. War is terrible, and the longer it drags on, the more damage it does.
- 6.8** And so, Johnson—some people urged that strategy, but Johnson's attitude was the opposite. He increased the troops' strength only incrementally. He didn't commit to a large-scale force initially. It just got built up gradually over time, as it seemed necessary. He did engage in bombing campaigns against North Vietnam, but on the other hand, he limited the bombing very severely to protect civilians. He engaged in pauses in the bombing. We'd bomb for a while, stop and see if that brought the North Vietnamese and the Viet Cong to the negotiating table. When that didn't work, then bomb a bit more and so on.
- 6.9** He refused—this is the part that I least understand, perhaps—he refused to bomb anti-aircraft batteries that were under construction because—why? I mean, you would think that if this is the enemy's defense against what you're doing, you would try to destroy the defense. But he thought somehow that was bad sportsmanship and would not do it, hence endangering our own pilots and endangering our aircraft and so on. There were extensive and very restrictive rules of engagement. You could only shoot if you were fired upon. I

knew someone who was a captain in Vietnam. He would be ordered to take a certain hill. He would do that. People would be wounded or killed. Then a few days later, given the order to abandon the hill, and would do that, and then was ordered to retake the hill and so on. None of this made very much sense from the point of view of soldiers on the ground.

6.10 And so, Paul Johnson has written this. "Self-imposed restraints by a civilized power are worse than useless. They are interpreted by friend and foe alike as evidence, not of humanity, but of guilt and lack of righteous conviction." In that way, the U.S. lost the propaganda battle, but it also created a great deal of confusion. In a sense, the propaganda wasn't just propaganda. It was a matter of, "What are we doing there and why are we doing it?"

6.11 Initially, there was a story that people thought they understood, and many people continued to support throughout. But the anti-war movement grew, and partly because all of this came across as not humanity, but a lack of conviction. It made people think, "Do you even believe in what you're doing?" So there is a sense here in which a moral question that might have seemed initially fairly clear-cut, at least to many people, began to seem increasingly cloudy.

6.12 Now, the propaganda aspect of this became critical with the Tet Offensive. It was a broad-based attack, all the way across South Vietnam by North Vietnamese and Viet Cong forces. And it turned out to be a huge military victory for the United States. It was repulsed with relatively few South Vietnamese and American casualties, huge casualties on the part of the Viet Cong and the North Vietnamese.

6.13 But it was reported in the United States as just the opposite. LBJ is said to have said, "If I've lost Cronkite, I've lost Middle America," because it was being reported on the news as something that was a disaster. It wasn't so much the result; I mean, the results were very, very good for the United States and the South Vietnamese Army. However, it suggested to a lot of people that the Viet Cong and the North Vietnamese were strong enough to mount such a massive and extensive offensive, and that itself seemed to worry them.

6.14 In any case, increasingly, there was a split, not so much in the Republican Party as in the Democratic Party. Liberals like JFK and LBJ were on one side of this growing ideological split. Anti-war radicals were on the other side. And so that actually led to LBJ not running for re-election, the strong opposition within his own party.

6.15 That led to the election of Richard Nixon, initially in a very close contest, just as in 1960, where he very, very narrowly lost to John F. Kennedy. In 1968, he narrowly defeated Hubert Humphrey, but then in 1972, was reelected in a landslide. Nixon began to withdraw U.S. troops from Vietnam. He continued the war. He didn't end it immediately. But we had more than half a million troops in Vietnam when he took office. The next year, there were only a little more than half as many, only half as many as that the following year. By 1972, it was down to 24,000. And then by 1973, it was 50 military advisors, and that was all. So gradually, the South Vietnamese army took over the effort, and relatively successfully for a while.

6.16 But then came the Watergate crisis. An editor said this about Nixon: "There's got to be a bloodletting. We've got to make sure nobody ever thinks of doing this again." What was he referring to? What was "this"? Well, it surely wasn't getting the United States out of Vietnam. It surely wasn't actually conducting the war in Vietnam, since after all, it was

democratic presidents who had started it. Nixon didn't start it. Really, it was probably a reference to his role with the House Un-American Activities Committee, back in the late '40s and early '50s, and the prosecution of Alger Hiss.

- 6.17** But whatever it was, in any case, Nixon was hated by editors, hated by the far left. That ended up leading in ways that are rather hard even, I think, in retrospect to understand, to the Watergate crisis. But that in turn led to a loss of faith in leadership that still affects us. It began a long slide of a loss of faith in American institutions and American leaders. There was a shift in power also that resulted from the executive to Congress to the legislative branch.
- 6.18** What happened? Five people were arrested, breaking into the Democratic National Committee headquarters at the Watergate complex in Washington, DC, in 1972. There are a lot of fundamental questions we don't understand. For example, who authorized the Watergate break-in? There was never actually any evidence that Nixon authorized it in the beginning. So how did this all come about? Who said, "Do this"? Secondly, why would you do this? What were they trying to discover? Moreover, Nixon was way ahead all throughout that campaign. It was obvious he was going to be reelected in a landslide. Why bother to do this if you're already way ahead? What were the burglars even looking for? And then once it happened, what did the President know and when? Was there an attempted cover-up, and so on?
- 6.19** Here's what's disturbing. Even now, many, many years later, we don't know the answer to any of those questions. We still don't know who authorized it. We don't know why, what they were looking for. We don't know what the President knew and when. In any event, this was a huge news story for more than two years. And finally, Nixon resigned office.
- 6.20** The War Powers Resolution was passed during this time, which required Congressional approval for military action. It has been largely ignored since then. Every President has declared it unconstitutional. Congress has never brought a suit in response to any of these presidential actions by presidents of both parties throughout the intervening years. It's never been challenged in court. It remains unclear what the status of that resolution is. But it was one symbol of a shift in power, or at least an attempted shift in power, from the executive to the legislative branch.
- 6.21** In 1973, the Arab-Israeli War, also known as the Yom Kippur War, ended up leading to a huge oil embargo and a giant increase in the price of oil. I can remember when a gallon of gasoline was 19 cents. That's a long time ago, before 1973, for sure. Since then, there has been a dramatic inflation in the currency.
- 6.22** John Maynard Keynes, in 1919, said, "Lenin is said to have declared that the best way to destroy the capitalist system was to debauch the currency. By a continuing process of inflation, governments can confiscate, secretly and unobserved, an important part of the wealth of their citizens. By this method, they not only confiscate, but confiscate arbitrarily. Lenin was certainly right. There's no subtler, no surer means of overturning the existing basis of society than to debauch the currency."
- 6.23** The serious inflation had been going at levels that were considered unacceptable throughout the 1960s. Nevertheless, it didn't really spike until 1973, and it has been a continuing problem since then. There was a huge slowdown in the United States and in Europe. There was a massive transfer of wealth from the West to oil-producing countries.

The inflation was serious. A dollar in 1973 is worth about \$7.32 today. Or to look at it another way, a dollar today, to have an equivalent in 1973, you would have only needed maybe 12 or 13 cents. That's depressing. Anyway, governments ended up abandoning the gold standard, and since then, the price of gold has soared. Maybe the best way to look at that is, really, the value of currency has dropped dramatically.

6.24 In any case, as I mentioned, Nixon resigned. He was replaced by Gerald Ford, who decided his strategy on defeating inflation was to give people little WIN buttons, "whip inflation now," something that had absolutely zero actual economic effect. But what did have a serious economic effect, and continues to have it today, was a law passed in 1974 at the height of the Watergate crisis. It was called the Congressional Budget and Impoundment Control Act. It established the Congressional Budget Office, and it removed the President's power to impound or rescind funds. That process, that change in the democratic process and budgeting process, has produced deficits in almost every single year since, and growing deficits, so that the national debt has soared exponentially.

6.25 What really happened there? Well, before that, Congress had to pass a budget, and it did it, department by department. So it would say, here's the budget for this part. Here's the budget for that. They would come up through separate negotiations. They'd be voted on by the House and Senate. There would be a reconciliation. They would send it to the President and so on.

6.26 Increasingly, since this Act, there is simply a continuing resolution. Let's just keep spending all that money, and with maybe a few cuts, with maybe a few increases, and the result of all that is just these last-minute government shutdowns, et cetera, et cetera, the things we've become all too familiar with. The change happened right there. It was 1974. It did involve a massive shift of power. Before that, a president could say, "Yeah, Congress, this is a waste. I know you authorized the money for that bridge to nowhere, but I'm not going to spend that money. That's stupid." But that power went away. And so, as a result, presidents really have very little control over the budget process.

6.27 There were a variety of consequences to the changing in budgeting and the Democrats sweeping Congress and changing the rules in a lot of other respects. Congress halted the bombing of North Vietnam, then banned all military involvement in Southeast Asia. They cut the funding to South Vietnam, at first by 25%, and then completely. The result of that was the fall of South Vietnam, and in particular, the fall of Saigon, April 30th, 1975. There you see the last helicopter getting out of Saigon.

6.28 The result? Reeducation camps. One to three million people were sent to these camps, where they were tortured and indoctrinated, given no medical care, minimal rations. Some stayed there as long as 17 years. Hundreds of thousands died. Hundreds of thousands also died trying to escape to other countries. Many did successfully escape, often in boats that they managed to get to neighboring islands, for example, regions in Indonesia or New Guinea or other types of places. The result of all this: more than 58,000 Americans killed in combat, more than 200,000 South Vietnamese, more than a million Vietnam— or Viet Cong and North Vietnamese.

6.29 In some respects, it did stop the dominoes from falling, which was the theory that was behind opposing communism and its spread in Southeast Asia. On the other hand, it didn't

work entirely. Laos and Cambodia fell to communism, but at least other surrounding countries remained free.

- 6.30** But all of this brought back these questions of normativity. It made people feel that there was a sense of unclarity, a loss of faith in leadership, a loss of faith in the postwar consensus about what right and wrong were. To some extent, the Cold War led to the thought, "We're the good guys. We're on the right side. They're the bad guys. They're on the wrong side. We have just societies, they have unjust societies," and so on. Increasingly, people began to worry that that was way too simple.
- 6.31** Sometimes that spread to a general disillusionment or cynicism about morality altogether. That began to affect other spheres like sexual behavior and other kinds of social standards. But it also meant that there was this strong feeling of doubt. And yet somehow, as a result of all this, by 1980, for example, potential leaders on both sides, everyone in every campaign, more or less, was using morally loaded language and speaking unapologetically in normative terms. Somehow, "oughts" had gotten back in style.
- 6.32** How did that happen? How was it that the gap between "is" and "ought," which seemed to widen throughout the '60s and '70s, began to shrink again, and people started again taking these questions very, very seriously? That's something I'm going to be talking about now, but also in the next couple of lectures. So "oughts" did become—were back in style in some way, and yet not much agreement emerged about exactly how to understand them.
- 6.33** I think here is one thing that, philosophically, was crucially important in doing this, but also to some extent may be simply a symptom of a change in attitudes. I want to talk about a changing conception of objectivity, and in particular, the thought of Saul Kripke. Kripke is maybe the most important philosopher to have been working over the past, say, 60 or 70 years. He died only recently, in 2022.
- 6.34** Kripke was himself a student of Quine and others at Harvard, and is a remarkable case. He published his first paper, which revolutionized philosophy, in 1959. He wrote the original draft as a high school student, which is incredible. Then he went to Harvard, got his degree, and immediately got hired onto the faculty, first at Rockefeller University and then Princeton. He never went to graduate school. He was just such a brilliant undergraduate; they hired him right away.
- 6.35** That first paper was called "A Completeness Theorem in Modal Logic." It revived and made much more sophisticated Leibniz's idea that necessity is truth in all possible worlds, all ways the world could be, all possible situations. Then he followed that up with lectures in 1970, "Naming and Necessity," that did something, I think, very important philosophically, that I'll be talking about. Then came other works, "Outline of a Theory of Truth," "Wittgenstein on Rules and Private Language," all important milestones in modern philosophy.
- 6.36** But let me start with this question of the relationship between language and the world, between mind and the world. At first glance, it might not seem related to moral questions and moral confusion, but I think, as Murdoch saw, it really is. Let me return to that thought, that there is something in between us and reality, that thought and language, in some sense, falsify or hide, that the mind, if it's a mirror of reality, in some way distorts things or flips them around, or perhaps that it's foggy, or maybe it consists of a certain structure that may not match reality.

- 6.37** In any case, lots of things in language don't seem to relate to the world, or at least don't seem to describe an individual thing in the world, but other things do. In particular, when I use a definite description, I talk about the cat or the screen, the typewriter, the phone; they are dealing with things in the world. I've already talked a little bit about Russell's view here, that when I use such a description, I am using something that isn't actually referring to an object, the way it seems to be referring to an object. Instead, it's making a general claim about the world.
- 6.38** So his idea is that there is this film or net or web of concepts between us and the world. And even when I say "that thing," or that, that actually is one thing that he says that might be an exception. But otherwise, if I say "the cat," I'm making a general claim. There is one and only one cat, and then whatever I happen to say about the cat. If I say "the cat is orange," I'm not making a direct reference to a thing in the world, the cat. I'm saying there is one and only one cat, and it's orange.
- 6.39** There are lots of orange cats, so I can't mean this quite literally. I've got to mean in whatever the context of my utterance is. In context, there's only one orange cat, let's say. Now, if it turns out I'm in a place, let's say, a cat show, and there are lots of cats around, and I say, "The cat is orange," the obvious response is, "What cat?" There's an assumption of uniqueness there. But in any case, I am making a general claim about the world: there is one and only one cat, and it's orange. So, there are concepts there—cat, orange, and so on—that are part of this general description of things. I'm not really relating to the world directly. I'm always trapped behind this screen.
- 6.40** Traditionally, people have thought that not only are things like the cat like this, but proper names are like this. Proper names actually refer to a thing in the world. John Stuart Mill said that, yes, a name is just a tag. It's just a label for a thing in the world. There's no descriptive content to it. It just means that. So, if I say "Nixon resigned" or "Aristotle was an ancient Greek philosopher," "Cicero denounced Catiline," and so on, I'm talking about Nixon. I've got a label here, and I'm referring to Nixon or Aristotle or Cicero or Catiline. I'm doing things that are directly linking me to the world.
- 6.41** But Russell thought that was wrong. They were general statements and abbreviated descriptions of some kind. So, he thought, to use a proper name is really to have in mind a description. If I say, "Nixon resigned," it might be the guy who was elected President in 1968, reelected in 1972, resigned. I am saying something general about the world. It doesn't seem like I am, but actually, that proper name is not really anything that refers directly to the world. It still puts me behind a web of these concepts. It's just that I haven't told you what the concepts are, because I haven't explained exactly how I define Nixon, how I define that name. So the idea is, I have a description in mind, or at least there's some set of descriptions that pick out the object uniquely.
- 6.42** Let's think about Aristotle, for example. Maybe for me, that's short for Plato's most famous student, or the tutor of Alexander the Great, or the last great philosopher of antiquity, or some combination of descriptions, whatever that happens to be. Then if I say, "Aristotle wrote the 'Nicomachean Ethics,'" I'm saying something like, "Plato's most famous student wrote the Nicomachean Ethics," or "the last great philosopher of antiquity wrote the Nicomachean Ethics." I am saying something like that. What that means in particular is

some general statement. There is one and only one person who was the last great philosopher of antiquity and who wrote the *Nicomachean Ethics*.

6.43 Similarly, Richard Nixon might be short for all sorts of things—the man who investigated Alger Hiss, Eisenhower's vice president, the man who lost to JFK in 1960, who was elected President in 1968, the man reelected in 1972, et cetera. It might be any of those. It might be some combination, and so on.

6.44 Now, Kripke says there's something fundamentally wrong with that idea, that a proper name is still some kind of general statement that divides me from the world. It's not. He says, if that were true, then some sentences like "Aristotle was Plato's most famous student," or "Aristotle tutored Alexander the Great," or "Aristotle was the last great philosopher of antiquity," should be necessary truths. I mean, they should be truths by definition. Sort of like saying, "Aristotle is Aristotle," or it should be like saying, "Bachelors are unmarried men," where it's a necessary truth. It's just part of the way we use the term. But it's not like that.

6.45 And similarly, they should be what philosophers refer to as a priori. In other words, things I don't need experience to learn. They're just obvious, like bachelors are unmarried men. I don't need experience. That's just what the word means. If Nixon just meant "guy who was elected in 1968," then, that Nixon was elected in 1968 would be a necessary and a priori truth. But it's plainly not.

6.46 It's not a necessary truth that Aristotle was the last great philosopher of antiquity. Hey, he might have had a student like Theophrastus, who became great. He might have actually tutored Alexander the Great, and then he decided, "You know, I've decided to give up on this conqueror idea. I think I'll do philosophy, too." If that had happened, then he wouldn't be the last great philosopher of antiquity. Is it a necessary truth that Aristotle was Plato's most famous student? No, he might never have studied with Plato. Maybe all his works were lost, and he wouldn't have been famous or remembered at all.

6.47 And what about Nixon? Was it a necessary truth that Nixon lost in 1960? No, it could have gone either way. That he won in 1968, that he was reelected in 1972? No. Any of those elections could have turned out differently. You can't learn those things just by learning how to use the name Nixon. None of those sentences are a priori. It's not as if Humphrey's saying, in 1968, "I'm optimistic. I think we might win. Things are improving." Somebody says, "You're running against Nixon, right?" "Yes." "But Nixon is the guy who won the re-election in 1968. So give it up." I mean, that just defines the term Nixon.

6.48 That's ridiculous, of course. It could have gone either way, first of all. Secondly, it's something you have to learn from experience. If I say that Nixon once met Elvis Presley, that's something I have to learn through experience. It couldn't be something I just say, "Ah, of course, that's a logical truth. It's necessarily true." Why? Because what I mean by Nixon is "the president who met Elvis Presley." That's absurd.

6.49 And so, Kripke says we need a different sort of account. A name is not short for a definite description. It is not something that somehow involves some concepts that separate us from the world. A name is a "rigid designator." John Stuart Mill was right. It's just a tag for a thing. It picks out the same thing in every possible situation, in every possible world. It is a tag for that thing. I could give a name like that to anything.

- 6.50** I could call this tie Bobby. If I do, well, then I can talk about Bobby and so on, but it's a name for this thing. It is not something that, "Oh, there's some complicated description about the striped tie that Dan Bonevac was wearing," and blah, blah, blah. No, it's just this thing. That's it. He says, "When I think about what Nixon might have done, for example, I'm thinking about what that guy might have done, not what Eisenhower's vice president might have done, or what the winner of the 1968 election might have done and so on.
- 6.51** Similarly, if I think about what Aristotle might have done—like, say, he might have written additional works if he had lived longer—well, I'm thinking about Aristotle, that person. I'm not thinking about the greatest philosopher of antiquity or Plato's most famous student, etc. And so, there is a difference between examples, and this is something that Quine talks about, the difference between something like nine and then the number of the planets. For the moment, I'm just settling the controversy, or assuming it to be settled, whether Pluto is a planet.
- 6.52** Let's go back in time to when Quine was writing all this around 1960, and say Pluto is a planet. There are nine planets. Assume that for the moment. But now, the number of planets, if we look at various possible worlds, we realize that it could vary. Let's say there are actually nine planets, but maybe Pluto just drifts off, or maybe it disintegrates, or what have you. We say okay, not a planet, so there are only eight planets.
- 6.53** But maybe then an asteroid comes in and it's quite large and it gets trapped by the sun's gravitational field. We say now there's an additional planet. Now, maybe there are 10. That's it. All these things could happen. And so the number of planets, that's something that's going to pick out different numbers in different possible worlds. But the number 9 does not pick out different numbers in possible worlds; it picks out exactly the same number. Nine is nine.
- 6.54** I could say if this asteroid entered the solar system and got caught in the gravitational field, why, then, it could turn out that there are 10 planets. That's true. But if I say this asteroid might come in and get caught in the sun's gravitational field, and then the number 9 could be the number 10, that's absurd, right? The number 9 is the number 9. It's not the number 10. Those things are necessary. Nine picks out the same number in all possible worlds. The number of planets does not.
- 6.55** So Kripke says, all right, names are tags. They pick out the same thing in every possible world. And now he says that we need a different explanation. How on earth do I know what guy Nixon is? He said, "Here's what the story is. It's a causal story." Somebody gives somebody a name, let's say. How does that work? And he says, "Here, this isn't so much a theory as actually just a story I'm telling you," but it's a story that he thinks works in general.
- 6.56** There's an initial baptism. Here, Kripke is actually an Orthodox Jew. He doesn't really, literally mean a baptism. He means, there is an occasion where I give something a name. It's complicated to say exactly how that works. J. L. Austin, years before, had written a very funny paper about the complexities of this. One of his examples is, someone is there with a bottle of champagne about to christen a ship and actually name it something. And this "low type," as he puts it in the essay, comes running up, grabs the champagne, smashes it against the ship, and says, "I dub you the Generalissimo Stalin."

- 6.57** Is the name of the ship now the Generalissimo Stalin? Well, no, because that guy didn't have any right to do that. I wish he had lived long enough to actually talk about the Boaty McBoatface case. They said, "We're going to name this boat whatever wins this vote of people." The name that won was Boaty McBoatface. They decided no, that's too stupid. We're not going to name it Boaty McBoatface.
- 6.58** There was an artificially created lake in a town where my wife's family has a cottage, and I guess I'm now a partial owner of this cottage. Anyway, it's Goshen, New Hampshire. They had a contest like this to name this new lake. The name that won was submitted by a high school student. "Call it the Goshen Ocean." They decided, again, like Boaty McBoatface, "No, we can't call it an ocean." So they changed it to some boring name, Gunnison Lake. But actually, everybody in town still calls it the Goshen Ocean.
- 6.59** In any event, baptisms can go wrong, but there is some kind of social convention about how names get assigned. And as long as they're properly followed, then somebody tags this thing, that, Gunnison Lake, let's say, or Dan Bonevac, or Richard Nixon, whatever it is. In that case, what happens? There's a baby, and Richard Nixon's parents name the baby Richard Milhous Nixon. As long as that's properly done, then that's the name of that baby, and then the subsequent person. That is tagged in that way.
- 6.60** And so, it's not a question of what's the description? The child of those parents, blah, blah, blah. No, it's a matter of, this person now has the name Richard Milhous Nixon, and that name refers to that person. Then how do the rest of us learn to use it? Through a causal chain. They say, "Oh, the baby's name is Richard." Other people then pick up the use of the name, and it spreads and so on. That's what names work like. They're tags, and we learn how to use the tags by this social process of transmission.
- 6.61** All sorts of things could go wrong, not only with that initial thing, as the Generalissimo Stalin case indicates, but sometimes things change. For example, Madagascar was a name originally given to a bit of the coast of what's now Mozambique, but now we use it to refer to the island. Sometimes there's an initial baptism of this kind, but then usage changes.
- 6.62** That's true of any kind of word. It initially has this meaning, and then the meaning changes to that. The reference might be this, but then it changes to that. That can happen. It's not a strictly causal story in the sense that that thing always ends up keeping that name. Sometimes it might decide, "I want a new name." Well, the island didn't decide, "I want a new name," but instead it was rather a matter of people deciding that. But a person can change their name as well.
- 6.63** And so, these tags can change, but nevertheless, that's it. It's just a tag. There's a direct link between me and the thing in reality. When I use the word Nixon, I'm referring to that man. I am not referring through some cloud of definite descriptions.
- 6.64** So Kripke's point is you're thinking about the connection between mind and world and acting as if this is a really complicated thing, and maybe we're caught under the net of language or of concepts. He says, no, names link us to the world very directly. It's a link we make every day to objects we recognize and the people we recognize. There's no cloud of concepts. We are contacting reality all the time. We're contacting it causally when we touch things. We are contacting it causally when we see things. And naming is one way that this works in language.

- 6.65** So do demonstrative pronouns, like this and that. They, too, link us to reality directly. And so, we don't have to worry about contacting others only through this screen, and we worry about possible reflections, and cloudiness and other things that are barriers; we can break through the screen. We can get ourselves out of the net. We do it all the time, every time we talk about "that man" or "this thing," or use a proper name. So we can talk about reality directly. It is independent of how we think and talk about it. We can change the labels. The labels are not something that trap us. It's not constructed by our concepts; neither is our reference to it. There's a direct and immediate link between us and the world.
- 6.66** This does transform philosophy. At first, you might think—and in fact, I took, as a graduate student, a course in the philosophy of mind, and mostly it was about this. It was about Kripke's theory of naming, and then various reactions to it. At first glance, as a young student, I thought, "I thought this was a course about minds, not about names. What's going on?" It took me a while to realize, "Oh, this is fundamental because it's about what is the issue, or how to think about this issue of the connection between mind and world."
- 6.67** Kripke is saying there's a very direct connection. It's not that complicated. In that respect, the idealist who says we're trapped in the world of perception, we're trapped in the world of ideas, Kripke is in effect saying no, we're not. The world is independent of us. It's right there. I can give it a name. When I use that name, I'm talking about it. I'm not trapped in some kind of cloud or looking in some kind of mirror. It's right there. I'm naming it, and I am linking to it directly. So, to some extent, he is responding not only to that overall tendency toward idealism, but he is also responding in part to his own teacher, Willard Van Orman Quine.
- 6.68** Quine imagines a situation where a jungle linguist encounters a native who says, "Gavagai." He starts noticing, trying to translate this, he starts noticing the native says, "Gavagai," when and only when he's in the presence of rabbits. So he thinks, "Gavagai means rabbit." Now, Quine says that's an entirely reasonable translation. But it's also a choice. Actually, that might mean a bunch of things.
- 6.69** "What's really there?" he says. Is it a rabbit? We might translate this as rabbit, or there's a rabbit. We could translate it as "there are undetached rabbit parts." We're heading into Thanksgiving. I'm sure my daughter is going to make a joke about undetached turkey parts. Then it could also mean, well, there's a temporal stage of a rabbit. It could mean platonic rabbithood, exemplified. It could be talking about an event. "Hey, it's rabbiting," kind of like it's raining. It could mean any of these things.
- 6.70** And Quine says, "What is there actually in the world? Is it rabbits? Is it temporal stages of rabbits? Is it rabbithood? What are we even talking about here? Maybe it's events of rabbiting, or undetached rabbit parts." And actually, what are we even doing when we talk about the term rabbit? I can't tell you what the native means. And then Quine realizes, "Wait, when I use the term rabbit, what do I mean?" And so he says, "Relativity begins at home. I can't even know what I'm referring to." So that's an extreme form.
- 6.71** Kripke, again, changes it dramatically. Not only do we have contact with reality directly, we refer to reality directly, not only with proper names or things like this and that, but also with natural kind terms, like rabbit or water or tiger. We're talking about that kind of thing. The world consists of objects that fall into these natural kinds, and we give the kinds labels, just as we give individual things a label. So, we can label that kind of animal, rabbit. We can

label that kind of animal, tiger. This kind of substance, water. In doing that, we are talking about that kind of thing. Again, it is a direct link to a kind.

6.72 If you say, "What is that kind exactly? Can you give me a definition of tiger?", I don't have to give you a definition of tiger. I know what a tiger is without being able to define it. A tiger is that kind of animal.

6.73 Or you say, "Wait, what is a passionfruit?" I say, " We're in a grocery store. Here, I'll show you. That's a passionfruit." I'm doing it by just ostending the thing, but also by saying, "I mean that kind of thing." I'm not giving you a description. Actually, I don't know much biology. I have no idea how to define passionfruit, but I can take you into the supermarket and say, "That!" That is what we do with kinds as well. We can say that "gavagai" refers to that kind of thing—that kind, and that gives it a content independently of this, "it's rabbiting" or "undetached rabbit parts" type of question.

6.74 My colleague, Galen Strawson, has said that once you go down this step, it really changes all sorts of things. He wrote, "I took up philosophy in 1972 and thought I was taught all these things, like, I don't try to get something because I want it; I want it because I try to get it. Or I don't act on some information because I believe it; I believe it because I'm inclined to act on it. I don't use the word correctly because I know what it means; I know what it means because I use it correctly," and so on and so forth. "I don't have table-ish experiences because there's a table in front of me; I say there's a table in front of me because I have certain table-ish experiences."

6.75 That was the received and rather idealistic view of a lot of philosophers throughout much of the 20th century. But after Kripke, you can actually say that's all ridiculous. I see it. I have these table-ish experiences because there's a table there. I can refer to the reality, and the reality is what explains it. And so Galen says, "It seems to me all these claims were the wrong way around. I started feeling insecure about my ability to do philosophy. I still think they're all the wrong way around, but I feel less insecure. Things are looking up a little in the 21st century."

6.76 The reason they're looking up a little is Saul Kripke. He was able to say, "Forget all this weird stuff where everything's really reversed. No, when I talk about tables, I'm talking about tables. When I talk about rabbits, I'm talking about rabbits. When I refer to Nixon, I'm referring to Nixon. I'm making a direct link to the world." There are other things he does. He uses this, for example, to suggest that minds really do exist that are independent of bodies and a variety of other really interesting things. But I'm going to skip past some of that since I've already talked about it enough and gotten, I hope, you excited about learning more about Saul Kripke.

6.77 Now I want to link it to morality a little bit more closely. I think the person who does this, right around the same time that Kripke was writing, though completely independently, I don't think they were pretty aware of one another, is Joan Didion. Now, Didion is a strange person to talk about in terms of philosophical ideas, partly because she wasn't really a philosopher. That's not what she did. She got a BA in English at Berkeley and started writing for Vogue, and then wrote a variety of books, some of them fictional, some of them nonfictional.

6.78 She ended up winning the National Book Award for her book, "The Year of Magical Thinking," which was her reflection on her own grief after her husband died. But I want to

say what she starts discussing in a couple of essays on morality, because I think it's analogous in some way to what Kripke was doing, and trying to revive a robust sense of right and wrong.

- 6.79** She says, "I want you to understand exactly what you're getting here. You're getting a woman who, for some time now, has felt radically separated from most of the ideas that seem to interest people. You're getting a woman who, somewhere along the line, misplaced whatever slight faith she had in the social contract, in the ameliorative principle," in other words, in progress, "and the whole grand pattern of human endeavor."
- 6.80** So her writing, she says, "I'm out of step with the times. I'm doing something different." She had this public image of someone who was happily married, lived in this beautiful house overlooking the Pacific Ocean in Malibu, drove a Corvette, and so on. So there was definitely an image that went along with all of this. But nevertheless, kind of proudly out of step with the times.
- 6.81** She wrote a couple of essays, one called "On Morality," and the other "On Self-Respect." Let me start with "On Morality." She says there is a fundamental morality that actually everybody shares. We disagree about a lot of things, and it's easy to be cynical when you focus on the disagreement. But she says there's a certain level at which—and you really see it when survival, when life and death, are on the line. You see a certain kind of social code emerge, a certain kind of ethic emerge, that really is basic to being human and that is universal.
- 6.82** She says, "I'm talking about a kind of social code that's sometimes called, usually pejoratively, 'wagon-train morality.' That's precisely what it is, the only kind of morality that seems to me to have any but the most potentially mendacious meaning. A code that has as its point only survival, not the attainment of the ideal good." So, too often, she says, people have thought about morality in terms of what is the good, or what is right, what is wrong? And she thinks that's the wrong way to go about it.
- 6.83** Now, as somebody said, it's the way that most moral theorists, most philosophers, think about it. We're shaped by Socrates, who said, "You claim that that's wrong or that this is right? Define what's right, or tell me what it is to be wrong." He thinks that if you can't give a definition, you don't understand it, and you haven't justified your claim. But Didion is saying that's the wrong way around. Don't start thinking about the ideal good. Think about basic questions, basic questions of life and death, about survival.
- 6.84** She's suspicious of these other claims. She says, "'I followed my own conscience.' 'I did what I thought was right.' How many madmen have said it and meant it? Except on the most primitive level—our loyalties to those we love—what could be more arrogant than to claim the primacy of personal conscience?" She starts the essay by describing a situation where there's been a horrible crash. She's on the edge of Death Valley, and there, out in Death Valley, somebody crashed, and this woman's husband was killed. She stayed out there with the body to keep it from being eaten by coyotes or attacked.
- 6.85** That is something Didion is saying: that's very primitive and very basic, and something that has to do with personal loyalties, with love, and also just respect for humanity. It is something that goes beyond anybody saying, "I know what the ideal good is," or if Socrates comes in and says, "You think that's what she should do? Define should." You want to slap Socrates and say, "Come on, man, are you human or what?"

- 6.86** She says when people start going far beyond that and saying, "This is what a true, just society should be like," she said, don't take that seriously. The ethics of conscience is something she's suspicious of. "Of course, you'll say that I don't have the right, even if I had the power, to inflict my unreasonable conscience on you; nor do I want you to inflict your conscience, however reasonable, however enlightened, upon me." Beyond certain basic things, we can choose our own visions of the good.
- 6.87** She says, "We've got to be aware of the dangers which lie in our most generous wishes." She's quoting there Lionel Trilling. "Some paradox of our nature leads us, when once we've made our fellow men the objects of our enlightened interest, to go on to make them the objects of our pity, then of our wisdom, and ultimately, of our coercion." She says, "I want to insist there is no way of knowing—beyond a fundamental loyalty to that code, that wagon-train morality—what is right and what is wrong, what is good and what is evil."
- 6.88** So, from one point of view, she sounds cynical about moral discourse. She is saying, "Yeah, right and wrong, good and evil, just and unjust. Look, I don't know what they mean. I don't think there's any way to know what they mean." But that doesn't mean that morality, that ethics, is hopeless. Not at all. We have many different ways in which we might characterize the good, many different ways in which we might try to define what is right, what is wrong.
- 6.89** But nevertheless, she wants to say that from one point of view, you could say there are many ways of doing this. When we disagree, there's no way of sorting out the disagreements. That is a classic traditional argument for skepticism. We can't possibly know what's right. She says, at a certain level, that is true—lots of different ways of characterizing what a just society would be like. We have no way of deciding among them. So she's saying, "Let's not take so seriously this question of what a just society is."
- 6.90** But, she says, "Don't think that then you're left completely in skepticism. You're not." Why? Because all of those conceptions, which are truly different, nevertheless overlap. We don't share conceptions of the good, but we do share an interest in survival. There are things that human beings have in common, and so there is a core of morality. She's willing to call it "wagon-train morality." That, about basic questions of life and death, and personal loyalty, and love, friendship and so on, that really is a core that is universal.
- 6.91** So we don't share lots in morality. We disagree about many, many questions, but there are certain questions about which we do not disagree. We actually share an interest in survival. We share an interest in protecting those we love. We share an interest in trying to promote the good of our friends. Those things are basic. They're basic to being a human being. And so, however much we might be of different political parties, let's say, or different religions, or see certain kinds of social questions and ethical questions differently, when you come right down to it, we don't disagree about those things.
- 6.92** We think life is important. We think that you should protect those you love. We think that it is better, ordinarily anyway, to survive than to die. And so, there's a lot of the rest of it, she says. Then we can be cynical about, so about those basic questions of life and death, you shouldn't be cynical. Those are real. We can know what the answers are. As Bellow said at the end of *Mr. Sammler's Planet*, "We know, we know." Those things are fundamental, but a lot of the rest is not only unknown, but unknowable.

- 6.93** The result of that is, she says, a lot of ethical discourse, political discourse, it's just moral grandstanding. It is just virtue-signaling. "Questions of straightforward power (or survival) politics, questions of quite indifferent public policy, questions of almost anything— they're all assigned these factitious moral burdens. There's something quite facile going on, some self-indulgence at work. All the ad hoc committees, all the picket lines, all the brave signatures in the New York Times, all the tools of agitprop straight across the spectrum, do not confer on anyone any ipso facto virtue."
- 6.94** I'm sure today she would be writing about Facebook symbols and things like this. It's saying none of that makes a difference. Having hashtag blah, blah, blah does nothing actually for the cause of blah, blah, blah. And so it doesn't matter what you do and what you say. You're just signaling, "I'm on the right side of the issue of the day." You're not actually conferring any virtue on yourself. You're not actually accomplishing anything.
- 6.95** She says, "When we start deceiving ourselves into thinking not that we want something or need something, not that it's a pragmatic necessity for us to have it, but that it's a moral imperative that we have it, that's when we join the fashionable madmen. That's when the thin whine of hysteria is heard in the land, and that's when we are in bad trouble. And I suspect we're already there." Well, she didn't know the least of it. She should be around today to see all of this. But her point is, apart from that core that we share, then the rest, yeah, we should be cynical about that. That is something that is largely detached from the real necessities of human life. That's where people are mostly moral grandstanding and not accomplishing much at all.
- 6.96** That is her attitude about the general picture. Yes, much of morality we should be cynical about, she says, properly so. People disagree about it, and that's because, really, there are different ways of looking at it, and there's no way of saying what's right.
- 6.97** Hayek, I think, would largely agree. He would say, "That's what I meant." There are many good things, and agreeing that those are good things, that's pretty much what we have in common. But then finding the right balance, and saying, "This is the right balance, or no, that's an incorrect compromise," that's where we can't really know. There's no common scale that allows us to make those judgments. So, I think his view coincides in many ways with hers.
- 6.98** But then she turns to self-respect and writes another brief essay on the notion of self-respect. This essay, by the way, is something that is absolutely remarkable. At the last moment, the author of a piece that was designated for this magazine withdrew and said, "I can't do it." And so the editor called up Joan Didion and said, "Listen, I need something by Monday, and it's got to fit on these pages. So I need it to be not just this many words, this many characters." She had to write this over a weekend to a specific character count, and she did it. That is the sign of a professional. I am impressed.
- 6.99** But anyway, she writes this essay, "On Self-Respect," and here's what she's arguing against, a psychologist who had written this, but she thought it was the common view within psychology. "The person with self-respect simply likes her- or himself. This self-respect isn't contingent on success; there are always failures to contend with. Neither is it a result of comparing ourselves with others; there's always someone better. These are tactics usually employed to increase self-esteem. Self-respect, however, is a given. We

simply like ourselves or we don't. With self-respect, we like ourselves because of who we are and not because of what we can or cannot do."

6.100 Now, at first glance, it will look like she's agreeing with this, but deeper down, she is disagreeing. She begins the essay this way: "Once, in a dry season, I wrote in large letters across two pages of a notebook that innocence ends when one is stripped of the delusion that one likes oneself. I lost the conviction that lights would always turn green for me, the pleasant certainty that those rather passive virtues, which had won me approval as a child, automatically guaranteed me not only a Phi Beta Kappa key, but happiness, honor, and the love of a good man."

6.101 And that, by the way, was the crisis. She was in school and in college and thought she was doing very well, and didn't get inducted into Phi Beta Kappa, the honor society. That shattered her image of herself. But anyway, that might seem trivial; nevertheless, that's what brought about these reflections. She says, "I lost a certain touching faith in the totem power of good manners, clean hair, and proved competence on the Stanford-Binet scale." And so she said, well, all of these were doubtful amulets. They were symbols.

6.102 She says, "To these things had my self-respect been pinned. I faced myself that day with a nonplussed apprehension of someone who has come across a vampire and has no garlands of garlic at hand." She suddenly realized, "Look, I've been treating myself as worth something because I can do this, because I can get high scores on tests, and because I can do this and that, and have clean hair and look nice," and blah, blah, blah, blah. She suddenly realizes, "Wait, maybe I'm not quite as good as I think." Secondly, maybe these things aren't the things that really matter.

6.103 She said, at that point, what happens? You decide not just that, oh, maybe my self-esteem drops because I can't actually do this or that as well as I thought. Instead, she decides, "I don't even like myself anymore. Here, I've been striving for all this, and now I feel like a fool. I feel like, yeah, who am I? What am I doing?" And so, it doesn't just challenge my sense of myself as a result of being able to do things. It challenges her own liking of herself.

6.104 So she says, "Although being driven back upon oneself is an uneasy affair at best, rather like trying to cross a border with borrowed credentials, it seems to me now the one condition necessary to the beginnings of real self-respect. Most of our platitudes notwithstanding, self-deception remains the most difficult deception." So I think here she's on the side of some of the postmodernists, oddly, saying, knowing yourself, that might be the hardest possible thing. Deceiving yourself is incredibly easy.

6.105 She says it is true that self-respect has nothing to do with the approval of others. We can deceive them easily enough. In any case, as Rhett Butler told Scarlett O'Hara, that's something people with courage can do without. But eventually, we have to face, well, ourselves. She says, "No matter how long we postpone it, we have to lie down alone in that notoriously uncomfortable bed, the one we make ourselves. Whether or not we sleep in it depends on whether or not we respect ourselves."

6.106 It's not a question of liking yourself. It's not a question of feeling proud of yourself. It's something else. She says, "That has nothing to do with the face of things, but concerns a separate peace, a private reconciliation." So what are these people with self-respect like? She says, first of all, they have the courage of their mistakes. They know the price of

things. They take responsibility. They have a certain toughness, what's called character. The ability, the willingness, to accept responsibility for your own actions and your own life. Very much like Sartre's concept of authenticity. That's the source from which self-respect springs.

6.107 So, Didion says, "This is something our grandparents knew all about, whether or not they actually had it." That instilled in them a certain discipline. To put fears and doubts to one side, to do what you have to do, to think hard about large intangible comforts and discomforts you want to attain or you want to avoid—in other words, to be willing to delay gratification and control your own desires—it's a discipline, a habit of mind. It can't be faked, but nevertheless, it can be developed. It can be trained.

6.108 So, she says, "To have a sense of one's intrinsic worth, that constitutes self-respect. That is, really, in the end, the ability to have everything—to discriminate, to love, to hate, to remain indifferent." All of that is, in some way, a matter of feeling a sense of your own intrinsic worth, your own dignity. I think here she's echoing Immanuel Kant, saying that you've got to treat everyone, including yourself, with respect. Treating yourself as an end in yourself. "Rational beings are called persons because their nature points them out as ends in themselves. They must not be used merely as means, and that means they must be objects of respect."

6.109 So the idea is that it is our ability not only to choose our own futures, as the existentialist thinks, but to live under the rules we set for ourselves, to be willing to set ourselves certain goals and sacrifice things for them and accept responsibility for that. That is something that is fundamental to our basic dignity. And so, being willing to live by those rules that you establish for yourself because of the things you truly care about, treating yourself as having a dignity, that's what it comes to.

6.110 She says, "It's a matter of knowing that anything worth having has its price. People who respect themselves are willing to take the risk. They invest something in themselves. They may not play at all, but if they do, they know the odds." Here I'm reminded of Kipling, who once said, "If you don't get what you want, it's a sign either that you didn't seriously want it or you tried to bargain over the price."

6.111 She's saying a person with real character, with real self-respect, if they do seriously want it, they don't try to bargain. They actually go for it and accept the risk that they might not get it. So she says, in the end, this is what really matters in life. It's a question of having self-respect. "Without it, one eventually discovers the final turn of the screw; you run away to find yourself, and find no one at home."

6.112 So, at the beginning, when we were talking about, say, Carl von Clausewitz, "War is terrible, get it over fast," philosophically, how do we reconcile the internationally recognized rules of war? How do you have rules of war?

6.113 Clausewitz didn't have much respect for rules of war. He thought you ought to throw them out, because war is terrible, and you want to end it as quickly as possible by whatever means. Now, I don't advocate that view. I think the idea that there should be no moral constraints at all in wartime is pretty horrible. On the other hand, I think moral constraints that are so restrictive that you end up saying, "We can't bomb these defensive networks they're setting up because that just wouldn't be cricket," I think that's insane.

- 6.114** So somewhere between the, "Hey, all's fair in war," to the, "We can't attack their—I mean, they have the right to defend themselves. We can't attack that," look, if they really do have this right, then you shouldn't be fighting them at all, right? So there's something that is hard to articulate and hard to get right, I think. But that's what just-war theories have been trying to do all throughout history, trying to say, "Here's what it is to fight a war justly." There's the question of when you can go to war, and then there's the question of, within the context of a war, how can you fight?
- 6.115** Here, von Clausewitz is on one extreme of saying, "Actually, I'm in favor of no rules at all about that." And you've got Johnson at the other extreme, saying, "Oh, I think the things that people have outlined traditionally are just the beginning. You've got to go much further." Now, for example, one of the rules I have in mind about this thing is that you shouldn't attack civilians directly. If civilians are collateral damage, but there is a legitimate military objective that can't be achieved otherwise, then it is acceptable to do things that you know are going to harm innocent civilians. But you shouldn't bomb innocent civilians as a means to your ends.
- 6.116** That, by the way, becomes—that's something that both sides in World War II violated extensively. There are things that were violated terribly, even in wars we consider just and overall good wars. But I think what Johnson was trying to do is win a kind of war of ideas by saying, "We're the good guys here, and we behave like good guys. We're not only going to follow those traditional rules of warfare, we're going to go further. We're going to show you how good we are. We're going to set a moral example."
- 6.117** You can see how Didion, who, by the way, was a Republican and not at all a fan of Johnson in this respect, thought, "You've got this conception, and it's a very strange conception. You want the rest of us to go along with that. That's crazy." There are basic questions about life and death that, yes, are fundamental. But this is taking things in a way that almost nobody agrees with that position. Then you don't really have the right to impose that on other people.
- 6.118** So I think there is a connection, but I think somewhere in the middle is a reasonable position that theorists of warfare have been trying to sort out for centuries. It is surprising to me that politicians involved in the conduct of wars rarely show much awareness of that body of literature. Not that I really expect them to be reading Aquinas and Vitoria and other people who are major figures in that, but still, there are people who are specialists in that.
- 6.119** Now, to be fair, our military academy has ethicists who do teach all of this stuff. And so, anybody who is an officer level, let's say, in the military has been exposed to this theory and knows a lot of the basic rules. In, for example, the Iraq War, the United States tried to follow those rules very precisely and did not go to extremes, but also did not, in general, engage in immoral activities. It said, "Here are the rules the Marines, for example, are going to try to obey." It was firmly based in that kind of theory.
- 6.120** But when you look at the entire history of warfare, I think that's an exception rather than the rule. Usually, people go in the direction of von Clausewitz and do things that they really shouldn't do. But sometimes, as with Johnson, they go too far in the other direction and refuse to do things they really ought to do, if they want to end the fighting.
- 6.121** My students, by the way, ask me this question, saying, "What was he thinking? Why do that? What view of ethics leads you to that?" I had to admit, I don't know, except in the

context of thinking of this as something like a game, and that would be violating the rules of the game. It wouldn't be a fair fight. It'd be like, you hit me below the belt, or something. I think, so there's a kind of schoolyard sense of you're fighting fair, or you're fighting unfair. But the idea that destroying weapons that are trying to kill your people would be unfair seems to me pretty bizarre.

6.122 Going back to the names as rigid designators, when they had voted on that boat to be named Boaty McBoatface, and they ended up going with a different name instead, if the locals identify it as Boaty McBoatface, does that still follow in line with that philosophy of, they identify it as the item itself? Because they're referring to the essence of the item, even if they're not using the same name, the two different parties both know what they're referring to. Does that still follow that?

6.123 All right, great question. I think it gets at this question of, what is an actual naming convention? But also some of the questions that Gareth Evans raises in an article, a very well-known article, on the causal theory of names, where he's pointing out these complicated cases. In fact, Madagascar, that's one I'm stealing from Evans in this case. His point is that this story of baptism and then causal transmission in something like a tree-like fashion is too simple. There can be changes like the Madagascar case, but there can also be cases where, OK, usages arise in a way that's non-standard.

6.124 People say, "We're going to name it whatever wins this contest. Boaty McBoatface wins." That's ridiculous. So they name it something else. But now, notice, I can't remember the other name, the real name of the boat. I just remember Boaty McBoatface. I don't know if people continue to call it that. Maybe they do. I know in the case of the Goshen Ocean, more people call it the Goshen Ocean than call it Lake Gunnison, though maybe eventually that will change because people will forget the story.

6.125 But in any case, it's as if there are different ways in which these usages can arise. One way in which you can see this is in differences in language. For example, in the use of, let's say, proper names in different languages, they're different. For example, we call London, London. But in France, they call London, Londres. Actually, Kripke has a paper about this. Imagines a guy who has this storybook image of London from reading about it and thinks, "Oh, London is a beautiful, beautiful city."

6.126 But then he's a victim of a crime, ends up on a boat, wakes up in this place where he's like, "Oh, this is, this is disgusting." He's down by the docks, thinks this city is filthy. "I hate this city." And it turns out it's London. And he learns that this is London. But he's been saying, "Londres, it's beautiful, but London is ugly." Yet it's the same place. It seems like, causally, they're connected to exactly the same thing. So is he contradicting himself? Well, obviously not. Or is he? Anyway, Kripke starts worrying about this.

6.127 I think the Boaty McBoatface example is a little bit like this, so is the Goshen Ocean example, because then you've got these two traditions arising. What happens if somebody does not know those are names of the same thing? Somebody's, let's say, visiting New Hampshire and says, "I've been to Lake Gunnison, but I heard about the Goshen Ocean. I want to go visit it. I haven't been there." I was like, I guess the correct response, "Well, yes, you have. That was the joke name for this thing."

6.128 And so, I think a lot of complications arise there. And Kripke thinks we have to distinguish semantic meaning from speaker meaning, kind of the official use in the language, as

- opposed to the unofficial use in a given speaker's way of talking. It might be a large group of speakers like Boaty McBoatface, or a relatively small but still significant group like the Goshen Ocean. Maybe it's an entire language group that says Londres instead of London.
- 6.129** But you're right, those things are tied to sometimes different processes of assignment of the name, and then they might be different in various other ways. Maybe we start out with one concept and then it divides into two. There are lots of complications, some of which Evans talks about in that article. It's a great question. I think that's why people who have thought hard about this have realized, oh, it sounds like a really simple story in Kripke. It's part of the reason, by the way, he says, "This isn't a theory, this is just a story. This is how it often works."
- 6.130** People realized, actually that to turn that story into a theory turns out to be really hard, because how do names get introduced? How do they maintain reference? What happens when they shift the reference? What if people have two names for the same thing or one name for what's really two different things? One of my teachers talked about a case of a kid who has an ant farm, and he's especially interested in this ant he calls Charlie. It turns out what he calls Charlie is actually two different ants. They just look a lot alike.
- 6.131** Or you can imagine Shakespeare stories where they're identical twins, and is she in love with this one or that one, et cetera, et cetera? Or for that matter, I guess more common in Shakespeare is the, oh, this person's disguised as that one, et cetera. Yeah, it can get really, super complicated. So, there is no simple answer to those types of questions. It's actually pretty hard to figure out what's going on.

7. Murmur of the Absolute

- 7.1** I'm going to be talking now about the Murmur of the Absolute. That's my way of expressing the idea that this concept of normativity, the idea of what we ought to be doing and ought not to be doing, did enjoy a resurgence after World War II. There was a very strong sense that we had encountered real evil and that real moral choices had to be made. It was no longer possible to be cynical about morality, to just say it's just a matter of taste, and so on. Instead, people had the sense, "Oh, it's not just that I don't like the Holocaust. No, that was really evil." There is evil in the world. That sense that there is a real content, a real objective content to morality, became stronger and stronger.
- 7.2** Now, there was a great deal of moral confusion, as we've seen throughout the 1950s, '60s, '70s. But nevertheless, there was a growing sense that we had to recover a sense of what the "ought" really was. Whether or not we understood completely how it relates to the "is," we needed to be able to talk in moral terms and frank moral terms, and figure out not only individually in our own lives, but also collectively together how to understand and approach certain practical and moral problems. Hence, this recovery, this sense of the murmur of the absolute that had to be confronted.
- 7.3** Now, we've talked already about Joan Didion in a sense, trying to do that, but also in a sense, expressing cynicism that there was a lot of moral posturing going on. Nevertheless, there was a core of morality having to do with what she calls "wagon-train morality," about

basic questions of survival that provided a basis for that. It's not, however, maybe enough of a basis. Yes, it lets us call certain things truly evil and identify certain core duties.

7.4 On the other hand, what do we, together as a society, do in facing problems? How should we actually make decisions together, and what should we decide? It looks as if that's not enough to really provide us much of any guidance. So there was a desire to go back to basics, as it were, and try to figure out: can we do better? Can we expand that central core and try to understand more clearly how to think about problems in a far more general and in a more social or political way?

7.5 So I want to focus today on two really influential theories of distributive justice, and more broadly speaking, of government. These are attempts that I think have shaped a huge amount of thinking starting around 1970 and going to the present time about how to think of these problems. We're going to look primarily at two figures, and those two figures define, in a sense, the leading—at least until very recently—the leading ideologies of both the Democratic and Republican parties in the United States, but also similarly situated parties throughout most of the Western world.

7.6 What do I mean by this question of distributive justice? The concept goes back to Aristotle, who defined it this way: "It's a matter of how the goods and responsibilities of society should be distributed among its members." There are goods, and so we can think, yes, it shouldn't be the case that the wealth of a society, in general, is concentrated among just a few people. We don't want to be in the situation that Rousseau describes at the end of the "Second Discourse," where a few are gorging themselves on luxuries while the multitude lack necessities. On the other hand, we also want to think, but people deserve certain things for certain kinds of achievements, for certain innovations, and so forth. So, it's a complicated question of what would be a good or just distribution of the goods of society.

7.7 But there are also questions of responsibility. Who should actually gain political office and have political power, for example? That's something that especially concerned Aristotle. But there are other duties as well. Who should be drafted, for example, to fight in the military? And how do we decide on those things? What other kinds of responses—for example, who should pay the taxes? There could be a just or an unjust tax system. So we need to think about goods and responsibilities and ways of distributing them.

7.8 The first person to really focus on these issues in a modern context and try to develop a comprehensive theory of distributive justice was John Rawls. He started his career at Cornell University and then spent decades teaching at Harvard, and was maybe the most influential political philosopher of the 20th century. Rawls developed a concept of justice as fairness. Now, at first glance, that seems a triviality: to be just is to be fair. You could say, "Yeah, they're synonyms," but that's not very helpful.

7.9 However, he means something different. What he's really saying is that if we have a fair procedure for determining principles under which we agree to live, then that would be a just society. The fairness is in the process of decision making, and the justice is a substantive question of judging the legitimacy of the outcome of that procedure. He says that basically, as long as we follow a fair procedure and we're in a situation where people would rationally agree to accept the results, then we have a concept of justice.

7.10 Rawls's theory is a version of social contract theory. This is an idea that goes all the way back to Thomas Hobbes, who was writing in the 17th century. It's not only Hobbes, but

also John Locke, Jean-Jacques Rousseau, Immanuel Kant. A whole series of Enlightenment thinkers were social-contract theorists. This is the ideology that really lays behind the American founding. Our founders were also social contract theorists.

- 7.11** The idea is that the legitimacy of government depends on the rational consent of the people. It addresses really the most fundamental question of political philosophy, which is simply: what makes government authority legitimate? After all, the government has a huge amount of power over the individual people of a society. It determines laws for them, and those laws are ones people have to obey. If they don't, they suffer certain penalties. It imposes taxes. It may require people to serve in the armed forces. It can do a lot of things. It can imprison people. It can even put them to death. And so there is an awesome power involved in government.
- 7.12** Why do we agree to serve under it? Why do we say sometimes this authority over us is legitimate, and other times we say it's not? The answer of the social contract theorist is that we would give rational consent to government in general and to that particular form of government. It is legitimate if the people would rationally agree to live under it. That idea that its authority, its power, its privileges rest on the consent of the governed, that is a key idea that goes all throughout the Enlightenment.
- 7.13** Rawls returns to that and says, "I think that's fundamentally right." It is the case that institutions or patterns of distribution or government in general is just if people would rationally consent to it. It has to rest on the consent of the governed. Any social contract theory is going to have three parts. The first part is going to say that it depends on the rational choice of the people. So, first of all, we have to ask: under what circumstances are the people going to be making this choice?
- 7.14** In reality, of course, there are actual circumstances historically that people get together in some cases. Often, government is just imposed on them through force. But in principle, people can, as in the Mayflower Compact or the U.S. Constitution, get together and collectively decide this is going to be our form of government. So, there are actual circumstances.
- 7.15** But we're thinking really here about idealized hypothetical circumstances. After all, most of us aren't in that situation. I have not been part of a constitutional convention, and I doubt that many of you have. But the idea is: would we agree? So have I given consent? I don't know. Maybe. I didn't leave the country. I do pay my taxes. So I think in some sense I've given consent. On the other hand, you could say that what really matters is: would you consent, and would it be rational for you to consent?
- 7.16** So we need to spell out the circumstances that would define what a rational choice would be in this case. It's going to be hypothetical. It's going to be in some sense, idealized, but there are going to be circumstances where we say: what would you do faced with this situation?
- 7.17** Secondly, how would we choose? What are the rational criteria for choice? The idea is that it rests on the rational consent of the governed. But what do we mean by rational? What would count as rational?
- 7.18** Finally, there's the question of what we would choose. What principles, what institutions, what forms of government would we actually choose in these hypothetical circumstances?

I have to think, "When would I be choosing here? How would I choose? Then what, in the end, would I choose?"

7.19 Rawls has a theory about each of these parts. The first part: when to choose, what are these hypothetical circumstances like? In various versions of social contract theory, these are spelled out very differently. In Thomas Hobbes, the state of nature, a situation without government, would be a war of all against all. Life would be solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short. So, I'm willing to give up a huge amount of power and authority to the government just to save my life. In John Locke, it's not nearly so bad. There are ways in which we would broadly enforce a law of nature. Nevertheless, there would be problems, and so we would agree to form a limited government.

7.20 Well, John Rawls says that these are hypothetical circumstances, and here's where we have to ensure that the process is fair. He calls this state not the state of nature or something as Hobbes and Locke do, but instead the original position. This is the position from which we would make a rational choice about various principles of justice. What would make it fair? He says that in this circumstance, we would have to choose under the veil of ignorance.

7.21 Let me explain the various parts of this. First of all, a group of us would get together in these idealized circumstances and choose principles of social justice or institutions or forms of government to govern our association. Certain things have to be the case for this to be a fair choice. First of all, the people involved have to be choosing freely. We have to be free. We shouldn't be acting under coercion. In fact, it's a worry from his point of view if we've got a war of all against all going on. Maybe we're not making a very rational choice. We're just forced into it. We want to be choosing freely.

7.22 We want to be rational. It's got to be a rational choice. If people would agree to this, but through an act of craziness, that's not going to justify much of anything. People, he says, should be behaving in a self-interested way. In other words, he doesn't want to start with a moral conception and now say, "People are going to be enforcing their own morality through government." He instead wants to say, "We're going to make this choice and voluntarily consent, freely and rationally consent, because it's in our interest."

7.23 The whole idea here, in a way, is to say that the legitimacy of government depends on us choosing it because it is in our self-interest to choose it. We're trying to get from self-interest, from prudence, as it were, to a moral requirement that we actually obey the law, for example, or that we submit to the authority of government.

7.24 Finally, for this to be fair, we all have to be equal. If some of us are in positions of power over others and a few people are deciding for everyone else, then that's not going to meet these demands of fairness. Each of us has to be in a position to say, "I rationally consent, I voluntarily consent to be governed in this way." Those are the requirements of fairness.

7.25 Now, to do it competently, we have to know a lot. We have to know the relevant facts about society, about economics, about politics, and so on. Here's a hypothetical and highly idealized thing. We want to imagine that we know what we're doing. After all, if we choose principles of justice rather naively, like bringing a bunch of kindergarteners together and saying, "Okay, you're going to determine the rules of this kindergarten; we turn it over to you."

- 7.26** By the way, this is what Bismarck thought of democracy, essentially allowing the nursery to rule the household. But in any case, if we think of it that way, it's like, yeah, these kids don't know what they're doing, and they're going to say, "Okay, every hour on the hour, candy," and so on. We're not going to say that's the right set of rules to live under. In short, we have to know enough about society, politics, economics, and so on to make rational choices.
- 7.27** However, not only do we want no prejudices or even moral conceptions, various contingencies to affect the choice, we want to make sure that nobody actually can tilt the process in their favor. This is the most controversial part of what Rawls is saying here. He says that we have to make the choice under the veil of ignorance. That is to say, we're to be highly knowledgeable about these general facts, about economics, politics, society, etc.
- 7.28** But we must not know our own place in society, our own natural abilities, our own propensities or dispositions, our own character, in other words, even our own conception of the good. I've got to make a choice without really knowing much about myself. Here's the idea: I am going to be designing a society and imagining that I'm choosing the form of government or the rules of justice for that society, but I don't know where I'm going to fit in, and I don't know what I'm going to be like.
- 7.29** For example, in reality, I love baseball, and so I could say that there should be taxpayer-funded baseball stadiums everywhere. But that's not reasonable, he thinks. That's not a fair process. I have to decide as if I'm deciding for somebody else. So he says that there's an obvious objection. Maybe if I don't know anything about myself, I can't make a rational choice. How do I know what's in my self-interest if I don't know what I like and I don't know what my interests are?
- 7.30** Indeed, one of my colleagues criticized Rawls on this basis. He thought Rawls was trying to pull a rabbit out of a hat because the hat doesn't really tell me anything about myself, and I'm supposed to be saying, "Aha, this is what would be in my self-interest" without having any idea what my self-interest is.
- 7.31** But Rawls responds by saying, imagine that you are hired by somebody to be their agent. They can't come to this hypothetical, idealized negotiation about the principles of justice. They say, "Represent me." But you don't really know anything about them. So you show up to represent their interests. And now, what are you going to be deciding on the basis of? Only the things that human beings have in common. So you're going to think, "I don't know who this person is, whether they're male or female, whether they're American or something else, maybe. But they're going to be part of this group somehow. I just have to decide on the basis of what would be good for a human being in general, because that's all I really know about."
- 7.32** Here's a way of thinking about all of this that I think lies behind Rawls's concept: I am designing a society. It's a bit like designing a game, but I don't know actually what player in this game I'm going to turn out to be or how the dice rolls will go or anything else. I'm setting this up. And then, there's going to be a grand lottery. We say that here's going to be our principles of justice. Here will be our institutions. Here's our form of government. Now, what role are you going to play in this society we're creating? We don't know. That'll be determined by lottery.

- 7.33** We might imagine there's going to be a normal distribution on all sorts of things, but that's going to be determined at random. For you, you don't know what it's going to be like. In particular, there are going to be environmental, personality factors, genetic factors, you won't know. Will you be born into a healthy, really strong family or a weak and dysfunctional family? That's going to be a matter of the lottery. What's your social status going to be? Are you going to be upper class, lower class or somewhere in between? It depends on the dice roll or the spin of that roulette wheel.
- 7.34** What about your family's income or your family's location or your own cognitive ability? You're going to be smart or average or dumb? That's all going to be determined by the spin of the wheel. The same thing, are you going to be beautiful or homely? Are you going to be athletic or not? You're going to be healthy or sick?
- 7.35** What about your personality? We're not going to know that either. Think about the Big Five personality traits. Are you going to be open to new things? Are you going to be conventional? Are you going to be conscientious or not? You're going to be extroverted or introverted, agreeable or disagreeable, neurotic or pretty healthy psychologically? The fact is, you don't know. It's all going to depend on the lottery. What religion will you be? What will be your attitudes about all sorts of things? You don't know.
- 7.36** The point is: all of that is up for grabs. You don't know how that's going to be. Think of it as designing a game. They're going to be different players, different roles, and you don't know which you're going to end up playing. That will be determined by lot, and you have to choose nevertheless. So you have to choose, how exactly?
- 7.37** That brings us to the question of how to choose. Now, in part, there's a question I don't want to go into a lot, although I've written about this and think it's very important. He says that one way we'll do this is to try out various principles and then see what happens, and think through: does that match what intuitively seems just to us? We're going to adjust our principles and sometimes maybe adjust our intuitions about justice so that we bring them into alignment. It's not as if we can just say, "Here are the principles once and for all." We're going to try things out, and people are going to say, "Wait, if you do it that way, then blah, blah, blah." So, there's going to be a process of adjustment here.
- 7.38** But what really matters, I think, for him, is how I think about the various possible outcomes of this game. We're designing this game. I don't know what role I'll play. How much risk am I willing to tolerate? For example, here will be one of the outcomes: the dice are thrown, and your character dies. Part of the rule is that if your character dies, you die. I wouldn't play that game. I would say, no, I don't want to do that. "Hey, let's play Monopoly, and the first one to be bankrupt gets killed." No, I'm not going to do it.
- 7.39** So Rawls says that there are certain risks we're not willing to take. It's all going to depend on the dice or the roulette wheel. It's like, that's a terrible outcome. I don't want it to be like that. "Ah, you spun that. I'm sorry, you're a slave in this society." "Hmm, I don't like that one either," and so on.
- 7.40** So he says that we're going to adopt a maximin principle. That's a principle of minimizing risk. The thought is that there are certain outcomes that are so bad, I don't want them. And in fact, I realized there are a whole bunch of possible outcomes for me as I enter into this game. I am looking to minimize my risk, so I want the best worst-case scenario. I'll say, "Suppose this is the outcome of the wheel or the dice, then what's the worst thing that

could happen to me?" I'm going to choose the one that is the best worst-case scenario. That's, in other words, maximizing the minimum. What's the worst case? Some of those are really terrible, some are pretty bad. I want the best possible worst case.

7.41 Now, this is controversial. We don't have to end up there, and Rawls gives a variety of complicated economic arguments for why we should choose that. But it is a place where a lot of people have said, "I don't know. I don't think I would choose that way." So there is a real question there. Can we choose without knowing our conception of the good? Well, Rawls says, yes, because I can imagine just choosing on the basis of what we human beings have in common.

7.42 However, you might think, "I don't know. How tolerant of risk am I?" After all, people invest in lots of things that are somewhat risky investments. If you think about the economic condition, the financial condition, people think in terms of the stock market: how much risk can you handle? How safe do you want these investments to be? Rawls is basically saying to invest in T-bills. I don't know if they're any longer low-risk, actually, but assuming they are, take the lowest risk investment and put everything in that.

7.43 That's not the way most people do things. So, there are various possible ways of responding to this setup. This is a real substantive issue about how we would go about choosing, and I'll get back to it. There are various alternatives we might want to consider here.

7.44 In any case, what would we choose? What would be the outcome of this process? He says that the answer is two principles of justice, and one of the two has two parts, but the first one is called sometimes the maximal equal basic liberty principle. That's complicated and has a lot of words. But on the other hand, here's the key idea—he's taking this over from Thomas Hobbes. He's saying, "Each person is to have an equal right to the most extensive basic liberty compatible with a similar liberty for others." That, at least, is how he spells it out in "A Theory of Justice," the first and most influential book that he published on this.

7.45 So what exactly does this mean? Maximal: we want the largest amount of these basic liberties as long as it's equal, as long as we can have everybody enjoying the same liberties. It might be that we could have even more liberty by allowing these people extra liberty. But the idea is, no, we want to have liberty apply across the board. We want this to be fair and even. So, how much liberty can we grant everyone before your liberty starts infringing on mine? We want to be able to do that, but he says, not with all liberties, with "basic liberties."

7.46 What are the basic liberties? They are the liberties that have to do with participating in a process of choosing the rules. So it's not as if—and here I come back to that idea of reflective equilibrium—we're going to engage in that as we deliberate, but also then we're going to implement certain rules or principles of justice, and we're going to have to adjust them. New things are going to arise. There will be court cases, for example, that none of us anticipated, and we'll say, "Oh, we have to decide about that, too? We never even thought of that."

7.47 In fact, philosophers are fond of taking obscure hypothetical cases, like thinking about the trolley problem, the out-of-control trolley, and you're standing there near the switch and so on. We think of wild cases. And yet you look at the history of constitutional law, for

example, and you think, "Oh, it gets way wilder." Reality has a wildness to it that people can't really anticipate. I'm thinking, yeah, we're going to have to keep adjusting these as things develop and we learn more and more. I want to be a participant. I want to be a free, rational, equal participant in that process of revising our principles and our rules. And so what does that mean?

7.48 I want freedom of speech. I want freedom of assembly. I want freedom of religion. I want the right to petition my government. I want to be able to have input into changing the rules. I want freedom from unreasonable searches and seizures so that I can be secure enough to actually participate without fear. I want to be able to be subject to the due process of law and have rights to life, liberty, and property. I want to make sure that if I'm accused of something, I'm tried by an impartial jury and an impartial judge and so on.

7.49 In short, the things we enshrine in our Bill of Rights, I'm going to insist on those because I want to be able to say that I'm going to be able to participate in the process. I don't want to be thrown in jail for a tweet, for example, or holding up a sign at a protest, or doing a variety of things that could get me into trouble so that I can't participate in the process. I want to make sure this is an ongoing process of reflective equilibrium in which I can participate.

7.50 Now, that first principle isn't actually all that controversial. There are some people, primarily Marxists, who don't like it, but overall, that's not where the big controversy about Rawls's theory arises. That has to do with the second principle.

7.51 The second principle, he says, "Social and economic inequalities must be arranged so that they are"—and now we're going to fill in the blank, but this is the key issue of distributive justice: social and economic inequalities. In other words, how are the goods and responsibilities of society to be distributed among the members? This is where we get the key part of the answer.

7.52 First of all, the difference principle: they must be reasonably expected to be to everyone's advantage. That's how he puts it in "A Theory of Justice." The thought is that I want these inequalities to actually be to everyone's advantage. Well, if I am getting more in this inequality, yeah, that's to my advantage, you might think. So, really, the issue is: what if I get less? What if I have more responsibilities or I have fewer goods given to me? Is that to my advantage? His answer is, "It's just if it is to your advantage."

7.53 At first glance, you might think, how could that be to my advantage? Well, if it's a question of this person getting more because I get less, that's clearly not to my advantage. But if the thought is, this person gets more and then hires me, and I'm better off, then it's to my advantage. His point is that a certain amount of inequality helps everybody, even the people at the bottom of the society. Why? Because those inequalities allow people to innovate. They give people rewards for achieving things, accomplishing things, innovating things. And so that person who becomes, let's say, very wealthy, it may be good for a society that they have that wealth because it enables them to build factories, to hire other people, in short, to invest in the future, to accomplish things that otherwise wouldn't be accomplished.

7.54 So here's a way of establishing absolute equality: assign the same income to everybody, no matter what their position is, no matter what their job is. That would not be good for society, Rawls recognizes. Nobody would get any reward for doing anything. So who

would take risks? Who would innovate? Who would actually work hard? There are experiments we talked about a little bit when we talked about Marxism, where people really tried that, and they found out that everybody wanted to just be a musician, and nobody wanted to be a farmer, for example, because you get paid just as much for tooting on your kazoo as you do for actually tilling the fields. So everybody wanted to be a kazoo player. Well, that doesn't work well.

7.55 So we need a degree of inequality just to motivate people, and that can actually improve the welfare of the people at the bottom. So he says that is really a key. There are times when inequalities help even the people who are at the losing end of the inequality. Not always; some inequalities really are zero-sum games where I gain at your expense. That, he says, can be unjust.

7.56 Here's how he puts it later in "Political Liberalism": "These inequalities must be to the greatest benefit of the least advantaged." In other words, it's the people at the bottom we have to worry about here. Are they being raised up by the inequality or are they being pushed down? If it's a question of the rich getting rich because the poor get poorer—bad, that's unjust. But if the rich get rich and then improve the lives of even those who are poor, then that's good; that is just.

7.57 He does add one more thing. He says, "Consistent with the just savings principle." He starts recognizing—and economists started pointing out to him, "Wait a minute, your principles aren't taking account of the fact that we need to invest in the future." We consume a certain amount in society, but we also invest. It's those investments for the future that actually lead to improvements in economic growth. If you're thinking about this, not at a moment, but instead, dynamically, you're thinking: what's going to improve the lives of the people at the bottom? In part, innovation. How is that innovation going to be financed? Through savings and investment that is going to promote the future.

7.58 David Schmidtz, in fact, has a nice paper in which he says that we don't want to eat the seed corn. A certain amount has to be set aside for next year's planting. If you say, "But we could improve the least advantaged by letting them eat the seed corn." Well, true for this year, but then we all starve the next year. So it's important to set aside a certain amount. Rawls says, yes, but what's a just amount to be setting aside? How much should we consume? How much should we invest? It's a hard question, and he realizes, "I have to answer that separately. We have to make a rational choice about that, too." That's a complication he recognizes by the year 2000 that he didn't recognize in 1971.

7.59 The second part of this principle is these inequalities have to be "attached to positions and offices that are open to all." This is an equal opportunity principle. It's not to say we all have to have an equal chance. If I say, "I think I'd like to be a cornerback in the NFL," I don't have much of a chance of succeeding at that. But he says that you've got to have an opportunity to try. I could walk on for the Pittsburgh Steelers and say, "Here I am. I'm going to be a defensive star," and they can say, "Okay, run for us." And then, they'll say, "Yeah. Goodbye." I don't have to have a real chance, but I have to have the opportunity to apply. If whole classes of people, let's say, are left out of the process, if they are discriminated against, that violates this principle. But it's not to say that everybody has to be actually given an equal probability. It's just they have to have an opportunity.

- 7.60** We could think, yes, think about all this as some "infinite game of chance"—to use the phrase from Borges—and I've got to have an equal chance with everybody else. On the other hand, we don't predetermine what the outcome of that process will be. What's your problem with Rawls? There have been all sorts of discussions about this, and I want to point out a few alternatives that's worth considering as you go through this process that he describes, but also then talk about his own objections to his earlier theory as they emerge in works like "Political Liberalism" and "The Law of Peoples."
- 7.61** First of all, there's that question of what we would choose and how to choose. Should we be really that risk averse and adopt the maximin principle? Say, I want the best worst-case scenario. There are alternative ways of answering that question. For example, if you're a utilitarian like Jeremy Bentham or John Stuart Mill, you're going to say, "I want to maximize my expected benefits here." So, I'm willing to tolerate risk. I want the best possible return. This is like the investor who says, "Yeah, I'm willing to invest in some risky stocks. I just want the best return over time. I'll risk certain amounts." Now, there are things I won't risk, like I might get killed if I lose that dice throw. Yeah, I don't like that. But on the other hand, as long as it seems like, given a certain base level, maybe, then I want just maximal returns.
- 7.62** There are still complicated questions like is it the average return or is it the total? The number of people in the society may actually make those differ from each other. So there are subtle questions, but nevertheless, I want the best overall expected return. That's different from saying, I want to minimize my losses.
- 7.63** Aristotle would say that it's not just a financial thing. "I want to maximize human flourishing." There are all sorts of dimensions of that: I want to develop people's characters. I don't just want to give them money. I want to make sure they turn into good and virtuous people. That's going to lead to a different criterion.
- 7.64** We could have—and in fact, in surveys where people are actually asked this question, this is the one that tends to win: I want a safety net. I want to make sure I don't fall below a certain level. So yeah, I don't want to be a slave. I don't want to be killed as an outcome here, but I'm willing to be quite poor for a chance of getting rich. So, as long as I don't fall below a certain level, I am willing to go along with this idea of maximizing my expected return. I just want to maximize total or average well-being as long as nobody falls below this. That's not saying I want the best possible worst-case scenario. I just want a good enough worst-case scenario. Then, beyond that, I just want to maximize my chances.
- 7.65** Well, you could see the utilitarian then and Rawls as opposite ends of an extreme about risk aversion or risk tolerance. The utilitarian says, "I'll tolerate lots and lots of risk." Rawls is saying, "I want to minimize risk." And then, that safety net conception being somewhere in between saying, "I'll tolerate a certain amount of risk, but no more than that." So, we have a choice there, and Rawls is taking one side of that, but lots of people might take another position.
- 7.66** Now, here's the one that really worries Rawls: can we reach agreement? In "A Theory of Justice," he says, sure. People in the original position behind the veil of ignorance would agree on a conception of justice. We would choose those two principles. But by the time he writes "Political Liberalism," almost 30 years later, he's saying that maybe we would,

maybe we wouldn't. He worries that a well-ordered society, something he had assumed in "A Theory of Justice," might be unrealistic.

7.67 Why? He said that the way we look at society and the world and the way we look at this choice of principles is going to depend on our comprehensive doctrine of the world, the general worldview that we happen to have. Here's the problem: people have different comprehensive worldviews. They have different perspectives and comprehensive doctrines. They conflict with each other. A society that's pluralist in this way isn't really well-ordered. It's unstable.

7.68 People may or may not find the overlap that Joan Didion assumed was there. She thought all of us as human beings care about survival. All of us care about certain things. And so there's this core where we all agree. But by 2000, Rawls is thinking, "I don't know if that's true anymore." Think of those comprehensive doctrines, those moral views that we talked about when discussing Didion. If it's a well-ordered society, they do overlap. There is "an overlapping consensus," to use Rawls's term. We don't share our comprehensive doctrines. There's lots of pluralism. We have different views. But nevertheless, there is some core, whether it's "wagon-train morality" or something else, where these things do overlap. We have a consensus about those things, and that's a well-ordered society. It's not a society where everybody agrees. It's not monolithic. It's still pluralist. On the other hand, there are certain rules where we say, "We go into this process, we can agree on principles of justice. We can agree on a form of government."

7.69 But what if we are in an unstable society where there's no overlap? By the year 2000, Rawls is thinking that maybe that's where we are. "I don't know if we can agree any longer on principles of justice." And by that point, he says, that maybe this isn't going to work. So he begins to worry, and this is, I think, the most serious objection to Rawls's earlier theory. It's really Rawls later who's saying, "I don't know about this." If we've got, as a permanent feature of our public culture, a diversity of reasonable, comprehensive, religious, philosophical, and moral doctrines, and they don't overlap in this way, if we don't have an overlapping consensus, we're in trouble. We're not going to agree on principles of justice.

7.70 He hopes that we can still be civil to each other. We can commit to respect other people's rationality and their comprehensive doctrines. But he says there's a serious problem here because I might say that I'm going to try to explain what I want in terms that would persuade you, even though there's no overlap between our conceptions. But now that forces me to discuss things in a way that leaves everything that is really an essential and distinctive part of my comprehensive doctrine out of my discussion, out of my attempt to persuade. In effect, this is a way of saying in the public square, "Don't bring in your religion, don't bring in your moral views, don't bring in this, don't bring in anything that anybody else would disagree with."

7.71 I might start thinking, first of all, is there anything left for me to say? But secondly, here he says, "The difficulty is I've got to discuss the most fundamental questions of society with my fellow citizens, and I'm not allowed to refer to what I consider the most important and most fundamental truth. So how do I do it?" He calls this the paradox of public reason.

7.72 He says that in a society like this, in one that goes beyond the well-ordered society where there's an overlapping consensus, to one where people simply don't agree about the most basic things, and can't agree to choose any principles, then somehow I've got to explain

things and persuade other people without relying on my own comprehensive doctrine. And yet my fundamental approach and the things I take as most basic depend on my comprehensive doctrine. So how can I do it? He says that this is a paradox, and he doesn't really propose a solution. He admits that we might be in serious trouble.

7.73 So, this is part of the reason that Rawls writes "The Law of Peoples," where he says, "Actually, I think here I was talking about individual people, and I was assuming they were in a well-ordered society where there was an overlapping consensus. But now I'm starting to realize maybe societies have an interest in maintaining that overlapping consensus and that peoples have a right to determine their own boundaries." And so Rawls starts turning, for example, anti-immigration and starts thinking, pluralism is very good up to a certain point.

7.74 But if you lose that overlapping consensus, you're in fundamental trouble. You're faced with a paradox of public reason. All of a sudden, at that stage, it becomes very hard to see how you can sort out political issues. Basically, at that point: political polarization, and polarization is misleading because it suggests, too, here, it's like this society is going to come apart in thousands of different directions.

7.75 Well, Rawls's ideas both gave expression to the vast expansion of government that took place after the Second World War and especially in the 1960s and 1970s. It also helped to motivate and provide a justification for much subsequent expansion of government. But on the other hand, it wasn't the only conception. I'm going to skip past what I had been planning to say about the 1970s and the political situation and the economic situation and so on. Lots of things were disruptive.

7.76 Instead, skip ahead to the view that gave a voice underlying the movement in the 1980s and subsequently toward a different conception of distributive justice and a different conception of society. So Rawls is laying out, broadly speaking, the philosophy of political liberalism. He's trying to say that by 1971, we had seen a vast expansion in government's role, but there was no theory justifying it. People did this stuff, but there was no explanation of why that was a just society. Rawls tries to provide that.

7.77 A colleague of his at Harvard, however, wrote a book that said that there's an alternative. "Anarchy, State, and Utopia," in 1974, won the National Book Award, providing a different account. Robert Nozick said, "First of all, I don't like talking about distributive justice, even though I'm writing a book about it." He says, "Here's what I don't like about it: it suggests that there is a central authority that distributes. For example, somebody says, 'How should the goods of society be distributed?' I think, 'Well, I don't know.' I'm imagining that I'm distributing, and you get that much, you get that much, and so on. But there is no central authority like that. There shouldn't be."

7.78 Similarly, responsibilities: there's no central distribution of responsibilities. Sometimes there is. We have a central decision about tax rates, for example, or we have a central decision about how the draft is going to operate and so on. But overall, many goods and responsibilities come attached to particular people, people who make the goods, people who undertake the responsibilities. So, I grow some tomatoes in my backyard—which I can't do since I live in the Hill Country in Texas—but anyway, if I could, I would do that, let's say, and then who gets the tomatoes? Well, I grew them. They're mine. I did that. Or I have a baby, and then I say, "Who's going to take care of this baby?" Well, it's your job to

take care of the baby. You had the baby. So a lot of things come attached to individual people.

7.79 Now, Nozick says that there are different approaches to this question of distributive justice, or as he prefers to say it, justice in holdings. He thinks that's a much more neutral term. It doesn't assume there's anybody doing the distributing. He says that some people have end-result theories of justice. That's a view that says the justice of a distribution can be judged structurally by, for example, inequality, independently of who in particular has what. The identity of people doesn't matter.

7.80 Rawls has a theory like that. He says, "As long as the least advantaged are being benefited, consistent with a just savings principle, it's just." That means we could really just look at the math, look at the curves, and judge justice without saying: how did this come about or who has what exactly? We look at that overall distribution.

7.81 The utilitarian is like this, too. They say, "Is this generating maximal happiness or wealth or whatever it is for the entire society?" That's all that matters. We take the integral and the area under the curve, and like, "Okay, we're good."

7.82 Rousseau also has one. Rousseau's theory of justice is: tolerate neither rich men nor beggars, but otherwise, judge according to the general will, which really means the common good. It's something like maximizing happiness or well-being, given that nobody's too far up above everybody else and nobody's too far below it. It's as if he has not only the safety net conception, but a maximal thing like, "Nobody should be richer than that." Why does he say that? Because that person can become rich enough to manipulate the process and make it unfair.

7.83 In any case, that's an end-result theory. There are lots of people who have this theory. They look at situations of extreme poverty, and they say, "That's terrible. That's somehow unjust." They start talking about poverty rates, for example, or they think about measures of inequality and start reporting on, "Oh, this could be measured in many different ways." For example, the ratio of the richest 20% to the poorest 20%, which varies a huge amount from country to country. Or they could look at what economists refer to as the Gini Index and rate countries as more or less equal in that way, either pre-tax or once various kinds of taxes and income supports are taken into account.

7.84 They could think about developments per person or per household. They could think about this at various ages, like how does this look if you're a certain age group or an older age group? It's actually really complicated to do this. We could think of it in terms of income mobility. If you're at the bottom, what are your chances of rising during your lifetime to being in a higher income bracket and so on.

7.85 Anyway, there are lots and lots of open questions here. It's not as if the end-result theory is one theory. It's a whole cluster of theories, and they're complicated, moral and economic questions about how to actually understand it.

7.86 The second theory is a patterned theory. The idea here is that the justice of a distribution of holdings is just if it matches some natural dimension or some combination of natural dimensions, it roughly fits the formula: "from each according to blank, to each according to blank." And there have been a variety of people who have this theory.

7.87 For example, Marx: "From each according to his abilities to each according to his needs." That's such a view. In order to determine the justice of a distribution for Marx, I can't just

look at the curves of who has what. I have to say that I need to know people's abilities, and I need to know what people need. If people aren't getting what they need, then that's a real problem. If, on the other hand, people have a great amount of ability that isn't being tapped, isn't being used, that's not good either. So, the Marxist says, "I need to know more. It's not just a question of knowing the shape of the distribution curve. I've got to know how that relates to abilities and needs."

7.88 Aristotle has a theory that is also of this general kind, though it's very different from Marx's. He says, "From each according to his relevant merit, to each according to his relevant merit." And so he has an example in the "Politics": somebody has given us a flute. Who should get this flute? Well, the best flute player. Who should play that Stradivarius? The best violinist. Who should have a higher income? The person who's contributing more. Think about the relevant merit of the various people and distribute the goods and the responsibilities according to their relevant merit.

7.89 Now, there's an important difference between Aristotle's view and Marx's view. In Aristotle's case, the blanks get filled in by the same thing. Why does that matter? Because you get rewarded for the same thing that is tied to your responsibilities: adopt more responsibility, you get more reward. Whereas in Marx, they're independent things. A lot of the objections to Marxism, like how do we motivate people and so on, really come out of that difference. It's going to emerge anytime you fill in different things there, no matter what those things are. Whereas Aristotle is going to say to fill in the blanks in the same way. That way, you keep motivation going, you keep the thing tied together in a way that doesn't generate those problems.

7.90 If we think about a particular good, like a classic car or whatever, we can ask, if you're a utilitarian, "Does it promote the common good that you have it?" Rawls will say, "Does it make the least advantaged worst off?" That would be a bad thing. Marx will say, "Do you need it?" Aristotle will say, "Do you deserve it?" But when you frame it that way, you realize that's odd what applied to a lot of particular holdings.

7.91 Now, sometimes it's very clear that we want one of these theories rather than another. How should a professor distribute grades? Almost everybody is going to say: according to relevant merit, performing in the class, for example. It would be odd to say—although students do sometimes have this—help the least advantaged: "But I want to be a doctor. I want to go to medical school. I really need this. I know I didn't show up through the whole term, but I was really busy and stuff, but I need an A." Okay, well, that's an appeal to needs, maybe to helping the least advantaged, but it is not very persuasive ordinarily.

7.92 How about a vegetable garden? I don't ask—well, I might ask, "Who needs these tomatoes?" But I might also just think, "Great, I grew them." And so it seems odd—I don't know what it would be to deserve the tomato, for example.

7.93 And then, let me talk about my most valuable possession. Normally, in class, I would have it, but I was afraid to bring it on an airplane. Too many things could go wrong. But anyway, a 1979 World Series baseball. What should we be asking? According to these various theories, I should be asking, "Does my having that baseball promote the common good?" I have no idea. "Does it make the least advantaged worst off?" I don't know how to answer that question either. "Do I need it?" Well, nobody really needs a 1979 World Series baseball. "Do I deserve it?" Oh, no. I have to tell you something. Do I have sufficient

baseball merit? There's the guy who hit this, Dave Parker, and he had a lot of baseball merit, winning the Most Valuable Player Award and things like that.

7.94 But here is what Nozick would say, "The real question isn't a question of merit. The question is: how did you get it? Here's how I got it. Game 5, 1979 World Series, first inning. Dave Parker is at bat, he swings, and the ball is popped up in my general direction. Everybody in my section stands up and is looking up at the ball. I look up; I can't see the ball. Here is actually the screenshot. Doug DeCinces, the third baseman, is running straight at me, I realize. I'm looking up there; I don't see the ball. So what do I do? There's a fellow there you can see standing up with a green jacket. That's my brother.

7.95 But you might also see someone next to him going— That's me. Talk about baseball merit. There's a ball hit toward me, and I go like this [hunches down and covers his head with his arms]. Well, the ball falls, and you can see my brother going like this [leans away to avoid the ball]. And what happened? The ball hits the shoulder of someone else and goes right into the pocket of my jacket.

7.96 It's October, Pittsburgh; it's cold, and I'm wearing my dad's old 1951-issue Korean War jacket. It's got big floppy pockets. So the ball falls right into the pocket of my jacket. So, I put my hand in and cover it. Then immediately, five other hands go into that pocket trying to grab it from me, but I hold on. So, baseball merit? I suppose a little merit in holding all of the ball, but overall, no. A fly ball hit to me, and I go [hunches down and covers his head with his arms]. So, definitely not a question of sufficient baseball merit.

7.97 Nevertheless, here's what this teaches us: Nozick says that the justice of a distribution depends on how it came about. The obvious question is: how did you get the baseball? If I say, "There was this sporting goods shop, they had it on display, and I stole it," then it's not just that I have it. If it's something where I was at game 5 and it ended up in my pocket, not through theft or anything, but just—

7.98 It would have been an interesting question if somebody else had grabbed it out of my pocket, even though I was trying to hang on. Would that have been just? I don't know. I don't care since I held on. But in any case, I asked how it came about. Similarly with that classic car, the question isn't, "What does it mean for the least advantaged that you're driving this old Corvette?" The question is, "How did you get it? Where did you get it? How did this come about?" And so he says that we need a historical theory of justice. The justice of a distribution depends on how it came about. That means we need to talk about three subsidiary principles.

7.99 The first principle is acquisition. We obtain some things justly because we get them from nature. We have to spell out how we justly acquire something from nature. A second is a principle of transfer. How do we transfer holdings justly? Because after all, you don't get baseballs from nature. You don't get lots of things from nature. So, how do you go about buying and selling and entering into contracts and so on justly? And then finally, we need a principle of rectification. How do we correct an earlier injustice? If the world were perfect, we could just have the first two principles, but it's not perfect. Sometimes things go wrong, injustices occur. How do we fix them?

7.100 First of all, the principle of acquisition: somebody acquiring a holding in accordance with the principle of justice and acquisition is entitled to it. What is the principle? Nozick doesn't tell us, and you might be disappointed, but his answer is that this is a really complicated

question. You can acquire things from nature in all sorts of ways. You can, for example, pick blueberries that happen to be growing wild. Or you can engage in farming. You can do all sorts of things. You can do drilling for oil and gas. You can mine various kinds of natural resources.

7.101 This is the whole theory of, for example, oil and gas exploration, of holdings in land, of agriculture, of all sorts of things. All of that is something that is going to take place under the principle of acquisition. This isn't something a philosopher can lay out in a paper and defend. There is a huge body of law, really a complicated set of huge bodies of law that involve that principle of justice. It's a complicated question.

7.102 The same thing is true of the principle of transfer. If you acquire something in accordance with the principle of justice in transfer from someone who holds it justly, then you're entitled to it. That's an important principle. But again, you say, "What is this principle of justice in transfer?" That is the entire question of the law of contracts, the law of buying and selling, so commercial transactions, and so on—a huge body of law.

7.103 The same thing is going to be true of the principle of rectification. If you acquire something in accord with the principle of justice and rectification, you're entitled to it. But what's the principle? Now we're talking about the entire law of torts. Some injustice has occurred to you, or you've been victimized, and so you sue someone, for example. There's a huge body of law there. So again, not the thing a philosopher can spell out in a chapter of a book. It's the thing that we have law volume after law volume and a whole series of case law to try to characterize what that principle of justice really is.

7.104 He says, finally, that there's a principle that just says no one's entitled to a holding except by one through three. In other words, that's the only way to get something justly. You acquire it from nature justly, or it's transferred to you justly, or you're given it as compensation for an earlier injury or injustice, and that's it.

7.105 Here's an equivalent way of putting it: you hold something justly if and only if there's a chain of holdings back to an original acquisition from nature or a set of acquisitions from nature with no uncorrected injustices. So I can say, "Here's why I hold this justly. I got it from that person, and they got it from that person, they got it from that person," and so on. And we can trace this back. If any injustice has occurred, we fix it.

7.106 Or he later says, what if there are injustices so extensive in the past that there are no chains back, at least they go back very far, where we have no uncorrected injustices? He says that there's a statute of limitations here. The further back you go, the less certain you can be about this. You can't really know whether it's been compensated for or not. So beyond a certain point, it just goes to zero.

7.107 But in any case, think about the baseball. How did I get it? I got it on Sunday, October 14th, 1979. Who had it before? I guess Mike Flanagan, the Baltimore pitcher. He got it from the catcher. He got it from the umpire. He got it from Major League Baseball. He got it from Rawlings. They got it from a factory in Costa Rica that put it together from materials like cork, rubber, wool, cotton, polyester, latex, leather, and ultimately, all those things came from nature.

7.108 So was there any injustice here? No. In each case, the transfer was perfectly legitimate. Major League Baseball bought it from that factory, from Rawlings, and those people got it

from various farmers and others who were collecting the raw ingredients. The umpire got it justly, so did the catcher, so did the pitcher, and so did I.

7.109 It hasn't, by the way, always been the case that if a ball was hit into the stands, you were entitled to keep it. That's something that changed in 1920 when a ball player got hit by a really dirty ball right in the head. Carl Mays, the New York pitcher, threw a fastball and hit the Cleveland shortstop in the head, and he died. At that point, they said, "You know what? We can't keep playing with the same ball for the entire game." They started saying that if it's hit into the stands, you can keep it. That puts fresh balls in place so the players can actually see them.

7.110 The idea is this: a distribution is just if everyone's holdings under it are just. That's all we need to say. How did these things come about? There's no one answer, "Oh, this distribution came about in this way." It's a complicated thing. How did you get that? How did you get this? And so on. It's just if it results from another just distribution by legitimate means.

7.111 So, he ends up saying, If you want a principle, here's the principle. It looks like a patterned principle, but it's not because there's no pattern to this: "From each as they choose, to each as they are chosen." But since there's no real pattern to people's choices, this, although it has that form, is not really a patterned theory of justice at all. Sometimes you receive things because you bought them. Sometimes you got them from nature. Sometimes you received them as compensation. Sometimes people gave it to you as a gift. All of those are legitimate ways of getting things. So it depends on the choices you made and the choices other people made.

7.112 Now, he says, "Here's my argument why this is the only theory that actually protects human liberty. Pick a distribution that's just according to some other principle, an end-result theory, a patterned theory, whatever." Now, he says, "People are going to make free choices that will mess it up. Even if all needs are met, people can transform that distribution into another one by engaging in free economic activity."

7.113 He talks about Wilt Chamberlain, a great basketball player who, let's say, is so great that people want to spend money to come to see him. They do that. They are a little worse off from the point of view of economics because they've spent some of their money. He becomes rich. But Nozick says that's the result of their free choice. But notice it can mess up your distribution, "Oh, the least advantaged are now a little worse off economically because they keep spending their money to go to basketball games," and so on.

7.114 He says, "Is that resulting distribution just?" If your answer is yes, you've got a historical theory because it results from people's free choices. If you say no, your theory has to limit freedom in order to maintain distributive justice. So he says, historical theory is the only one that can protect freedom. Every other theory has to restrict people's freedom because it has to say, "No, you can't spend your money on that. That is going to disrupt our distribution." End result and patterned theories involve constant interference in people's lives.

7.115 In the end, he says, "Socialist societies would have to forbid capitalist acts between consenting adults." But it's not even just socialist societies. It is any society that rests its conception of distributive justice on an end result principle or on a patterned theory.

- 7.116** Even if it's Aristotle's idea of a patterned theory, if people can trade this good— notice, grades fit Aristotle's theory very well, but people can't buy and sell them, or at least they're not supposed to be able to. They cannot trade them and so on. You can't just give them as gifts. It's not like one student says, "I've got a 4.0 here. I'll toss you an A." It's not like that. Aristotle's theory can work well there. There isn't really liberty to trade.
- 7.117** But in other contexts where there is, that theory is going to fall apart. We look at economic freedom across the world. There are very different degrees of economic freedom. Nozick is going to say that corresponds to principles of justice in that society. The more a society is wedded to an end result or patterned theory, the less freedom it's going to allow and the worse off people in that country are going to be. More economic freedom means higher income. It means more prosperity. There's a utilitarian argument we could give for this, but his real stress is on freedom per se. Any theory that deviates from his historical account is going to limit human freedom. In the end, it's a question of, "From each as they choose to each as they are chosen."
- 7.118** Finally, he says, liberty disrupts patterns. It disrupts patterns of matching something. It disrupts patterns that an end-result theorist would have. So, the only way to protect freedom is to adopt a historical theory. The end.
- 7.119** Looking back at Rawls, it seems to me that it's a question of mathematics, that as the group grows, as it scales up, the averages are going to get lower, the odds are going to decrease. As that grows, you're going to remove that central: the philosophy, the morals, the religion. That's where you get that spread in, I guess, the "wagon-train" theory.
- 7.120** I'm curious what you think about, from his point of view, as a response to his later work in 2000, what would happen if, for example, in the United States, right now, our representatives, we're still at the same number of representatives historically. They represent such a huge amount of people. What if that grew, so you kept those groups smaller so that instead of 500 people in Congress, maybe we have 5,000 people in Congress? Would that possibly be a way to reconcile, I guess, his doubts that maybe this isn't even possible?
- 7.121** All right. Yeah, that's a great question. It's not just the size of the population that matters, but the diversity of the population and whether or not there's sufficient overlap. But I agree with you that the smaller the group, the more likely an overlap is.
- 7.122** I mean, a lot of theories of justice work well on a small scale. For example, within a family, you can be a Marxist: "from each according to his ability, to each according to his needs." But the dad doesn't say to the two-year-old, "You're not bringing in much income here." So it works in that very small scale. Blow it up, and it stops working. In fact, probably once you get beyond, say, 150, that starts breaking down. People can't identify in that really intimate way with a group that's very large.
- 7.123** The same thing happens, I think, in other contexts. I've sometimes thought about what you're suggesting. If we kept the same ratio of people to representatives, we would have a vast Congress. It couldn't really meet—I mean, it would have to be a virtual thing, presumably. But on the other hand, you might think that would actually enable each representative to really do a much better job of representing their community. I think there's lots of evidence for that. The larger a city becomes, for example, it seems to me the worse governed it tends to be. There are exceptions, but overall, that seems right.

- 7.124** I see this demonstrated graphically where I live all the time. I live in Austin, which has become a very large city. On the other hand, my daughters live in much smaller communities in Pflugerville and in Round Rock. There, it seems to me, government works much, much better, and partly because they're smaller. If you're governing a community of 100,000 people, more or less, that's really different from governing a group of about a million people. Here, there's not much overlapping consensus, and things get—
- 7.125** We even advertise the slogan. We get weird. Pflugerville advertises itself as "between a rock"—Round Rock—"and a weird place." It's much better. But people there—it's small enough that people know the people on the city council. I mean, my daughter knows people on the city council. That is not something that is normal in Austin. It's far too big. And it goes the other way: there, people on the city council actually know lots of residents and interact with them all the time and talk to them. That's not nearly so true in a very large city.
- 7.126** So, I think you're right that for Rawls, a lot depends on the possibility of that overlapping consensus. The larger something is, the less likely it is to have an overlapping consensus. Also, you want the people in positions of power to reflect that overlapping consensus. The larger it is, the more likely it is they're going to be representing their little corner over here, and that's less likely that they're going to actually represent that overlapping consensus or even know what it is.
- 7.127** I think it's a great observation. It's statistical. You can have very large things that manage to work because there's lots of overlap and people identify it. But you can also have—and you can also have small groups that are insane. Look at any faculty council in a university. But still, I think you're right that there is a definite correlation here. It gets way harder as the group grows, not only in size, but in diversity.
- 7.128** When it gets too large, Rawls starts realizing it becomes utterly impossible. His fear by the year 2000 is that we're there. He didn't even think about that in 1971. He assumed that we're human; of course, we'll get together and agree. But later, he thought, that was really optimistic.

8. No Other End of the World

- 8.1** No Other End of the World—I've taken my title here from a poem by Czesław Miłosz: "Only a white-haired old man who would be a prophet, yet is not a prophet for he's much too busy, repeats while he binds his tomatoes: 'No other end of the world will there be. No other end of the world will there be.'"
- 8.2** We're getting close to the end of the ideas of the 20th century, and there is this attitude near the end of the 20th century that we're close to the end of history. In fact, as we'll see, there's a book talking about the end of history and the last man. I want to think about things from that point of view. It did seem as if, indeed, a huge historical change was taking place. So, I want to talk about the movements that led to that, some of the key ideas of it, and also try to figure out maybe what that tells us about where we are now.

- 8.3** Let me start with the thought of Aleander Solzhenitsyn and the various ways in which he himself experienced the Soviet Union and helped to contribute to its eventual collapse. Let's start with a series of earlier developments after the war that indicated serious problems within communist societies. There was a rebellion in East Germany in June of 1953, put down by Soviet tanks. Something similar happened in Hungary in October of 1956, then in Czechoslovakia during the spring and the summer of 1968. In all of these cases, there were pro-democracy movements that challenged the Soviet puppet government and were brutally put down by Soviet forces.
- 8.4** Then, in 1980, the rise of Solidarity in Poland: a bunch of shipyard workers in Gdańsk began to rebel against the government, and it finally led to a very significant change, though it took many years. But it wasn't just those individual movements that suggested increasingly that there were very serious problems behind the Iron Curtain.
- 8.5** A group of French intellectuals in the 1970s who called themselves the New Philosophers began to challenge socialism and Marxism in ways that were really new. I'm talking about people like André Glucksmann, Bernard-Henri Lévy, Alain Finkielkraut. They broke with postmodernism, and they broke with Marxism altogether.
- 8.6** Now, Marxism, after the Second World War, had become increasingly popular in French and really European intellectual circles in general. In fact, Camus was something of an outlier who never went along with this. But Jean-Paul Sartre and other existentialists tried to combine Marxism and existentialism, a marriage that makes no sense at all. But nevertheless, the New Philosophers came along and said, "Wait a minute, there's something fundamentally wrong."
- 8.7** These uprisings behind the Iron Curtain tell us something really important: the will to power is at the core of Marxism. In other words, this idea we've encountered in Mussolini and in a variety of other figures of combining Marx and Nietzsche, combining the idea of the class struggle with the will to power, it's a natural mix. It's not some odd combination of views. It is a very natural combination of views. Marxism, they said, leads to the Gulag, as inevitably as Nazism leads to Auschwitz. So they began to argue that there is something deep and fundamentally wrong with Marxism and with principles of government that rest on similar foundations.
- 8.8** Why? Marxism, they said, is essentially a two-level theory of society. They're going to be those who understand the underlying class struggle, and then there are going to be those that don't. So some people will understand the basis of things. Think about that two-level idea: there's a scientific level and a manifest level.
- 8.9** Some people understand this basic level. They understand the connections, and they see themselves through that unconstrained vision—to use Thomas Sowell's terms—to say, "I am now in a position to manipulate things, to bring about the changes I want to bring about in the manifest level." So they say, "I see how to do all of this, and I should naturally be in a position of power to be able to implement it." Other people don't get it. They don't see it. They are simply the masses that are being led by those of us who are enlightened enough to know the social structure and understand this base level.
- 8.10** So essential to that entire way of seeing society as resting on this two-level conception is that it seeks to remove decision-making from the ordinary people and place it in the hands of those who know. It's sometimes been described as a form of neo-gnosticism for that

reason. It's not so much that the knowledge gives you spiritual enlightenment as the traditional gnostic thought. No, it gives you this ability to actually transform society and turn it into a utopia. So naturally, you should be the ones who are suited to rule. In that way, this two-level conception, where there's a base level determining what goes on at the manifest level, leads to a two-level conception of society. There are those who understand that picture and those who don't.

8.11 Now, the postmodernists, of course, had said that there's something fundamentally wrong with that whole meta-narrative, that whole grand narrative idea that underlies this. And so in a way, the New Philosophers were breaking with postmodernism and breaking with Marxism. But on the other hand, from another point of view, they were saying, "That's right." In other words, take seriously what you've said. All too often, the postmodernists said, "Yes, down with grand narratives, down with this account," but then embraced it utterly in all their explanations and indeed had a grand narrative of their own; they just wouldn't admit it.

8.12 The New Philosophers are saying, "Be consistent, get rid of all that." But the moment you get rid of that grand narrative picture, that picture where we have a base level controlling the manifest level and knowledge of it entitles you to rule, then you realize you are no longer in a position to actually give the critiques you were giving.

8.13 So, they say there is a natural sense in which Marxism expresses this unconstrained vision. There is a group, let's call them—using Sowell's terms—the anointed, really self-anointed, saying, "We get it. We understand the scientific image. We understand the connections to the manifest image, and we understand it and how to transform it into something much better. The people don't get it, so we have to leave out the people, and we have to take power, we have to implement our vision, our understanding.

8.14 That is something the New Philosophers argued is simply inherent in Marxism. There is an account there, according to which everything that appears on the surface is really driven by something else. It is driven by economic relations, the class struggle. There are particular ways of describing it. Once you get syndicalism as part of the mix, you can say that now it's really ideas that are shaping this narrative, stories, blah, blah, blah. But whatever you say, it doesn't matter in a certain sense what the details are. You're going to be saying, "And I understand it, and that means that I get to say what goes on." The moment you do that, you realize I'm taking power from the people and putting it in this small group, and that is essential.

8.15 Of course, that's in effect this Nietzschean idea: yes, we all have a will to power, and I should seize power so that I can actually bring about this authentic and ideal society. That's the problem. So the New Philosophers say there is something inherent in this that implies that ordinary people don't understand who they are. They don't know what's good for them. They don't even know what they want. So, in some sense, their consciousness has to be raised because they aren't conscious of even who they are and what would truly fulfill them.

8.16 Consequently, they're like children. Their freedom has no value. They are foolish children. In fact, they keep making stupid decisions, for example, voting for capitalist candidates and participating in a capitalist economy and supporting it and thinking their lives would be better if only they worked fewer hours or got more pay. So, we have to substitute our

judgment for them. They're the unenlightened, but we are the enlightened. That transfer is at the heart of Marxism, said the New Philosophers. So avoid it. Get rid of that.

8.17 Conception—you get rid of that form of human oppression. They emphasize the importance of speaking honestly and plainly in common-sense terms. In fact, Henri Lévy says we've got to call things what they are. Our first obligation is to change the word. Marx had said that the philosophers have only interpreted the world; the point is to change it. So changing the world, Henri Lévy says, yes, but there is a falsification brought about by that whole way of looking at things. First, change the word. If you want to change the world, first change the word. And what he means is not to change it into something that promotes your narrative. That's what the Marxists had been doing, he thinks. Instead, you've got to put things back to what they truly mean, restore things to their common-sense meanings, and express things in common-sense, intelligible terms.

8.18 Now, the anointed are going to demand obedience from the people, but they're going to demand things that make no sense at all in terms of the manifest image. They're going to say, "You've got to do this." But the people will say, "Wait, look, I care about material comfort. I want more food," things like that. They're going to say, "No, that's not what would truly fulfill you. This would truly fulfill you. This was what would liberate you." That violates common sense. People are going to say, "Well, no, I'd rather have a bit more to eat."

8.19 So, in the end, the anointed have to change the way the people are thinking, change the way they speak. And so this idea of Newspeak, of doublethink, of trying to get rid of certain bits of language as "double plus ungood"—to use Orwell's phrase—don't let them do that. Don't let them change the language. Insist on speaking in plain terms.

8.20 Well, this idea that there's something about Marxism and related views that have the anointed trying to implement their own vision of society, regardless of what the people want, seems fundamental. It suggests that certain forms of social and political organization have to lie. They have to change the language because what they're arguing for doesn't make sense in common-sense terms. That key idea of falsification is something that I think underlies the work of Solzhenitsyn and others who were dissidents against the Soviet Union and related puppet governments in Eastern Europe.

8.21 Let's talk about Solzhenitsyn. He graduated from Rostov University in 1941, a few days before the German attack, rather unfortunate coincidence. He joined the army and spent three years in combat in World War II. In 1945, he was arrested for referring to Stalin in a letter to a friend as "the man with the mustache." To call Stalin "the man with a mustache" does not seem to me a terrible insult. Nevertheless, that was enough to get him sentenced to the Gulag. He spent eight years in prison camps. He battled cancer during that time and wrote a book about it called the "Cancer Ward." Then, after that, he became a small-town high school science teacher.

8.22 He began writing and, in 1962, published a book, "One Day in the Life of Ivan Denisovich." It was actually published in the Soviet Union about life in the prison camps, which was somewhat shocking. But in the early '50s, Stalin died, and his right-hand man, Khrushchev, took over for him and gave a speech before the assembly, a very large group, not only of the Central Committee, but top party officials, when he took power. In that speech, he laid out many of the things that were crimes committed by Stalin and

ended up telling the crowd, "There is a Stalinist in each of you. There's even a Stalinist in me. We must root out this evil." So he began liberalizing things within the Soviet Union, allowing the publication of works like Solzhenitsyn's in a way that would have been impossible before under Stalin.

8.23 Now, I have to tell you a story about that particular assembly. He was describing these crimes of Stalin, things that happened during the Great Purge and other aspects of the history, and was quite open about it. And then, someone from the back shouted out, "And while all this was going on, what did you do?" He was, after all, Stalin's right-hand man. There was a silence in the auditorium, and Khrushchev simply looked out at the crowd, and everybody thought—Khrushchev said, "Who said that?" Of course, no one stood up. No one raised their hand. Who said that? No one would admit it. Then Khrushchev said, "That's what I did, too," and proceeded to go on with the speech. Everyone was too afraid to speak out, even Stalin's right-hand man.

8.24 Eventually, Khrushchev was thrown out of power. Leonid Brezhnev replaced him and suppressed the works of Solzhenitsyn. So it was a short window where Solzhenitsyn could actually articulate his views publicly. In 1970, he won the Nobel Prize for literature, and he announced in the speech, "It is within the power of artists and writers to do much more: to defeat the lie!" He described the prison camps in his book, "The Gulag Archipelago." Sixty million people at certain points passed through those camps, and it's not clear how many died. There might have been a few million, perhaps as many as 20 million. It's unclear. Eventually, we found out through the release of records that it was many more than people initially thought.

8.25 Let's talk about that book, "The Gulag Archipelago." It wasn't published in the USSR till 1989 with the fall of the Iron Curtain. But it was actually published and available in the West as of 1973. David Remnick has said this: "In terms of the effect he's had on history, Solzhenitsyn is the dominant writer of the 20th century. Who else compares?" It is a dramatic book about his own experience in the prison camps where he spent eight years, after all, and saw a lot. The account is poignant in a number of different ways. At one point, he says, "In the midst of exhausting prison camp relocations, marching in a column of prisoners in the gloom of bitterly cold evenings with strings of camp lights glimmering through the darkness, we would often feel rising in our breasts what we would have wanted to shout out to the whole world—if only the whole world could have heard us." That, of course, is what he's trying to do in the book: express what they all would have wanted to shout out.

8.26 Now, part of it begins when you're placed under arrest. Remember, this is now Stalin's Russia, where anyone could be arrested for anything. Everyone was vulnerable. "The universe has many centers,"—he says—"but you feel like your universe is shattered when they hiss at you: 'You're under arrest.'" Suddenly, everything is different. People were guilty of nothing and unprepared to put up any resistance whatsoever. There was a general feeling of being destined for destruction, a sense of having nowhere to escape. A submissive sheep is a find for a wolf.

8.27 "That universal innocence led to a universal failure to act. Maybe they won't take you? Maybe it'll all blow over? Maybe they'll realize it's a mistake. The majority sit quietly and dare to hope. Since you aren't guilty, how can they arrest you? It's a mistake. They're

already dragging you along by the collar. You still keep on exclaiming to yourself. It's a mistake. They'll set things straight and let me out."

8.28 "But how we burned in the camps later thinking: what would things have been like if every security operative, when he went out at night to make an arrest, had been uncertain whether he'd return alive and had to say goodbye to his family, or if during periods of mass arrests, as for example in Leningrad, when they arrested a quarter of the entire city, people hadn't just sat there in their lairs, paling with terror at every bang of the downstairs door and every step on the staircase. What if they understood they had nothing left to lose?

8.29 Why didn't they set up in the downstairs hall an ambush of a half dozen people with axes, hammers, pokers, whatever else was at hand? You knew those people were out for no good purpose. You could be sure ahead of time, you'd be cracking the head of a cutthroat." So why didn't we do it? Maybe the whole machine would have ground to a halt. Why didn't we fight back? Why didn't we do anything? We just let them take us. But that is, in a sense, why he says that the universal innocence was part of the problem. You kept thinking, "It won't be me."

8.30 On the other hand, he says, here were the kinds of crimes that were considered real crimes in the Soviet Union: anti-Soviet agitation, counter-revolutionary activity, counter-revolutionary Trotskyite activity—which is much worse—suspicion of espionage, contacts leading to suspicion of espionage, counter-revolutionary thought, dissemination of anti-Soviet sentiments, socially dangerous element, socially harmful element, criminal activity—in other words, just generically, what do you do? "Something criminal." Like what? "I don't know. Criminal activity."

8.31 A member of a family of a person convicted of any of these—in other words, your brother might know somebody who knew somebody who was suspected of espionage, so you could be arrested as someone who was associated with somebody who was associated with someone who was associated. In short, all of these are so vague. Everyone was, in a sense, vulnerable. Everyone could say, "But I haven't done anything." On the other hand, did you have a counter-revolutionary thought? "Well, I did really enjoy that Borscht." Is that a counter-revolutionary thought? I don't know. In short, his point was that these were all crimes in the Soviet Union. They could get you sent to prison camps for years. And yet, how do you know whether you've committed any of these? Have you committed any counter-revolutionary activities or any counter-revolutionary thoughts? Are you a socially dangerous element? How would you possibly know?

8.32 What was sad, he said, is that the universal innocence made people think, "I'm not guilty of anything. They won't arrest me." But also made them suspect that the people who were arrested had actually done something. So Solzhenitsyn said, "How easily we let ourselves be taken in by the partisan labels. How easily we agreed to regard these devoted men as traitors." After all, they were accused of anti-Soviet activity. And so others thought, "We haven't been arrested, and we're innocent, so you must not be innocent." And they didn't realize that everybody is subject to this. None of those people did anything either.

8.33 He says, "What depths of enforced ignorance were achieved by the monstrous lies of the state? Even the most broad-minded of us can embrace only that part of the truth into which our own snout had blundered." In short, the lies were so pervasive, so strong, not

only about, in general, the circumstances, but about that person's guilt or that person's guilt that people believed it. They couldn't believe that things were quite as bad as they were. They would only believe it when they themselves encountered it.

8.34 I myself have noticed in certain contexts, people do not believe things that you tell them until finally they see it themselves. You might say, "But wait, no, these people are innocent. These people are making allegations that are completely false," and not until they see it happen themselves and realize, "But I was there. That did not happen," only then do they begin to realize the extent of the lies. That's something that Solzhenitsyn said that pervaded the entire society. People were so taken in because the lies were everywhere, so much so that you didn't recognize them as lies until finally they hit you in the nose. Then you would say, "Oh, wait a minute." But even then, You would only think "this part" went wrong. You wouldn't understand it's all like that.

8.35 Solzhenitsyn reflects and says, "If...If...—" Why didn't we rebel? He said, "We didn't love freedom enough. We had no awareness of the real situation; we spent ourselves in one unrestrained outburst in 1917, and then we hurried to submit. We submitted with pleasure! We purely and simply deserved everything that happened afterwards." That's a harsh way of putting it. But he's saying, in effect, that people did this, and then they submitted to it. They went along with it. Why? When people were starving, when agriculture and industry were destroyed in the immediate aftermath, why didn't people say, "Okay, that was a mistake. That didn't work. Let's do something else."

8.36 But they didn't. They submitted. He says, in that sense, we deserved what happened later. We had opportunities to rebel, and we didn't do it. He says, moreover, we look at the past now, and a lot of people want to say—keep in mind, he's writing this in 1973 at a time when there had been some liberalization. It had then been wiped out. But still, he's able to smuggle this manuscript to the West. And he's saying that the difficulty is that a lot of people now want to say, "What happened under Stalin, yeah, that was bad. But let's move on. Let's get past that. Don't stir up the past. Yeah, there are a lot of people around now who participated in that and were part of the problem, but what good does it do to raise those old issues? It's not happening so much now, so let's forget about it."

8.37 And he says that that's a very dangerous thing. Don't sweep this under the rug. "We have to condemn publicly the very idea that some people have a right to repress others. In keeping silent about evil, in burying it so deep within us that no sign of it appears on the surface, we're implanting it. It'll rise up a thousandfold in the future. When we neither punish nor reproach evildoers, we are not simply protecting the trivial old age; we're thereby ripping the foundations of justice from beneath new generations."

8.38 So he's saying to look at what happened in Germany, for example, after the Second World War. There was a process of denazification. Lots of people were tried and stillprison camp guards are being tracked down, and a few, even elderly people by now, are nevertheless being found in various places and prosecuted. He's saying that nothing like that is happening in the Soviet Union. Nothing like that seems to be about to happen. He says that this is really dangerous. Instead of facing our history, honestly, and thinking, okay, horrible things happen, we've got to punish people to make sure nothing like this ever happens again. Instead, we're sweeping it under the rug, saying, that those Stalinists, yeah, they did all this stuff, but now they're in their '80s and '90s. Let's pass by.

- 8.39** He still is living with, "Hey, I spent eight years in a prison camp for referring to Stalin as 'the man with the mustache.' So don't tell me we have to sweep it under the rug." He says, "It's going to be uncomfortable, horrible to live in a country—" a country that does not face its past and actually denounce, at the very least, or prosecute wrongdoers.
- 8.40** At Harvard in 1978, he came and gave a graduation speech, and he shocked the audience because instead of just elaborating some of these themes against the Soviet Union, he started talking about Western civilization and got a little close to home for some of the people at Harvard. He said, "I've said this about the Stalinists, but now what about the U.S. anti-war movement? They betrayed Far Eastern nations. The result was a genocide, suffering imposed on 30 million people. Do those convinced pacifists hear the moans coming from there? Do they understand their responsibility today or do they prefer not to hear?"
- 8.41** So he says, "You all, too, have people who really supported totalitarian regimes in the past, gave them comfort, helped to oppress large numbers of people now." Are those people being held responsible? Are they even being criticized for this? He says, "You, too, are taking people who backed—not just, 'Hey, I backed the wrong side, so now I'm in big trouble,' but instead, you knowingly supported totalitarian regimes that were involved in oppression, and you knew would oppress people, and you never let us support it." Is that okay? Shouldn't we hold you responsible, at least to the extent of saying you made a horrible misjudgment at best, and at worst, you backed evil, an evil that has cost a lot of people their lives.
- 8.42** In any event, he says, "How has all of this happened?" The 20th century has been a century of astounding destruction. A hundred million people dying in world wars. A hundred million people killed at the hands of their own government. What made that possible? He says that, in the end, it is ideology. "That's what gives evil doing its long-sought justification. It gives the evildoer the necessary steadfastness and determination. That's the social theory that helps to make his acts seem good instead of bad in his own and in others' eyes, so he won't hear reproaches and curses, but will receive praise and honors."
- 8.43** Think about this: an individual criminal could do a lot of damage. A serial killer can kill a lot of people. Nevertheless, we're not talking about millions and millions of people. We're talking about, at worst, maybe a few dozen and so on. But ideology, that's what enables people to kill people on a large scale. The ideologist can go along with killing tens of millions of people. That's not an individual criminal act. That's something that has a different source. Namely, they have an ideology that tells them that's what they're supposed to do. That's what they ought to do.
- 8.44** So he says, "Thanks to ideology, the 20th century was fated to experience evil doing on a scale calculated in the millions. It can't be denied or passed over or suppressed. Who destroyed these millions? Without evil doers, there would have been no Archipelago." And without ideology, there wouldn't have been those evil doers. So evil doing has a threshold magnitude. Each of us has good as well as evil in our own hearts, and we bounce back and forth between good and evil impulses. We slip, we fall back, and so on, and we repent. We try to do a better job, but there is something inside every human heart that is a problem.

- 8.45** But he says, eventually, people can cross a threshold. Eventually, the evil doing reaches a stage where repentance and reform seems impossible. The good is just overwhelmed by the evil. At that point, the person has left humanity behind, and maybe the possibility of return is gone. Yes, we can have these, as it were, good and bad forces within us. We can have the angel and the devil speaking in our ears. But eventually, you listen to the devil long enough and the angel goes away. The angel gives up. That's what enables people not to just do this or that wrong act, but to actually engage in an entire pattern of wrong acts that ends up killing large numbers of people.
- 8.46** Now, in his Harvard address, he begins to talk about Western civilization and moral character, and he looks around himself and he says, "When I look at you all, I've been so far blaming the Soviet Union. Easy for Americans to say, 'We love Solzhenitsyn. He says, Those bad guys are really bad, maybe even worse than we thought. Yay.'" But then he turns things to Western civilization, and he says, "A decline in courage may be the most striking feature that you observe in the West today. That is noticeable among the ruling groups, especially, and the intellectual elite." This is the beginning of the end of a civilization. It's just a loss of courage in the entire society, but because it's a loss of courage of its leadership.
- 8.47** He says, in the end, then people are timid, and we have a choice to make: we can either remain a servant of falsehood or we can "shrug off lies and become an honest person." He sees too many people lacking the courage to tell the truth. They consciously choose to remain a servant of falsehood. He says that's a serious problem. Why do people lack courage? Why are people such cowards?
- 8.48** I think it's important that he was giving this talk at a university because after all, many of the people out there who are not just the graduates, but the faculty, they have tenure. What do they have to lose? There's a sense in which a tenured professor has greater security than anybody else in society. And yet you would expect the faculty with tenure to be actually free to speak out. That's the whole idea of the concept: "Hey, we want you to be free to tell us the truth." Instead, those are some of the most cowardly people who go along most willingly with the lies.
- 8.49** So he says, "How does this come about?" Partly because you've achieved in the West a great deal of prosperity, a high level of security, and you've achieved happiness, or at least the necessary conditions for happiness in a remarkable sense, but it makes people soft. He says, "It's not advantageous to an organism to be extremely safe and in a state of extreme well-being." You stop really working for things. You think it's all to be taken for granted, and you don't recognize that this is the result of generation after generation taking risks and doing things that involve a lot of hard work and hard choices.
- 8.50** He says, "Look around. You hardly ever see voluntary self-restraint." You talk a lot about human rights and want to be given things. Hardly anybody talks about human obligations, about duties, about what we owe to our society and to each other. He says, as a result, Western civilization is turning itself into something that cannot resist the corrosion of evil.
- 8.51** Then, he starts talking about particular things. He says, for example, culprits can go free, and are treated so leniently that the government cannot fight crime. It can't even fight terrorism. As soon as you do something, the public accuses you of violating people's civil rights. And consequently, it turns out that criminals get away again and again. They are

allowed to go free even when they're guilty. He says, increasingly, as a result, this society is tilting toward evil. It will not resist evil. Instead, it sympathizes with it. It talks about rights and is very jealously guarding rights, but it doesn't think about duties. It doesn't try to defend the innocent from the depredations of the guilty. And so all of this needs to be corrected.

8.52 He says, "Moreover, I see lies increasingly,"—which were a pervasive feature of the Soviet Union—"I see it increasingly in the West." Who's resisting it? Who takes responsibility for it? It looks like nobody in a position of actually speaking to the public actually takes responsibility for telling the truth. And so as a result, he says you say you have freedom of speech, freedom of thought, freedom of association, and so on. But he says, "I look around, and I see a very different situation. Nothing's forbidden, but what is not fashionable will hardly ever find its way into periodicals or books or be heard in colleges." Instead, everybody parrots more or less the same line.

8.53 It's the same complaint, incidentally, that Tocqueville said was pervasive in America in the 1830s. He looks around, and he says that nowhere from one point of view is there greater freedom in America. On the other hand, nobody wants to offend anybody else. So he says, yes, there are fewer penalties for speaking out in America than there are in Europe. On the other hand, Americans are afraid to say anything that might make anybody else unhappy. Well, if that was true in 1830, it's much more true in 1978 when Solzhenitsyn gives his speech, and he's saying, yes, nobody here is willing to say anything unfashionable.

8.54 So the result of that is "strong mass prejudices, blindness. It's a dangerous thing. There is this self-deluding interpretation of the contemporary world situation. It will only be broken by the pitiless crowbar of events." In other words, increasingly, the way that the leadership in the West is seeing the world is deviating very far from reality. Eventually, it's going to crash into reality, and it's going to become clear this is not right. But on the other hand, it looks like there is nothing any longer within this culture to provide an internal self-correction. Eventually, it's going to be reality that has to actually puncture that false narrative that's been constructed.

8.55 In the end, he says, here's one of the hard truths I want you to hear: "socialism of any type and shade leads to a total destruction of the human spirit and to a leveling of mankind into death."

8.56 How do we defeat these tendencies? He tries to be optimistic here and says that here's the key: the human spirit longs for things that are higher, that are warmer, and are purer than the things available now. We have certain living habits, and we have all sorts of sources of information, news and so on. Television, he says, intolerable music—he clearly hates the popular culture in the West, and I think it's not improved, really, since 1978. But in any event, he looks around himself and says, "I see people's minds taken up by junk. It's all just cultural junk food, and I don't see anything in the West that is actually uplifting the spirit, leading us to something more spiritual, something higher, something that would emphasize human obligations."

8.57 He says that the mistake here has to be at the root of this civilization. It isn't just, "Oh, it was a mistake to pass that law or those budgetary reforms or something." He says, "I'm talking about something that started in the Renaissance and then developed in the

Enlightenment." Call it rationalistic humanism or humanistic autonomy, this idea that there's nothing higher to which we have to answer.

8.58 I started this course by talking about a divide. Is it the case that human institutions are the sources of morality, are the sources of normativity, or is there something higher? Do we have to answer to the unread book? In other words, to reality, to God, to something that is higher than humanity? And he says that that's the mistake. The Enlightenment said, "There is nothing higher. Humanity is the source of all obligations. It is the source of meaning. It is the source of significance." That was a fundamental mistake. We put mankind at the center.

8.59 Protagoras said, "Man is the measure of all things." Kant says, "Here's the basic rule: treat humanity as an end in itself, never merely as a means." John Stuart Mill says, "Acts are right in proportion as they promote happiness." All of those things say it's humanity and it's human happiness that's all that matters. That is the highest thing. Yes, we can judge human institutions and laws and policies and rules and procedures and individual acts on the basis of those things, but they all just relate to humanity.

8.60 Solzhenitsyn says that it's a mistake. Actually, that is not enough. Only moral criteria and ultimately spiritual criteria can lead the West out of this trap. "There are no other criteria. Practical or occasional considerations of any kind, they're going to be swept away by strategy." As long as you think it's humanity that is the only source that we have to think about, you are going to be misled by people who say, "We can make human beings happier or better or more prosperous or whatever." Whatever that story is, and we can say a lot about happiness or authenticity or whatever you substitute, it doesn't matter. But he says, Look, in a sense, it's all starting from the wrong premise.

8.61 "Our task on Earth,"—he says—"has to be the fulfillment of a permanent, earnest duty. One's life journey must become an experience of moral growth. You've got to leave life a better human being than you started." It's not a question of making the world a better place. It's a matter of making yourself a better person. He says that we've got to start there. That's what can enable us to change this. As long as I'm thinking, "What would make me happier, what would make me richer, what would make me experience more pleasure," and so on, we're looking at this small frame, and then it's very easy to be distracted by things that don't matter. We've got to think, "How do I become a better human being?" Only when that becomes central in our culture can we actually accomplish what we need to accomplish.

8.62 Now I want to move to the second thinker that I want to focus on: Václav Havel. Havel, instead of just blaming some people, said, "We're all responsible. We are all guilty." Who was he? He participated in the Prague Spring, Czechoslovakia, 1968. He founded Charter 77 in the Committee for the Defense of the Unjustly Prosecuted. So he was not only a dissident, but a leader of the dissident movement in Czechoslovakia. He, from 1979 until 1983, was imprisoned as a result of these activities. But eventually, he participated in the Velvet Revolution, so-called in Prague in 1989, overthrew the puppet government, and then became President of Czechoslovakia until 1992. Then, when Czechoslovakia was divided into the Czech Republic and the Slovak part, he became the President of the Czech Republic.

- 8.63** He begins by talking about a poster in a typical shopkeeper's window behind the Iron Curtain: "Workers of the World, Unite!" The person puts that in the window, and he says, "Why? This manager of a fruit and vegetable shop places in his window, among the onions and carrots, the slogan, 'Workers of the World, Unite!' Why does he do it?" Here's what he's saying. Is he saying, "I'm a true Marxist. Workers of the world, unite?" Not really. He says, here's the content of this: "I, greengrocer XY, live here, and I know what I must do. I behave in the manner expected of me. I can be dependent on. I'm above reproach, I'm obedient. I have the right to be left in peace."
- 8.64** There were a lot of these posters that were posted all over the place: "Workers of the World, Unite!" or "Stand Firmly for the National Government," whatever it is. It says: "I'm loyal. Don't mess with me. Don't arrest me. I won't cause any trouble. I'll play along." Does that mean, really, "I believe in the ideology"? He says, at least by the 1980s, people didn't believe this ideology, but still they put the posters in the shop. They were willing to go along because they were trying to say, "I'm not going to cause any trouble. It's okay."
- 8.65** "Ideology,"—he says—"is a specious way of relating to the world. It offers the illusion of identity, of dignity, and of morality, but it makes it easier for people to part with them." So it basically says, I'm a good guy. I'm on the team. I'm not going to cause any trouble. But in fact, that is a way of, yes, identifying: I'm with the dominant group. I have dignity. I'll be moral. I won't cause trouble. But in fact, what I'm doing is enabling evil.
- 8.66** So he says, "Ideology creates a bridge of excuses. It spans the abyss between the aims of the system and the aims of life. It pretends that the requirements of the system stem from the requirements of life. It's a world of appearances trying to pass for reality." That's the danger. It really says that this is the world I believe in. I'll go along with it. Even though at root, it's a lie, and the person may even know it's a lie. They don't really believe it, but they're willing to go along with that world of appearances. He says, "That's why the system is so thoroughly permeated with hypocrisy and lies," and he begins to talk about some of these lies.
- 8.67** For example, "Government by bureaucracy is called popular government." Or "the working class is enslaved in the name of the working class." "The complete degradation of the individual is presented as his ultimate liberation." "Depriving people of information is called making it available." That's the official Soviet newspaper from back in the day, Pravda; Pravda means truth. The joke was: "There is no pravda in Pravda," "There's no truth in Pravda."
- 8.68** "The use of power to manipulate is called the public control of power. The arbitrary abuse of power is called observing the legal code. The repression of culture is called its development. The expansion of imperial influence is presented as support for the oppressed. The lack of free expression becomes the highest form of freedom."
- 8.69** "Farcical elections become the highest form of democracy." "Banning independent thought becomes the most scientific of worldviews." "Military occupation becomes fraternal assistance." He says all of these are lies, but the language is shaped in such a way as to make it hard to think the truth. Eventually, the regime becomes captive to its own lies. It starts believing this stuff, and then it falsifies everything.
- 8.70** "It falsifies the past. It falsifies the present. It falsifies the future. It falsifies the statistics. It pretends not to possess this omnipotent and unprincipled police apparatus. It pretends to

respect human rights. It pretends to prosecute no one. It pretends to fear nothing. It pretends to pretend nothing." And all of this is a smokescreen. All of this is a lie. It corrupts its own database. It starts telling this lie and that lie. And then to keep up the fabric of appearances, it tells more and more lies until it convinces itself of the lies.

- 8.71** This is what makes doublethink possible. The person says something. They say it with full sincerity. They seem to believe it. They do believe it. And yet at some level, they know it's all a world of appearances. It's as if you're talking about a work of fiction, and within the work of fiction, you're serious about it. You discuss it. You're discussing, let's say, one of Shakespeare's plays and *Romeo and Juliet*, and what's really motivating this or that character. Within that world, you're saying it, and you're saying it fully, sincerely, and you believe it. Yet, it's not even very far back in your mind; you know it's a story. It's not real.
- 8.72** That's the state of mind that people develop. They're within the world of appearances. They'll put themselves in that framework and discuss it as if they're discussing a work of fiction from one point of view, but they act as if it's completely reality. He says, "At one level, individuals don't have to believe all these mystifications, but they do have to behave as though they did. They have to at least tolerate them and really pretend to go along with them,"— putting that sign in the window, for example. They've got to live within the lie because the moment you step out of it, you're in trouble. You don't really have to believe it. You just have to accept it enough so that you will not rebel against it.
- 8.73** That means—what are you doing? You're confirming the system, fulfilling the system, making the system. In the end, you are the system. It's because everyone goes along that everyone else feels like they have to go along. In a sense, he says it is not the case in most of these Eastern European countries that things were nearly as oppressive as they were in Stalin's Russia. It wasn't like that. Instead, it was this fabric of everybody going along with it. What would happen if you stepped out of line? Nobody's quite sure because it's very rare that anybody steps out of line. Well, Havel found out: step out of line, and you end up spending four years in prison.
- 8.74** But that is how the whole system operates. It doesn't, at a certain point, really require an extensive intervention in people's lives because they police each other. Not even in the sense of the networks of informers, though there was a lot of that—the Stasi, the secret police in East Germany, it was discovered after the fall of the Berlin Wall that one out of six East Germans was an informant for the Stasi. So, actually, there was a huge amount of this. You couldn't trust even members of your own family. But in places like Czechoslovakia, it wasn't really quite that extensive. But it didn't matter. Still, nobody was willing to step out of line.
- 8.75** He says, "At some point, the greengrocer decides to step out of line." He says that at some point, he takes down the sign. That's all he does; he just takes down the sign. No more of this, "Workers of the World, Unite!" just onions, carrots, et cetera. He says that it is a revolutionary act. "He steps out of living within the lie. He rejects the ritual. He rejects the rules of the game." That might seem a minor thing, but in fact, it's really a vital and important thing. "He discovers his suppressed identity and dignity. He gives freedom a concrete significance. His revolt is an attempt to live within the truth."
- 8.76** He says, "I won't deny it. I'm not going to say, 'Down with the workers of the World,' or anything like that. I'm just going to say, 'Down with the sign, I sell onions and carrots.'"

That's it. That is an attempt to live within the truth. He says what he's done there seems minor, but it's really very important. He has said, "I'm not going to go along with the rules of the game." He's broken them. He's disrupted the game, and he's exposed it as a mere game. He said, "We're all just playing along with this, and I'm going to stop playing along. This is a work of fiction." He shatters that world of appearances. He points out that it's fiction, and that is the fundamental pillar of the system.

8.77 Havel says that he's upset the power structure. He's torn apart what holds it together. If other people aren't saying, "I go along with this," all of a sudden you start thinking, "Why do I have to go along with it?" So he demonstrates that living a lie is living a lie. You don't have to do this.

8.78 Now, he says that is a profound threat. Why? Because the main pillar of the system is living the lie, staying within the lie. The moment you point out it's a lie, and you don't even have to say anything, just stop saying the lie, that is the most fundamental threat to the system. Why? Because it's living the truth. It is saying, "All of this is fiction." He says that's why it has to be suppressed more brutally than anything else. The most important sphere of activity is living within the truth. Serving it consistently, purposefully, articulately, organizing that service. Don't go along with the lies. That is something that increasingly had real power.

8.79 Throughout the 1980s, those dissident voices of Solzhenitsyn, of Havel, of Lech Wałęsa in Poland, of lots of leaders behind the Iron Curtain, began to have an increasing influence. It was partly because of other leaders as well who heard those voices and responded. One of them was Pope John Paul II, who was an immensely popular Pope. The largest human gathering ever recorded was a mass that he held in Poland for three and a half million people, which is an astounding, astounding number. But he was not the only one.

8.80 Margaret Thatcher in Britain, for example, helped to take part of this revolution, pointing out that the lies were lies. Thatcher started out, incidentally, as a chemist. She studied chemistry in college and was part of the group that invented soft-serve ice cream. So anytime you have frozen yogurt or soft-serve ice cream, think and thank Margaret Thatcher. She eventually became the first female Prime Minister of Britain in 1979, in what in Britain was known as the Winter of Our Discontent—nice reference to Shakespeare there. She ended up winning three elections in a row, the first Prime Minister to do that since 1832. So for a time, at any rate, she was immensely popular.

8.81 She was denounced by her critics as the Iron Lady, and she loved that, so adopted that as her phrase, and was famous for saying things like, "The promise with socialism is that you eventually run out of other people's money." She once said, asked what her greatest achievement was, her answer was: "The defeat of socialism." Indeed, she thought of herself that way as the person who had taken that postwar socialist society that Hayek had seen forming and denounced in "The Road to Serfdom," but had been implemented for more than 30 years; she was the one who recognized that has to be defeated.

8.82 She privatized a lot of the industry that had been nationalized after the Second World War. She curbed the power of unions, ended strikes, recaptured the Falkland Islands, and reestablished a clear moral sense. When I'm talking about the resurgence of normativity, she is one of the key figures who said, "I'm not going to be ashamed to talk about what's

right and what's wrong, what's fair and unfair, what is legitimately owned or illegitimately owned." She became a reliable ally of the United States.

8.83 Ronald Reagan in the United States had much the same role. I want to talk a little bit about his ideas because there was a huge amount of interaction between what Reagan was saying and what the various dissidents in Eastern Europe were saying. He gave a famous speech in 1964 in support of Barry Goldwater. His campaign for the presidency was called "A Time for Choosing," but now it's just known as "The Speech."

8.84 He talks about this as the central issue of that election, but I think in many ways, the central issue in general. He is prefiguring what the New Philosophers were saying about 15 years later. He says, "This is the issue: whether we believe in our capacity for self-government or whether we abandon the American Revolution and confess that a little intellectual elite in a far distant capital can plan our lives for us better than we can plan them ourselves." That is exactly the way the New Philosophers saw it. It's a question of the elite saying, "We can do a better job of controlling your life than you can."

8.85 He won an overwhelming victory in 1980 and an even larger victory in 1984. He took office at a time which was very difficult economically: a 15% inflation rate, a 21% interest rate, 18% on mortgages, 8% on employment. But during his presidency, there were 20 million new jobs. The gross domestic product was up 27%, manufacturing up 33%, median income up 12%. So it was a time of a significant economic boom. He did that in part by lowering tax rates, dropping them dramatically from 70%, initially down to about 35% and then to 28%. So, there was a very significant resurgence of confidence as well as of prosperity.

8.86 But what I want to really focus on is his confrontation with the Soviet Union. He was asked about his strategy, and he said, "Here's my strategy on the Cold War: we win, they lose." "Of the four wars in my lifetime,"—he said—"none came about because the U.S. was too strong." So we engaged in a military buildup that the Soviet Union, being in a very weak economic position, could not possibly match.

8.87 But I want to talk about the ideological aspect of this. He gave a famous speech to the House of Commons in 1982: "What I'm describing now is a plan and hope for the long term, the march of freedom and democracy, which will leave Marxism-Leninism on the ash heap of history, as it's left other tyrannies which stifle the freedom and muzzle the self-expression of the people."

8.88 Then, he talked about the evil empire. He said, "Because 'quiet men' do not 'raise their voices,' because they sometimes speak in soothing tones of brotherhood and peace, because like other dictators before them, they're always making their final territorial demand, some would have us accept them with their word and accommodate ourselves to their aggressive impulses. But if history teaches anything, it teaches that simple-minded appeasement or wishful thinking about our adversaries is folly. It means the betrayal of our past, the squandering of our freedom."

8.89 And so in the rest of that speech in 1983, he said, "It was C. S. Lewis, who in his unforgettable 'Screwtape Letters,' wrote, 'The greatest evil is not done now in those dens of crime that Dickens loved to paint. It's not even done in concentration camps and labor camps. In those, we see its final result. But it's conceived and ordered (moved, seconded, carried, and minuted) in clean, carpeted, warmed, and well-lighted offices by quiet men

with white collars and cut fingernails and smooth, shaven cheeks who do not need to raise their voices."

- 8.90** "I urge you to beware the temptation of pride, the temptation of blithely declaring yourselves above it all, and label both sides equally at fault, to ignore the facts of history and the aggressive impulses of an evil empire, to simply call the arms race a giant misunderstanding, and thereby remove yourself from the struggle between right and wrong and good and evil."
- 8.91** I had dinner with a group of people that very night after the speech. It was common in the news media to say, "This is Reagan again being provocative. He is needlessly provoking the leaders of the Soviet Union. This is going to make the situation in the Cold War worse." They were all echoing that opinion. People were talking about that. Finally, that conversation died down. There was a woman sitting at the end of the table who was silent throughout all of this.
- 8.92** And finally, when the conversation stopped, she said, "But it is an evil empire." Who was she? She was the daughter of Mykhailo Dray-Khmara. She was the little girl whose father was taken away when she was just seven years old and sent to Kolyma for writing that poem, "White Swans." She was the one who said, "But it is an evil empire. He's telling the truth, and it's a truth that needs to be faced."
- 8.93** A Soviet general later described Reagan's speech as a turning point in the Cold War. Why? He said, "Because we knew it was true. That punctured the lie. It showed it was a world of appearances." He said, "I couldn't look at myself in the mirror. I went in the next morning to shave and looked at myself and realized I am an agent of an evil empire." He knew it was true.
- 8.94** Partly, the USSR simply fell because it was involved in Afghanistan—never a good idea to get involved in a land war in Asia. But nevertheless, it was partly that, partly it simply couldn't match the U.S. military buildup because its economy was not nearly as strong. And so part of it was that, but part of it was pointing out that that world of appearances was just a world of appearances. It had a real normative element. It wasn't just false; it was an evil empire, partly because it was falsifying reality, but partly because there was an oppression of the human spirit taking place, sometimes very directly, sending people to prison camps, but sometimes indirectly, simply by forcing them into that fabric of lies.
- 8.95** Later in 1987, he went to Germany and said in front of the Brandenburg Gate in Berlin, "General Secretary Gorbachev, if you seek peace, if you seek prosperity for the Soviet Union in Eastern Europe, if you seek liberalization, come here to this gate! Mr. Gorbachev, open this gate! Mr. Gorbachev, tear down this wall!" It's maybe Reagan's most famous speech. His speechwriters and others in the State Department kept trying to strike that out, and he wrote it in again and again and insisted upon giving it. They kept saying, "It's needlessly provocative." He said, "No, I want to say it." Indeed, it took until he was out of office, but within two years, the Berlin Wall did indeed fall in 1989. And then, two years after that, Secretary Gorbachev resigned as the leader of the Soviet Union, and the Soviet Union was no more.
- 8.96** All of that happened suddenly and dramatically. It looked like we were heading toward maybe a huge conflagration, the Third World War between communist countries and free

countries. It turned out that one side simply collapsed. Collapsed without really any fighting, certainly without a world war. What happened?

8.97 Timur Kuran, in a book called "Private Truth, Public Lies," talked about this as preference falsification. It has to do with living in that bubble of lies. He said people routinely misrepresent their preferences to appear socially acceptable. And yet the moment somebody takes down the sign in the window, that shopkeeper helps launch the revolution. The moment a leader like Reagan says, "It is an evil empire," the illusion starts breaking. So things can change very, very rapidly.

8.98 People all of a sudden realize that other people around them are just going along with the lie. They don't believe it either. At that point, preferences can change dramatically. All of a sudden, it can seem like everything is smooth in East Berlin, for example, or in Prague, or in Budapest. And suddenly, there are millions of people in the street demanding change, millions of people flooding the border, millions of people dramatically bringing down entire governments, all without a shot.

8.99 I want to talk a little bit about the contrast that then emerged when the Berlin Wall fell. Here is a high point of German engineering: a Porsche Panamera. Here is the height of East German engineering: the Trabi. The Trabant, it was famous. It was the car that gave communism a bad name. It had a two-stroke pollution generator that maxed out at 18 horsepower. It was "a hollow lie of a car constructed of recycled worthlessness," says one person. "It smoked like an Iraqi oil fire when it ran at all."

8.100 So yeah, here are some jokes that were common in East Germany: "How can you double the value of your Trabi?" "Fill it with gas." "How do you measure its acceleration?" "With a diary." "Why do some have heated rear windows?" "To keep your hands warm while pushing them." "What's the difference between a Jehovah's Witness and a Trabi?" "You can shut the door on the Jehovah's Witness." "When does the Trabi reach its top speed?" "When it's being towed." So people were falsifying their preferences, and things were really deeply misleading.

8.101 But it seemed as if a huge historic dam had broken. Suddenly, and largely without a shot, the world was transformed. And so by 1991, it looked as if we were now in a very different period of history. Francis Fukuyama wrote a book, "The End of History and the Last Man," declaring there's something like the end of history: from now on, it's simply going to be liberal democracies facing practical problems and trying to solve them. But nevertheless, ideological conflicts are over.

8.102 Well, history did not end. And so now we live 35 years later, almost, recognizing that, yes, a lot has changed, but a lot has also happened. History did not stop. And so, how do we look at that now? Fukuyama was right that there was a fundamental shift in the period of history we're living in. On the other hand, history says back to Fukuyama, "We're done when I say we're done." Evidently, it is not yet. The end.

8.103 What advice would you give someone considering a major or career in philosophy, especially when it comes to trying to navigate a seemingly widening ideological divide among peers or anyone, really?

8.104 Yes. If you're interested in philosophy, what should you do? It's a good question. I went to graduate school in philosophy, being well aware of the fact that the odds of my getting a job were not that great. Everybody, all my professors, everybody, urged me not to do this.

But I was young. I was graduating college at 20. I was applying to schools at 19. I thought that if this doesn't work out, I always have time to go to law school or do something else. Not everybody has the luxury of being in that position.

8.105 But anyway, I thought, I'm going to take the risk. But here's what I have to do: I have to go to a really good place, and I have to really work hard there and become one of the best students there. Then at least I maximize my chances. Then if it doesn't work out, then I'm not going to spend lots of time in a one-year position here and moving over there and doing— No, then I'll go to law school or do whatever else I want to do. I'm not going to stay with it.

8.106 I still think that's pretty good advice. If you're serious about it, go to a really good place and study with really good people. Work hard and make sure you do a great job there. Then I think your chances are very, very good. I teach in a top-10 graduate program in philosophy, and our graduates in general do very, very well. So it is still possible. I'm not even saying, don't do other things. There are people who go to schools that are ranked far lower but manage to get jobs; it's just a different job, usually. If you're looking for a teaching at a small college in a certain region, that can be a good thing to do. On the other hand, a minority of the people actually end up in tenure-track positions. So your job is to make sure you're one of them; be in the top third of the people coming out with degrees in philosophy. So I think it is possible.

8.107 Let me give you the good side, which is that, first of all, I found graduate school way more fun than undergraduate education. I loved it. I had a great time. Now, part of it is I was studying with fantastic teachers who were not only great scholars, but great teachers. But also, I got to do what I wanted to do. I didn't have to take courses in other areas to satisfy this requirement or whatever. I could just say that I've got fantastic people teaching great things. Sometimes I made bad choices, and I now realize, "Why did I take that instead of this? That was really dumb." But in any event, it was fantastic. I loved the experience, and I learned a huge amount. Then, to actually have a career teaching, if you like interacting with people, if you like teaching, if you like the world of ideas, it's wonderful. I'm so glad this is what I do. All of that is great.

8.108 What's the downside? Well, it can be the case that you get trapped in this one-year appointment, one-year appointment, one-year appointment thing. Sometimes that leads you to a tenure-track job. It's just a budgeting thing. "Okay, we'll hire you for this year, but we don't know about the budget situation. Okay, one more year, one more year. Now, okay, we got a tenure-track position. We think you're great." So odds are you're going to get it. So it can work out well, but it's a real danger, and it can lead people to really waste much of their 20s and even early 30s doing something that in the end isn't going to lead anywhere. So in that sense, there's a real downside.

8.109 The other downside is that I don't love the situation in higher education right now. I think a lot of traditional institutions are going to be in trouble, partly because of the availability of great online education like this, but partly because it costs too much money. We've got to find a way of bringing the cost of college down. It is insane what's happened. I went to one of the most elite and most expensive colleges in the country, and it was \$3,000 a year, tuition room and board. Even if you adjust for inflation, that's under \$20,000 a year. Today,

those places are \$80,000 or \$90,000 a year. That is insane. We've got to find ways of reversing that.

8.110 Also, I think we've got to become much more focused. I mean, I teach at a great university, and yet I look at it and think it's trying to be something for everyone. It's the equivalent of an academic cafeteria. That's an analogy, by the way, that the University of California pioneered and actually became the dominant way of universities thinking about themselves ever since the late '40s and early '50s. They've thought, "Yes, we're an intellectual cafeteria. You want to study physics? Great. Philosophy? Great. Business? Sure. Engineering? Yeah. Nursing? No problem."

8.111 When you think about what's happened to cafeterias in the restaurant business, you start thinking, "I don't love this. It seems to me maybe the future is the little ethnic restaurant that really specializes in this and excels in that." So, are we going to get beaten by, here, the model would be something like Juilliard, let's say, in music, where they're small conservatories. Yes, you can go to the University of Texas at Austin and study music in our Butler School of Music, and it's very good. On the other hand, most people who really are serious about music are going to go to Juilliard or Oberlin or someplace where there's a dedicated conservatory where that's what they do. I start thinking, "Are we dinosaurs?" That worries me. Anyway, it's a transitional time.

8.112 At the time I did it, I thought higher education has a great future. For my career, it has. But now I look at people who are young, and I think, "If I project 40 years into the future, what's it going to be like?" I don't know. There's a big uncertainty there that's a source of risk you really can't control.

8.113 With this grand transition of higher education, if traditional higher education—in the sense that it has recently been—becomes obsolete in the future so that the availability of these online platforms with such rich resources, such as this one in addition to those really unique niches, like you're saying, of some of the specific schools, then this now becomes available to a wider audience as well—older people and much younger people than historically was available—then somebody, like he's asking, going into heavily studying of the ethics, if this is now available to somebody while they're also in middle school or high school, and they can be learning these things alongside any other studies that they're doing, and they're then ready to apply that to the world to start solving the world's problems by the time they would normally be spending time in a traditional university, like they're ready to deploy, what is the best case use of how they can apply all of these things that they're learning in these new environments?

8.114 Yeah, great question. I think we need to develop ways of evaluating people's competence on the basis of what they actually know and can do, not on what's written on a sheet of paper. I will tell you honestly that many of the students at my university—and in the academic hierarchy, I'm not at the very top, but I'm at a university that is quite high in that hierarchy—still, a significant number of my students shouldn't be in college. They don't have enough interest. I don't know if they have enough ability because they don't apply themselves hard enough for me to find out if they have the ability. The fact is, they're not into this. They're here because they think, "I have to get my ticket punched in order to get a job in order to do things." They're not really very interested in philosophy or psychology or business or whatever it is they're studying.

- 8.115** I think we need to find alternative paths. It is dumb to have people who are not paying much attention and not really working very hard and just getting by to get the stamp. I mean, why do we care about the stamp so much? We should care about what you've learned, what you know, what you can do. I think we have to get back to that model. I think it used to be there. It didn't used to be the case that you needed more than, say, a high school education to do lots of other things. It was a question of how much you know. What can you actually do? Here, we'll give you this low-level thing, see how you do at it. I think that has to become resurgent. We have to stop the credentialism that is now overwhelming. Lots of credentials don't mean very much, and lots of people acquire knowledge and skills apart from any credentials. We have to stop this focus.
- 8.116** Actually, in music, there's a good example of this. Do we care that much where you went to school and who you studied with and so on? In the program, we'll talk about that and brag about it to try to get the audience in, but the fact is, you're there doing what you're doing because you can play. Let's say you want a new saxophone player for the band, you interview people and see play the saxophone. You don't say, "So what's your degree in, and where did you study?" You just say, "Let me hear you play." I think that is something we need to do to a much greater extent. Because you're right, people can learn so much, and even at an early age, that they can start doing all sorts of things, and they don't need the credential. What's the point of the credential? In fact, if you already know how to do it, you're wasting your time going on and getting that stamp.
- 8.117** Conversely, we've got all these people with all the credentials who actually didn't do much, didn't accomplish much. When Harvard in their publication is saying, "Students, you need to go to class." When students are saying, "Why isn't anybody going to class?" You are hanging out with your Harvard students, and you know you're going to get by with an A minus anyway, even if you never show up. We've got a serious problem. Partly, I want to kick those people like, "You're one of the most privileged human beings in the world, in the history of the world. Go to class!" But partly, I want to say that shows that the whole system is broken somehow, that we're caring about the symbol rather than the reality.
- 8.118** To tie it into the lecture, we're caught in a world of appearances. We've got to say, "Forget the appearances; deal with the reality." I think online education can give people the reality. It is often not yet at a stage where it gives people the appearance and the stamp. One way of getting out of this is to say, "Let's find ways of giving people the stamp." But I think a better way is to say, "Let's stop caring so much about these credentials and care about ability again.
- 8.119** In regard to Solzhenitsyn's grievances against the West and how they value human happiness and human comfort over their duty to other human beings, have there been attempts made in philosophy or in certain thinkers where they tried to replace a higher spirit, a higher entity, with the human collective? Or do you think that if they place the value on the human collective, that it's still lacking the higher calling of the spirit that Solzhenitsyn was recommending for the West?
- 8.120** Great question. I think Solzhenitsyn says it's not enough to take humanity at the center. The Renaissance and the Enlightenment were all about developing humanism where it's humanity at the center. Whether you do that in terms of treating people as ends, not as means, or in terms of focusing on human happiness, you are focusing on something that's

purely at the human level. You might say, "What's wrong with that? It is higher than the individual, so I'm still looking at something higher: humanity and my fellow humans. Isn't that enough to motivate me? After all, I'm concerned about other people. That's the core of the ethical attitude. So why isn't that enough?" I think that is, in effect, the position of the Renaissance and the Enlightenment and the modern world, saying, "Yeah, humanity is enough. We don't need God. We don't need anything higher."

8.121 Solzhenitsyn thinks it's a mistake. I think for the same reasons that Dostoevsky thought it was a mistake. Interesting that it's Russians who see this more clearly, maybe, than anybody else. But they say, yeah, here's the problem: when I think I want to make the world a better place, a better place for humanity, I want to treat you with full respect, I want to maximize human happiness, let's say, what do I count as a happy human life?

8.122 Or let's say I'm an Aristotelian. I say I'm about promoting human flourishing, and that's maybe the richest and broadest. So it's not really just the Enlightenment and the Renaissance. It goes all the way back to ancient Greece. Aristotle is really saying, "Yeah, it's humanity. I want to promote human flourishing. I want a flourishing human community." If that's all I have, then what counts as a flourishing human community? What counts as human well-being? I fill in my own conception of that. I think: what's my idea of the right way to live? What is it for me to flourish?

8.123 Some of that you hope you have in common with everyone else. But it naturally leads to this attitude where I say that I know what human flourishing is. "You're not flourishing. You're not flourishing," and so on. I can tell you how to lead your life better than you evidently know how to lead it yourself. It's a small step from that to saying, "Let me substitute my judgment for yours," because what we care about is human well-being, human happiness, human flourishing. "I think I know that better than you do. It really involves, let's say, authenticity, or it really involves this or that other thing. You're not living that way, so I'd better get you to shape up and live the way I want you to live."

8.124 Indeed, you could look at what Solzhenitsyn was saying at Harvard as an example of that. I think some people took it that way, like, "He's coming in and telling us how to live now. Great." But I think that his point is that unless you have this higher vision, you think, "My job in life is to become a better person," you have to have an idea of what a better person is. But if it's just coming from you, you're going to be projecting your own narcissistic desires and conceptions, and you're going to be trapped in narcissism—that was Dostoevsky's point—then you're going to try to force that on other people.

8.125 But I think he thinks, no, look higher than humanity, look higher than human well-being or flourishing. Look higher even than your own idea of what it is to be a better person, and look at some model that is bigger than you. Here, in part, I think it's a spiritual sense that we are more than our present selves, but it's partly that you, in trying to decide what human flourishing really is, are an isolated individual. Humanity has been wrestling with this question for thousands of years. There's an entire history.

8.126 So stop trying to do what Saul Bellow is denouncing, saying, "Act as if you can start from ground zero, and you just define what a good human life is." He says, "No, this is obviously wrong." We have an entire history—many people who have lived pretty awful lives, but many people who have lived wonderful lives. Look at that history, learn about it. Study the people who are the great models and imitate them. How do you know they're

the great models? Partly because they did understand there was something higher than their present self, and they are people who look to something above them.

8.127

I think in the end, he thinks that, really. It's not as if it makes no sense to say humanity is what I focus on. You can tell that story. He says, "I think what history shows us is that that's not enough. You need something higher." You get led into socialism or communism or some other -ism. Maybe it's materialism. Maybe it's something that it fulfills a certain part of the human spirit, but it doesn't fulfill all of it. He thinks inevitably you get trapped in a partial story about what it is to be human.